Stars Through the Snowstorm

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/48595261.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Other She-Ra Characters Appear

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Aliens, Alien!Catra, Human!Adora, Road Trip!, Adora has a lot of anxiety, Catra has a lot of trauma, Castaway Catra, Catra is stuck on a primitive planet, And mad about it, Humans are kind of insane, Friendship, Fluff and Angst, Falling In Love, Hurt/Comfort, A Christmas fic like how Die Hard is a Christmas movie

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Stars Through the Snowstorm

by MageofRadio

Summary

Adora had thought spending Christmas at her family's cabin up in the mountains would be a relaxing break from high school. She did not expect to get snowed in up there, much less with no one but a sassy cat-eared alien castaway to keep her company. Forming an unlikely duo, Adora quickly finds herself at odds with her family and what seems like all the forces on Earth and in the stars above as she embarks on a cross-country quest to get her new friend home.

Notes

Notes and chapter-specific trigger warnings (TWs) will always be at the end of the chapter.
Initial general content warning: canon-typical violence, some blood, and occasional swearing

Chapter 1: When the Snow Falls

Chapter Notes

> And suddenly my thoughts then turned to you
> Who came to me upon a winter's night,
> When snow-sprites round my attic window flew,
> Your hair disheveled, eyes aglow with light.
> - Claude McKay, The Snow Fairy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was now quiet and wild.

The snowstorm had come down from the west, obscuring the sun as it set and smothering the world in a thick gray haze. Snowflakes filled a darkening sky, coiling down into the huge drifts rising on the ground like a frozen tide, burying rocks and bushes and the boards of the cabin's deck, and all the while in quiet. An ominous, beautiful quiet that whistled against the walls, softly scraping and whispering words Adora knew too well. 'It was too late to leave now.' The storm said.

She watched the quiet encroach from the couch. Amber firelight glowed in front of her. The dry log in the hearth crackled softly as she took another sip from the mug between her hands, knuckles white. The motion activated her phone's screen again, and she glanced at it, dreading the seconds ticking by. Soon now.

It was difficult to see much outside. The familiar view of the mountains now a mere memory in her mind; her brain drawing the sharp flanks and rounded peaks where they should be onto the bleak canvas of the storm.

It was too quiet. The house was too quiet. The phone finally rang.

Adora nearly spilled her cocoa as she dove for it, fingers fumbling over the screen as she struggled to answer. "Mom?" She asked,

pressing it to her ear, but only the faintest hint of a voice replied. "Mom, can you hear me?"

"Ho-" She caught a clipped word before silence briefly blanketed the line, then static returned. "It's har-"

Dammit, she should have known. "Mom, I can't hear you." Adora set her mug down so she could plug her opposing ear and try and focus on the words. "It's . . . there's . . ."

"A—rahhh? Ca-alkzaa-yotztztzu?"

It was no use, she knew, but God dammit did she wish hoping could make it so. The solution was obvious, despite how much she didn't want to do it. She looked out into the main room of the cabin where, between the wooden floor and the vaulted ceiling rafters twenty-five feet above, taxidermized animals watched her agonize with glass eyes. The staircase was there, beside the fully lit and present-stuffed Christmas tree, leading down, leading outside. Then she looked back out the windows, clenching her jaw.

It wasn't going to get better out there.

She needed to talk to them.

Adora left her mug on the cushion as she pounded down the stairs. "Mom, I can't hear you. I'm going to call you back." She hung up the line and, even though it was futile, drafted a text to the same effect. She was unsurprised when the little red mark appeared next to the word 'unsent'.

The main floor of the cabin was technically the second floor. At the bottom of the landing was the mudroom, normally packed to the gills with winterwear, now unsettlingly bare. She felt like a trespasser as she retrieved and donned a second hoodie, then her thick red snow jacket, then a white scarf. Below the waist she pulled snow-pants over her pajamas, making sure the hems were tucked inside her boot's cuffs and the stretchy bands of the snow-pants were wrapped over them. Ski-goggles, a knitted hat, she

pulled her jacket hood up, then gloves last before she faced down the door.

It opened inward and revealed snow up to her thighs and a rush of frigid air. Adora shivered, then steeled herself. The cabin was situated in the lee of one of the many round, barren prairie hills that dotted the floor of the rural valley. If she wanted a cell phone signal, she would have to climb.

Her boots crunched down the snow, a muffled sound in a muffled world. Though the wind now whipped over her hat-covered ears, everything was still quiet. The soft pattering of snowflakes against the ground and on her goggles were a white noise that damped everything. Adora looked up. The cloud deck was thankfully above the peak, and she could just make it out through the blizzard. A barely distinguishable line between two near-identical shades of shadowed gray. She had never made this climb alone before, much less in conditions like this.

With a thirty-degree slope and in the deep fresh powder, it was much more a scramble than a hike. Snow was somehow making it through the seams of her cocoon of winter gear, compacted balls of ice stinging her wrists and ankles as she ascended up and away from the little glowing beacon of comfort that was the cabin, whose details were already vanishing into the white death that was the edge of her vision. Getting lost was not an option here. Adora knew what happened if you lost all bearings in zero visibility. Once you had, the chances of getting back to where you started were . . . well, not wise to bet on, that was for sure.

Fifteen minutes later and three hundred feet vertically, she reached the craggy peak of the hill. On the rocky outcrop at its summit, stiff gloved hands gripped the tallest boulder in the spots where Adora was used to doing this in the summer, and heaved herself up with a grunt, landing on her stomach with a soft woosh of compacting snow.

“Hah . . . ha . . . made it.” She announced to no one and forced herself to stand. Here, above the windbreak, the storm was far

fiercer. Shearing gusts blasted her body, buffeting and threatening to blow her over. The snow in the air became biting missiles, pinging and burrowing into her chin, the only skin exposed to the elements. She should have brought a gaiter.

Adora would have said it was a beautiful view - she nearly always did, because it nearly always was atop the hill – but tonight there was nothing to see but gray. Only an orange tint rising from below signaled any hint of humanity. She pulled off a glove, flexing her rapidly cooling fingers before fishing in her fluffy pockets for her phone. It rang only once, and the signal was much much better here. "Hey, Mom." Adora greeted. "Yeah. Yeah, I'm fine. I climbed the hill." She cringed at the shout that followed that. "No. No. I'm fine! It wasn't too bad actually . . . just some well-needed exercise!" She laughed, but it came out a little hollow. "No. Yeah, I bet. So . . ." She inhaled sharply, bracing for the worst. "How are things?"

Adora listened. "Okay." She exhaled all the air from her lungs and elected to sit down in the snow. Thank God. "That's good. Yeah. Tell her- . . . okay. Good. Can I . . . No? I understand." Adora sighed and reached up to switch hands, stuffing the already aching bare one in a pocket. "I was just hoping - I'll call tomorrow. When do you think you'll be able to come back up?" Her eyes widened. "Really? That long? I know the storm is bad but . . . okay . . . okay." They spoke for another minute or so, but by that point, all was pretty much said. Adora would be alone up here for the foreseeable future. Thankfully, there was plenty of food and water, and gas for the generator should the power fail. She would survive. She said her goodbyes quickly, "Love you too." and hung up.

With another huge sigh, she sat slumped for several minutes, one glove over the lower half of her face to block the snow. The cold was seeping in little by little, bitter and lethargic. Adora forced herself to stand and get ready to move. No point sulking here.

Without warning, two amazingly loud booms suddenly roared in Adora's ears. Thunderous, one after the other. CRACK! CRACK!

Like someone had fired a double-barreled shotgun a foot from her ears. Every muscle in her body spasmed at the shock, and she jumped to turn and face north, eyes widening.

In the midst of the distant clouds that way, there was a mote of orange light, growing brighter. Growing closer. Awestruck, Adora watched as the flashing light became a long-tailed streak of fire, tracking across the sky over her head through the clouds. She followed it, blinking through her goggles as it fell southwest and disappeared behind a hill she knew to be half a mile or so from the cabin. An instant after it vanished over the hillside, the ground shook. Snow sheets sloughed off the rocks, and Adora was thrown off balance. Arms pinwheeling, she cringed as she fell backwards off the boulder. Crap! There were sharp rocks down ther-

Whoophf. She sunk a few inches into a deep snowbank. Oh. Good. Nice. Not impaled in the middle of a blizzard. Like that.

Adora scrambled up and trudged a few paces to try and see better. Was that a meteor? It wasn't moving very fast to be one. Not that she was experienced with them. Were meteors slower than she thought they were? Or maybe it was a plane.

Her breath caught, and the agonizing began again. Someone could be hurt. Though she couldn't see any of the other cabins scattered around the valley in these conditions, she knew most of the other families had been smart enough to not come up with a storm like this brewing. There was probably not a single other person in the area that could go help. They would freeze to death long before someone else could reach them.

But it was one thing to climb to the top of a hill where you could see where you came from. It was a whole other to drive out into the night chasing a fallen star. The snow was deep, the roads unplowed, trails ungroomed. But there was a trail that led over there, Adora knew, and she could see even now. The outline of the hill reappearing through the snow as fire began to glow behind it. It was like a tiny second sun was trying to rise, creating a foreboding scarlet dawn.

Adora swore bitterly to herself and started the scramble back down the hill. If someone was there, they might burn or freeze in the wreckage, but it wouldn’t be because of her inaction.

After tripping on frozen rocks and roots and nearly having a heart attack several times on the way down – snowballing down a three-hundred-foot hill might sound fun, but the number of broken bones you receive at the bottom generally makes the experience not worth it - Adora came crashing back into the mudroom and went right out again, this time through the other door into the garage. The garage was the rest of the first floor, a concrete room currently with four very cold snowmobiles inside. She ran to the Polaris 40 horsepower, quickly found the key and started it, then ran to open the garage door.

It whirred up, letting the huge mound of snow that had fallen against it slump into the garage. The storm rushed in after it. Crap. She should have cleared that first; now it would melt on the floor, and she would get an earful. Adora looked at the shovels in the corner, then decided against it. They would forgive her if someone was hurt.

Tossing her hat and goggles, Adora tied her hair up into a tight bun before donning a black balaclava, then her white motorcycle helmet over it, flicking the visor down as she mounted her mechanical steed and drove out into the night.

The snow was very deep, and so fresh it flew up and around her face as she drove. With the flakes filling the air, she was nearly blind as she quickly rode through the unpaved driveway to the main road. As the cabin's lights disappeared behind her, the world became homogenous and indecipherable, a featureless sphere of gray. The whirr of the two-stroke was the only anchor to reality. At least for a time, Adora could navigate by the gentle mounds that marked the borders of the road, but quickly had to start going off memory. She turned on the headlights, their old incandescent bulbs casting a pitifully weak beam ahead of her.

Half a mile down the valley, she slowed and looked left for the wooden post that marked the trailhead. She found it, only just, sides covered in windswept snow. Adora turned onto it, then really let it rip, roaring up towards the ridge of the hill. The snowmobile struggled through the powder, threatening to slip sideways into a drift and become stuck. Adora gave it more power and fought the handlebars, heaving the machine away from the rocks hidden beside the clear track. She had ridden the Polaris since she was nine; it wasn't hard to tame whenever it got rowdy.

Ten minutes of driving brought her to the ridge of the hill, the fringe lit by whatever was beyond. When the snowmobile lurched over the edge, Adora stopped, standing up on the kickplates and pulling her helmet off. Her balaclava came with, and blond hair tumbled out into a ponytail as she stared down on the scene.

Behind this hill, there was a small circular valley where, shaded from the harsh prairie wind, a grove of hardy trees had managed to eke out a living. The conifers - pines and firs - stood green between barren larch, which towered like grey sentinels above their brothers, guarding them from whatever had fallen within. From the center of the copse, a huge pillar of smoke rose up into the snowstorm, and orange light flickered between the trunks. Adora could see that from the same direction that the star had fallen, a swath of these trees had been shredded and ripped asunder, and at the end of the carnage, she could just make out a large dark object.

She drove in closer. Stopping where the trail came nearest to the trees before dismounting and venturing into the pocket forest. Her footsteps crunched over the soft sound of creaking wood and the blizzard wind tugging the highest branches. Reaching into her pocket, she retrieved a flashlight and shone it up and ahead.

The trees that had been in the meteor's way were thoroughly destroyed, sheared roughly twenty feet up at the edge of the clearing, then growing closer to the ground at a perfect angle as she moved inward. Huge pale splinters as long as Adora's arm lay scattered all around, not buried by snow, and above, embers

drifted through the air, some the size of her palm, edges rippling with red heat. She pressed between the lower branches of trees and winter-bare woody bushes, squinting ahead.

The fires were already going out. Yes, a few large branches still burned or smoked, and the snow was blackened all around, but it wouldn't spread any further. It was too cold for that. Adora ducked beneath a broken section of trunk, then stopped when she saw it there.

The . . . thing . . . was big. At least forty feet long. The shape was smooth and fusiform, perhaps fifteen feet in diameter in the middle and tapering to a narrow but rounded point at both ends. On the side near her, what she presumed was the rear, there were large baffles that folded out at shallow angles, and gave the entire structure the look of a half-opened pinecone.

Adora stopped a good thirty feet away. This was not a meteor. Half crouched in the snow, she waited and watched. The ship was made or coated entirely in some kind of dark gray material that didn't reflect much light. Judging from the long gash in the earth, it had slid nearly a hundred feet through the trees before stopping. For several long minutes, nothing happened. The ship remained perfectly still. Gentle curls of smoke ascended off it into the air. The forest creaked, and Adora grew colder.

Gaining the courage, she traced a wide circle around the craft, moving to be able to see its right side. But even though it was hard to see much through the snow and trees, she couldn't find any markings of any kind. No words, no windows. No identifiable anything.

"Some kind of military drone?" Adora wondered in a whisper and, confident it was at least mostly inert, crept closer. She snuffed out a small burning branch she passed with a kick of snow, then, getting an idea, crouched to form a powdery snowball. It didn't stick together well, but it was solid enough for her to lob at the object.

With a soft whisking noise, the snowball left a circular splatter mark on the side of the craft. Adora tensed, ready to run, but nothing happened. Alright. Feeling slightly silly, Adora stood and closed the final twenty feet.

Her breath fogged in front of her face as she reached up and carefully touched the surface. It was very warm, even though thick gloves. When she pulled away, her fingertips carried soot stains with them. A satellite of some kind? It definitely seemed like it had come from space.

Carefully, she began to walk the circumference of it, hand hovering just an inch above the skin as she did, appreciating the ambient heater. Rounding the front of the object, which was raked with streaks of pale ash as well as the dark gray burns, she found something on the other side. Ten feet from the nose, a third of the way up, there was a panel of sorts, a clear line in the otherwise unbroken skin of the craft. Square with rounded edges, Adora ran her fingers over the seam, then wiped down across the middle of it, revealing the beginnings of something.

Not caring about her gloves, she rubbed around the spot, and quickly uncovered a large red symbol. Two dragon or bat wings surrounding a small diamond. Adora stepped back, trying to place the icon, but didn't think she had seen it before when it suddenly began to glow.

Adora gasped and jerked away, stumbling backwards into the snow. The symbol glowed a dim scarlet. Then there was a hiss, and the panel shifted inwards. Adora's heart hammered. She pressed back on her hands and feet, trying to put some distance from it without making too much noise. Over her heavy breathing, the panel slid aside, and a torrent of liquid poured out of the hole left behind. Adora was very confused, but instinct forced her up before the flood of translucent green fluid, thicker than water, reached where she had been sprawling.

It flooded over stones and snow and burning branches, smothering their heat with a hissing noise. Adora watched, wide-

eyed, and the thought finally struck her.

It's an alien goddamn spaceship. No. But . . . maybe? A real alien spaceship? Right in front of her? It seemed impossible but, she had touched it. She had touched something that may have been made light-years away, under an alien sun.

The flood of liquid continued for several seconds, then slowly began to ebb. But when it was just about to turn to a trickle, something washed out of the dark interior of the craft onto the ground.

No, not something. Someone.

It was a humanoid figure, about Adora's size, half curled, half sprawled out in the middle of a half-inch deep puddle of alien goo. Adora, frightened, turned to shine her flashlight on the body.

It, or she, Adora guessed by her proportions, was wearing a red and black jumpsuit or uniform of some kind. An alien? Adora couldn't quite believe the idea. She looked quite human at first, the arms and legs all in the right places, and her face, visible in the beam, was humanlike. Two closed eyes, a nose, a mouth. But her ears. She had huge triangular cat-like ears that stuck out from the sides of her head. In fact, Adora squinted. It almost looked like her face was covered in short fur. It was. It was a real alien.

Suddenly said alien started coughing, and Adora watched frozen as more greenish slime flew out of her mouth, splattering with a disgusting sound. The hacking lasted several seconds before she took a deep inhale and slumped back into unconsciousness.

Adora was shaking. She had expected to find nothing, or perhaps a smoking meteor or a downed airplane. This was crazy. She stood lock still for a long time, mind whizzing with so many thoughts that it all blurred together into paralyzing blankness as she stared at the being before her.

What shook her out of it was the fact that they obviously needed help.

Adora, driven almost subconsciously, carefully dipped the toe of her boot into the green liquid. When it didn't hiss or melt away the rubber, she stepped fully in and approached the alien. Kneeling just a foot away, Adora reached out and touched them with her glove. Their breathing was shallow, and her skin was already feeling cold. Adora looked around her, wary of the moment when a spotlight would suddenly switch on and reveal an entire platoon of soldiers about to descend on her and surround the site in a plastic bubble. But the wood was still and quiet and dark, other than Adora's somehow still contained panic and the beam of her flashlight. Okay, maybe she had seen too many movies.

Slowly, Adora leaned down and shuffled her arms under the alien. The goo was unsettlingly warm and thick, and when she pulled back to lift her up, it proved to be very sticky as well, forming sinuous connecting threads as she hauled her up. She was as heavy as Adora expected, about one human's worth of dead weight, and now with her in her arms, she took another look at the alien's face. Indeed, there was thin fur there too, even on her closed eyelids. The subtle motion of her breathing transferred into Adora. She looked back at the extraordinary object the alien had emerged from.

"Oh, please don't want to eat me." Adora begged, then headed back toward the snowmobile.

Curses tumbled from Adora's lips as she struggled to get the sticky unconscious alien up the stairs from the mudroom. Carrying her bridal style, she managed to bash their head against the left wall once, and their feet against the right several times. Also a regret was the decision to take her boots off below, her slippery socks on slick wood now threatening to send them both tumbling back down the flight.

At the top, she looked left and right around the dim, cozy cabin. The main room contained everything that wasn't a bedroom, bathroom, or closet. Couches and the TV in one corner, stools

lined against the bar-style kitchen in another. The dinner table near the far wall, and there were throw rugs all around. Everything was lit low by the now much-diminished fire, embers reflecting in the red beads, ornaments, and shiny paper-wrapped presents stuffed beneath the Christmas tree. The left wall had her nook, and the right was all windows, floor to ceiling, giving a view of the deck. Adora elected to lay the strange girl down in the center it all on the hardwood. It would be much easier to mop up the sticky goop than wash it out of couch cushions, she hoped. Pulling off her gloves, jacket, and disgustingly gooey snow-pants and leaving them next to the alien, Adora turned her back and went to the light switches. With a click, she could finally get a good look at the person she had definitely not kidnapped.

Adora exhaled after she did so, still facing the wall as she quickly reset her hair into its poof and ponytail. It was half a miracle she had even found her way back through the blizzard. So, maybe she was a human pilot or something, and the weirdness could be over? Please? Maybe she had that wolfman condition. Adora turned slowly. The one where you grew hair all over your body and . . . nope. She was definitely not human.

Head slightly tilted, Adora approached again. If you squinted, the two looked very much alike. No extra arms or tentacles, no weird proportions. A visible bust and hips that she had identified as female. Though she supposed if they were an alien, any assumption like that was liable to be wrong.

Only her hands below the wrists, head above the neck, and, now she just now noticed it, a furry tail, cylindrical and as long as an arm, were exposed from the skintight jumpsuit she wore, which was black around the shoulders, down the arms, and below the knees, and a rich maroon in between. Pinned on her left breast was a pentagonal badge of some kind, green with the same red logo that had glowed on the spaceship. Her hands had five fingers, all seemingly human, but the nails on the ends of each were black like a dog’s, long and curved like claws. Adora sensed they were very sharp. Her hands, like all her exposed skin, were coated in a thin, honey-colored, velveteen fuzz.

This fur blended with the darker hair on top of her head. Though she supposed it was fur too . . . whatever, it looked like hair. It was a wild wiry mane the color of mud. Adora sensed it would stick out in all directions if it wasn't currently matted in hopeless knots and filled with green slime. Her eyes were closed, but Adora could still tell they were very large. Her nose was slightly upturned at the end, though the nostrils beneath were very thin.

If thin nostrils were how Adora could identify alien species, then maybe Star Trek wasn't far off just sticking points on actors' ears.

Most surprising was that she looked young. Like, as young as Adora. It seemed unlikely someone her age could work on a spaceship. Maybe she aged differently, but still. How had she ended up here?

She seemed uninjured at least, despite what was surely a very high-speed impact earlier. Adora knelt at her side, watching the soft rise and fall of her chest with a half-raised hand. It was strange she hesitated now to touch her again. She had just carried her up here. But this seemed more personal somehow, no gloves.

The ears, though. They looked just like a housecat's ears, though huge, each triangular organ the size of her entire hand. She wondered how well she could hear. Her trepid fingertips gained the courage, and she slowly reached up to brush the long hairs on the tip of one. As they touched the soft sticky fur, it twitched, flicking at her as if trying to dispel a fly. Goosebumps ran up Adora's arm, and she pulled away, hesitating again before reaching down to gently shake her shoulder. A cheek twitch was all she received in response. She was out cold.

Adora considered what to do next. She didn't want to disturb her or accidentally hurt her in any way. But just leaving her on the cold, hard floor, still covered in whatever it was, seemed wrong. She went to go get some towels, but not without carefully looking back before she left the room.

Retrieving a laundry hamper, she wetted four shower towels with warm bath water and returned to carefully begin wiping the green liquid off her. Running the towel through her short fur and over her suit was a surreal experience. Like a dream where everything was just a little off. She was alone in the family cabin, which had never happened, washing an alien like a dirty baby in the middle of the night. Her heart had hardly slowed down since she'd seen the falling star, and by the time she finished drying her fur and untangling her 'hair' with a brush, she was exhausted.

But she couldn't sleep. At least not until the alien woke up. If she woke up, the fearful corner of Adora's brain worried. What if she had gotten some kind of brain damag-No! She would wake up. Adora just needed to be sure she was awake for it when she did.

Selecting a less sentimental blanket from the pile in the corner. Adora laid it over one of the two couches in the room before picking the alien up again and setting her down on top. Stepping back and touching her chin to observe, she adjusted their arm, then folded the blanket down over top before going for coffee. One cup with sugar in her hands later, Adora sat on the opposite couch and watched the tucked-in cat slumber. The placid look on her face made her seem very peaceful.

The coffee vanished as time crawled, and Adora waited. She kept the fire steady with logs and listened to the clock tick softly over the empty house. Above her, the taxidermy heads watched over them both. Deer and pronghorn, sheep and elk, and above her head as a centerpiece, a massive moose up to the shoulders, antlers five feet across.

Minutes turned into hours. The alien did not wake. Adora went for a second cup of coffee, and then a third, but her body felt like lead. The whirlwind of the last twenty-four hours with everything, then the storm, and now *this* had taken its toll. Each was an anchor trying to drag her down into the depths of sleep. She swam against it as fiercely as someone who was really really tired could.

The softly breathing alien was a promise of how incredible the rest would be, however. Sitting in front of a softly roaring fire under a warm blanket in a warm winter cottage. Adora began to grow irrationally jealous of the cat alien, despite the fact that she had just survived a fall from space. Why couldn't she have been the one to fall from space, then she could be sleeping right now, was her last thought before the overwhelming drowsiness finally swept her under.

When Adora woke again, there was a knife to her throat.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None this time.

Hey all, welcome to Stars Through the Snowstorm! First off, some good news! This entire story is already written! I've been working on it on and off for a long while and am finally ready to start posting now that I'm sure I'll finish it. The current word count is right around 130,000 and updates are going to be scheduled for every other week, but there may be a few chapters that come out a little early or late depending on how happy I am with what I have/how much editing will need to be done. Note as well that the final chapter count listed maybe be subject to change if I decide to break up some of the really long chapters I have.

Also, this is my first time putting my writing out there so I want to extend my thanks in advance for giving it your time. I hope you all really enjoy the journey, and I would appreciate any constructive criticism you have. The goal for this is to be about 80% of the quality I would want out of an original novel I will one day hopefully publish, so comments about pacing, prose, style, dialogue, etc are welcome.

Chapter 2: First Contact

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Adora realized what the cool sharp touch on her neck was, her entire body locked up, and her eyes flew open, revealing the flickering shadow of the alien above her. Their form was poised, straddling her with one arm holding her shoulder down, the other pressing a steel knife from the kitchen block on her jugular. Instinctually, Adora tried to move, but she was held in place by a strength greater than the alien's size.

Their eyes stared down at her. They were huge. They were glowing. Irises twin vast oceans that filled each socket, eyelid to eyelid, casting a soft glow down on Adora's pinned body. They were two different colors. The left a pale gold, the right an electric blue. Heterochromia. It was probably because of the existential panic, but Adora found herself fixated on them. A sun and a moon, hung in the dark, shining beside one another.

The alien glanced away at a perceived sound, and their tall dark pupils flashed with eyeshine. When they returned to her, they were hard and fierce. Falling asleep had been a mistake.

The alien loudly barked out words, ears flat and back. "Strotae! Imra toshtar!" Her teeth glinted in the firelight, canines pointed and fanglike.

Adora's heart hammered. Of course they couldn't understand each other. What had she been expecting? "I-I mean you no harm." She began regardless, speaking very slowly and calmly.

The alien's knee dug a little deeper into Adora's ribcage. "Broara'plethas kuche qath!?" She spat. "Stroatae'a!?"

"Please!" She said louder, beginning to panic. "Y-you fell out of your ship. You were freezing . . . I-I brought you here. I mean you

no harm!”

When Adora insisted, something changed in the alien’s eyes. They dilated, going from narrow almonds to huge and circular, and she leaned back off her, sitting on her heels. A deep exhale rose from the human’s throat as the knife came away with it. “Albae?” The alien asked, or Adora thought she was asking a question, then her brow suddenly knitted in pain. She snarled, reaching up to clasp her temples tightly.

Adora, shaking like a leaf, pushed herself half up into a sitting position, her hand habitually reaching forward to comfort the alien that was clearly in pain as they hissed and twitched. Briefly, Adora considered going for the knife held loosely in her right hand, then hoped she'd never had such a stupid thought again.

Adora instead elected to slowly scooch backwards on the couch, putting a hand over the armrest should she have to spring out of reach. The iron poker for the fireplace was a few feet away; she could use that as a weapon it if she had to.

The alien’s migraine lasted around ten seconds. When it had passed, she carefully removed her palms from her head, looking around the house again, then at Adora. She blinked several times, but the feral glint that had burned in her eyes was gone, ears now neutral and pointing upwards at a shallow angle. A staring contest began, both beings holding perfectly still as they observed one another, Adora sprawled on her back, the alien light on her heels.

After a minute of silence, Adora gathered her courage. “Hello?”

The alien’s ears twitched, swiveling to zero in on her voice. “Hello.” She replied confidently.

Adora's eyes bugged out. "You can speak English!?" It came out a panicked whisper. What had just changed?

"Where am I?” The alien answered her question with one of her own. Their voice was effeminate as well, with a soft raspiness in

the back of her words. A subtle hum, audible now that she wasn't yelling.

"You're . . . in my family's cabin." Adora managed to answer. "Umm . . . planet Earth. United States . . . Idaho."

The alien took this in, squinting to herself slightly, then nodded, definitely nodded. Was that gesture universal? They leaned over and laid the knife down on the coffee table, leaving it there.

Adora, very slowly, slid off the couch and stood, eyes remaining on the knife the whole time. "I found you by your ship. You were unconscious. How can you understand me?" She reached forward, carefully watching for a reaction, then grabbed the knife when there was none, pulling it away from the cat.

"Universal translator."

"Your head?" Adora asked, and she nodded again, confirming that was what the pain had been. Maybe the technology took some time to take effect? She wondered. "What . . . are you?"

At this, oddly enough, the alien's voice became sassy. "Wow, nice to meet you too." She moved off the couch stood as well. They were five feet apart. She was a few inches shorter than her, so pretty average for a human woman. "Is that not rude to ask here?"

Adora's eyes narrowed. "Well, maybe I'd be more polite if you hadn't just . . ." She shuddered, fingers reaching up to trace her throat. There was a tiny mark there, where the blade had touched. Too shallow to draw blood, but there.

"I woke up in a strange place with a strange person, what do you expect?" The alien crossed her arms, glancing up at the dead eyes of the animals with similar ears to hers looking down on her.

Adora scowled lightly. 'Person', singular. They knew Adora was alone. "An apology, at least? 'Thanks' would be nice too, considering." What the hell was happening right now? Why was

she talking to her? She had just . . . Shouldn't she be calling the police right now? The police could arrest her even if she was from outer space, right? But it was super early, judging by the still deep indigo sky painted on the windows behind them. The storm had passed; she could see stars twinkling. But there was white nearly two feet up the glass. She was snowed in, and the nearest sheriff, who worked in the town south of the valley, would probably take an hour to get here.

"Fine." The alien said through grit teeth. "Thanks."

Adora very cautiously nodded. Keep her talking. ". . . My name's Adora." She started again. "What's yours?"

"Catra." The alien introduced.

Adora forced down the smirk. Be respectful. Even if 'Catra' was now without the knife, those claws were definitely super sharp. She didn't want to fight, but with the weapon now in her hand, she would if she had to. "And you're . . . an alien?"

"To you."

Goosebumps. Despite her having been pretty much convinced by this point, the confirmation was still shocking. She really really was an alien. Adora took in a shaky breath, then started coughing. Water. Water now. She made the walk over to the kitchen whilst being sure not to turn her back on Catra, grabbed a glass, and filled it from the sink. Her *guest* followed, keeping a comfortable distance away, watching what she was doing. Adora watched back as she downed the entire thing in one go. "Umm . . . want some?" She asked, breathless.

Catra nodded, and a drink was put in her hands. Adora saw her claws retract as she drank it nearly as fast, becoming flush like human fingernails. Apparently, that was one of her catlike traits. Needing to lap up water like milk in a bowl was not, apparently.

"I meant what I said. I mean you no harm." Adora clarified.

Catra glanced at the ready knife. “Good.” She set the glass down.

Adora clenched her jaw. “Do you?”

“Not unless you give me reason to.”

Adora was certainly trying not to. Her nerves jittered like sparking wires. Too much fear, too many questions in her mind. She needed something to focus on. Her stomach growled. There. Either not knowing what else to do, or by some deeply ingrained sense of hospitality, she asked. "Are you hungry? Can you eat human food?"

Catra shrugged. "Do you have any meat?"

Adora's instincts screamed at her not to trust this person. She rubbed the nick on her neck again, glancing at the fridge. She would have to turn her back to open it.

"Like you said:" Catra flared a fanged smile. "I mean you no harm. I won’t hurt you unless you hurt me." Her tail swished back and forth.

Adora swallowed and realized she had two choices. She was stuck here, alone with an alien, an alien who picked up knives and threatened people with them, for far longer than she could reasonably keep alert. Cooking, sleep, the bathroom, and a dozen other tasks would force her to let her guard down. Eventually, Catra would have the advantage. So, Adora would either have to put the knife down and trust her a little more, or seize the initiative while she knew she had it.

Adora carefully turned around, slipped the knife back into the block amongst its brothers, and let her hand drop from it. A heartbeat, then two. Adora throat wasn’t slit by black claws. A tiny knot of tension left her, but her hands still shook as she opened the fridge and rummaged through the meat drawer. “Do you like bacon?” She asked nervously, grabbing the packet and glancing behind her. Catra was still standing in the same place she had been when she looked away.

“I don't know what that is." The alien admitted.

"W-well,” Adora took the plunge, heart still pounding. “you should!" She started getting things ready, pulling out a pan and some plates before realizing. "Wait, if you can speak my language how do you not know what bacon is?"

Catra raised an eyebrow: a somewhat darker, slightly longer streak of fur. "You meet an alien and that’s the first question you have?” She asked, baffled.

Adora flushed. “I’m not exactly an expert in this.” She murmured. Oh my god, she was the first human to ever talk to an alien species. She could be in like, history books or something. Adora Grayskull makes first contact with intelligence beyond Earth: talks about bacon.

“Well, I’m not an expert on translators, so . . .”

The gas stove sparked to life. "But, I mean, you're the one using it." Adora noted. Using it? Was *using* the right word? “Also, you know what meat is, that's kind of specific."

"But we have a word for meat - look, it's complicated, okay?” Catra said, frustration clearly building. “I’m not a linguist!"

“Alright.” Adora backed down immediately, tearing the package open and laying the skillet atop the whispering blue flames. Awkward silence was cut by the bacon starting to sizzle, and a few minutes later Adora plated half a dozen strips and slid them onto the kitchen bar. “Umm . . . you can sit, if you’d like.”

Catra looked at her, then to the high stools. Awkwardly, she clambered up onto the nearest one and sat on her heels, perched with her hands between her legs. Adora raised an eyebrow but decided not to comment. Catra touched the bacon with a fingertip, jerking away and shaking it. Too hot. “My escape pod?”

“Crashed a little ways from here.” Adora took some bacon for herself. “What happened?”

“I was on a survey mission.” The alien explained, looking down at her plate, expression dour. “But something went wrong. There was . . . it was chaotic.” Adora wanted to ask about the nature of the accident, but considering how upset she seemed, it didn’t seem smart to.

So instead, “You’re a scientist then?” she tried to ask casually.

"Huh?"

"You, said you’re from a survey ship, but what did you do on it? Why do your people want to survey our planet? What are they called? Where are you from?”

"That's a lot of questions." Catra said.

"I think it’s time for questions.” The human asserted. “Are you going to answer them?”

After a pause, Catra did. “I’m a force captain. I do lots of things on the ship, logistics, organizing maintenance, leading away missions; whatever the actual captain tells me to. My ‘people’ are a coalition of species. Some of us are sent out to scout solar systems, looking for resources, potentially habitable planets, life. Yours’ was quite the event. An advanced civilization.” Adora felt a flush of pride at aliens being interested in her species, then realized that that might not be a good thing.

“And what do you do when you find civilizations like ours?” Adora asked.

Catra’s shrugged. “I’m not a diplomat. Another ship gets sent I know though. Never been in this situation before.”

“So, you, your people, you weren’t surveying to . . . you know . . . *encourage* us to join your coalition?”

“What?” Catra asked, bewildered.

The human didn’t want to offend, but. “You know what I mean.” She pressed, voice a little colder.

Catra’s eyes changed just so, and though Adora wasn’t sure she liked it, she got her answer. “My people do not want to conquer your planet.” The alien cleared the air matter-of-factly. “And I just want to get back to my ship. To do that I need to see my pod, not sit here answering idiotic questions from some primitive local.”

“We’re not primitive!” Adora defended.

Catra looked up at the taxidermy. “Says a member of a species that mounts the heads of their victims on their walls.”

Adora's eyes went wide at the implication. “First off, those are animals, not people. Second, they’re pretty old and I actually think it’s pretty unsavory. My grandmother hunted when she was young. I tried to get my dad to take them down but he likes the *rustic aesthetic*. Plus, it apparently adds value to the cabin if we ever wanted to sell it so trust me you shouldn’t be worried about . . .” Adora’s rambling trailed off as she noticed Catra staring intensely at her. “What?” She asked. Catra’s seriousness broke after a second and she started laughing. Actually laughing. “What!?”

"You should see your face." Catra smirked at her. “Hey, Adora? Anybody every tell you you’re too serious?”

The whiplash of Catra’s tone threw Adora for a loop. “I think I have a right to be serious.” She said. “You . . . you were . . .”

Catra gestured over her shoulder. “Does the tree ‘add value’ too? That was surely a mighty hunt.”

“That’s . . . a cultural thing.” Adora insisted.

“Riiight.” Catra sassed, but when she found Adora still staring nervously at her, she got more serious, sighing. “If you’re so scared of me, then you should want to get me out of here as fast as possible, right? The best way to do that is help me.”

Adora’s scowl faded little, but. “I’m still not sure if I should.” She admitted.

Silence filled the empty cabin, and they stared at one another again. Then Catra huffed out a breath. “Fine. I’m sorry.”

“What?” Adora blinked.

“I’m sorry about the knife.” Catra repeated, glancing away. “That's what you wanted, isn’t it? Happy now?” Catra took a confident bite of her bacon to cap the sentence, but the effect was spoiled when her body betrayed her. Head twisting slightly, Catra did a double take, staring at the strip in front of her. She took a second tentative bite, then a third more eager one, then practically jammed the rest of it into her mouth in one go. She closed her glowing eyes with a full mouth and a blissful expression.

Adora, despite her fear, chuckled. *That* look, and the apology, made the idea of trusting her and helping her get home, more palatable. “Glad you like it.” Adora grabbed a deliciously greasy strip for herself. They ate on opposite sides of the counter until the light in the house suddenly increased. Catra looked behind her. The sun had crested the eastern ridge and lit the cabin and valley below. Adora blinked at the dawn, not quite sure how much sleep she had gotten, but knew it wasn’t enough.

Catra was out of the chair, having walked across the room to the floor to ceiling windows. Carefully, she put her hand up onto the glass.

The quiet reverence with which she watched the sunrise cast Catra in a third light. Knife-wielding psychopath? Sassy wisecrack? Lost castaway? Adora felt like she was still in a dream. She wondered again if Catra was as young as she looked as she pulled her hand off the cold window and rubbed her palm curiously. The pads of her fingers were hairless. Alone in a strange new world; Adora would be defensive too.

Maybe just maybe, she could get over the knife to the throat. “Welcome to Earth.”

Catra snapped out of her daze, looking back. “It’s very . . . white.”

Adora moved to stand nearer to her. The rolling prairie valley ran north-south and was one mile wide. The cabin was nearer the steeper western mountains. The eastern hills on the other hand, built up more slowly, and that was where the best snowmobile trails were. There were perhaps fifty cabins in the valley, then nothing for three miles south until its mouth, where the nearest 'real' town was. Real in this case meaning a population of 400. Following the blizzard, everything in sight was covered in snow, and the normal terrain, treeless, uneven, and interspersed with rocks, was brushed over smooth with an even frosting of white.

"Well yeah. Do you not have snow in space?" Adora asked, and Catra looked at her blankly. "Haha." She laughed in embarrassment. "Stupid question. I know there's no snow in space. Do you not have snow where you come from?”

"No." Catra replied. "It was always warmer."

“. . . Well, it's always warmer in most other places on Earth, but uhh . . . hey, what are you going to do?”

"Live somewhere else?" Catra offered, incredulous, blue and yellow eyes catching the snow-reflected sunrise.

"Maybe someday." Adora conceded. "But it's not my choice yet."

“Well, maybe you’re not a total idiot then.” Catra smirked. “You don’t live here by yourself?”

Adora considered lying about her family, but there seemed little reason for it. Trust, right? “This is my family’s vacation home, we come up here in the summer and winter.”

“Then where’s your family?” Catra asked, seemingly uncurious about the response.

“They had to go back before the storm yesterday, suddenly.” She said. “Want to go out there? See the snow?”

Catra pursed her lips, but nodded. Adora walked over to the door which opened to the deck. Her coat and snow pants were still in the washer being degooed, so she simply threw on some thick slippers and vowed not to stay out long. The door swung open, letting winter inside.

The morning was startlingly bright in the snow, and the wind was up. When it blew after a storm like this, all the freshly fallen icy particles were lifted off the ground, up into a mist which caught the sun, filling the air with light. Adora shivered, looking through the doorframe. The sky was clear save for a few thin high-altitude clouds. The new day sun was surrounded by a full rainbow, and amazingly, at the two points where the rainbow was parallel to the horizon, there were spots of shining sunlight, hanging in the air apart from the rest of the disc. Sure it was cold, but Catra could hardly have picked a better morning to arrive. It was beautiful out.

“Your world doesn’t have three suns.” The alien said, squinting up the ridge.

Adora let out an amused huff. "No. That's called a sundog."

If Catra found that term strange, she didn’t show it. Instead crouching down to reach outside and run her fingers through the snow, which had hardened somewhat during the night. She came away with a small snowball, which she crushed in her fingers, letting it crackle and spill out of her palm as she squeezed. White clung to the undersides of her claws.

When she rose again, there was a soft unfamiliar sound. Adora looked down to just catch the material of her skin suit retreat from her feet, seemingly flowing like a liquid up to her ankles. "Whoa." She breathed. The alien took a tentative step outside, making a pair of first footprints.

Adora joined her and closed the door behind, crossing the deck and brushing a section of the accumulated snow off the railing clear with a sleeve. She set her elbows down in the gap. Catra approached and did the same next to her, leaning forward with two feet between them. Adora looked over and saw Catra take a deep breath, tail curling and back arching slightly. When she exhaled, her breath fogged and she shut her eyes, seeming to simply revel in the open air. Despite still being a stranger who'd sort of tried to kill her, Adora felt a moment of connection with Catra. When was the last time she had breathed open air? The human wondered. When Catra opened her eyes again, the human saw less of a scary, uncanny, inhuman alien, and more just a wary, sassy, cat-eared girl. Hehe, cat-girl.

"Well?" Adora encouraged an opinion. Not often you got first impressions on an entire planet.

Catra seemed to find the question a little chintzy, judging by the look Adora received, but answered regardless. "I've been to uglier ones." She wriggled her toes, then lifted her feet off the snow one at a time to re-encapsulate them in the strange material her suit was made of.

"Is that thing warm, by the way?"

"No." Catra admitted, tail tucking around her waist. "My ship was an oven inside; this thing is better at keeping me cool."

"But I thought it was really cold in space." Adora revealed her ignorance.

"It isn't anything in space. No atmosphere, no temperature. But sunlight heats up the hull, and it's hard to get rid of it once it's inside. Can't just turn on a big fan and blow it away."

"Huh." Adora nodded.

Then, more seriously, Catra asked again. "I need to see my escape pod. Will you help me?"

Adora straightened a little. "I will.” She decided. “But I'm not sure it's still there. The government, the one that runs this part of the planet, might have come and taken it away by now." At least they do in movies.

"Will that make a difference until we check?" Catra returned.

Adora didn't see why it would.

Ten minutes later, Catra was bundled up in an eclectic collection of spare winter clothes Adora had managed to find around the cabin. This included a hoodie and pajama pants to go over her skin-suit, an extra pair of her father’s ski pants (which were the right length), gloves, a pair of boots that were way too big for her feet, only held on by two layers of fluffy socks (also over her skin suit), a turquoise, black, yellow, and hot pink ski jacket that couldn't have been more 1995, and-

"Helmet." Adora passed the black dome to her. Catra looked skeptical after so many layers.

“Spacesuit’s more complicated.” She muttered as she pulled it over her head.

"Does that . . . hurt your ears?" Adora asked, concerned. They had been pressed down, little fluffy tufts sticking out of the bottom of the helmet.

Catra's nose scrunched up through the visor slot. "I'll be fine."

"Alright." Adora conceded, not entirely convinced. "It's not a long ride anyway. Plus, now you pass as human." She moved to hit the garage door opener, trying not to look at the pile of snow that had half melted on the concrete overnight. It thankfully hadn’t spread far enough to soak anything that could be soaked, but still. A problem for when they got back.

“Is that important? To look human?” Catra inquired.

“Not here it isn’t. I’m the only one for miles.” Don’t remind her or yourself of how far help is Adora, she thought as she sat down on the Polaris.

“Wow, glad I got lucky then and landed next to a dork who doesn’t care.” Catra said, surely smirking beneath the helmet.

Mmm. Alright, if the sass wasn’t going to go away. “You’re lucky you landed near someone that won’t force you to walk for that comment.” Adora replied with a smile of her own.

Catra rolled her eyes, revealing two little crescents of whites when she did. Oh, so they were just really big irises. “At least then I would have some peace and quiet.”

Adora chuffed in annoyance at being teased, but she couldn’t quite bring herself to force Catra to walk. "Hop on." She tapped behind her.

Catra slid onto the seat, a gap between them. “Where can I hold on?”

Adora hesitated, this would be the first time Catra touched her again. “My waist, if you want.” She consented, then pressed the ignition. The machine sprung to life, filling the echoey concrete garage with a roar.

“Hey, Adora? What does this thing run on!?” Catra asked, voice lifting an octave.

"Gasoline."

The concern in Catra's voice grew with her sarcasm. "Highly flammable petroleum byproduct, great."

Adora was rapidly learning what kind of a person Catra was. "Anyone ever tell you you're a bit of a downer?" She snarked.

"Anyone ever tell you your planet is savage and backwards?" Catra chirped back.

"Mmm, at least once." Adora revved the engine, and rolled out as quickly as she dared onto the snow. The yelp she received at the sudden motion was satisfying, and an instant later Catra's puffy coat arms were around her waist. For a split second, Adora's mind showed her the strength of those arms holding her down in the dark. She shook her head and set off.

As they drove the ten minutes back to the crash site, Adora realized that she hadn't thought about what the government's reaction to all this would be. She hadn't exactly covered her tracks last night. If they suspected she was harboring an alien . . .

Images of *E.T.* and *Close Encounters* flashed in her mind. Of Catra being dissected on a table. Level of trust notwithstanding, if Adora had learned anything about Catra, it was that she was a person. No person deserved that. Another thing to be wary about, this one for both their sakes.

She rumbled up to the ridge slowly, stopping short. Dismounting, Adora said, "Keep your helmet on until we're sure we're alone." Catra nodded, and they snuck up.

Crouching, the unlikely pair peeked their eyes over the top of the snow drifts and looked down into the valley. Catra whistled. "Well, I made an impression."

Indeed. Though the fires had gone out in the night, the destruction was much more clearly visible now. At least two dozen trees in the pocket forest had been totally destroyed, and probably three times that many were missing tops or large numbers of branches. Looking down the path that had been cleared by the impact, it was easy to see the escape pod in the depths of the clearing.

"It's still there." Adora stated the obvious, mostly out of surprise. She hadn't heard any activity before she'd fallen asleep last night. No helicopters or tanks. But still, was she really the only one who had noticed this?

“Mmm.” Catra acknowledged. “We good?”

Adora couldn’t see anyone else around, nor any footprints other than her own mostly snowed-in ones from last night. “Yeah, let’s go.”

They rode down into the valley and bushwhacked through the bare branches, coming up to the monolithic gray object again. Adora hung back, aweing at it in the light as Catra trudged ahead, heading for the hatch she had emerged out of. The whole thing was listing forward, nose buried slightly in the frozen earth, the rear stuck up. It was like some great bullet, shot from China, had landed here and slid to a stop.

“Hey!” Catra called, and Adora stopped staring at the rear baffled parts that she now recognized as some kind of strange engines or air brakes and followed.

Surprisingly, the sticky green liquid hadn’t frozen overnight and still lay exposed in snowy pools around the empty hatch. “What is this stuff?” Adora dipped the toe of her boot in a puddle, lip curling in revulsion at how it clung when she pulled it away again.

“Gee-shock fluid.” Catra explained, not looking back. “It stopped me from turning into a fine red mist on impact.” Adora’s eyes widened at that grisly image and she felt her distaste for the slime abate a little. It wasn’t the fall that killed you after all . . . “Towel?”

Adora lifted one off the stack she had brought with them and passed it to Catra, who approached the main hatch and draped it over the entrance. She pulled off her helmet and set it in the snow, took another towel and a flashlight, then with a nod and limberness that surprised Adora, leapt up back inside her pod. “So, what’s the goal here?” Adora asked, peeking into the dark interior after her. “Fly away in this thing?”

“Nope, ‘this thing’ is only good for falling in. I have to contact my ship.” Catra clicked the flashlight on. “Make sure they’re not dead.

Then they can pick me up."

Adora activated her own flashlight and swept it through the interior of the pod. But if she was expecting a shining silver Buck Rodgers cabin, she was sorely disappointed. It was a maze of bulbous dark green panels, interwoven pipes, and complex machinery, all practically bursting from every wall. Honestly, it was a cramped oppressive mess. But Adora supposed if it was an emergency lifeboat it didn't need to be pretty. She reached for her phone and started taking pictures regardless. "How are you going to do that?"

"Subspace radio." Catra's voice echoed back.

Adora's flashlight found two rows of six seats jammed in the main area of the pod. Not exactly first-class legroom either. "Were you alone when you came down?"

"Yeah." The alien replied, and Adora's light moved over to find Catra sitting up near the nose of the pod in what was definitely the pilot's seat. With the flashlight in her mouth and a towel over the seat, she tapped away at a menagerie of switches and dead screens. Above her, something Adora hadn't noticed from the outside, a curved triangular window looked forward and upwards, mostly coated in a thick layer of gray soot. "I got there first. Tried to wait for others, but some kind of automatic failsafe triggered. The door shut and shot me off. The force threw my head against a wall." She rapped the nearest pipe with her knuckles. "I woke up with you."

"I'm sorry Catra. Does that mean that the rest of your crew might not have-"

"There were other escape pods. They got out." Her tone left no room for doubt.

"Right." Adora dropped it, not wanting to judge where she had no business judging or upset where she had no want for upsetting. She continued to look at the interior of the pod, even briefly

considering clambering in after Catra to explore before remembering that literally everything in there was sticky. She did be sure to snap a picture of Catra sitting in the chair above however, broken beams of sunlight striking her wild hair through the blackened window.

"And that's even if the ship was totally lost, which I doubt." Catra continued. "That thing is a tough bucket." She angrily jabbed a button three times in a row. "But **this** damn thing's not working!" She kicked a screen.

"What's wrong with it?"

"No power." She grumbled, jumping out of the chair and sliding down the angled floor to mess with something. "This might take a while."

Adora understood. "I'll keep watch." And turned to begin walking around the escape pod, eyes open for any curious locals or big scary tanks. She documented the site with her phone, snapping pictures of the broken trees, of the escape pod itself from all angles, of the gee-shock liquid. Bow would get a kick out of all of this. Hell, he would have a whole god-damned Olympic kickboxing tournament over it. Was kickboxing an Olympic sport? Whatever. She tried to imagine the look on his face if he met Catra. "Least I have pictures to prove I'm not crazy." She noted, checking some of the shots. They were fine, if looking like something taken at a crime scene. Adora suddenly realized that it was possible that Catra's people could pick her up immediately. This whole ordeal could be in and out of her life without Adora getting possibly the most brag-worthy picture of all. "Umm Catra!?" She hollered back into the pod. "Can I ask a question?"

"Yeah!?" Came the annoyed response.

"When you're done with this and not sticky, could you do an Earth thing with me?"

“What? Sure! Whatever!” She snarled back, obviously angry at the pod and not her. Apparently, it wasn’t going well.

Nearly twenty minutes later this was confirmed when Catra emerged and sat on the hatch frame, fur and neon jacket mattered with goo. “How bad?” Adora asked, balling up another snowball and trying to strike a tree twenty paces away she had been trying to hit for the past thirty snowballs.

“Bad.” Catra tried futilely to wipe her face off with a washcloth. “The generator won’t start, and the primers are blown.” She paused, gripping the edge of the hatch very tightly. “Which means . . . it’s dead.”

Adora turned, and saw the young alien looking . . . shaken. Already it was almost shocking seeing Catra without a cocksure smirk. Adora sympathized. She didn’t know what to say though, at her being potentially stranded. So, she said the only thing you could say when there weren’t any better words. “I’m sorry.”

Catra jumped down. “Gee thanks.” She said sarcastically.

“Is there anything you can do?” She returned to throwing snowballs. That Catra was stressed seemed an understatement. Adora often found it easier to work through a problem when she had something to do with her hands, even if it wasn’t related. Also looking at Catra being stressed made her stressed.

“I don’t know, maybe!? I'm not an engineer!" Catra hissed. "I was never really good at all this stuff, technical stuff."

Adora nailed the tree on the next throw. Me neither, she thought. “Not a linguist, a diplomat, or an engineer.” She noted with a smirk, hoping to lighten the mood. “What are you good at?”

Catra threw her hands up for a second, then paused, and looked at Adora as she balled another snowball and turned away. When Adora looked back, Catra’s pupils were very narrow and catlike. She didn’t notice the balled-up projectile until it was already flying right at her head. “Taking action!” Catra declared.

Adora squawked as white powder exploded in her hood, filling every line and crease in her face with stinging freezing snow-burn. Terror gripped Adora, and she tensed for the inevitable mortal wound that was about to come. But it didn't come. Instead Catra was howling with laughter, voice snapping up and down, clutching her chest. It took the alien several seconds to calm down, and not a second too soon as a white streak rushed back at her. "Augh!" The alien barely dodged. "**Hey!**"

Adora wiped the melting snow off her face. The adrenaline spike fading into a competitive smile. Maybe that was why she decided that it wasn't worth scolding Catra for nearly giving her a heart attack. She had a better idea. "If you're not prepared to take it." She tossed a second snowball up from her hand like a baseball, "Don't dish it out." and wound back for another throw. This one scored on Catra's torso, splattering in a satisfying way.

The alien looked at herself, then back with those narrow eyes again, which she now recognized as focus, and maybe a little mischief. "Oh, it is so on!"

The fight was less lopsided than Adora would have liked, considering she had however many years since she could throw a snowball's experience over Catra, who had literally devastated her with her first attempt. But as white cannonballs and, to Adora's surprise soon after, laughter crisscrossed the broken clearing around the fallen spaceship, she was happy with landing more hits than she received. Catra's left leg, right shoulder, then Adora got caught on her arm. She scored back two against Catra's torso. The alien got her in the stomach.

Finally, Adora caught Catra in the neck, and she squeaked with surprise. Freezing like a statue before, after a moment cringing, revealed. "Oh stars, it's inside my clothes!"

"Do you yield!?" Adora shouted from her hiding spot behind a fallen tree, a stack of five at the ready should she decide to prolong the war.

“I yield I yield!” Catra surrendered, putting her hands up on her head and dropping her final weapon.

Adora beamed and emerged onto their impromptu battlefield as Catra knocked snow from her hood. Her ears twitched as it flew out and onto the ground, tips catching little flakes. “Now, only because I am gracious in victory will I admit that I had a worthy opponent.” The human assured.

“Naturally.” Catra tipped her head. “How do you put up with this stuff all the time?”

“We only have to for part of the year actually.” Adora explained as she dusted herself off, a smile persistently sticking to her face. It was the first time she had really smiled since yesterday morning. “All this snow will melt in a few months, and the ground will be exposed again.”

“Hmm.”

“Yeah, we definitely wouldn’t live here if it was like this all year round.” Adora assured. “But at least it’s good for a fun distraction, right?”

Catra’s own faint smile suddenly vanished. “Yeah.” She said, turning back to face the escape pod.

“What now?”

Catra sighed. “The stars damned emergency manual says I’m going to have to pull the whole radio out and try and fix it that way. Can it stay somewhere in that house you live in?”

"It's not radioactive or anything right? Or going to kill us?” Adora asked. When Catra assured her that it wouldn’t, she consented, and another twenty minutes later a hunk of green machinery about the size of a carry-on suitcase fell out of the hatch and into the snow.

There was a panel on one side that was definitely the front, with dials and knobs and little screens mounted on it, all that same sickly shade of khaki green. The back was an absolute rat's nest of wires and pipes and things Adora couldn't guess the function of.

Catra leapt down after it, holding an object that looked kind of like a briefcase in each hand. "Let's get going."

"I can't haul all this back with us at once." Adora rubbed the back of her neck, trying to figure out where she would strap a space radio down. "We'll have to make two trips."

"Radio first." Catra immediately decided.

"Alright."

Together, gloves slipping on the heavy thing, they hauled it back to the snowmobile, and with Adora's flakey knowledge of knots and the length of rope always kept under the seat, they soon had it precariously strapped down where Catra had sat on the ride over. Adora insisted on a towel over the top to hide the strange technology. Chances were slim that they would be spotted, but still.

"Do. Not. Let it fall." Catra warned seriously.

"I won't." Adora insisted. "You're sure it's not radioactive or anything?" She asked for the fourth time.

"Yes." Catra returned for the fourth time. "Now go! Before I freeze to death." Catra shoved her forward lightly.

Adora shook her head with a smile, catching herself on the snowmobile's handlebars. "Be back soon." She jumped on and started the careful journey back to the cabin, going slow.

Adora realized halfway back that she hadn't minded the shove. Actually, it had been pretty endearing. Adora wracked her brain as she dragged the magic alien radio thingy into the garage. Catra

had been endearing. Was that worrying? She acknowledged now that the alien seemed much more like a kid who dropped out and wandered the streets than a psychopath. But that still put her into the zone of ‘people Mom and Dad don’t want me to associate with’. She really probably shouldn’t talk to her any more than she had to, and yet as soon as Adora spotted Catra, her cases, and their towels as she got back near the pod, a little smile slipped back onto her face. Was Catra someone she could call a friend?

Adora pulled to a stop and lifted her visor, asking. "May I take your bags, sir?”

"I’m fine.” Catra slipped on the snowmobile, wedging the cases between the two of them.

Whoosh. Adora thought. "What are those things?"

"Show you when we get back." She said mysteriously, and wouldn't give any more. So Adora shook her head and flipped her visor down, making the drive for the sixth time in twelve hours. God she was still really tired.

Inside the house they both pulled off their outer layers and once everything that was sticky was in the washing machine, she did chores in the basement as Catra began to tinker with the radio. Adora mopped the floor of any melted snow, set up the space heater to dry what had soaked in, and refilled the Polaris with gas, checking the oil while she was there.

Once that was done, Adora looked at the green cases, but her eyelids were more powerful than her curiosity. She was going to fall over if she didn’t get some rest. Instinct made her dislike the idea of leaving Catra alone in the basement, but then she thought of the way she laughed as she’d jumped over a snowball, her big mismatched eyes sparkling.

“Where are you going?” Catra looked up from the fresh towel she was sitting on, surrounded by alien tech, as Adora headed for the mudroom.

"To bed. I'm exhausted Catra."

"Is that a thing for your species? We just got up."

"You didn't stare at a mysterious unconscious alien for hours before falling asleep. And the things said alien did after they woke up didn't exactly help." Catra hardly reacted to that second part. Adora sighed. "Promise not to blow up the house with that thing?"

She considered, then shrugged. "Sure, yeah."

Adora raised an eyebrow. "Promise not to blow up the house with **anything** at all while I'm asleep?"

Catra considered for longer this time, longer than necessary. "Alright, will do." She smiled.

Adora flashed a thumbs up, not caring if it was a rude gesture in her culture. "Thank you. My bedroom's last on the left. There's food in the cupboard. Turn off that space heater if you come upstairs. Wake me when you need me, and make sure you don't need me for at least six hours." She saluted limply and headed for crashville.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None.

And that’s Chapter 2! Thank you all for the warm reception last time! It’s super encouraging to hear your kind words!

Also, I’ve upgraded the archive warning to ‘Graphic Depictions of Violence’ out of an abundance of caution. Nothing is going to get bad (i.e. only some blood on top of the already stated canon typical violence), but I don’t want anyone to be surprised going in.

Chapter 3: Cabin Fever

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Hey, Adora.” The human felt a poke in the thigh. “Hey.” Adora mumbled something back; she forgot what it was immediately. Catra was probably staring at her. Yes, she was a messy sleeper. It was impossible to deny. Her family loved to joke about the splayed limbs and tangled blankets. But it wasn’t like she could control it! “Hey.” Adora got a louder call.

“Nooo . . .” Adora groaned, rolling over. “Five more minutes.”

Catra said something quietly, Adora caught the word ‘pampered’, before she shouted “Wake up!” in time with a sharp jab in the same spot.

“Wha-” She jostled awake, eyes opening to see, yep, Catra staring down at her from the bedside. “Umm . . . hi.” She greeted, quickly grabbing her phone and glancing at the clock. Catra had actually waited the requested time before bothering her. “What’s up?”

“Do you have any electricity?” Catra asked.

Adora sat up, blinking. She resisted looking up at the lamp on her bedside. “Yeah . . .” She nodded, reaching up to begin putting her tangled locks into poof and ponytail. “How much do you need?”

“Like enough to power this house.”

“I suppose you could use the generator.” Adora pursed her lips, taking a better look at Catra and realizing she was covered in filth. Black oil-like stains mattered her fur, and in other places, it glistened with gee shock liquid. “You’re tracking grime everywhere!” She stood up, looking at the dark footprints on the carpet in horror. “What happened!?”

“I had to disassemble part of the radio.” Catra replied easily. “By the way can you show me where that food you made for me earlier is?”

The sigh was deep and echoed through the house. “Come on. I will, *after* I show you the shower.”

Honestly, Adora should have expected it, but Catra was not thrilled that the most common form of human washing involved water being sprayed onto you. “Look, just . . . you can just stand there for a minute. You don’t even have to use anything! Just wash it off your skinsuit!” She shouted through the closed door and crashing of soap bottles. “Just . . . relax!”

“Why is the water thing mounted on a hook?” Catra asked. Oh no.

There was a shriek followed by the sound of the detachable showerhead spraying in all directions. The ceiling was definitely wet now. Adora then heard what she could only assume was the shower curtain and rod ripping off the wall and clattering to the ground with a tangled-up cat inside. “Eff me.” She set her forehead against the door.

After forcing Catra to help her clean up everything she had spilled (the shower curtain rod would have to be screwed back into the wall at some point when she wasn’t dealing with Catra’s ignorance), they headed for the kitchen. Once there, Adora rubbed her eyes and hoped she was still dreaming. It was even more of a disaster than the bathroom. Boxes of various foodstuffs were scattered all over the countertop, some opened with whatever was inside scattered everywhere. “*Catra.*” Adora growled.

"I couldn't find anything to eat." She explained behind her.

“I . . .” Adora bunched her fists, vibrating for a moment before exhaling. “will make you something.” She stacked cans and reboxed unopened granola bars. Was this worse than their first encounter? Probably not, but still. It was halfway through

restocking the pantry when she found a torn open bag of flour. "Did you . . . did you try to eat this!?" She held it up.

"No!” The alien defended; arms crossed. “I tried to drink it. Duh.” Adora's eyes widened, and Catra wiped her lips with her wrist. "Didn't taste good." There was a glass on the counter with a thick milk-like substance in it. She'd tried to mix it like Kool-Aid.

Yeah, from now on brunch - Lunch? Dinner? Linner? the second meal of the day - was Adora’s responsibility. Scouring the depths of the cupboards, her delving eyes landed on some unfrozen tortillas. “Tacos.” She decreed and pulled out ingredients. Again, Adora insisted Catra help for all the trouble she’d caused, and threw a couple comments about how it was important to be a respectful guest in human culture on for good measure. Catra gave her a stubborn glare for it, but her ears drooped and she browned the meat without complaint. That meant she was probably at least a little guilty of the mess, right? Adora was guessing, being the alien body language expert she apparently was.

After her job was done, Catra watched Adora work, awkwardly crouching heels-down on a stool again.

"Do you not have chairs in space?" Adora asked when it became unbearable not to. Catra didn't seem to understand. So, Adora walked over and demonstrated the proper technique. The alien squinted, but then mimed it and parked her butt, tail poking through the back slats.

Adora reached over at some point and turned on the big old countertop radio, which happily played country music through the cabin. She didn't even have to tune it to find the station because, in the valley, 101.7 THE RANCHER was the only radio station.

It was oddly domestic, her chopping peppers, lettuce, and olives and giving them to Catra to taste test. The day was bright but clouding over. The house was warm. The embers of last night’s fire were still smoldering despite how Adora felt like she’d lit it

weeks ago. Catra didn’t mind the first two ingredients but made her feelings very clear about the last. Adora sliced just enough for herself. Soon taco assembly into their warm microwaved flour shells was almost complete.

“Here.” Adora passed her the hot sauce last. “Put a bit of this on too, adds some pizazz.” Catra glanced at the bottle then shrugged, pouring a couple glugs over top. “Now you just roll it up.” Adora helped her fold, watching eagerly as she bit into the end.

“Hmm.” Catra said, chewing a little. “This is . . . oh . . .” The chewing slowed. “Ohh . . .” Her face began to pucker, and she swallowed. “This is . . . pahh!” She opened her mouth and stuck her tongue out, suddenly panting. “Aglfh!” She nearly gagged. “Agh Sthars!” She jumped backwards off the stool, clutching her throat as it clattered to the floor. “Makh it stalph!”

Adora laughed a little. “Not used to spicy?” But the humor rapidly faded as the pain in Catra’s face rapidly twisted into panic. She stumbled around aimlessly, rubbing her tongue with one hand. “Hey, are you okay!?”

“Makh-” Catra started then realized her hand was still on her tongue. “This hurts! Make it stop!”

“Umm.” Adora stood as well, running closer to Catra, trying to see her tongue. Crap crap crap. Please say I didn’t just poison her. Please say this is just the hot sauce. “Uhh . . . crap okay. It’ll pass soon! Don’t worry. Umm . . . how do you feel?” Adora’s hands had come up into the air in front of her, as if to grab the problem and somehow stop it.

Catra backed into one of the couches. "Adora, I'm dying!"

"Don't exaggerate stuff like that!" She cried back. "I want to know if I've accidentally poisoned you!"

"Well, it feels like you poisoned me!" She shot back.

"Look, milk helps with spiciness but-"

"But what!?"

"But you're probably lactose intolerant!" Most humans were lactose intolerant like Bow, and Catra was an alien!

"Will it kill me if I am?"

"Nooo . . ." Adora guessed, deeply unsure. “Probably?”

"Then I don't care!"

Adora ran for the fridge and grabbed a glass and the jug of milk. Catra ripped the latter right out of her hands and just started slamming it back. Some spilled onto the floor but the deep sigh of relief she made was all Adora needed to know that it was working. “Stars Adora,” She gasped. “never give me that stuff again.”

“Noted.” The human exhaled, heart still racing, very glad that this didn’t seem to bring out knife-wielding Catra. Maybe they were getting closer.

“Your species eats that stuff for fun!?” She glanced at the hot sauce bottle with wide eyes.

“That was actually pretty mild.” Adora admitted. The look Catra gave her at that realization was pretty funny, and Adora laughed a little. “You should be glad you didn’t land in India; I didn’t realize you were such a lightweight!”

“I didn’t realize your species downed military-grade weapons like candy!” She cried, then tilted her head at the milk, taking a second swig. “But this stuff ain’t half bad.”

Forty minutes later Catra vomited the milk and the rest of what she had eaten back up again.

“I swear Adora, as soon as I can I am going to destroy all of that white poisoHughhH!” Adora cringed and tried to block out the horrible liquid splashing sound that came out of the bathroom.

“Sorry!” She called, again. Alright: no dairy, no spicy foods. She would make something else for dinner. Maybe bacon again, and nothing else until Catra left.

When Catra’s stomach was empty and then gingerly refilled with bacon, they returned to the basement. Adora rolled out a large tarp for Catra to work on, and she watched the open the first of the two green briefcases, revealing a tool kit and an actual physical repair manual. She began to detach the front panel of the machine. Adora looked down at the book with a raised eyebrow. "You really use a physical thing even though you're from space?" She asked, taking in the angular squiggling glyphs that was their writing and the even more complicated-looking technical diagrams below.

"What else would we use?" Catra asked.

"I don't know, some fancy hologram thing?"

"Holograms are gimmicks." She muttered. "Physical copies don't run out of battery. Don't break."

That was true. She supposed if she had a hologram, then the hologram would need a physical repair manual of its own.

In their last phone call, Adora’s family told her they would be back at the cabin in two days. Catra assured that she should be able to fix the radio before that time, hook it up to the cabin’s generator, and use it to contact her ship. They would pick her up; Adora would collect her ‘E.T. Go Home’ merit badge and thus avoid a **weird** conversation. So, two days with Catra. Two days to spend time with an actual alien and learn about the universe from them. There were worse prison sentences.

Adora realized this was the perfect time to multitask. She ran upstairs and came back down with her math and Spanish packets that needed doing before school started again. If she could finish them, then all her time could be spent bothering Catra with ‘idiotic

questions from a primitive local'. So, with a foldout table, her winter coat, and her nose to the grindstone, she worked, exchanging conversation with Catra, enraptured as the alien painted a picture of her coalition's various species and planets in detail. Weaving a complex tapestry of life among the stars. From gruff towering lizard-like people and sinuous squid people, to small mumbling species that floated around wearing billowing cloaks, working on technology that sounded like magic to Adora. Towering cities on jewel-like words around alien suns. Arcologies and starships, space stations made from hollowed-out asteroids filled with air and greenery, where you could look up and see the opposite side above you. Politics and business, doctors and engineers. The realization that it was all just **out there**, an entire interstellar civilization, made Adora feel very small in a deeply exciting, humbling way.

Solve for x using the quadratic equation.

"What are your people called anyway? Ooo, and what's your ship called?"

"We're called the Horde. My ship is the Fright Zone."

Adora's face twisted slightly. "The Horde? Fright Zone? Not very . . . optimistic, is it?"

Catra sighed as if finding it exhausting to explain all this. "Translators can give bad results both ways. There aren't always words in your language that give you the right context." Adora nodded, wondering if every time she talked Catra was hearing her voice in an alien language. That would be really cool. "Fright Zone is like . . . a place you've discovered where you're humbled by it. Something so huge you cower before it!" She ended the sentence with mock gravitas, clear she didn't find the name's intent very inspiring.

"Like awesome?" Adora asked. "Like as in literally awe-striking?"

"Yeah?" Neither seemed too confident.

“Who decided on Fright Zone?” Adora smirked. “Doesn’t seem like the branding is working well.”

Catra’s face sank. “The Captain: Shadow Weaver.”

"Ooo." Adora grimaced, noting the way her lip curled. "You don't like them, do you?"

"Ohhoho no. Shadow Weaver’s a bitch."

"Shadow Weaver? You sure you're the good guys?" She elbowed her in the ribs.

"Shut up! Your planet's called Earth! I mean, come on. Naming a planet after dirt."

“It's self-explanatory!" Adora cried, defending it for some reason. "Fine. What's your planet called?"

"Beast Island."

Adora snorted.

"Bad translation!" Catra justified.

Write the two potential pairs of values of x and y from the following equation.

In return, Adora told Catra about the Earth and humanity. The questions, now that she was settled in and rested, poured out of her. Questions about the climate, nature, animals, and plants. Questions about her species, their biology, cultures, habits. Adora was impressed by how quickly she was asking smarter more nuanced questions. But if the countries never agree then does that mean this United Whatever thing barely works? Yes. What happens when it doesn’t? Wars. Humans thankfully didn’t fight as many as they used to, but they happened. Adora tried to convey everything in a truthful but also optimistic light. Yes, humanity was flawed, and dangerous, and inclined to profound acts of stupidity (including an obsession with capsaicin, apparently). But

things were getting better. Adora wasn't sure she had faith in everybody, individually. But she did have faith in everyone, collectively. More good was being put into the world than evil every day, by lots of people, and as good begot good, it was slowly adding up, compounding on itself. Adora believed that very strongly, and hoped Catra understood why.

Conjugate the verb 'correr'.

"How old are you?" Adora tried to ask casually.

"35." She replied. Adora's eyes widened. "In standard years, obviously." She added at the reaction, pairing it with another one of those 'you're an idiot' looks that somehow didn't make her feel bad about it. "How long are the years on this planet?"

"365 days."

"And we're about halfway through a day?"

"Yeah, but the nights are longer in winter. Since the sun came up has been about a third of a day."

Catra nodded, then took a long moment to count with her fingers, making the conversion. "Bout 16 then? 17 maybe? Like I said, not good at math."

They were the same age, and the realization came with words from Adora's mouth she wasn't expecting. "I'm sorry."

Catra blinked, and for an instant seemed disarmed. "What?"

"I'm . . ." Wait why did she say that? She sputtered on. "I mean, you're so young" God no, that made her sound like her mother. "-to be serving on a starship. I just became old enough to get any kind of job, and you've already got like . . . a career at the same age."

Catra looked back at her radio. "I had to grow up fast."

Write a paragraph en Español about a recent vacation you took.

“Damn it's cold in here.” Adora pulled her coat around her a little tighter.

“You’re the one that lives here and you’re complaining about it. What, your species gotten so used to automatic heating you can’t live outside anymore?”

“I can survive.” Adora pouted. “But it's nicer when it's warm.”

“Then go upstairs.”

Adora met her smarmy eyes but didn’t move, looking back down at her packet.

Write a paragraph describing the person in this picture.

By noon Adora slammed her pencil down, beaming. “DONE!” She announced, kicking her feet up and cockily crossing her arms.

“Sorry?” Catra looked up from her work. She had oil on her face again.

“As of this moment, I am done with everything I need to get done before my break. Which means!” She jumped up. “I can help you full-time.”

Catra looked left and right, as if that comment might be targeted at someone else around. “Thanks?”

“You’re welcome.” She nodded. “So! First, is there anything I can do to help with . . . all’a’this?” She waved a palm at the radio situation going on before her.

“Can you read this?” Catra held up her alien handbook.

“No.”

“Then no, not really. I could use a finger to hold some wires now and again though.”

“Then I will do that!” Adora jammed a finger at the sky. “Whenever you need to.” Adora walked over and sat cross-legged near Catra, watching her work with her strange tools with glowing tips on her strange machine. “Just let me know.”

It was about an hour before Catra let her know. The boredom had just about killed her but this was to help someone in need, and holding some wires out of the way was kind of cool, she guessed. It was literally alien technology. The machine was even more of a rat’s nest inside than out, and Adora wondered how anyone could wrap their head around it.

Reconnecting something that the alien had taken out, Catra told Adora they could test it out. This was something she could do! Adora helped wheel the generator into the middle of the room, connecting it to the points on the back of the radio, and fired it up. She flashed a thumbs up, and Catra took a breath and flipped an important-looking switch. Strangely Adora didn’t so much hear anything as feel it. Deep in her gut, and yet coming from everywhere and nowhere, there was a nauseating vibrating sensation, like someone had put her soul on a shake table. She wobbled slightly, reaching for her stomach. “Is it working!?” The human asked over the generator, woozy.

“No.” Catra turned it off again. “That’s just background noise. It’s not doing anything.”

“Background noise feels weird.” Adora noted, blinking a few times before shutting the generator down.

“You get used to it.” Catra admitted, then glanced at Adora to confirm that she wanted more details. “How to I explain this?” She grumbled as they both sat, reaching for another tool to re-disconnect whatever subsystem that was. “It’s basically like sea legs. Once you’ve been on a boat long enough you learn to walk with the waves.”

“Boats? I thought you lived on a starship?” Adora asked.

Catra chuffed like she was an idiot. “I grew up on an island.”

“Wait really?”

“I had to grow up somewhere.” Catra said.

Adora nudged her with her foot. “Duh . . . tell me about it?”

“About what?”

“How cold your butt is right now, what else?” Adora replied sarcastically. “Your home Catra. I’m curious what it’s like.”

“Oh.” Catra replied, and her hands worked through a silent beat. “It was alright. Better than a lot of other places, I guess. Warm sand, bright suns-light, green water, blue frond trees.”

“Mmm . . . family?”

Catra immediately froze, and Adora immediately regretted asking. “No.”

“I’m sorry.”

“You didn’t know.”

It was shocking how vulnerable she sounded in that moment. Even the tiny three-word sentence, spoken with a mildly open tone, was like looking into an open wound. Adora began to think it was unlike her, then realized that maybe how she presented herself all the time was unlike her. Cats with more than one life? She wondered.

Catra growled and reached into the radio, grabbing a part with two hands. With a heave, it came out of its slot. Alien curses rumbled under her voice as she inspected it, glancing over to reference the book.

"Hey." Adora called her eyes. “You got this; you know? I bet you’ll get this thing picking up Jimmy Buffett in another few hours,

tops.”

Catra’s tail puffed up slightly. Removing another big panel, She asked. “Hey, Adora? I know you want to help but I really need to focus here, so maybe if you could . . .”

The human was up like she was sitting on a spring. “I understand!” She assured with a smile, putting her hands up. “Yep. Totally get it. I’ll . . . I’ll give you some space.” She speed walked for the stairs, hands wringing.

A few hours later, Adora sat up from her spot on the – now designated in her mind – ‘knife attack’ couch to Catra coming up with the second briefcase. Kicking it across the hardwood floor towards her, it spun satisfyingly as it slid to a stop at her side. “Open it.” She encouraged.

Adora grabbed the handle, moving to lift it onto the coffee table, but was amazed by the weight. “Jesus Christ.” She groaned, needing two hands and a good heave to get it up there. “How were you carrying this so easily?” Catra just smiled – all teeth – walking over to sit (like a human) on the armrest as Adora found the latch and lifted the lid, eyes going very wide. “So yeah,” Catra continued, monotone. “thanks for saving my life or whatever, you can have what you want out of this.”

“Catra . . .” Adora reached in and pulled out one of dozens of bars of metal the size of her palm from the felt-covered slots. Its weight and bold yellow color made it clear: it was solid gold. “This is crazy.” There were at least fifty slips of a similar size in the box; of various metals and other materials. Many were silvery, and as she picked more up, she could only guess which was silver and which was platinum. “This. Is. Crazy.”

“They include these boxes in all escape pods, in case you need to barter with primitive locals. No offense.”

“None taken.” Adora whispered back. She had never held this much gold at once. Never seen this much gold at once. Each bar, she didn’t know the exact rate, was certainly worth tens of thousands of dollars. “Catra this stuff is worth more than this house!”

Each bar was the same size, but different materials were embossed with a different pattern of lines, hatches, waves, corkscrewing spirals. Everything was marked except the gemstones, and oh my God, the gemstones. Adora reached down and picked up one of four huge clear gemstones the size of an apple, cube-shaped with beveled edges. “Is this a diamond?” She gawked.

“Yep.”

Adora very carefully put it back into its slot, to stop her shaking hands from dropping it. That one was worth hundreds of millions of dollars, at least. “Catra this is worth enough so that me and several generations of my family never have to work again. I . . . I didn’t do anything to deserve this!”

“Anything? What, like saving my life?” Catra asked.

“That’s not what I meant.”

“I never really got this part.” Catra reached in and grabbed one of the diamond cubes, casually tossing it up into the air and catching it again. “I mean it’s just some rocks.”

It took a lot of willpower to resist stopping her. “Rare rocks. Useful rocks. Circuit boards and stuff. It is surprising they have value?”

“I can toss my garbage into a chute in my bunk wall and ask the unit to turn it into gold for me.” She explained. “Just fuses it all together.”

If only it were that easy. “Thank you Catra, for this. It’s . . . it’s really going to help my family.” No more worrying about her college fund. Holy crap.

“I don’t need it.” Catra declared, setting the gem down and going for the kitchen. Food was more valuable to her in this situation. She came back with a granola bar.

As Catra snacked and Adora came down from her ‘suddenly stupid rich’ high, she asked. “Don’t you have a space radio to fix?”

Catra swallowed and pulled something from where the skinsuit had been holding it behind her back. It flowed out of the way to show Adora an object that almost looked like a fluorescent lightbulb. A clear glass ampule, nine inches long or so, with metal connection points on both ends. In the center of the tube was something floating, something solid, something strange. “I couldn’t get a damn signal out of it, so I pulled the main housing apart.”

“What . . . is that?” Adora stood, finding it difficult to remove her eyes from the object.

“The lens. It’s supposed to be one piece, but look.” She twisted it at various angles, and the **thing** changed. Flickering and flashing, little crystals appeared and vanished, changing shape as facets physically grew and shrunk, looking at once like and unlike shards of frosted glass in water.

“It looks . . . wrong.” Adora stood, unsure whether to be curious, unsettled, nauseous, or angry.

Catra glanced at it too, seemingly unaffected as she set it down on the table. Sea legs she supposed. “Higher-dimensional prism.” She said, then scowled at it. “Adora, I’m . . . without this, the radio is useless. I’m fucked, Adora.”

Adora, despite Catra’s graveness, couldn’t stop looking at the broken crystal. It was just . . . wrong somehow. Like staring at two corners that didn’t line up even though they should. Like a hole in the world. Like some subconscious part of her just had to stop and try and find out the pattern, try and make the weird

changing crystals slot into reality like everything else did. “Adora!” Catra raised her voice slightly.

“What was that!?” Her head snapped up, then immediately glanced down again. The alien sighed and, after moving it around and enjoying watching Adora’s eyes follow it magnetically, threw a nearby blanket over it.

“Primitives.”

Immediately Adora found it much easier to focus on the matter at hand. “Sorry . . . that was weird.” She shook off the trance. “Is there no way to fix it, or a backup?” Looking at Catra she seemed . . . upset. Definitely upset. Alien body language expert indeed. “There’s nothing else on your pod that can help?”

“No. There’s no spare.” Catra grumbled, then recited stiffly and definitely from the manual. “If the subspace lens is damaged, seek a replacement to use in the mechanism.”

“Like from another escape pod?” Adora offered.

“They could have landed anywhere on this planet. Even if they were close, I’d need a working lens to contact them.”

Need a lens to get a lens. Not the best design. “Wow, give that engineer a raise.” Adora joked darkly. Catra nodded. The snarky light in her eyes was muddled. Sympathy bloomed in Adora’s heart, and for a minute she tried to think of the way out of this. But that component was unlike anything she had ever seen. She was sure nothing like it existed on Earth, and if it was required . . .

But never say never. There had to be a way to get Catra home, even if it had to be through some other method than the radio. Adora had no idea what that method would be, but it had to exist. She didn’t give up so easily, and she suspected Catra didn’t either. She was tenacious. Unfortunately, in any case, she sensed a solution probably wasn’t going to happen tonight. "Hey." She stood and approached Catra, not confident enough to put a hand

on her shoulder or hug her. She just tried to smile reassuringly. "I am going to help get you home. Whatever I can do to help, I'll do it."

Catra didn't react much to that, eyes remaining unfocused and still. “You promise?” She asked, soft but guarded.

Adora felt a heaviness in her chest. She hesitated only a moment. **“I promise.”**

Catra shuddered, ever so slightly at that. “Thank you.”

Adora nodded. "Go wash up. I have an idea."

Begrudgingly, Catra stood. She went to get the grease off her arms and by the time she was back, Adora had a small fire going in the fireplace and was sitting close enough to feel the heat. She patted the carpet next to her.

Catra approached, but very slowly, eying the flickering tongues of light carefully.

"What?" Adora glanced back at the fire. "What is it?"

“I’ve never seen an open flame before. At least one that wasn't . . . an immediate danger."

"Really?" Adora asked, amazed. Catra nodded.

"Fire and spaceships don't exactly mix." She muttered.

Nowhere to run on a spaceship. Adora thought, frowning. “Not even on your home planet?” Catra shook her head. “Well, it’s not dangerous so long as you don’t fall in.” Adora found a smile. “And even if you do, I’ll save you.”

“My hero.” Catra drawled, sitting next to Adora, knees of their crossed legs nearly touching.

“You know, I think I deserve that title, I’ve already saved you like, twice.”

“Twice?” Catra balked. “Don’t push it, Adora.”

“I don’t know.” Adora lilted. “You would have frozen trying to get to your pod again without my winter clothes.”

“Says the girl who could hardly stand sitting in your garage.” Catra said.

“Rude. I could push you in there myself you know.” She gestured at the fire.

“Aww, but you won’t.” Catra smiled saccharinely. “You’re way too much of a softie to do that, aren't'cha?”

"Shut up!" Adora demanded, but there was little venom in her voice. It was bizarre, the ease with which they talked now. Catra seemingly always able to find a chink in her armor to tickle her through. She had known her less than 24 hours and had only half a dozen conversations and yet it felt like a lot longer. In fact, Adora wasn’t sure she had ever clicked with someone as quickly as she had with Catra. What did that say about her attempts to make friends with other humans?

To distract herself from that worrying thought, Adora reached to her side, grabbing the two thin wooden dowels and a plastic bag full of marshmallows. She passed Catra one of each and encouraged her when she speared it on the end of the stick. "Nice." She loaded her own sugary treat. "Now you just hold it over the fire, not too close though."

"Why?"

"Cause it tastes better this way." Adora mounted her own marshmallow and carefully angled it towards the fireplace. The bigger logs were still cold and had ice wedged in the bark, so it wasn't ideal, but you worked with what you had.

“It’s not going to taste like that other thing?” Catra asked.

Adora laughed. “No. It doesn’t taste like hot sauce.”

Catra nodded, and they sat in comfortable silence as their marshmallows toasted agonizingly slowly.

"Careful." Adora eventually warned. "It's gonna-"

"It's gonna be fine." Catra replied, leaning hers closer.

"It's gonna catch on fire."

"No, it's not." Catra rolled her eyes looking at Adora with a smarmy look. For a moment Adora was captured by her glowing firelit irises again. Their alien shine now somewhere between familiar and exotic. It took her a few seconds to look back at their marshmallows.

"It's on fire." Adora said flatly. Catra's tail puffed out, and she squeaked, pulling the rapidly blackening snack away, only to realize that pulling it out of the fire meant putting it closer to her. She leaned back as far as she could without lying down. "Uhh . . . what do I do!?" She asked in a panicky voice.

Adora just smirked. "C'mere." She leaned to her right and grabbed the stick, blowing out the marshmallow with a puff of air.

"Oh." Catra squinted as a curl of smoke drifted upwards off it. "Yeah, right. I knew that. I was just testing if you knew proper fire safety.” Sureeee. “It’s a very important skill . . . if . . . you know . . ."

"Know what?" Adora asked.

"If we're . . ." Catra's ears dropped and she scrunched up her face, as if having to force the next part out. "gonna be friends."

"Aww!" Adora's eyes sparkled. "I would be honored."

"Whatever." Catra scowled, then looked at her blackened treat. "Now what the heck do I do with this?"

"You can still eat it." Adora assured. "Some people even prefer it that way." She turned her own marshmallow. "Heretics."

Catra, very tenderly, opened her mouth and consumed the marshmallow in one bite. She chewed, then shrugged.

"Yeah, the burnt taste kind of ruins the experience." She pulled her own out, perfectly golden. "Here, try this one." She swapped sticks with Catra and put the first back in the fire with a new marshmallow. She liked the golden ones more too. They sat for three more each. Night fell around the cabin, and Adora remembered one last thing to do today.

“Where are you going?” Catra asked as she stood.

"I promised my parents I'd call them every night, but I can only get a signal at the top of the hill so . . ." The alien seemed to understand, so she offered. "You wanna come? The view’s beautiful.” Catra's laugh was one firm 'hah!' and Adora’s little smile flattened. The alien went looking for another marshmallow. "Just come rescue me if you hear screaming."

Catra tossed the marshmallow raw into her mouth, chewing while talking. “Sure thing Princess. Just be sure to scream loud enough that I can hear you over the sound of me being warm and dry.”

Adora blinked, not sure where that nickname had come from, and felt a swell of anger rise in her. "Well sorry for rescuing you too." She grumbled and left to begin the trek a second time. She headed out, shuffling and slipping her way up the now even deeper snowy hill in a sudden bad mood. Dammit. The thought came halfway up. That was definitely a sarcastic comment wasn’t it? What wasn’t sarcastic out of her mouth? It didn’t ease her prickled nerves. Adora knew the sudden annoyance was irrational, which only made her madder that it had been so impactful. “Princess.” She muttered. She wasn’t a princess.

As the top came closer, the consideration of what to say to her parents about the cat that had come crashing through the clouds into her life came to the forefront. Should she mention it? It seemed relevant, if astonishingly unbelievable.

Hey Mom just wanted to let you know that I nearly got my jugular severed by a stranded alien.

No, don't mention that part. Adora decided, foot slipping a little, and a yellow lock flopped out from her hat, falling in her face. She huffed it out of her eyes with a breath, reaching through the slightly harder-packed snow to clamber a little higher. Jesus this climb sucked. Every time she thought it would be easier. Every time it wasn't.

Hey Mom so I ran into this girl who's staying in a nearby cabin, she's actually pretty cool-. Who's cabin? Oh, they're AirBnB-ing, no I don't know which one.

No, that would never work. Her family knew who owned every cabin for ten miles. They would insist, and Adora would have to pick one, and then that family would inevitably get a call from the world's nosiest parents and discover the lie.

By the time Adora had reached the top she still hadn't decided what to say; exhaling as she sat on top of the craggy rock and looked down at the cabin. It had clouded over at some point, so the night was fiercely dark, so black other than the tiny halo of light around the cabin. She pulled off her glove to call.

"Hi Mom! How are you?

Good. I'm good. It's been an interesting day. How's Dad and . . .

Oh . . . right. Well, I'm happy nothing's changed. Is she coming home tomorrow morni . . . good. Yeah thanks, I really want to. I need to. Tell her I'm sorry I wasn't there during the . . . yeah." Adora sniffled, reaching up to wipe her eyes with her glove. Dammit as soon as she thought about it, they started to water.

Not without good reason. One part of her brain said before she silenced it. “Okay. Okay. I’m glad. Keep me updated.

Yeah, the weather’s been clear today. The snow stopped before sunrise. There’s about two feet of powder, but it’s melting off the deck and compressing down. Okay. Right. Day after tomorrow.” Hopefully, they could figure out a solution for Catra by then.

“The house is good. Food’s going a little fast, be sure to bring some extra.”

She hurried through those minutiae to get to main point number one. “Can I call tomorrow so I can talk to - yes. In the morning.” Adora insisted. “Yes. Before noon.”

She chuckled. “Alright after ten. I’m not that bad! How about 11? Good.

Okay fine yeah, I was up late last night but it was for a good reason!” Main point number two. “Hey Mom I just wanted to mention something weird happ-oh. Oh, is that dad . . .? Hi dad!” The phone had been passed over. Adora frowned through her upbeat greeting. “How you holding up?” She got the same question right back. “I’m alright. Yeah, trying not to think about it too much.” Lots of distractions recently. Has she said anything . . . no. Okay. Yeah, they’ll be plenty of time.” There had to be. “I’ll figure it out, you know I’m nothing if not a conversation master.” She laughed at her own joke, but it came out hollow and cynical. “Yeah. Yeah, I promise not to beat myself up about it too bad. Now you. Promise me right back.” She got an excuse. “No. Dad. You need to too.” She got her promise. “Make mom promise too. She needs it as much as all of us.” She got a joke in return, and Adora laughed a little more heartily this time. “Yeah, living alone up here’s really turned me into a wise old woods witch huh? Don’t come get me. This is my home now.” Her dad was always good at making her laugh. Witch? Could that be a better nickname? No. Even if it was better than princess it didn’t seem like her. Too goth. “Alright. Yeah, you can pass me back.” One more small chuckle. “I promise. No mischief, still hunkered. Love you.”

The phone was passed back, but her Mom was immediately on goodbyes as well. Adora suppressed a sigh. Maybe it would be smarter not to mention it at all. As much as it twisted her gut, they were going through a lot, why make them worry more than they already are. Ignorance could be bliss in this situation.

"Look out for yourself Adora. I love you." Was the closing line.

"Will do Mom. Love you too. Say the same to . . . yeah. Okay. Bye." She heard the click, and Adora sighed. The phone slipped back into her pocket, and she descended.

When Adora got back, she was surprised to find Catra still watching the fire. "Good, you're not dead." She decreed casually.

Adora blinked, apology for reacting badly to 'Princess' catching on her lips with surprise. "You're still up?"

"Too quiet here." The alien explained, then elaborated when she saw Adora's confused look. "Noise in a starship is good. Means the systems that are keeping you alive are working. It's the quiet you want to be afraid of."

Adora found that phrasing unsettling and was unable to not think of *Alien*. Adora loved space, the vastness, the primordial beauty. But staring up from an entire planet with breathable air, it was easy to forget that every spaceship was, in essence, an insult to entropy.

"Come on." Adora ushered her up. "Lemme show you the guest bedroom. We can run the humidifier, that'll help."

Adora woke with a yawn and sigh of deep relief the next morning. She had gotten a full night's rest, and no one was trying to kill her yet. Dressing in a t-shirt, red and black flannel pants, and the thickest socks she could find, she quickly put her hair up into the standard 'poof and ponytail', then checked her phone. It was already 10:30. Crap. She only had half an hour to eat, psych

herself up, and make the climb. She threw together a breakfast sandwich as fast as she could, scarfing it down before fortifying with layers against the cold and with softly repeated mantras under her breath. “I’ve got this. I’ve got this. I’ve got this.”

In the mudroom, she heard sounds of work in the garage. Nice, that meant Catra probably had an idea for fixing the crystal lens. She knew she would figure something out.

Adora zipped up her jacket and steeled herself. This was going to be one of the hardest conversations she had ever had, but Adora wouldn’t miss it for anything.

Adora waited in the mudroom for nearly fifteen minutes after getting back. Checking with the camera on her phone to be sure her puffy red eyes had gone down. Her stomach felt empty despite the meal she’d eaten, hollow and tight.

There was a ringing metal sound from the garage. Talking with Catra would probably cheer her up. She opened the door.

The basement looked like a murder scene.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Anxiety

Chapter 4: Out Where the West Begins

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's eyes went wide as she stepped into the garage. Scattered well beyond the bounds of the tarp was the radio, shredded into pieces. On the floor were twisted pipes and frayed wires, crumpled panels raked through with quartets of claw marks. Some pieces laid in the corners of the room, where they'd landed after having been thrown. Others were now no more than tiny pieces of metal and glass, ruined so thoroughly it was impossible to tell what they had once been a part of.

In the center of this grim constellation, next to the mutilated hulk that was whatever couldn't be pulled off the radio like flesh could be off bone, Catra was curled in a tight ball, on her side, hands over her head, shaking.

". . . Catra?" Adora spoke.

The alien snapped to attention, dilated eyes locking onto her. Adora saw fury and strength, and anguish and horror and shame in them, blue and gold oceans wet with a film of tears. Instinct made the human set a foot back, but she stopped it there and forced it forward again. No. She would not fear Catra. Not when she was so clearly hurting.

"Catra." She repeated, much more sympathetically, and took a step closer, arms rising to go and comfort her.

"Get out." The alien whispered, only able to be heard in the echo of the concrete room.

"What?"

"GET OUT!" Catra roared, reaching over and grabbing a piece of debris. Adora just barely jumped out of the way as a foot-long

triangle of metal flew past her torso, clanging with frightening speed against the wall behind her, point chipping the concrete.

Adora swallowed and retreated. Hands shaking as she undid and redid her poof and ponytail on the way upstairs. She knew she was a heavy sleeper, but heavy enough to sleep through Catra doing that? Quickly, she brewed some tea, let it steep for as long as her panicking nerves could bear, then descended again. Taking a breath, Adora cracked the door and, without looking in, set the steaming mug inside before closing it again.

It was very hard to remain calm with the situation downstairs. The sickening feeling in her stomach getting worse and worse. Catra had been fine after Adora got back! Just seemingly content to sit a comfortable distance from the fire and eat a scarily large number of marshmallows. Adora had said she was going to bed, and that they would find her a way home, and Catra had said: 'Sure we will; see you tomorrow.'

She hadn't said it like it was a death sentence.

One thing was for certain, the radio was **gone**. No one, not even an alien strong enough to tear her claws through sheet metal, could rebuild it. So, they would definitely need a completely human way for Catra to contact her people. Adora had meant what she had said. She wanted to help get her home. She just wished she had any idea how she was going to do that. Hell, she wished she had a damned idea where to even start.

"Please let it just be the radio that's destroyed." Adora muttered. It had looked that way during her brief glimpse, but if she had to tell her parents about everything so far **on top of** explaining why all the snowmobiles had been torn to shreds. Well, that wouldn't be pretty, no sir.

Yeah, until she could check that everything down there that hadn't come from outer space was okay, she was very very nervous.

Footsteps on the stairs coming up. Adora stopped pacing and tried to make like she wasn't totally freaking out. She was pretty sure she failed spectacularly. Catra appeared slowly, like an image loading through a terrible internet connection, from the top down, one line at a time. Wiry brown hair, messier than usual. Next her eyes, the fury in them was gone, replaced with exhaustion and emptiness. Then her uniform, looking dull and very oil-stained, and finally the pair of pajama pants Adora had lent her last night. Yeah, those were ruined. She stopped at the top of the stairs, not quite able to meet Adora's eyes. Instead, they were down in front of her, where clasped between her hands was the empty mug. "Could I-" She began, voice hoarse. She coughed once, and with quavering words, asked. "Could I have another cup of that stuff?"

Adora exhaled some of the tension from her chest. "Of course."

An unusual expression passed Catra's face. She closed her eyes and shuddered, then nodded a few times, though whether to herself or Adora, the human wasn't sure. Without another word, she set the mug on the bar and headed deeper into the house. The shower started running.

Adora shook her head. Every time she thought she'd gotten to the softer side of Catra she lashed out. She knew the alien was prickly, but still, too many brushes with sharp objects recently. Prickly, sassy, frustrating, infuriatingly-witty, wary - and most importantly: scared - cat-eared alien **girl**, Adora reminded herself.

Catra emerged after a long time. Adora reheated the second glass of tea and, after making sure it was okay to lightly touch her back, led her gently over to the couch. Catra followed along like a zombie, feet moving the bare minimum amount. She sat her down, passed the mug, then wrapped a blanket over her shoulders. "I'm sorry. I should have realized just how much this would affect you."

Catra gave her a look like Adora was insane. "I make a mess like that and you're apologizing to me?" She asked. Her voice was

closer to normal now, but Adora could still hear a hint of unguarded disbelief.

“Yeah, I am.” Adora said. She was upset about the mess downstairs, but there would be time for that later.

Catra stared for another moment, then sipped her tea, mumbling something into the liquid.

“Mmm?” Adora urged.

“This stuff is good.” Catra said louder.

“I’m glad you like it.” The human pursed her lips. “Not to be nosy but, is there anything I can do about this? I can be here to just listen or help you brainstorm, anything. Like you said: friends, right? That’s what friends do.”

The words ‘friends’ drew Catra’s eyes. Her tail curled around her abdomen protectively. “It’s not supposed to be like this.” She said, locking her jaw. “The training they gave me . . . it never . . .”

“What, they didn’t prepare you for getting drinks delivered in a lovely country cabin?” Adora asked with warm irony. Catra frowned at her. “Not trying to get any praise here.” She put her hands up. “Just trying to understand the truly horrid environment you came from.”

“Just listen huh?” Catra’s ears drooped down.

Adora shut her mouth so fast her teeth clacked. “I’m sorry.”

“S’alright.” She sipped again, then didn’t speak for a long time. When the cup was empty, she just said. “I don’t know what I’m going to do.”

It was terrifying, Adora could see. The knowledge that you had no way home. She knew Catra would likely never admit it, but she was scared right now. Adora wanted to ask so many questions, try and wriggle out any hope. But that wasn’t what she needed. She

just needed some comfort and some time. Silently, she stood and headed for the bathroom, stepping over the wet towels on the floor and the shower curtain rod, searching the sink cabinet drawers. She returned with a hairbrush, holding it up to Catra before gesturing to the couch.

With Catra sitting on the floor in front of her, Adora slowly worked out the tangles in her hair that had been built up by hot showers and various alien fluids. The unruly fibers were denser than any hair she had ever had to deal with before, so she tried to be careful, holding the base of each tress firmly before pulling the plastic bristles through. The clock ticked, and time passed, and Adora brushed.

When it was as good as it was going to get – Adora only broke a couple of plastic bristles - she reached up to pull her hair tie out. Shaking out the poof and ponytail, she grabbed Catra's mane and bundled it together. The sheer volume in front of her made it impossible to get it all, so the alien ended up with two loose tails falling down to either side of her face in front of her ears. Adora set her hands on her hips and admired her casual handiwork. Noting a stray hair, she ran her fingers over her scalp to tuck it in. The sound that came out of Catra's throat was subtle, but so shocking it might as well have been a thunderclap in Adora's ears.

Oh my god. Adora quietly moved her second hand up, applying a little more pressure as she massaged her head gently. Yep. Catra was purring. Oh my god. Not daring to speak, she scratched where she seemed to like it, now cursing putting her hair into a ponytail. After lingering on her scalp, Adora moved her hands down to massage her shoulders.

Catra jumped up. Damn, pushed too far. The alien paced away but paused when she passed the mirror hanging near the door to the deck, reaching up to touch one of the new locks beside her eyes.

"What a downer of a day." Adora sighed and leaned back, confident enough that Catra was eased enough to talk again. "God it's actually really nice out and everything." The hike up the

hill had been close to bearable. The sky was clear, and it was warm. She turned her head to look at the thermometer that was suctioned cupped to the outside of one of the big windows. It was almost ABOVE freezing. C'mon!

Debate swirled in the human's mind on how to cheer Catra up, various ideas swirling before it settled on a somewhat crazy one. One that would maybe tip the scales tomorrow from disagreeable behavior to actually being in trouble. If she got caught, that was.

If she got caught. Adora pursed her lips at that thought. It was unlike her. She considered for a long while, looking out at the perfect December day.

Hell, in for a penny, in for a pound. "You know what." Adora slammed her hands down on the coffee table and stood. Catra's shoulders jumped towards her ears. "We're hitting the trails!"

"What?"

"Today. Right now." She walked over to Catra and offered a hand. "C'mon."

Catra watched it skeptically, then took it. They headed to suit up.

"I can ride behind you if you want." Catra was saying, staring as Adora prepped two of the snowmobiles, none of which had - thankfully - been destroyed.

"What now?" Adora seemed confused, then chuffed. "Oh no. You're going to get to drive your own!" She checked the oil on the Polaris, all good, then sat to start it. The snowmobile thrummed to life, and she gunned the throttle a few times to make sure it was running well, filling the garage with booming noise. "I'll just have to be sure to refill the gas level to what it was at before."

Catra lifted her hands off her ears. "Why do I get the feeling that you're not allowed to do this?"

“I’m not allowed to go out on the trails alone.” Adora informed. “You’re going to be with me. I’m not alone!”

“And . . .” Catra rolled her hand to get the other shoe to drop.

“I’ve never been allowed to go out just with a friend before. One of my parents always insisted on coming. BUT! They never said that the second person had to be one of them, so we’re good!”

“That’s a technicality.”

“You, of all people, I’d expect to live on technicalities.”

Maybe it was the fact that she’d just come out of an emotional crisis, but Catra seemed genuinely shocked to suddenly be put into a corner like that. After a stunned silence, she let her head tip over to a playful angle, a lopsided smile matching. “Don’t ever let anybody tell you that you don’t have spunk.”

“Noted.” Adora beamed, so happy to have ‘won’ a bout of their banter. She jumped off the sled and sat Catra down. "Gas is this lever here." She reached forward and pulled it quickly, making the snowmobile lurch and Catra squeak in surprise. "On off is here.” She snapped the kill switch bracelet to her wrist so it couldn’t run off on her. “There’re no brakes . . ." Catra's eyes widened. "But!" Adora eased before she could interrupt. "Just let go and the track won’t move, you'll stop real fast. Turn with the bars, it's easier if you go at least at a slow speed. And . . ." She considered. "That's pretty much it!"

"That's it?" Catra was skeptical.

"Yeeaa . . . Oh!" She pointed upwards. "If you feel the ground beneath you start to give or you think you're going to get stuck, just give it more power to try and push through. Lean against whatever way it wants to sink. Otherwise, just follow my lead, I'll have your back." She tapped her chin. "Also, watch your tail on the engine, it gets hot. I should have mentioned that when we went out to the crash site." She wasn't exactly considering people

with tails in conjunction with the snowmobile at that time. She was mostly going HOLY CRAP HOLY CRAP A REAL ASS ALIEN!

"Are you forgetting anything else?" Catra's eyes frowned through the visor.

"Umm . . . Nope! Don't think so." Adora went to sit on the 50-horsepower Ski-Doo that her father normally rode. “Just follow me!” She started the engine and headed outside. The sun shone harsh and clear, and despite it being rendered white and heatless by winter, still retained enough power to make the icicles above the deck drip soft random melodies against the boards. Adora looked behind her as she went up the driveway first, watching as Catra at first followed unevenly, but after thirty seconds was already keeping a good pace behind. She wasn't surprised. Riding a snowmobile is easy.

They followed the route towards Catra’s crash site but instead of turning off there, continued another half mile over the snow-covered main road to the trailhead. Half an hour of easy riding took them out into the empty land north and east of the valley, and Adora picked a path that balanced beautiful views without being too technical. This was going to be fun.

Catra was really trying not to enjoy this as much as she was. But the smile came back stronger each time she revved the engine and her snowmobile roared like a predator. As she accelerated, wind rustled her extremely gaudy jacket as she sped for the next little undulating hill and shot off the top of it, momentarily catching air before she landed back in the snow and rushed onward. She and Adora had woven up along hillsides through wooded evergreen forest dusted with morning frost, the scale barked trees flanking the trail breaking occasionally to reveal wide open views of the mountainous landscape. They passed through valleys, and over snowy passes. This was a hard planet, Catra thought, wondering if there were places like this on her homeworld far from where she’d grown up.

At one point the land suddenly opened up, and they came out onto a wide shallow vale clear of trees. The glare on the snow almost swallowed the landscape up entirely. Adora spread her arms wide at the long even hills sloping up in all directions towards higher wooded peaks. “Wow, I’ve never seen it so clean here! Guarantee you all this will be covered in snowmobile tracks by next week. My sister and I would always race up that one,” She pointed toward a particularly tall bare-topped hill. Adora hadn’t mentioned she had a sister.

Catra looked over at Adora with mischievous eyes, and she matched them back, clacking her visor down and revving her engine. They drove to the base of the hill, side by side and Adora lifted her first three fingers. In local units, Catra figured it was a three-hundred-foot climb to the top. Adora dropped her fingers one by one. Three, two, one. They took off together.

Skid to skid, the snow was kicked up between them. Catra pressed the throttle down deeper and deeper as the hill steepened. The engine came through the helmet into her ears, echoed up her spine. Under the helmet, Catra’s smile was wide. Both contestant’s eyes held more to each other than the way ahead. Catra started to gain a small lead, and she seized it, revving up to full.

For five glorious seconds Catra was winning, but then the handlebars suddenly became sluggish in her hands. Catra tried to turn, but the sled sunk right, and Catra felt her weight get thrown in that direction. She yipped, letting off the gas, but everything just became less stable. Trying to lever left to escape the trap proved futile; it was already too late. With an undignified lurch to a stop, she was beached in a thick drift. Catra cursed the stars, trying to shake and power herself free, but the efforts only buried her deeper. Adora just kept going, regaining the lead and ascending to the top of the hill, where she stood up in the kickplates and lifted her hands above her head with a whoop. It was only then that she glanced back and noticed that Catra was still only halfway to the finish line. She came down and stopped next to her. Catra watching more closely now at how she subtly

leaned into turns, and reacted quickly and sharply whenever the machine did something she didn't like.

"I think this makes three times I'll save you now." Adora flipped her visor up, pulling out the electronic rectangle she always carried to take a picture of her stuck in the snow.

Catra released a long breath. "Do I need to say that it doesn't count when you were the one that got me here?"

Adora smiled that stupid smile. "You can, but I'm still putting it on the list."

Once Adora had alternatively rocked and powered the Polaris out of the hole Catra had created for it, they tarried deeper into the wilderness. Adora took a deep breath as the trail wended its way along graded paths carved into the sides of steeper valleys. They undulated with little jumps and switchbacks, and over the course of several hours, her and Catra played and laughed through the beautiful conifer-capped frontier.

This land was all Sawtooth National Forest, wild and undeveloped. It wasn't uncommon to see mountain lion prints crossing a trail, or a moose which had wandered up into the high country. Adora loved that she lived part of the year out here, that she got to see the cragged cliffs and forgotten hills. It was remote enough that most of them were still nameless, unbesmirched by some self-righteous settler two hundred years ago who deemed himself important enough to inscribe their title upon this or that peak. Yeah, perhaps some had old Shoshone names from before humans with her skin tone roamed these mountains, and perhaps they each had a geological survey number in some government database somewhere: county peak #362. But it was more than gladness, more than relief to Adora to know that there were still some places left that were unlabeled.

So often it felt like humanity was everywhere, had discovered and built on or littered in every hidden corner of the globe. So often

Adora felt like things only seemed to really exist after people had come and made sense of them. Taken the samples. Categorized the soil. Counted the trees. That sensation was so prevalent that now: places like this were unsettling. From millions of years ago until the present that hill or that ridge had existed. It existed when there were no human eyes on Earth to see it and it still existed now, and nothing changed when the first Paleolithic person took their spear and followed a lion up the little brook between its mountain neighbors until they saw it. Past that moment until when Adora was looking at it now, her species' impact on it was nil.

The rush of that perspective, that sonder on a scale of the Earth, whose continents moved in seconds as long as the lifetimes of species, was thrilling and humbling. Adora thought it helped keep her sane. She was small and transient; the mountain was big and steadfast. That just meant her life was all the more valuable when she used what time she had for great things, things that made the world better. Imagine how jealous the mountain would be if it could know how bright she'd burn. How much she would do with so little.

Maybe that was why the existence of an entire interstellar civilization was as exciting as it was terrifying, because regardless of humanity's knowledge of it, it existed. Her species' impact on them was nothing not because they couldn't be bothered to bring bulldozers up here and knock the mountain down. It was nothing because the entire collective efforts of her species were like an anthill in a crack in a New York City sidewalk.

When you were that small, Adora struggled to imagine how much light would be needed.

Adora realized that she was probably too focused on being philosophical when one of her skis suddenly shot into the ground. She had drifted too far to the inner side of the trail, and her right side broke the packed snow at its edge and careened into the ditch beyond. As soon as it was over the side, the snowmobile rolled. Adora barely had time to react before she was flung over

the handlebars into the trough. She landed on her back, eyes on the sky. The dead switch bracelet on her wrist was yanked with her, so the motor quit, but the inertia of the machine was more than enough to keep it moving. Adora watched as her view of the startling blue sky split by green pine boughs was swallowed by the bulk of the snowmobile as it twisted after her, lurching over.

Adora screamed when it landed on her left side. She felt something move in her shoulder. Pain split like lighting across her chest.

"Adora!" She heard Catra shout from where she had been riding behind her, her engine stopping too. The snow crunched under the alien’s borrowed boots, unnaturally loud without the motor sounds as she slid down into the ditch with her. The alien pulled her helmet off, fast enough it grabbed the balaclava with it, and her ears popped out, up and alert. Her eyes were wide and panicked. Catra checked her quickly and efficiently, hands moving over Adora's body. "Be ready to move." She said, then stood and braced herself with arms and shoulders against the snowmobile.

With one mighty heave, Catra easily lifted the snowmobile up and off Adora, tipping it back onto its skis. The human scrambled away, hissing through her teeth as she got out of its shadow. Damn, Catra was strong, she was reminded again. An instant after the Ski-Doo settled, she was back at Adora's side. "You okay?" Fast too.

“My arm." Adora gasped. "I can't move it."

"Shit, alright." Catra shuffled in close. "Come on Adora, up." She grabbed her around the torso and tried to move her into a sitting position.

"Catra." Adora hesitated.

"Up!" Catra barked, her tone suddenly hard and leaving no room for disobedience. The shout broke through the pain, and Adora managed to shift half her back up to lean on the nearest tree.

Catra pulled off Adora’s helmet, then unzipped her jacket and pulled it down off her shoulders. "Let's see." She reached in and started feeling along her arm, searching for the bones. "Shoulder blade. Plexhas. Tusas." They moved over her collarbone and down her arm, alien words whispers on her lips. "Epsos, kaesos, laesos. Lemme see the other side." Catra shuffled over and did the same checks on her good arm. She felt along, settling at the top of her humerus. "Move this." Adora did, and Catra exhaled. "Your shoulder's dislocated, I think."

"You think!?" Adora managed through the pain.

"I'm sure." Catra clarified. "Our anatomies are pretty similar. Lie down." Adora, head cloudy with pain, obeyed the strong knowledgeable voice and did so. "This is gonna hurt." The alien informed and began to raise Adora’s left arm out and away from her body. Adora immediately grunted, and her vision flashed white. "Close your mouth, don't bite your tongue." Catra ordered. Adora nodded through tightly shut eyes. “Relax your arm.”

With an even precision, Catra lifted the limb nearly perpendicular to her body. Then with one hand on her shoulder blade and one at her wrist, slowly began to pull the arm away while twisting. Adora felt the muscles move unnaturally as her shoulder stretched. She huffed and grunted. "UouhghaaaAAA!" A hiss grew into a scream as the pulling force built rapidly, and the pain with it. Catra kept steady, moving just a little bit further.

Suddenly there was a lance of pain, a clunk-like sound deep in her shoulder, then instant relief. "Ohhh . . ." She exhaled, amazed. "Wow. That's better. Thanks." She blinked through cold tears, looking up at Catra, eyes watching her with existential concern.

"Don't move it much yet." She said, still all business. She unzipped her own coat and pulled off her hoodie.

"What are you doing!?"

“Take off your shirt." She replied.

"What!?" Adora's face turned red.

"This is a medical emergency Adora. Your shoulder needs this or it's going to be weaker. Don't be a prude."

Adora fought to control her reactions, then nodded. With Catra's help to brace her arm, she pulled off her coat, hoodie, and t-shirt underneath. It was very very cold now. Her upper body completely exposed to December save for the parts covered in a sports bra. Every patch of uncovered skin rose in goosebumps as it flushed.

"Strap." Catra commanded. Adora couldn't look her in the eye as she carefully pulled it down over her sensitive shoulder and let it hang loose. Catra ran her fingers over the skin, then set her hand at the top of her arm and closed her eyes, taking a deep breath. For a moment, nothing happened, then Adora watched with wide eyes as Catra's skin suit began to move. Like a liquid or some kind of slimy animal, her sleeve broke off at the elbow and flowed down off her arm and onto Adora. She tensed as the material touched her; it was unsettlingly warm. Quickly it began to envelop her shoulder and wrap itself over her skin.

"EeeeeEEEhEhehe!" The sensation was of bizarre, ticklish, undulating waves of pressure.

"Feels like a million bugs crawling over your skin, huh?" Catra said. Adora nodded. "Yeah, well, serves you right for being an idiot."

Adora hummed in response as the alien cast settled, forming a flexible covering from the edge of her shoulder blade, the middle of her upper arm, and down past her collarbone in front. As it stopped moving, it suddenly began to cool and feel like a soothing ice pack on her muscles. "Ohhh . . ." Adora exhaled, feeling the pain dissipate even more. "Thanks, that feels good."

"Just . . . be more careful, okay? You're my only hope of getting off this rock."

Adora smirked. "Wow, I'm beginning to think you actually like me! That’s so embarrassing.”

"Ugh!" Catra wheeled on her, ready to shove, then stayed her rage. "Shut up." She grumbled. "I don't like you."

"Mmm, yeah. Keep telling yourself that." Adora replied, then reached for her shoulder again, feeling the strange rippling of the skin suit as she rolled it a little. The coolness wasn't exactly welcome in this climate, she could already feel herself starting to shiver, but it was definitely helping numb the pain. It was a reminder that the winter around them, while beautiful, was also cold, hard, and unforgiving. The air sharpened her sight but also dulled her nerves, her judgment. Whenever you went out, especially without other more experienced people at your side, it was like fighting a battle. You had to keep going, keep your sword up until you could get out of the thrall of it. Because while you could fight the winter, you could never defeat it. The only way to win was to outlast. Their spontaneous trip was suddenly a lot less fun. "Where did you learn that, by the way?"

"What?"

"My shoulder, how did you know how to put it back in?"

"Oh." Catra's ears lowered a little. "I’ve picked up stuff like that, here and there.”

"On your starship?"

"On planets." Catra replied.

Adora nodded through her shivering. “I said I’d have your back, turns out it's more like you’ve got mine.” She chuckled as she layered up again.

“Three to one.” Catra said.

Confusion filled Adora. “What?”

“Saves.” She clarified. “We’ve got each other’s backs.”

Adora’s eyes widened. “Right.” She realized. “Guess we should stick together for both our sakes, huh?"

Catra looked at her in a different way. “Alright.”

“Alright?”

“We’ll stick together, until I can get home.” Catra said, and Adora didn’t think it was a joke.

“Alright.” She confirmed, now serious. “We stick together.” A smile found its way to her face, even if she wasn’t quite sure why. “Well, I guess this is as good a spot as any for lunch.” She picked up her helmet from the snow and noted the huge scratch along its left side where the snowmobile had glanced across it. She was lucky she didn't have a concussion. Yeah, sticking together was definetly a good idea.

The spot Adora had fallen was near a small rushing mountain stream. The ice-choked rill babbled and burbled as Catra drove their snowmobiles off to the side of the trail and Adora unpacked lunch. It was meat and vegetables layered between a pillowy kind of material Catra guessed was a grain. This species seemed to really like grain. They sat next to one another on one of the snowmobile seats. The food was cold but filling. They ate not in silence but with the ever-present sounds of the planet all around. Catra's sensitive ears picked up dripping from the tips of the icicles on the trees, and little creatures that sang in the air. Birds, Catra would later learn from Adora. Fluttering creatures with strange wide hairs all over their bodies that were somewhat like the wings of bugs, but arrayed in rows that formed crescent and wedge-shaped airfoils that let them dart and dance above their heads, and as they did, warbled wonderful complex songs. She had seen flying animals before, but never any larger than a bug. She’d heard stories from her crewmates though, ones from lower gravity worlds. Something skittered behind her, and Catra's head

snap turned to notice a small fluffy animal as it peeked out of a hole in a tree, then scurried down into a little hollow among its roots, a seed of some kind stuffed in its mouth.

It had been so long since Catra had been out in nature. Now it felt like someone had snuck up behind her and slapped her upside the head with it. So many weird noises made her twitchy. Catra turned to find Adora staring, a worried look on her face. ‘Are you alright?’ was the question hanging on her lips.

“I’m fine, Princess. You worry too much.” She said.

Adora scowled, but nodded, then lifted a fist out to her. Catra was confused but got it once the human mimed the gesture. They bumped fists, and Adora smiled. "Hey, we are gonna get you home, alright? But it's okay to relax a bit too.”

It wasn't though. There was something Catra was missing. Something she wasn't thinking of to get it done faster. "Sure." She wished Adora would quit bringing it up. Catra finished her meal with this conundrum on her mind. The solution to making contact had to be ‘home grown’ so to speak, but how to do that? She had seen the technology Adora had been using these past few days. Could one of those work? “That box in your kitchen, the one that plays music, does it use radio?” She asked, remembering an obscure conversation she’d had with the Fight Zone’s communications officer over ration bars. Well, not ‘had’ per se. Sat in on while Scorpia excitedly chatted up the photosynthetic crewmate. One advantage of being stranded on a primitive planet: you didn’t have to sweep the flower petals Perfuma left behind out of your shared bunk every night.

“Yeah.” Adora nodded, taking a second to figure it out. “Of course! Do you think we could contact your ship that way!?” Her eyes were sparkling again.

“Maybe.” Catra nodded but wasn’t ready to commit to more than that.

“Well, I don’t know much about radio, but maybe tomorrow we can call my friend, he’s a bit of a tech nerd.” Adora finished her food, and then took a long look around, eyes falling on a particular spot.

“We should head back.” Catra said. Adora was injured, and literally out of her element here.

“Shh.” Adora replied.

“What?”

Adora quickly turned around and reached over, putting a finger where Catra’s lips were through her helmet. “That means quiet.” Adora hushed, then pointed across the gorge. The rolling mountain hills unfolded to the north, jagged and draped in white, with rocky outcroppings jutting up in rows like teeth from a jawbone. Adora was pointing just above a narrow crevasse, where a row of large gray-brown creatures were moving. "Bighorn." She explained.

Catra narrowed her eyes, trying to discern them better at this distance. It was hard until one clambered up on top of an impossibly steep pinnacle. It was a stocky quadrupedal animal with long legs, a white rump, no visible tail, and on its triangular head, a pair of huge corkscrew horns. "There's a head of one of those in the cabin." She noted.

Adora nodded. "It's rare to see them here. Usually, they stay further north. That's a male there." She pointed to the lookout. "The females have the small crescent-shaped horns."

They watched for several minutes as the group of possibly thirty individuals of both sexes settled on top of the ridge, moving about and grazing, rummaging through the snow for stover. Occasionally over the wind, Catra would hear their subtle cries, a soft grunting gurgling clicking sound.

"No way." Adora whispered and tapped Catra's shoulder excitedly. She pointed out two males off to the side that were standing near

one another. It was hard to tell, but they seemed to be kicking each other's undersides with their front legs.

"What are they-" Catra began but Adora hushed her again.

"Watch."

The soft scuffle continued for nearly a full minute. The males whacking each other as they walked in slow circles, sides touching as they rubbed their horns together, twitching until, at some invisible signal, they both turned away, quarrel apparently decided.

Catra frowned, disappointed by the anticlimax, then suddenly the pair reversed course, reared up on their hind legs, and came slamming down towards one another with amazing speed. Their horns clashed together, and Catra heard the sharp CLACK, that echoed over the empty valley.

Adora beamed, shaking her head in awe. "Amazing. Never seen that in person."

Catra glanced over at the strange native of this planet, so excited by its animals bashing their heads together. While it was impressive that they didn't break their necks doing it, Catra supposed, she'd seen thicker skulls.

"You actually like it out here." Catra realized.

"I do." Adora smiled.

Catra shook her head in disbelief. "Well, I guess it is peaceful, in a freeze-to-death kind of way." Adora rolled her eyes and twisted to bump Catra with her shoulder, immediately wincing as it was with the injured one.

"Oww." She rubbed it before punching Catra very lightly. "We're just a weird species I guess."

"I was going to say there's weirder, but my confidence is waning."

"Oh?" Adora was curious again. “Who’s the competition?”

"Alright." Catra conceded. "So, I work with this other Force Captain. She's got these big pincers . . .”

After that story, Adora fished out her phone, calling “Human thing!” as she snapped a picture she called a ‘selfie’ of the two of them sitting next to one another.

They went much slower on the way back. Catra knew it was because Adora’s shoulder was really starting to hurt, but neither brought it up. Adora went at only a little faster than running pace for most of it, no longer jumping hills and often steering with just one arm.

Pulling into the garage, Catra pulled off her helmet and looked it at in her hands. “Hey Adora?”

“Mmm?”

“Thanks. For that.”

“Course.” Adora smiled, her torrent of helmet hair all in her eyes and teeth. She looked down at the mess of scrap metal scattered around. “We should clean this up.”

“Not yet.” Catra said, earning Adora’s gaze. “Your shoulder needs rest.”

“Doctor’s orders?” Adora asked, smirking.

Catra just nudged the human towards the stairs. But, of course, instead of resting Adora gabbed the countertop radio and started talking about how her friend ‘Bow’ had something called a ‘HAM Radio License’, and that he would be pretty good at helping them figure out how to get in touch with The Fright Zone.

“Why don’t you just call him now?” She asked.

Adora suddenly looked nervous. “Well . . .” She launched into a monologue about how he and her sister had something called a ‘movie night’ going on today, and she didn’t want to intrude. “Did that make sense?”

Catra stared blankly at Adora. “Besides the fact that you used ‘night’ and ‘today’ right next to each other? No. What’s a movie?”

Now Adora looked confused. “You . . . you don’t know what a movie is?” She asked. “Moving pictures? Stories on a screen?” She walked over and pulled a plastic box from a shelf beneath a black flatscreen on one wall, as if that explained anything.

“Is this like a video manual? Cause I don't exactly watch those for fun.”

Adora looked flabbergasted. “You really . . . you really don’t have movies in space?”

“No.”

Adora ran her fingers through her poof. “They can travel the universe but don’t have Star Wars.” She muttered, then spoke up energetically. “Well, we have to fix this! Sit down! Kick back for some culture!” She ran for the kitchen and threw something in the microwave. Catra did as she was told, plopping down. Well, at worst this would be a distraction.

Adora was almost getting more entertainment at Catra staring pretty much unblinking at the movie than she was watching it herself, smirking as the alien grabbed another handful of popcorn without looking away from the screen. “I hate this stuff.” She said with a full mouth.

“Then why do you keep eating it?” Adora took some from the big bowl between them. They were already on their third bag.

“That’s why I hate it."

One movie had turned into two. Adora had picked *The Goonies* first, hoping it was something of a crash course in human culture, even if a slightly outdated one. There were lots and lots of questions and confusion about the 80s, but Catra liked the moving pictures, even if she didn't seem to click with them until she'd had to start explaining the human concept of pirates. That's why they went for *The Curse of the Black Pearl* second, which Catra enjoyed immensely.

"One more?" Adora asked after it ended, holding up the VHS for *Lilo and Stitch*. "This one's animated, and has aliens."

"But that's like several hundred thousand different pictures. Why would anyone draw that many?" Catra asked after Adora had explained what animation was.

"Animation lets you show whatever you want." Adora said. "Also 'cause it's pretty." She nudged Catra in the side. They had ended up on the floor at some point, backs against the couch, sides touching.

"Seems like a waste of effort." Catra pursed her lips at the strange aliens depicted in watercolor on the box. "Also, aliens don't look like that."

"Well, sorry my species didn't have any reference pictures!" Adora cried, then blushed at her own enthusiasm. Catra just reached for the popcorn bowl. Adora stood and announced. "Gonna make my call, wanna come?" The last two words weren't really a question, she wasn't expecting 'warm and dry' Catra to-

"Sure." Catra shrugged.

"Wait, really?" Adora searched her face.

Catra pushed herself onto her feet. "What, don't want me to now?" She stretched an arm up. Adora smirked but didn't dignify that with a response. Catra gave an exaggerated exhale when she saw she wasn't going to play. "Well with you babbling about it all the time I figured I gotta see this 'beautiful view' right?" Adora

just rolled her injured shoulder, feeling the chill that she had gotten used to but was unable to not notice. “How’s that feel?” Catra asked by means of changing the subject.

“Kind of stiff." Adora admitted. "No pain though."

Catra nodded. “That means it’s been working. I’ll take it off in the morning, you should be good by then."

Adora shrugged. "Okay. Thanks for your weird alien medicine?"

"Sure, whatever." Catra shrugged, then turned to get dressed for the climb.

"Would it kill you to say ‘You're Welcome’ sometime?" Adora asked as she went down the stairs.

"Maybe!" She shouted back.

"Dang cat."

They donned and set out, the path in the snow now well-blazed by Adora’s nightly trips up and down. But that also meant the compacted snow she’d tread down was hard and slippery. Adora made sure to press her soles into the hardpack firmly before heaving her body up another few feet. Catra followed behind, only the sound of gloves scraping snow in Adora’s hood.

Halfway up, Catra suddenly squeaked. “Hey . . . Adora!”

“Whoa!” Adora reached back as Catra slipped in the snow, grabbing her wrist before she could eat any. A breath of relief came from the alien as Adora tried to drag her up to more stable ground. Catra’s boots flailed cartoonishly, and she ran in place for several seconds before stumbling to the ground beside the path. Adora laughed and received a venomous glare. She covered her mouth to try and stifle it.

“Damn cold ass planet.” Catra bushed herself off and took Adora’s hand to be pulled up for real this time. “If you climb this thing so

often you should build some stairs at least."

"Well, if you want to come back this summer, I would appreciate the help." Adora smiled under her goggles but immediately saw the upset look on Catra's face. "Sorry." She apologized. Don't imply she's never getting home. You are going to get Catra home.

Catra sloughed off her grip and continued upwards, making a new route through fresh snow to Adora's right. The night was cold and clear and almost perfectly windless. The sky burned above them. The arc of the galaxy like a luminous cloud, ethereal and silent. To the south, you could see the nearest town. Its streetlights twinkled in a golden grid near the horizon, a circuit board of humanity surrounded by darkness.

They sat together at the top as Adora dialed. "I'm going to try and talk about you, okay?" She set it on speaker and into the snow. It picked up after two rings.

"Hello?"

"Hi Mom." Adora smiled, enjoying the sound of her voice. She wondered when the last time Adora had spent this long away from her family was, and realized it was never. Not since she'd met them. That made her pause, and she missed what her mother had said. "Sorry, what was that?

"We're playing a game right now." The voice on the phone repeated. "I can't talk long."

"Oh." Adora was unable to hide her disappointment.

"I'm sorry darling. We'll have plenty of time for games this week."

"Right. How are things though?"

Her mother sighed softly, and she could picture her doing that tiny self-reassuring nod she always paired with that sound. "Well enough, the doctors gave her a clean bill and orders to eat the

kind of diet teenagers dream of. Her appetite's not quite there yet, but it's returning,"

Adora leaned back into the snow as she listened, spending the seconds looking up, naming familiar stars in her mind.

Sirius. Aldebaran. Vega. Castor and Pollux.

There was a planet there. Jupiter, she guessed, in the southwest. At some point Catra laid down as well, head near hers. She wondered where her ship was up in that big sky. If it was still up there.

"Well, I'm glad." Adora said when her mother was finished, smirking at how much it had sounded like a military briefing.

There was muffled talking in the background of the call. Adora caught Bow's voice, he was still there. When her mother spoke next, it was with the finality of a conversation soon to be cut short. "We'll be up tomorrow late morning or early afternoon. Please have the sledge ready."

"Yes ma'am." She replied over more talking. Tell her. You need to tell her!

Her mom pulled the phone away from her ear again. "I'm coming!" Then brought it back. "I have to go."

"But Mom there's one thing you should know about!"

"Adora, I'm sure it's very interesting but I really don't have time for . . ."

"But I really think you'll want to hear about it!"

Another sigh, more beleaguered this time. "Alright."

Adora leaped into her explanation, speaking fast. "Well, the night you left this crazy thing happened. There was a meteor that flew over the house and-" She was interrupted.

“Adora?”

“Yes?”

“Has the cabin burned down?”

“No, but-”

“Are you out of food?”

“No, but-”

“Then you can tell me in person. I love you, be safe, have a good night.” The call went dead and after a flash of disbelief, Adora groaned, putting her gloves over her face.

“Nice job.” Catra snarked.

“You’re hilarious.” Adora grumbled, pocketing her phone. With Catra’s ears, she shouldn’t be surprised that she could hear both sides of the call. She briefly considered sending a picture she had taken of Catra’s pod to her mother, then realized that that was probably something she didn’t want over the NSA-monitored internet.

Mercifully, Catra didn’t comment on that absolute failure of a conversation further, instead asking. “Your sister, she was sick?”

Oh right, Adora hadn’t told her. She bit her lip. “Something like that, yeah. That’s why I’m up here all alone. They ran out of the house the morning of the day you landed so fast I got left behind. She had to go to the hospital.”

Catra didn’t reply to that, and it was quiet for a minute. Then she surprised her. “You have a nice sky.” She announced, having apparently decided.

Adora smiled, pinching herself at that statement. An alien thought the Earth had a pretty sky. “Yeah, we do.” She sighed happily. The nights in the north prairie were alike to the landscape: vast and

untamed. Looking up at these skies was like looking through a fish eye lens. The ground seemed to pool at your feet, and the stars swept out and down close to fill your vision. On nights like these, you thought you just might be sucked up into them. The human and the alien looked up together, the former's family troubles receding into the back of her mind. Honestly, it was going to be easier to explain all this in person. "Hey. Which one are you from?"

"Huh?"

"Which star?" Adora swept a hand up across the dome of night, gesturing at the thousands of twinkling lights above them.

Catra laughed. "You can't see it from here."

"What?"

"It's too dim." Catra explained. "Too far away. Almost every star you can see here is within a couple hundred of your lightyears."

Even that 'small' distance boggled Adora's mind. "And how far are you? From Beast Island?"

"About 2000." She answered.

Adora was forced to childish reactions. "Wow. That's a lot. Which way then? If you can't point to it specifically?"

At this Catra squinted her eyes a little, looking around above them for landmarks. "Let's see . . . which one is . . ." One arm lifted; her first finger drifted until, "There." She pointed at an instantly familiar star pattern.

"Orion?"

"Everybody's got constellations, Adora." Catra glanced at her. "But see there, that fuzzy bit, just below the three stars."

“Yeah. The nebula?” She was pointing at Orion’s sword, which in reality was a huge cloud of gas, dust, and newly forming stars.

“Your species is smarter than you look.” Catra snarked. “Yeah, the nebula. I’m from the far side of that. Up and to the right a little bit. Somewhere in that spot is a crappy little yellow star, with a crappy little blue-green planet swinging round it.” Adora looked over at Catra, watching her hand fall back to her side. She could never imagine being that far from home. So far that every trace of it was invisible, as if it didn’t exist at all. She wished she had the telescope in her room at home here to try and find it.

“You miss it?” Adora asked.

“Not really.”

“Why not?”

“Never did much for me.” Catra answered plainly. “Always wanted to leave.”

“I get that.” Adora empathized. “Little towns on the edge of a big world. A big universe.” Catra hummed. It was getting cold. “Come on.” Adora stood and offered her hand. “Why don’t you tell me about it on the way down.”

“Why do you care?” Catra accepted her palm.

“Cause you’re my friend, stupid.” She chuffed.

“Right . . . right.”

Resist it. Resist it. Adora scratched her coat with a gloved hand. “And cause it’s just so amazing!” She burst gleefully. “C’mon Catra! You’re like a Sci-Fi character on this planet! Gimme something!”

“I’ve given you plenty already!”

“Pleasseee!” Adora clasped her gloves together.

“Don’t make me throw another snowball at you.” The alien warned.

“It doesn’t even have to be about your home planet. A space story! Anything!”

“Alright . . .” Catra groaned, starting down. “One day when I woke up it was before my scheduled sleep cycle was over, so I had time to brush all my fur out. I walked over to the refresher pod and used my good brush. It’s great because it really gets into all the tangles. So, I started on my arms and-”

“Catraaa!” Adora scowled.

The alien cackled. “Alright alright fine, Princess.”

“Really?” Adora lit up, not realizing until later that it was in response to that nickname. “You mean it?”

“If you start walking so we don’t freeze to death. Sure.” Catra started heading down.

Adora hurried with the two cups of hot chocolate and another bowl of popcorn back to the guest (Catra’s) bedroom, eyes passing over the dark corners of the cabin. At night like this, with only the glow of the kitchen behind her, she swore she could see the shadows moving. Shutting the door with her foot she distributed the goods, then checked that the blanket fort she had set up above the bed was holding well. She’d used ski poles as posts and hung blankets off them, creating a warm den lit by a camp lantern from within. Adora sat cross-legged next to Catra. “Alright, I’m ready.”

Catra rolled her eyes, then began. “So, we were deployed to a gas giant around an old star starting its giant phase and were monitoring how the planet heated up as it expanded. It had rings, like the ones around that one planet in your solar system, the sixth one? Anyway, we slipped into them to study the ice. They’re hundreds of thousands of miles wide but only one or two thick. I

deployed in a shuttle to this little band of ring between two shepherd moons. Their gravity collects the ice together. So it was me and my usual team, Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle-"

"Kyle?" Adora smirked.

"What?"

"Nothing, just that's a pretty human name." A meme-y human name.

"Well technically it's short for Kyligherian or something pompous." Catra shrugged off, as if not able to remember. "We all call him Kyle."

"What's he look like?" Adora wanted a picture.

"Like a nerd." Catra noted, and continued on, describing a house-sized icy asteroid in the rings they investigated. Catra, Adora found, was a surprsingly good storyteller. She spoke with the requisite gravitas and detail and had that dry wit that made Adora laugh. She quickly found herself engrossed.

"And then the shadow fell over us." She said, and Adora leaned forward. "I looked up, and there was a wave of icy asteroids, two miles high. The shepherd moon was coming. It dips above and below as it orbits, so it presses on the rings, making ripples. We only had a few minutes. I knew we had to get out of there, so I start yelling at Kyle to move his pasty ass right!? But he was just so fascinated he got STUCK!"

"No." Adora inhaled, completely absorbed.

"I know!" She shook her head and crossed her arms, obviously still mad about it. "His arm was jammed into this little wedge in the ice. Rogelio and Lonnie were pulling on him but he couldn't get free. The ice was shifting as the gravity did, pinning him even tighter. I brought the shuttle in close, literally looking over my shoulder out the open ramp at the back to line the three of them up with the cargo bay. The maneuvering thrusters, they shoot out

hot high-pressure gas to push the ship around in space. They were blasting the three of them and the asteroid as I did. They're all shouting. Different instructions, '*LEFT!' 'RIGHT!' 'UP' 'UP!'* All something different of course.

'*Use the damn ice pick!*' I shout back at them.

'*We don't want to hit his suit!*' Lonnie said.

Now, I didn't give a damn about his suit at this point. There's ice everywhere, battering the windshield, the sides of the shuttle. The wave is almost on us. No time to hesitate. So, I slam the reverse thrusters. The ship shoots back, right around those three idiots and whacks the asteroid.

Lonnie was all swears. '*You're going to crush us!*" Catra cackled. "I ask if they can pull him out and of course, they still can't. Now, technically I may have dented the frame of the shuttle a little when I reversed but I also wedged the thing in there, so I say, '*GRAB ON!'*, and once they do, I thrust forward. Firing hot exhaust into ice like that: it flashes straight to a gas. It's like a hurricane inside the shuttle. Hailstones banging against everything. I glance back and watch as the asteroid suddenly shatters into two! Kyle's free as we're thrown forward. I accidentally ripped Lonnie's arm out of its socket before I could throttle down, but hey! It worked!

As soon as I get us out of the ring, I go back to make sure everybody's okay. Kyle sits up and holds out a stupid rock in his hands." Catra put on a nasally voice. "'*I got the sample, Force Captain Catra*!'" Adora started laughing. "He couldn't get his arm out because he wouldn't let go of a damn rock!" She put her hand on her forehead. "Stars Adora . . . Honestly if I had to bet on anyone getting stranded on an alien planet it would be that dork. Nearly dies over a sample. You should consider yourself lucky Princess, you'd've been driven insane by now if you were stuck with him."

Adora was still laughing. Wiping her eyes, she sassed. "Oh yeah cause you're suchhh a stress reliever."

“I’m a pleasure sweeter than First-Ones wine!” Catra insisted.

“Unaged wine.”

“Hey!” She sneered at her.

Adora snorted. "You know, for an alien diplomat you sure are a grouch!"

"Ugh." Catra somehow rolled her eyes even more sarcastically. "You know I'm not a diplomat. I'm here because I'm stuck. I'm not here to probe you. And I'm not here to make friends."

"Yeah, sure." Adora said.

Catra scoffed and continued. "I'm just here to hijack your tech and use it to hitchhike my way home, to use some cool human slang." She waggled her fingers in her direction. "Trust me Adora, I definitely do not want you to 'take me to your leader'"

"Ooo, you guys have that phase too?" The human noted.

Catra seemed off-put. "Yeah, sure, what else would we say?"

"I come in peace?" She offered with an eyebrow raised.

Catra reached towards Adora and posed her hand like a claw, sharp nails extending. "What, that wasn't obvious from the start?" She said, head tilted, smirk somehow both serious and sarcastic simultaneously.

Adora pushed the hand away. "Maybe to some." She admitted. "But I know you're just a big softie inside too."

"What!?" Catra gaped. "I-I AM NOT!" Her voice was shrill. "SHUT UP!"

"Only once you admit I'm riggghhht." Adora lilted, grabbed another handful of popcorn, chewing confidently. They were going through a lot of popcorn.

"Uhh NO. Not gonna happen."

Adora said nothing, just continued to look at the alien castaway, smile fixed and smarmy.

"Stop looking at me like that!"

Adora didn't move a muscle.

"Grrr." Catra growled, then suddenly leapt on Adora. She squeaked in shock the moment the furball landed against her, and suddenly they were wrestling, arms flailing and grabbing one another as Catra tried to pin her down.

Adora laughed while trying to stay focused. Yep, she really was strong and fast! "Oh no! You're sooo tough!" She sneered good-naturedly, fending off the hands, managing to grab a pillow behind her and flail it into Catra's face. The 'boof!' was very satisfying: another human tradition for Catra to knock off her list.

"Your species are dicks!" Catra wrestled, and after another twenty seconds of a truly spectacular display of fighting skills from the martial art of basically-just-slapping-at-each-other, Catra stopped playing and quickly pinned Adora's arms above her head. She snarled in victory, a very animalistic sound, leaning down near Adora's face to gloat.

But Adora didn't hear what Catra said. With her legs pinched between Catra's thighs and arms locked in place, the fun part of fun and games evaporated in an instant, and the sassy teenager with a tail became an alien shadow looming over her in the dark again. The ghost of the knife to her neck reflected glowing eyes. Adora stiffened, breath going shallow. It took Catra a second to notice the change. "Whoa, hey, Adora. Are you okay?"

Adora nodded sharply, her eyes slammed shut. Numb arms pushed up at Catra. When the alien realized what she was trying to do she practically jumped back, and Adora noted distantly that she slid back to kneel on the bed a few feet away. "Shit." Catra whispered.

Adora took a deep breath, trying to stop her brain from plunging. It had been a long time since she'd had a panic attack. She wasn't going to have one tonight. She **wasn't** going to have one tonight. Her racing heart slowed. Catra wasn't a threat.

After repeating that last bit to herself several times, Adora looked up and saw the girl sitting across from her was just that, a girl. One who was a prickly cactus to be sure, but nothing more dangerous. "Yeah . . ." She said, exhaling. "See, just a big softie."

". . . Stars Adora." Catra muttered, looking away to hide her face, but she couldn't completely mask the relief.

Adora chuckled, but the tussle and fear had sapped her. It had been a long day, and now it really felt like it. Without trying to slow herself, she collapsed backwards, enjoying the satisfying rush of air through the bedsheets. She breathed slowly, feeling the night settle on her, and listened to the subtle sounds of the house in winter for a moment. The soft thrum of hot water running through the radiator pipes. The occasionally settling creak of wood. Catra didn't apologize, but Adora could tell she was sincere in her hesitation to come closer to Adora again. When she did speak, it was to say, "Your family gets here tomorrow."

Adora nodded solemnly. "Yes."

A pause. "What are we going to do?"

Adora, under her closed eyelids, smiled a little. She liked that there was a 'we'. "I don't know." She admitted, too exhausted to want to think about the big conversation. "We'll come up with a plan in the morning 'kay? When we clean the basement." The basement **had** to be clean before they got here.

Adora heard Catra's tail swish nervously. "Okay." She agreed. "Are you gonna leave this bed?"

"Not unless you're going to carry me out of it." Adora admitted, stretching her back and feeling a satisfying crack. Ah, there we go. She melted deeper into the covers.

"Lazy." Catra snipped.

"Ungrateful." Adora cracked right back.

"Dork."

"Slouch."

"Know-it-all."

"Freeloader."

"Princess."

"Bitch." Adora ended with, and was happy when Catra released a breathy laugh instead of any genuine annoyance. She seemed to enjoy having her buttons pushed, so long as she didn't push them too hard. Adora felt the same. "Catra?" She called.

"Yeah?" She purred, obviously also tired now.

"I'm glad you landed here."

There was silence for a long time. "Me too, Adora."

"Adora Grayskull!" A sheer voice shattered Adora's dream like a hammer to glass. Startling awake, she looked up from the guest bed, rubbing her eyes of sleep to find her mother, Angella Brightmoon, standing over her, hands on her hips and toe tapping on the rug. Adora's eyes widened. Her father Micah was standing next to him, equally staggered. "What is the meaning of this!?"

Adora looked down. Catra was sleeping at the end of the bed, curled up into a tight ball, which was as adorable as it was a huge problem. "Five more minutes." She muttered.

"I . . . can explain."

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Description of dislocated shoulder, mild panic attack

Phew, longest chapter so far, but now we're cooking.

Also I want to note that I made an edit after posting the last chapter, adding two words to clarify that Shadow Weaver is the captain of the Fright Zone (and thus Catra's boss).

Also also I think this is the ideal opportunity to link the piece of art that inspired the last scene and this whole fanfic. I love Ikimaru's art style and when I saw this picture of what looks like Catra revealing secrets to an excited and a little out of the loop looking Adora, it turned into this huge adventure were on now.

Chapter 5: Moonrise

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora, sitting up, started to shake Catra awake.

"Who is this person!?" Her mother was saying. "Adora!"

"Mom!?" Glimmer's voice echoed from the depths of the house. Crap Glimmer. "Why is the shower rod ripped off the wall in the bathroom!?"

And Adora had forgotten about that. She swallowed loudly, meeting her mother's withering gaze. "I can explain that too." Catra still wasn't awake. "CATRA!" She shoved her.

"Wha-! What!?" Catra stirred, and in a second was standing at attention beside the bed as if roused for a military drill. "I'm ready . . . oh . . ."

For a moment, her parents were completely distracted by Catra's appearance, and they both took a big step back. Adora managed to untangle herself from the sheets and stand, moving between them. Her mother reached out to try and pull her away from the alien, but she stopped her. "Mom, Dad. It's okay. This is Catra. She's . . . an alien . . . from outer space." God, she sounded crazy. "Her escape pod crashed the night after you left. I rode out and found her unconscious. She's not dangerous Mom, she's just lost. I had to help her."

Both her parent's eyes were very wide. They glanced at each other, then at Adora, then back to Catra, where they became stuck. "I . . ." Her father tried, then cleared his throat. "You know, I have to give points for creativity at least."

"Micah!" Her mother exclaimed, head whipping to look at him, causing her long gently curled hair to – oh WOW her hair. She had

dyed it: pink with a purple underlayer. She must have done that to match-

"What's going on?"

Glimmer.

Adora turned to see her sister appear in the doorway, and her heart clenched. She fought hard not to immediately rush up to her and . . . she wasn't sure what but . . . Glimmer. She looked, in a word: awful. Exhausted beyond belief, the skin under her eyes was so dark it looked eye-black. Her cotton candy hair was a mess. The short boyish style she kept it in unbrushed, tufts sticking out in various directions. She was slouching too. Her shorter stature magnified by a sense that gravity was pulling down at every part of her more than it should be. But worst of all, that sparkle in her light brown eyes was dulled, dun and absent of the vigor that Adora had never considered optional. Glimmer without her gleam, it was a tragedy.

"Who . . . What is that?" Glimmer asked, pointing at Catra. Her voice was hoarse and scratchy.

"Glimmer I-" Adora began.

"Young lady." Angella snapped Adora's attention back to her with that tone that was never good. Angella, by contrast, was a towering presence. Literally, Adora was already tall, and her foster mother had a head and neck over that, accentuated by her perfect poised posture. Her oval face was like a pale pearl, makeup expertly applied, and even though it currently wore a scowl, not a single crease or wrinkle blemished it. "We leave for three days . . ." She pinched her nose. "and you . . . you allow *this* into our home without asking, without telling us?" She gestured at Catra like some sick or potentially dangerous animal. Catra herself looked like she was as much insulted as she wanted to be anywhere else.

Adora looked down at her feet, her cheeks red. Through a nearly closed throat, she managed to say. “I tried to.”

“Well perhaps you should have started with the fact that they were . . . well.”

“I didn’t know what to say. I didn’t think you would believe me.” Adora implored.

Angella sighed. “Still Adora,” She began but was stayed by Micah’s hand on her shoulder.

“I wouldn’t have Angie.” He said to her softly, having realized this wasn't a prank. Micah and Angella were an interesting couple to see next to each other, with him being over a foot shorter than her. His stocky physique, warm eyes, and salt and pepper beard contrasted with Angella’s regal height, sharp shoulders, and imperious aquiline nose. It was pretty obvious who Glimmer took after more, even if the three currently seemed to share the same level of exhaustion. Adora desperately wanted to hug them all.

“This is a lot to take in. I . . .” Angella began then trailed off. She was actually speechless. Adora had managed to make her mother speechless. It was terrifying. After a moment of thinking, she turned to the alien. “You there. Catra, was it? Can you speak English?”

“Yes.” Catra said, then added, “ma’am.” a second later. Glimmer’s eyes bugged out.

“Is what my daughter saying true?”

“Yes ma’am.”

Adora saw both adults shudder a little. “And has she helped you, since you arrived here?”

“She has.”

Angella looked back at Adora, and she leapt into a brief explanation of how she came to find Catra. When the story was finished her mother released a beleaguered breath. "Adora, could you please go and hook up the sledge to one of the machines and start unloading the truck? I'm sure your grandmother wouldn't want to be left in the cold for too long. We'll discuss the rest of **this** when you get back."

Grandma was here? Wow, it had been serious then. "Sure thing, Mom." Adora nodded, then tempted fate by asking. "Can Catra help?" Catra looked annoyed to be – as her father loved to call it - *voluntold* to come along, then seemed to decide it was probably preferable to staying here with her family.

"If you trust her, then I suppose she can." Angella consented.

"Thanks." She grabbed Catra by the wrist to get her out of there, dragging her towards the door. They passed Glimmer on the way by. Adora stopped briefly. "Umm . . . hi."

"Hi." Glimmer replied, but was lock focused on Catra.

Adora pursed her lips, then quickly ducked in to hug Glimmer, not too tightly. "It's good to see you." She said, voice dangerously close to breaking. The Brightmoons followed them out the door as if still trying to believe what they were seeing as the two of them absconded down the stairs. That . . . actually could have gone worse.

Adora opened the garage and had Catra haul the sledge, which was little more than a wagon with some old skies screwed on as runners, out into the open. Ignore the fact you never cleaned up the radio and that it was still all over the floor. Ignore that. One thing at a time. Adora drove the Polaris out and lined it up so they could connect the two, turning the sledge into a trailer. Catra jumped behind Adora and held on as they drove up the steep snow-drowned driveway. Their family pick-up truck sat at the top next to the mailbox. Its paint that was either gold or beige depending on how nice you were feeling was splattered with road

grime and dirty snow. Adora pulled to a stop behind it, where some plastic boxes had been laid out, Grandma's bag amongst them. She climbed off the sled and headed for the back door of the crew cab, opening it.

"Mara dearie!" The little frail woman inside the car blossomed. She leaned out to hug her. "Merry Christmas!"

"It's Adora, Grannie Razz." Adora put on a smile and tried her best not to be bothered.

"Oh?" She leaned away and adjusted her very thick glasses. "So it is! Hello Adora!"

"Hi Grannie Razz. Merry Christmas."

"It's good to see you, Darling. How have you been holding up? Are you eating?" She asked in her particular thick accent Adora had never been able to place.

"Yes, Grandma." She smiled, then helped her down. As soon as she was out of the car, a white streak blew past them both.

"Swiftwind!" Adora cheered. The extremely fluffy Samoyed turned from where he was running circles in the snow and literally leapt up into her arms. "Oof!" She caught forty pounds of excited wriggling dog. "Haha! I'm-pfplllft augh!" She squealed as she was assaulted with kisses. "Stahp!" Adora laughed. "I missed you too!" She held him out to look into his bright blue eyes. Little cutie. Razz liked to take him when she wintered in Arizona, so it had been a couple of months since she'd seen him. The weather here disagreed with Razz's bones as much as it agreed with Swiftwind's coat. Normally they had a 'second Christmas' in April to make up for both their absence, but she guessed that wouldn't be happening this year.

As soon as the dog was set back down in the snow and had sufficiently sniffed Adora's boots, the white blur was on Catra, running up to the stranger and barking excitedly. A sound not

unlike a shrieking yowl split the air, and an instant later Catra was on top of the truck, crouched and hissing at the canine.

"You're a walking cliché." Adora shook her head.

“You didn’t tell me a wild animal was coming!” She snarled back, eyes returning to Swiftwind, who was jumping up and yipping at Catra.

“He’s not wild!” She balked.

“Who is your friend Adora?” Grannie Razz appeared at Adora’s side. Standing, she didn’t even make it to Adora’s shoulders. Her big puffy coat was a violent purple against the otherwise natural landscape, and her hair, unable to be contained by any hat or hood, spilled down to her waist in huge silver curls.

“This is Catra. Catra, this is my grandma, Razz. Catra is . . . an alien.”

“Ohhhh.” Grandma Razz noted with a long sound. “That makes sense.” She released a short ‘Hah!’ “The ears. Come on now Adora. Let’s get inside before my giblets freeze!”

“Too much information, Grannie Razz.” Adora said as Razz picked up Swiftwind and then sat in the sledge for the drive back down. Well, that also could have also gone way worse. Apparently, Razz either didn’t understand what Adora had just said about aliens, or simply didn’t care. It was probably the latter, she was an awesome old lady. “Come on Catra, let’s get this stuff loaded.”

Their chauffeur service ended at her parents standing in the garage, staring at the wreckage of the radio strewn about. “Adora,” Angella said with a darkness that made her soul cower.

She jumped off the snowmobile. “We meant to clean all this up before you got here!” She cried, practically falling to her knees before her. “We just . . . lost track of time.”

“You will clean this mess us.” She decreed. “Then we will talk.”

“Yes ma’am.” She swallowed and immediately ran to start picking up pieces.

“What even is this stuff?" Micah asked, scratching his beard. "How did it get everywhere?”

“Umm . . .” Adora looked at Catra, who narrowed her eyes. “Catra’s radio might have had a mild case of . . . exploding.”

“ADORA!” Angella cried.

“I know I know! But it was her only way of contacting home! She tried to use it to . . . but it . . . well . . .”

Angella shook her head. “We’ll be upstairs.” She left with Micah and Razz and everything they’d brought, but not before turning back to have one last word. “I’m disappointed in you, Adora.”

The world stopped. Adora lurched. Her mouth turned bone dry and her hands started to shake. “Come on Adora.” Catra walked past her to begin.

“I . . . yeah.” She took a step forward but felt her muscles give out. Her knees struck the hard concrete, and she quailed. Catra turned, huge eyes concerned. “Haha.” Adora tried to pass it off. “Whoops!” She wobbled back up onto her soles. “Us humans and our jelly legs, you know.”

Catra didn’t say anything, and they picked up the broken pieces of the radio in silence. When all but the smallest scraps were gone, Adora got out a snow shovel and ran it back and forth across the floor, picking up all the little metal shards and chips of glass. As Adora carefully scraped them all into the waiting dustpan Catra was holding, the alien broke the silence. “Shadow Weaver, she-” She said, struggling, ears flattened and tail tense and straight. Adora blinked her wet eyes. “It hurts. I know.” She managed.

Adora took a deep breath and nodded.

Upstairs was quiet. But no longer eerily so, as it had been over the past few days. Razz was baking already; a pie dough being rolled flat on the dusty counter. Glimmer was beside her, cutting berries for the filling. Adora watched her quarter strawberries with a tired hand, humming a half-remembered song. "Glimmer." She called her eyes. "I-"

"Adora." Micah's voice.

Right, she had already forgotten. Glimmer looked at their father, then back to Adora. "Sure thing, Dad." Adora followed him into the master bedroom, where Angella was already waiting, sitting at the foot of the bed. Micah closed the door behind them and gestured for Adora to sit. She elected to stand, facing them as she told them both the whole story of the past three days. And by whole, she meant everything except for all the irresponsible and or life-threatening parts. The knife incident, the snowmobile joyride, her dislocated shoulder, the truth of how the radio had been destroyed. Those they didn't need to know, which was stressful because Adora was a **bad** liar. But if they suspected anything was being omitted, they didn't show it.

"And so Catra and I have been just hanging out while we figure out how to get in contact with her people. We've watched movies, eaten marshmallows, etcetera etcetera."

Micah exhaled. "Well, we're glad you've been able to be helpful." There was a 'but' coming. "But," Yep. "this alien, this person. You don't think she might be here to harm us?"

"No." Adora replied immediately.

"You don't think she's a risk to you, or the family, or the entire planet?" Angella repeated, looking bewildered to be even considering that last one.

"She's told me so much about her civilization Mom! It's a multicultural melting pot with hundreds of species working together. She serves on a science vessel, an exploration ship. She

just wants to go home.” Her parents looked at each other, clearly not entirely convinced.

“You’re certain?” Angella stressed.

“She’s always been honest,” Adora said. “and she has made us rich so . . .”

“Rich?” Micah asked.

Adora realized she hadn’t mentioned the case yet. “One sec!” She said excitedly and ran to get it, dragging it back into the room with her. Kneeling, she felt like a mob boss as undid the latch and lifted the lid, passing them a slip of gold each. “Merry Christmas?”

Cue another stunned silence, where Adora found herself wringing her hands nervously. She felt sick. She hadn’t taken getting the house clean seriously enough. But Catra had been so upset and Adora had been so tired last night - gah! That was no excuse. This shouldn’t have snuck up on her, and she should have had a better backup plan in case she ended up in this situation: having not gotten Catra home yet. Now her future depended on how Angella and Micah took to this not-so-great first impression. Crap crap crap. After her parents’ shock had passed, they pulled off that freaky brain-melding trick where they had a conversation entirely without speaking. Sometimes Adora wondered if they were aliens.

“Alright Adora.” Angella began again. “This is . . . wonderful, and your goal of getting Catra home is admirable. But by your own admission, her only way of contacting her people is ruined.”

“We can try and find another way,” Adora explained Catra’s HAM radio idea. “and even if that doesn’t work, we’ve got the resources to build something that will.” She held up another gold slip.

“I’m not so sure about that.” Micah said, breaking Adora’s confidence. “Where did Catra crash?”

“About a mile from here.” Adora said. “In that wood past the Thaymors' cabin.”

Micah nodded. “And what happens if a meteor falls on your land?”

Adora narrowed her eyes, searching for a trick question before answering. “You get to keep it.” She said, then realized the problem. “Oh.”

“Exactly. It’s not our land, so it’s not our gold.”

“But it’s Catra’s case!” Adora insisted. “She gave it to us!”

“And that’s another problem.” Micah revealed. “Catra is an illegal alien, literally. She's not human. Which means technically she has no rights on this planet.”

“. . . But she’s a person.” Adora said. “Not some meteorite.”

Micah rubbed his temple. “All of this is something a court would have to figure out but, probably? She’d be treated as a stateless person. That would give her some rights, but it also means if the government comes and demands we give her or her gold to them, we can't refuse.”

“What? We can’t just turn her over!”

Micah put up a hand. “We don’t have the luxury of making the rules. Now, technically what you’ve done so far isn’t harboring - capital H harboring – because you haven’t attempted to conceal or shield her from the authorities, but if they come, and you do, you will be guilty of a federal crime.” Adora’s heart clenched, and she was annoyed at how well-versed in law her father was. He was on the Board of Education for Christ’s sake, not a lawyer.

“We just think it might be wise to contact the authorities now.” Angella said. “After all, they’re probably better equipped to help Catra than we are.”

Adora paled. “But what will the government do with her? You said it yourself, she’s not technically a legal person. What if they don’t treat her like one? They could take her! Dissect her! Lock her away forever!”

“Adora.”

“Plus, even if they do want to help her, we don’t have time for that! We have to help get Catra home now before her ship like . . . leaves her behind!” Adora realized she needed to ask if that was a possibility because wow that was a whole other level of stress to add on top of this situation.

“Adora.”

“I’m not just going to sit by and let that happen. She’s my friend. She’s my friend and I promised I’d try and get her home!”

“Adora!” Angella raised her voice, and Adora realized how worked up she was getting. She shuddered, and let out the anger.

“Sorry.” She whispered.

“Your heart is in the right place, Adora.” Angella said gently. “We can see what we can do for Catra right now, but what’s most important is that we’re all together for Christmas. We need you to focus on this family.”

Adora was silent for a moment. “Do you understand, Sunbeam?” Micah asked.

Adora hated how he was using that nickname right now. He knew she really liked it. “Yes.”

“Good.” Angella said. “Now, could you go ask Catra here?” Adora nodded. Gotta interrogate the both of them, makes sense. Her parents stood and wrapped their arms around her. She hugged back, squeezing once. “Adora,” Her mother said last. “about Glimmer,”

“I know. I’ll talk to her.”

The pie was baking when she got back to the kitchen, Catra was there, staring into the oven.

“Will your ship leave you behind?” Adora asked. “If you don’t get you back soon enough.”

Catra looked over. “Yeah, we have a few weeks probably.”

Adora nodded, then sent her to her doom before looking for Glimmer. She was in their bedroom, the second twin bed now occupied. “Knock knock.” She called through the cracked door.

“Could you turn up the lights a little?” Glimmer’s hoarse voice came back. Adora entered and moved the slider on the light switch. The amber bulbs above glowed brighter, revealing Glimmer sitting prone on her bed, a book Adora hadn’t seen before in her hands. She was deep into it. “Thanks.”

Adora leaned against the doorframe. “Did you get that while you were . . .”

“The hospital had a library.” She explained, flipping a page. “Well, shelf more like. I had Mom check it out at the real library for me.”

“Well, I bet it’s much more interesting than trying to force my way through *The Outsiders*.” She referenced their required English book from last semester.

Gimmer twisted her lip behind the spine. “You didn’t like that? I thought it was pretty good.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. What was wrong with it?”

Adora made a pensive sound. “It’s just so . . . old.”

Glimmer chuffed. “You’re old Adora.”

“Eleven months older than you, old lady.”

“Thank you for proving my point. Or as the kids say, I know you are but what am I?”

Adora laughed. “It really is good to see you, Glimmer. I’m so glad you’re okay.” Only now did Glimmer put the book down, closing it and sitting up to look at her. Silence filled the room. When it stretched long enough that Adora was sure Glimmer wouldn’t answer, she sighed. “Glimmer . . .” Adora ran her hand through her ponytail. “I am so so sorry, for what happened. For . . . if I could have done anything . . .”

“If?”

“I should have done more.” Adora immediately backstepped. “I should have been there . . . should have seen.” She moved and sat on the bedside; hands folded in her lap as she took quick glances at her sister whenever she found the nerve. She had her head down. Adora felt her eyes getting wet. “And I . . . I’m just . . . I’m just sorry.” She wished desperately to stand, to run, to be able to **do something!** But she willed her body to stay, imagining her socks binding with the carpet.

“Adora.” Glimmer said.

Adora’s tears were the tide. The more she fought it, the more she risked getting swept away. “When it happened I just . . .” She continued. “I knew you were going through a hard time but I never thought . . . and when it happened, I just woke up and everyone was gone! I thought . . .” She sniffled, lip curling. “It took me a bit to find the note, and when I called and they said you were in critical condition I . . . I didn’t know what to do. I’m sorry I couldn’t’ve been there. I know I can be a heavy sleeper but,” She let out a laugh, a bitter dejected one. “never thought I’d be . . .” So useless, she didn’t finish.

“It’s in the past now, Adora.” Glimmer didn’t forgive, but perhaps acknowledged. “Obviously what happened happened, and most of

it is on, and is for, me, but I also . . . You didn't make it any easier, Adora. I just wish . . . I wish I felt like my sister had my back, you know? And you haven't, and I've been disappointed in you, Adora." She heard the sound of Glimmer's sleeve against her cheek. "God, I sound like Mom." She laughed an equally depressing laugh. "Ew."

Adora turned back to Glimmer in a flash. "I had this whole plan for when you got here but then Catra came in and it all went crazy!" Glimmer stiffened as Adora clamped her hands on her shoulders. "You should have seen it Glimmer; she turned the kitchen into a warzone!"

"What?"

"There was flour, everywhere." Adora gave a thousand-yard stare. "And I understand, cause she's an alien, who doesn't really know what's going on but-"

"Adora!" Glimmer raised her voice slightly. "Why are we talking about this?"

Oh. "It's-" An excuse. Adora's brain said. No. "I want your help."

"My help?"

"If Catra doesn't get home, Mom and Dad are going to hand her over to the government. But you know what that means. She'll be locked up, or worse!"

Adora could see the gears in Glimmer's head turning, taking several seconds to catch up. "Are you sure that's what's going to happen?"

"Do you need me to name half a dozen alien movies?" Adora asked.

"Movies, Adora. Movies."

“I know but,” She urged. Glimmer rolled her eyes. “I made a promise Glimmer.” She appealed. “I need to find a way.”

“And I can help with this how?”

“By calling Bow.”

“Bow?”

“His HAM Radio.” Adora explained. “He probably can figure out a way to contact Catra’s ship! Glimmer I know you don’t want to get thrown into a whole thing right now. Trust me, I understand. But Catra, she doesn’t have time. Her life could be at stake if we don’t do this. Please, can you just call Bow for me?

“Call him yourself!” She balked. “He’s your friend too!”

“More yours! What would I tell him?”

“I don’t know!? What would I tell him!?”

Adora exhaled sharply. “Please Glimmer.”

Glimmer looked at her like she was the alien, then huffed. “Fine, come on. I gotta show you what Dad bought anyway.”

“What is it?” Adora asked as they stepped out onto the deck, leaving the door open.

Glimmer knelt in the hardened snow, flipping the tripod legs of a spindly tower out. It had a dish on top, which she lifted on its telescoping pole and pointed towards the sky before plugging in a cable that led into the house. “It’s a satellite internet booster.” She explained, flipping a switch. A green LED blinked on the contraption. “Behold!” She lifted up her phone, and Adora stepped in close to watch in awe as a 3G signal appeared.

“Holy . . .” Adora whispered. “Dad bought this? I thought he said internet at the cabin was ‘sacrilege’.”

“Yeah, well . . . that was before you know what, wasn’t it?” She said lowly, dialing Bow. He picked up almost immediately.

“Heyy Glimmer! How’s it going?” Adora could hear his voice muffled through the phone and Glimmer’s ear.

“Hey Bow, and good.” Glimmer said. “I’m at the cabin now.”

“Nice! I can hear the new tech is working well.”

“Yeah!” Glimmer agreed, and over the next few minutes, they had a short catch-up conversation. Adora waited until she got impatient, eventually prodding Glimmer in the shoulder, who swatted at her but got to the question. “Hey, so the reason I’m calling is I’ve got a question. An engineering question.”

“Oh?” Bow’s voice lifted; interest clearly piqued.

“What’s going on?” Catra asked suddenly, appearing right behind Adora, who nearly jumped out of her skin.

“Catra!” She whispered angrily at her. Adora just got that smirk back as Catra sat cross-legged with her back against the glass. Well, at least she had survived the conversation with her parents with her attitude intact.

“Why do you have the door open?” Catra asked.

“Shhh!”

“Who’s that?” Bow asked through the phone.

“Nobody!” Glimmer replied too loudly. “Just Adora.” She put the phone on speaker.

“Hey Bow.” Adora said, glad Glimmer was keeping the secret. The fewer people who knew about Catra before she could get home, the better chance she had of staying out of a government lab.

“Sup Adora!” He said brightly.

“So, in theory, Bow." Glimmer began.

"Mmmhmm."

"If I wanted to contact an alien spaceship . . ." She hesitated, clearly trying to remember what Adora told her to ask.

"I'm this solar system." Adora whispered.

"In this solar system," Glimmer repeated. "with radio signals. How could I . . . do that?"

"Where is this coming from?"

“Oh.” Glimmer blanked.

“Just a conversation we had earlier.” Adora filled in.

Bow chuckled. “Glimmer do you wanna seem smart in front of - you know what, never mind. Well,” Bow started talking in that dorky way he did when having a problem to solve. “with my HAM radio you can get some pretty good signal strength. I’ve actually been meaning to try and contact the International Space Station; cause apparently you can do that!” Adora’s eyes lit up at that suggestion. She would have to ask to be there for the attempt. “But I imagine an alien ship wouldn’t be able to pick up similar signals unless it was in low Earth orbit . . .” Adora looked at Catra, who shook her head no. “After that, the best place would probably be a radio telescope somewhere. Places like the Arecibo telescope could send huge message pulses out into deep space."

"Didn't that collapse a couple years ago?" Adora asked. She remembered reading an article on it.

"Well actually yeah, it did." Bow replied, suddenly very downtrodden. Adora swore she heard a sniffle.

"Where's the nearest place we could do it?” Glimmer asked.

"Well . . . probably at Goldstone." Bow explained. "It's the American Deep Space Network connection point. They talk to the Mars rovers there." Adora pulled out her phone and started googling, the 3G signal taking forever to return results. She was quickly disappointed. It was in southern California, near the Nevada border. It was also familiar. “Wait . . . this is where Auntie Casta works.” She realized.

“Ohh yeah!” Bow’s voice lit up. “Is she still a mission operations manager for NASA there?”

“Aunt Castaspella . . .” Glimmer rubbed her chin. “I think so . . . God.” She snapped her fingers in frustration, then shouted into the house. "Mom! Where does Auntie Casta work again!?"

"In Fort Irwin for NASA!" Angella replied from somewhere else in the house. "It's in the Mojave." A pause. "Why do you want to know?"

"No reason!" Glimmer fibbed. "Just thought of her!" She looked at Adora, whose brain was flooding with ideas. They didn’t hear from her too often, probably because her schedule was most often based on the time zones of planets other than Earth, but still. Someone on the inside like that. It was a fantastic chance.

“Adora, did you really ask Glimmer about radio telescopes?” Bow continued. “Doesn’t really seem like a . . . you topic.”

“What!?” Adora blew a razzberry. “Of course I know about radio telescopes. I’m the space person. You know how they have the . . . radio part and the . . . telescope part.”

“This is pretty weird. You guys are being weird.” Bow said, but before he could press further he was interrupted.

“Why do you three have the door open!?” Angella suddenly appeared above them. “The internet makes it from space it can get through quarter-inch glass! You’re letting all the heat out!” Glimmer cringed and darted inside, stepping over Catra. “Honestly

Glimmer, why do you always do things like-” Angella suddenly stopped herself in her tracks, eyes widening.

Glimmer looked at her with a sad expression as she shut the door. “Sorry Mom.”

Angella took a moment to take a breath before asking the group. “It's alright. Could we talk for a second?”

“Sure." Glimmer said, making quick goodbyes. "Sorry Bow, gotta go. Like you lots.”

“Oh, um, you too, have fun up there! Text me! Bye Adora!”

“Bye Bow.” Adora waved at the phone, even though he couldn’t see it.

“Bye Bow, will do.” Glimmer ended the call, assuring Angella that they hadn’t mentioned Catra. Which was good because the ‘talk with the group’ turned out to be a lecture about not telling anyone anyway, followed by a question.

“Glimmer,” Their mother asked. “could you help cook dinner?”

Glimmer pursed her lips. Hesitantly, she said. “I already helped with the pie.”

“Oh, yes.” She nodded. “Adora?”

“I’ll be right there, lemme wash my hands.” She ran for the bathroom. “Thanks a million, Glimmer.”

Over the sink, Adora braced her hands and exhaled in relief. “We’ve got a chance.” She whispered.

“You think we do?” Catra asked from the doorway.

“Yeah.” Adora nodded. “I think so. I can call Casta tonight after dinner. If you can give me a frequency to broadcast on and a direction to point, hopefully, she can send a message.”

“The manual will tell me that stuff.” Catra said.

Adora knew that convincing a government employee to use its massive hardware for personal reasons probably wasn’t going to be easy, but Castaspella always liked Adora. She would convince her, somehow. She had to. “What did my parents say to you?” Adora asked Catra.

“Threats, mostly.” Catra admitted casually. Adora's eyes went wide. “Relax. They hid them behind nice words. But it was pretty clear I should be ‘watching myself’ around here, or else.”

Or else they’d call the cops right now, rather than after giving Adora a chance to help Catra. “At least they’re not locking you in a closet.”

Catra chuckled. “Like that could keep me. No offense Adora but the Grayskull household isn’t exactly a high-security prison.”

“Brightmoon.” Adora corrected automatically.

“What?”

Oh. Right. “It’s mine and the Brightmoons' house. Angella, Micah, and Glimmer Brightmoon.” Adora said.

“I assumed your other name was a family thing.” Catra said. “They called you Grayskull. Is it an honor title?”

Adora chuffed. “I wish I knew. I’m adopted, Catra.” She paused, not sure whether she wanted to tell this story so soon. “My name was the only thing my birthmother ever gave me. A handwritten note at the orphanage I was left at as a baby. It’s not even a real name, We’ve never been able to find anyone else with it, and we’ve checked, thoroughly. Everyone thinks it’s made up to throw anyone trying to find my bio-parents off their scent.”

Catra’s ears drooped. She glanced towards the rest of this house to make sure they were alone, then spoke more softly than Adora thought was possible for her. "I never had anyone else either, as a

kid.” Wow, two big Catra secrets in one day. Adora walked up and hugged her lightly. “What are you doing?” She asked tensely.

“Relax, it’s a human thing.” Adora joked, breaking it after a moment. “Did you not notice I don’t look much like my family?” Adora asked.

“How should I know how different humans should look from one another?” Catra replied, brusque. “People in the same family could have different numbers of arms for all I know.”

Adora smiled, then turned to head to the kitchen, but Catra didn’t step out of the way in the hallway.

“You not being biologically related to your aunt: that won’t affect things, will it?” She asked.

Adora was quiet for a second. “No.” She said, putting a hand on Catra’s arm. “Don’t worry, okay?”

Adora noticed movement and looked over to see Glimmer watching the both of them from further down the hallway with a stony expression. Suddenly the hand on Catra felt very personal. She pulled it away before going to help cook.

Glimmer was very confused. I mean, seriously! She had been gone three days only to get back and find Adora getting along with this complete stranger like they’d known each other for years. She watched them come upstairs after cleaning some mess they’d made in the garage, quipping and bouncing off one another like it was the most natural thing in the world. As she was slicing berries for Razz the alien jabbed at Adora for having stupid hair, only for her sister to quip right back by grabbing a lock of her wild mane and tickling her under the nose with it, causing her to sneeze. It was a soft squeaking noise that Adora seemed to find ‘adorable’, but made Glimmer’s hand slip, cutting her fingertip on the knife she was using.

Once the pies were in the oven, her finger was bandaged, and Adora was being good cop bad copped, Glimmer unpacked the - now second - backpack she'd brought up here, setting the various pamphlets she had been given at the hospital in her beside drawer where Adora wouldn't find them. There would be time for that later. Stepping back out into the hallway she jumped when saw the alien - Catra – there, leaning against one wall. Or, leaning against a painting hung on one wall. "Could you not do that?" Glimmer ordered bluntly.

The alien's bright eyes lifted to hers, slow and deliberate. "Oh, it's you." They said, and Glimmer shuddered. In the dim lights, and with her jagged messy hair, the alien became a bestial silhouette. Catra didn't push off the wall until glancing behind herself, seemingly noticing the art for the first time. Glimmer watched the motion with a fast heart. On the surface, everything was relaxed and languid about it, and yet some primal part of Glimmer's brain was set on edge. The alien might look calm, but she was constantly alert. Like the coiled spring of a mousetrap. Catra stood in the middle of the hallway, blocking the way.

"Could you move?" Glimmer asked. But the alien seemed distracted by the painting now, staring at it.

"Your species likes pretty gruesome art, huh?" Catra said.

Glimmer swallowed. "What?"

The alien pointed, and Glimmer glanced at it to confirm it was the one of the duck hunting scene. Three men stood ankle-deep in ice-choked reeds beside a lake, lifting long guns towards a flock of fleeing snow geese. Dogs sat around their feet, blood on their lips and the bodies of previously shot birds around them. "Tell me, is this one for food, or sport like the heads?"

Okay, now this was creepy. "This is for sport." Glimmer said. ". . . and I guess I agree it's pretty barbaric. A lot of people still hunt, but my family doesn't anymore. I've tried to get my dad to take

this down and replace it. But he likes the quote 'rustic nostalgia' of it."

Catra hummed, a deep sound from low in her throat. "Wanna know a secret?" She paused until Glimmer nodded nervously. "Most species are like that. They want to believe they've become more evolved, moved beyond their primitive ways, but deep down they all still enjoy the trappings, miss when they were hunters, just like every other animal struggling to survive." Sweat dripped down Glimmer's neck. She hoped her breathing wasn't too shaky. "I've never met one that shows it off though."

". . . Is that a bad thing?"

Catra laughed lowly, revealing pale pointed fangs. "Not as bad as you think."

Glimmer looked back at the painting. Aliens had come to Earth. Aliens who were apparently like humans in some of their worser ways. She thought of conquistadors and Native Americans, eyes on the guns in the painting, then at one of the dogs, a yellow one, looked up at his master with eager eyes, bloodstained tongue lolling. Glimmer had always joked that Adora was a golden retriever, so eager to please. And now here she was, retrieving something, and Glimmer couldn't help but worry that it might have been a bomb she just dropped at their feet.

She looked back towards Catra only to find her gone from her side, vanished. Goosebumps rose up her arms. "Catra?" She called, the ghost of the alien's teeth in the dark glinting in her mind.

A pointy-eared head peeked around the end of the hallway from the main room. "Yeah?" Jesus, how was she so fast? "You alright there?" Catra asked.

"Y-Yeah," Glimmer assured, waving her hand. "I'm fine."

Catra lifted an eyebrow at her before going back to whatever it was she was doing. Schmoozing up to Adora, probably. Glimmer

let out a breath that had been jammed in her throat, stopping her shaking hands by stuffing them into her pockets.

At dinner, Glimmer watched Adora practically jump over herself to get the full story of how she met Catra out to her and Grandma. She went on and on and on. About their movie night, about how they were the same age, about how cool her alien skinsuit was. Catra mostly nodded along, commenting and cracking jokes between bites of roast in ways that always made Adora laugh. It was sickeningly sweet. Glimmer was half listening until her parents asked and received some stories from the alien's society among the stars, becoming deeply annoyed as she realized Catra was a good storyteller. She managed to spin a surely dull tale about how she once traveled between two planets using shuttles and then a faster-than-light ship into something utterly fascinating, and that was infuriating. Adora seemed to only agree on the first part, stars in her eyes, clinging to every word. Glimmer just clenched her fork tighter.

When Adora started collecting plates to wash them, Glimmer sensed dinner was over. She grabbed her own and passed it to her sister, then tried to slip away back to her room and the quiet of her book.

"Glimmer!" Mom's voice suddenly shouted through the house when she rounded the corner. "Do you want to play cards!?"

She froze mid-step, clenching her jaw. "Sure thing, Mom." She flashed a practiced smile and sat back down next to Grannie Razz, who set her hand on her wrist, cold fingers easing her stress. Glimmer leaned her head into the crook of her neck.

Mom seemed to approve of this display, smiling at them with her hands clasped. "Adora?" She asked the kitchen.

"Ooo yeah!" Adora's eyes darted up out of the dish she had been scrubbing. "Catra!" She cried in a different direction. Glimmer suppressed her scoff. Catra Catra Catra. Could she talk about anything else anymore?

“What!?” Came the indignant squawk from the couch. A tail tip poked up over the backrest.

“Come play games!” Adora cried.

A long pause. “Finneee!”

Glimmer sat up straighter as the alien sauntered over, glancing warily at their huge discerning eyes as she sat down with her sister across the table. She swore they glowed. “Does she have to play too?” She asked.

"Don't worry Glitter, I don't bite." Catra smiled, once again flashing pointed fangs. The look was downright predatory.

"It's Glimmer, as I'm sure you know."

"Yuh-huh, sure."

"Catra . . ." Adora warned gently.

The alien sighed deeply. "Fine. *Glimmer*?" She said it with as much sass as she could muster. "Can I play this dumb Earth game with you?”

“Come on Glim, she’s a guest, right?” Adora urged, tapping her shin under the table with her sock.

Glimmer ignored her survival instincts. “Fine.”

Her unease and distaste for the cat festered as the first few hands of three thirteen were dealt. Adora was constantly leaning in near Catra conspiratorially to explain what each card meant, laughing at every comment the alien made, face-melting into one of such honest joy. “At least this is easier to understand than the 80s.” Catra snarked, and Adora snickered right along.

They had inside jokes. Glimmer thought as she picked at the band-aid on her index finger.

Glimmer played the whole game unable to stop paying attention to the pair. She came in last. Grandma Razz won.

“Great job Gran Gran!” Adora smiled at the triumphant woman.

“Thank you, Dearie! I think this is cause for celebration! Pie for everyone!”

“Hear hear!” Micah knocked the table with a fist, standing to get it.

The still-warm pies, one strawberry and one apple were set out on the table. Adora picked apple for both herself and Catra. The whole family went quiet and focused on Catra as she scooped a first bite. She noticed the staring with the fork halfway to her mouth. “What?”

“Nothing.” Adora nudged her shoulder, eyes eager. Ugh.

Catra rolled her own eyes and took a careful bite, then they dilated wide. “This is really good.”

Grandma Razz patted the alien on the shoulder. “I knew that, Dearie!” She cackled. “I wouldn’t serve it if it wasn’t!”

Everyone except Glimmer laughed and the atmosphere warmed. Glimmer took a small piece of strawberry. Partly because she was already pretty full; mostly to get out of this as soon as possible.

She was again about to flee for her room when her father suddenly spoke up. “Hey! I’ve got an idea, why don’t we open a few presents?”

Noooo. “But Dad, it’s not Christmas for like, four days.”

Micah smiled and wandered over to the tree. “Well, when you’re an adult you can decide whether or not to obey Santa’s rules. Tonight, I say we should each get one now.” He reached down and picked up one in particular, carrying it over and putting it in

Glimmer's hands. The paper was silver and green, tied with a red ribbon and bow.

“Alright.” She said. Her mom ran for her phone to record the unwrapping while Adora told Catra about Christmas traditions. After everyone was settled, she started tearing the paper, revealing . . . “A camera.” She said, holding the box up. A very nice DSLR camera. “Thanks.”

Glimmer looked up at her Mom and Dad, whose smiles faded as they saw her muted reaction. “You mentioned it a few months ago.” Micah said. “But if you don’t like it then we can-”

“No. No . . . it’s great. I did ask for it, thanks.” Glimmer said, smiling a little.

Micah and Angella looked at one another. “Alright.” He said. “Now, do you want to pick something for another one of us?”

Glimmer looked at Catra watching her with those alien eyes, then under the tree. “Dad?”

“Yes honey?”

“Could I just . . . go read . . . please?”

“Oh . . .” Micah exhaled. “Of course, if that’s what you want.”

She stood and fled for her bed.

The family didn’t open any more presents after Glimmer left, but Adora stayed on the couch, trying not to think about that last look on her sister’s face as everyone but Catra left. She distracted herself by calling Aunt Casta. It didn’t even ring once. Adora thought the new internet had broken until she was sent straight to voicemail.

“Hello there! This is Castaspella Brightmoon. I can’t come to the phone right now because I’m onsite, but leave a message and I’ll

get back to you as soon as I can!” She paused. “Or send a letter, it might get here faster!” She laughed. “Ta-ta!”

Adora narrowed her eyes and hung up before the beep. Onsite? Send a letter? No. No no she couldn’t wait on the post office. She needed to talk to her **now**. She pressed the call button again and listened to the same thing play over. She couldn’t leave a message. That was as bad as sending pictures over the internet. “I guess we'll have to try tomorrow.” She said to Catra.

Catra growled, hands clenching on the couch cushions, claws digging into the fabric. “How is it your backwards ass planet is just primitive enough that you’ve invented global communications and yet it’s still completely useless!” She grabbed the crumpled ball of wrapping paper Glimmer had left behind and snarled and she ripped it in half, shreds drifting down onto the floor.

“We’ll find a way.” Adora assured, then added lowly. “We better.”

Catra sighed. "Why am I guessing I don’t want to know why ‘we better’?” Adora explained her, hopefully unfounded, worries about dissection. “Oh, that's just perfect." She spat. "You really are all savages.”

Glimmer sat on her bed and tried to read, but her brain was so frazzled she kept having to go back to the beginning of paragraphs. Gritting her teeth until they hurt, she read and reread the same sentences, unable to get them through the haze that seemed to fill her mind.

A knock on the door snapped her out of it. “Come in!” She called. Her mother entered.

“Glimmer.” Angella seemed to glide across the floor, sitting with perfect grace on her bedside. Behind her mother, Swiftwind flew in like a comet, jumping onto the bed and nuzzling right up to Glimmer. She set her book down, using a finger to hold the page while patting Swiftwind with the other hand. He rolled over to

present his belly, and Glimmer smiled for the first time in she wasn't sure how long.

"Hi Mom."

Her mother then opened her mouth to continue, but no words came out. Wow, speechless twice in one day. She cleared her throat and tried again. "How are you doing?" Despite her best efforts, the question didn't feel natural.

"I'm doing fine, Mom." Glimmer insisted.

"Are you sure? I don't want you to feel you have to do anything that makes you-"

"I'm just adjusting a bit."

Her mother persisted. "If Catra makes you uncomfortable then-"

"It's fine, Mom!" Glimmer interrupted her, putting her hands up and losing her page. She scowled at the book, and Swiftwind scowled at her for stopping the belly rubs. "It's fine. I just . . . she won't be around long, will she? The government or someone will have to come and . . . take her, right?" That sounded heartless, but she looked up for an answer from her mother anyway.

"Presumably." She admitted.

Glimmer exhaled. "Then it's fine. What's a couple more days?" She asked the universe.

"You don't have to put yourself second." Angella implored.

Glimmer judged the concern in her mother's eyes. Things were supposed to be different now, they had promised. But of course, her sister was her sister. Dammit Adora. "I'm worried for us, Mom. For Adora. You know her. Sometimes she doesn't think."

Angella nodded knowingly. "I'm sure Adora will be fine, and we're keeping a close eye on Catra. You should focus on you right now,

getting better.”

Obviously. But, “And if Adora doesn’t want **us** to get better?”

“She will.” Angella insisted.

“Will she, or will she just find something else to focus on once Catra’s gone?” Angella didn’t have a good answer to that. When she left, Swiftwind stayed, and as Glimmer reached for her book to find her page again, he started whining. “Alright alright.” Glimmer went back to rubbing his belly. “You’re a glutton, you know that right?”

Thirty pages later, a knock sounded through her door. “Come in.” Glimmer answered. It opened, and she swallowed. It was Catra.

“Hey.” The alien greeted, stepping just inside and closing the door behind. Her eyes watched Swiftwind carefully, who had fallen asleep upside down next to Glimmer.

“Heyy.” Glimmer turned her book upside down, setting it on the bed while confirming that Catra was, once again, standing in the only exit.

“I wanted to ask you something.” She began. “Adora’s been talking about your government taking me prisoner and dissecting me. You wanna give me the odds of that happening?”

Glimmer blinked at the frankness she was being presented with. “You’re asking me?”

“You seem honest.” Catra said.

Glimmer was . . . actually surprised at how nice that sounded. “Well . . . umm . . . maybe? Honestly, I couldn’t guess.”

“Mmm.” Catra meowed. “And here I thought your sister had just seen too many movies.”

“Well, she definitely has seen too many movies.” Glimmer agreed. Distracted from reading, she reached over to pet Swiftwind. As soon as she did though, he shook awake and locked onto Catra. With an explosion of energy, he leapt off the bed, barking like mad. In a blink Catra was atop the wardrobe in the room, hissing, glaring at the dog as he ran back and forth below. Swiftwind’s wild jump knocked her book off the bed and onto the floor, landing closed. Glimmer tried to grab it as it fell, but she was too slow. She grumbled into the sheets before looking up and saw the dog sitting and staring up at Catra, watching her with his tongue hanging out of his mouth.

“You need to keep this thing on a leash.” Catra growled down from her perch. Glimmer noticed for the first time that the nails on Catra’s hands could extend like a cat’s as well, and were now fearsome black talons.

“Swiftwind’s a good boy!” She immediately defended him.

“He’s a little menace.” Catra responded, swiping at him when Swiftwind jumped and barked once.

“Don’t you touch him!” Glimmer ran and picked him up, walking over to the other side of the room. “Look, I understand some people don’t like dogs but if you’re going to be freeloading under our roof then you’re going to have to put up with a few inconveniences.” Swiftwind licked her in the face, which made her hard tone a little more difficult to take seriously. Come on Swifty work with me here.

“Freeloading?” Catra clambered down, scowling.

“Yeah, freeloading. It means mooching off kind people and giving them nothing in return.”

“Oh, alright, I see.” Catra scoffed. “I am sooo sorry that I was the victim of an accident that may have gotten all my crewmates killed. Sorry that I landed on this pathetic excuse for a planet in the middle of a frozen wasteland with no way to get home. But it’s

such an inconvenience that I'll have to stay here, in this huge house with you, when you've just spent the whole time moping in this one room, as you seem to enjoy so much!"

Glimmer hesitated when she was reminded of the alien's plight, but it was hardened again by the use of the word moping. "You would think that, wouldn't you, misses 'survival of the fittest'."

Catra looked at her for a second, then smiled. "Well, at least you don't seem to have to worry about making the cut."

Glimmer frowned. That should have been a compliment, and yet it still sounded condescending. That really was a talent of hers. "You know nothing about me, nothing about how I think or feel. Nothing about our species or our planet."

"I really shouldn't have to tell you I've learned quite a lot about those last two from Adora." Catra said casually.

"And from that you should know that I care about my sister. I don't know where you come from, but on this planet, we look out for our families." Catra flinched, but Glimmer wasn't done. "Adora might be convinced by you, but you better watch your back. I will not let you exploit her."

Catra started laughing. Glimmer's scowl darkened. "Wow." The alien said after taking a moment to breathe. "That would have actually been intimidating if a Tyrosaur was saying it. But coming from a little kid who can't cut fruit without cutting herself?" She gestured to the band-aid on her fingertip. "Not exactly putting me off. So, I'm going to keep letting Adora do what she wants. If that's talking to me, I'll talk back. If that's helping me, then she can help. You don't control either of us."

"Little kid?" Glimmer cried. "Says the one who's admitted she's no older than me. I bet you need to get back home so badly because your space mom will yell at you if you don't make it back before the streetlights come on."

Catra's eyes seemed to flash, and a growl rose in her throat. Swiftwind barked again, this time for Glimmer's protection. Catra glared at him like she wanted to cook the white furball over a fire, but after a moment that made the fear in Glimmer's blood spike, the menace and tension in the alien faded, replaced with that infuriating saccharine smile. "Oh ho ho, trust me, If anyone here's at mommy's beck and call, it's you. Lemme guess, always trying to live up to those eyes and yet always coming up short?"

Glimmer fought the reaction that **that** elicited. "You are so . . . annoying." She spat out between gritted teeth.

Catra just checked her claws casually. "Adora seems to think it's charming."

"Then Adora's an idiot." Glimmer muttered, barely audible, but Catra caught it with her huge ears.

"Ooo, and yet she seems to be the golden child? Wonder why that is?"

"Ugh!" Glimmer stopped her foot.

"Ah, maybe that's it. Real mature, Sparkles."

"Glimmer! It's Glimmer!" She stamped.

"Whatever."

"I can't believe I'm dealing with this." She muttered, then realized that shit, she didn't have to deal with this. "Alright! That's it!" Glimmer raised her voice and marched up to Catra, who backed away as she was wielding Swiftwind like a weapon in front of her. "Out. **Now.**"

Catra gave her a narrow stare, then backed off. She opened the door, but lingered in the threshold, one hand reaching up to scratch at the old wooden jamb. She looked at Glimmer, and her furious gaze before saying. "Earlier, with your radio friend. It helped."

That was definitely not an apology, but it wasn't an attack either. Damn her. "You understand how unlikely it is right?" Glimmer said without malice.

"I've faced long odds before." Catra assured.

"You want to know what I think will happen to you?" Glimmer asked. "You won't be dissected, but you'll probably get detained." Catra didn't react outwardly, but Glimmer knew she understood. "I don't think you'll let them do that to you easily."

"No." Catra confirmed.

Glimmer had to ask. "If you can't get home, and they do try and take you?"

The alien lifted a hand and Glimmer swallowed as her claws extended, curling into dark crescents. "Then I'll show them, or anyone, that I'm not somebody they can screw over."

Glimmer moved to set Swiftwind down, and Catra saw the meaning. Having gotten an answer to the question she came for; she disappeared behind the closing door. Glimmer scowled, then went to where her book was lying on the floor to find her page again. She couldn't figure this bitch out.

Forty pages later there was a third knock. "Come in." Glimmer said.

Adora did. "How's the book?" She asked as she opened a dresser drawer and started pulling out pajamas. Glimmer, after carefully putting her bookmark in place, put it down with a slap. She stared at Adora. Three two one. "Catra's sleeping on the couch tonight. Mom and Dad won't let her stay in the guest room, even after I offered Grannie Razz my bed! Isn't that just-" Yep.

"Adora." Glimmer stopped her. "Are you sure this is right? You seem convinced by her, but this Catra person, be honest, she's weird."

Adora scoffed. “Glimmer, come on.”

“No.” She stood her ground. “Adora, she’s weird.”

“She’s an alien.” Her sister flipped flannel pants over her shoulder, heading back for the door.

“She’s an alien who acts weird.”

Adora stopped with her hand on the doorknob. “What are you implying?”

“That you need to think about this.” Glimmer sat up as Adora blinked at her. She sighed, trying to figure out the best angle to go at this with. “Look . . . all I’m saying is that that you’ve maybe ruled out the whole Predator vs. Arnold Schwarzenegger angle here but I’m saying there might be more to it.”

“It’s not *Predator* Glimmer, it's *E.T.*” Adora assured. “I’ve been with her for days. She’s had a million opportunities to hurt me, and she hadn’t.”

“But that doesn’t me she won’t the moment we stop being useful to her.”

Adora was obviously insulted. “She wouldn’t.” She said, short, final.

“I don’t agree.” Glimmer replied.

“Why?”

“Because she’s come just about as close as you can to threatening me without doing it half a dozen times already.”

“And you and the others haven’t done that?” Adora asked.

“We’re not the invaders here.”

Adora seemed to wait for Glimmer to say more, and when she didn’t, “Anything else?”

Glimmer scoffed. “Anything else? You need more from me?”

“I’d like more, yes.” Adora nodded.

Anger flared in Glimmer. Did she really trust this alien more than her? “Swiftwind doesn’t like her!” She raised her voice.

“Auh, Swiftwind?! Cause he’s the best judge of character you’ve ever met!” Adora’s volume lifted to match as she rolled her eyes.

“He’s a dog. Dogs can sense that!”

“Swiftwind doesn’t like the mailman!”

“All dogs hate mailmen.” Glimmer justified.

“All dogs hate cats too!”

“She’s not a cat.” Glimmer stood. “She’s an alien creature we barely know or understand.”

“Because you won’t give her a chance!” Adora accused. “Calling her a creature. She’s a person!” She asserted, then went one step further. “She’s my friend!”

“No, she’s not.” Glimmer vowed. “She’s using you.”

“You’re wrong, she’s just-” Adora began, then stopped, turning away and wordlessly starting to leave.

“Adora.” Glimmer said. “Adora stop.”

“I’m not having this conversation again today.” Her sister replied. “Think what you want about her, but I don’t want to hear it anymore.”

“Adora STOP!” Glimmer walked after her. “How can you just trust this person!? You know nothing about them!” She grabbed her left shoulder hard, wrenching her back around.

When she did, to her shock, Adora released a gasp and bit back a scream. Shutting her eyes, her sister bore what looked like a very sharp wave of pair with her breath held, then said when she released it. "I do know about them Glimmer." She pulled down the collar of her shirt to reveal a black covering over the shoulder she had grabbed. "She treated me when I got hurt yesterday. She's spent time with me, listened to me, answered all my questions."

Glimmer felt bad for hurting Adora, but she still wasn't getting it. "You listen to her, you help her, but you're not listening to me!" She seethed. "You never have! You still aren't."

"I listen to you." Adora insisted. "I help you."

Glimmer laughed. "Oh yeah? When!? When I asked you to help me with my math homework earlier this semester?"

"I had a game." Adora justified.

"And I failed Algebra II!" Glimmer revealed.

Adora's eyes widened, and it took her a second to recover and launch back into it. "You can't blame me for that!"

"I don't, not entirely, but this is just like how it always is, isn't it Adora? What about that time I asked you to come dress shopping with me for semi-formal?"

"I was volunteering at the homeless shelter!" Adora balked.

"And I just wanted to spend time with my sister. Every time I need advice, or some support, or just want to spend time with you you've always got some excuse! Chores, or a game, or volunteering, and now Catra." She listed angrily.

"You're not being fair." Adora growled. "Maybe if you did more of the chores yourself, I'd have more free time. You say I'm not available but I say you're just lazy!"

Glimmer was pretty sure the scowl lines on her face would be permanent after this. “Oh, get your head out of your own ass, Adora. You know I do my shit!" Sure, maybe that was fewer chores than Adora did, but that was because Adora did them before her parents could even ask. "But you don’t want to see that, do you? You just want to be seen as the perfect little girl you think you are: always obedient, always working. I thought that maybe . . .” She swallowed and had to pause for a moment. “I thought that maybe, finally, we could talk to each other like people, instead of you just lecturing me. I thought that maybe things could be different. But now I think I’ve figured it out. You don’t care about anything but yourself.”

Adora’s eyes went wide. “What . . . you think I’m . . . selfish? You think I’m SELFISH! Everything I have done since Catra got here was for her! To protect her from people! From people like you who won’t give her a chance!”

“Oh, so you’re just going to do anything this stranger asks!?”

“She’s not a stranger!” Adora repeated.

“She is!” Glimmer jabbed at the ground. “You’ve known her for three days and yet it seems like you give more of a shit about her than your own sister!”

“My sister isn’t trapped on an alien planet! She’ll be here after I get Catra home!”

“Well, maybe I WON’T BE HERE, OKAY!?” Glimmer cried.

The silence was sudden and deafening. The red haze over both their visions fading into a horrible clarity. “Gimmer . . .” Adora took a step forward, voice breaking.

“Get out, Adora.” Glimmer said.

“What?”

“**Get OUT!**” She roared, pointing at the door.

Adora turned the corner with clenched fists, finding Catra lying prone on the knife attack couch with a chintzy magazine from the coffee table. "Wow, what was that all about?" She asked.

“I’m not in the mood, Catra.” She snapped back at her. Lifting a finger to rant, Adora took a deep breath, closed her fist, and dropped her blankets on the opposite couch. “I’m sleeping out here tonight.” She declared, reaching up to let down her hair.

Catra pursed her lips at the attitude, smarmily saying. “Woof.”

Adora sighed so deeply she worried her lungs would turn inside out. "You realize how ironic saying that is, coming for you, right?"

"I'll survive." Catra turned the page.

Not sure whether she wanted to laugh or punch Catra, Adora started to pace. She’d never thought Glimmer would be so distrusting. “I just . . . I wanted to give her something to do. Something to focus on. I thought it might help distract.” Something to make everything okay again.

“Distract from what?”

And here we are. Adora spoke very quietly. “The reason why I was up here alone. Glimmer tried to kill herself the night before you came.”

Catra sat up, setting the magazine down as she let out a quiet. “Shit.”

“My parents discovered her after she,” Adora’s words lodged in her throat for an instant. “after she took a lot of pills. She was overdosing. They had to get her to a hospital. So, they jumped in the car and they ran. It happened so fast they . . . forgot about me.” She looked up to see Catra’s reaction, which was subtle but pained. “And I understand it, I do. I know that every second counted but, it was the first time since I was nine that I was alone. Really alone. And it just made me so scared. So angry. I

thought . . .” She wiped the tears from her eyes. “Don’t tell Glimmer about this part. I don’t even want to bring it up. She’s going through so much and I don’t want her to . . .” She trailed off. I don’t want her to think I’m any more selfish than she already thinks I am. She sat down on the coffee table, head falling into her hands.

Catra stood and walked towards her. Adora expected a hug, but instead, the alien passed right by and made her bed for her, stretching the covers over the couch cushions. “Hey, Adora?” She said, pausing with a curse to the stars and a glance up to the judging glass eyes of the taxidermy heads. “Thanks.”

Adora looked at Catra like she was insane. “For what?”

“For trying, despite it all.”

Adora laughed, despite it all. “You didn’t exactly give me a choice.” She smirked up at her. Catra reached down with a hand to pull her up. Adora accepted and was moved from the table onto her makeshift bed in one tug. Catra threw the thickest blanket at her, which she caught with her face before unfolding over herself, and found that emotional exhaustion made sleep come quickly.

Adora woke to a gentle nudge on her shoulder. “What now Catra?” She mumbled, rubbing her eyes and sitting up. She found, instead of an alien, Grandma Razz and her father standing there dressed in full winter gear. “Oh. What’s going on?”

“Razz has to go get some things from town.” Micah explained. “We thought we’d have enough but we’re short on bacon and a few other things.” Adora cringed internally, knowing where that stockpile went. “How about you drive us? It’s a good chance for you to get some experience in the snow.”

“Oh.” Adora replied. “Umm . . . sure.” She did need to get better at driving through snow. It was her first winter with her learner’s

permit. Her and Razz and Dad out here in the boonies? That was good practice, if also suspicious. Had they heard her and Glimmer's argument last night, and if so, did they want her away from her sister for a bit? Or had Glimmer asked for some space?

"Can I come?" Catra said. Adora looked over to find her sitting at the base of the Christmas tree, shaking the remaining unopened presents near her ears.

Adora raised an eyebrow. "Really?"

"Why not?" The alien shrugged and stood. That wasn't exactly what Adora had been asking about.

Micah gritted his teeth, saying to Adora. "Umm, I'm not sure that's the best idea, Sunbeam."

Catra responded by grabbing a beanie Glimmer had left out yesterday, then walked over and opened a drawer Adora had never seen her open, retrieving a pair of sunglasses and an old COVID mask. Donning them all, she tilted her head. "There, incognito right?" The hat covered her ears, the glasses her eyes, and the mask most of the fur on her face.

Adora turned her best pleassseeee eyes on her father, who resisted for about five seconds.

"Fine." He grumbled. "But she can't come in the store."

That worked for her! Adora jumped up and ran to get ready.

Leaving the bathroom after brushing her teeth, Adora nearly jumped out of her skin. There, waiting for her, was her mother. "Miss Grayskull." Angella spoke darkly. Instantly, she knew she had overheard the shouting last night. Yes, it had gotten loud, but Adora had carried a fool's hope until this instant.

Pushing down the terror in her chest, she met her mother's eyes. She had seen them upset before. She'd even seen them mad a

few times. But this was the first time she saw white-hot righteous anger blazing in them. “Mom.” She swallowed.

“We assigned you one specific task.” She began, taking a step closer. Adora stepped back. “You said you understood that Glimmer was going through a delicate time. She is in a vulnerable state and you get into a **screaming match**!? That is not only the complete opposite of what I asked but simultaneously perhaps the most unproductive and unhelpful thing you could possibly do! It shows a complete disrespect of myself, Micah, Glimmer, and everything we’ve ever done for you! To say that I am upset by your actions would be an understatement on a scale with which I can hardly describe! Honestly Adora I’ve no idea what’s gotten into you! What were you thinking!?”

Adora braced herself. “She was insulting Catra.”

“Catra!?” Angella cried, then stopped herself and took a deep breath, steepling her fingers against her brow. “Clearly I underestimated how much this new distraction would affect you and Glimmer’s relationship.” She muttered. “After all that’s happened, I just wanted a nice normal Christmas with my daughter.” Adora flinched. “I would have thought that you would have wanted the same. What has happened to Catra is terrible, but she is not your priority at this moment.”

“But-”

“No buts!” She proclaimed with an ivory finger. “You will make things right with Glimmer. You will apologize, and Catra will no longer have an effect on such things. **Am. I. Understood?**”

“Yes.” Adora whispered.

Angella flicked her hand sharply. Dismissed. Adora bolted for the car.

Adora's nerves felt like they were on fire during the drive, making her hands jittery on the wheel, which wasn’t exactly helpful as the

truck threatened to slide over the snow a dozen times in a dozen different directions. All but a couple were small skids, but Adora was still worried for her heart health by the time they finally pulled into the empty parking lot of the tiny local grocery store in the town at the edge of the valley. Slumping over the wheel and releasing all the air in her lungs, Micah patted her on the back. "Nice job kiddo. One last time: the three lessons?"

"Keep your eyes far ahead." She recited what her Dad had told her on the way. The three most important 'driving in snow tips: patent pending'. "If you skid, look where you want to go." Her brain struggled with the last one.

"And . . ." Micah encouraged.

"Smooth movements." She remembered and got a fatherly nod.

"That was way harder than I was expecting." Adora admitted. The old truck had four-wheel drive, but it wasn't exactly state of the art.

"This snow is pretty deep; it won't be too often you have to deal with this." Her father assured. "Now come on, let's get going. Catra, I'm going to have to ask you to stay put."

"Aye, sir." Catra saluted sarcastically. Micah flinched slightly regardless. He coughed into his sleeve, then got out of the car.

Adora followed. The parking lot was plowed but very icy, so she walked around to help her grandma down. But by the time she got to her, Razz already had her own ideas. "Come now Mara dearie," She grabbed Catra's arm. "you can help me find ingredients for more pies!"

"Wha-!" The alien was yanked out of the car. Catra nearly stumbled on the ice, legs flailing while she tried to hold herself up and not pull Razz down with her. "Umm . . . but . . ." She pulled her hat down and sunglasses up.

"No buts!" She insisted and began to lead her towards the store.

“Razz.” Micah lifted his hands awkwardly, then turned one into an authoritative finger waggling as the surprisingly fast old woman began to get away. “Now . . . wait just a . . . slow down!” He tried to catch up, jogging awkwardly over the ice. Adora stifled a laugh until the moment he fell hard onto his butt.

“Dad!” Adora walked as quickly as she dared to help him.

“Christ,” He grunted as she lifted him up, nearly falling herself. “when did I become an old man?”

“Not yet.” Adora rolled her eyes.

“Oh, come on, with this gray?” He ran his hands through his beard.

Adora sighed, then pointed ahead. “Should we . . .” Catra was already hearing a story about how when Razz was a kid, milk was very expensive and they always drank the whole carton, and how she actually liked it when it turned sour.

“We should. But try telling her that.” Micah chuckled as he surrendered.

Adora was handed a part of the grocery list and she quickly wandered the small store grabbing items. After dropping them off in the cart her father waved her over. “Could you help me get the soda?” He called.

They didn’t need any more soda. Adora glanced at Catra, who was currently neck-deep in a lecture about pastry dough from Razz. “Sure thing, Dad.” She followed him back towards the secluded corner aisle. Stopping in its middle, Micah sat down on the tiles. “Umm . . . Dad?”

“Come on, sit with your old man?” Micah asked with a tired smile, gesturing to the other side of the aisle.

Adora looked right and left. “Won’t people see?”

“It’s not exactly Times Square around here, kiddo.”

Adora, confused, sat with her back to a wall of 2-liter soda bottles.

“I wanted to clarify what Angie and I talked about with you yesterday.” Micah began. Oh. “Adora, I understand your drive towards this new person in your life. And I understand that you made a promise to them. But I’m worried about your relationship with Glimmer. As tough as she is, she’s in a vulnerable place right now. We need to do everything we can to make sure she’s happy. Make sure she’s not stressed, yes?”

Micah was always good at this: short concise speeches. It was the politician in him. But Adora had just heard this story, and suspected what was coming next. “Yes.” She agreed.

“Good.” Micah nodded. “We heard your argument last night.”

Yep. Adora felt the exhaustion spike in every muscle in her face. “Mom made that very clear before we left.”

Micah’s eyes widened imperceptibly. “I asked her to let me-” He mumbled before cutting himself off.

“Dad, I know what I said was . . . harsh, but she disrespected Catra.” Adora justified. “She doesn’t deserve the things that she was saying about her.” That you’re all saying about her. She didn’t get to finish as Micah put up a hand to calm her rapidly rising tone.

“Your doggedness is admirable.” Micah admitted. “Honestly? It’s helped me reconsider her. As much as it may not seem like it at your age, I respect your perspective. She doesn’t seem so bad.” Adora was touched, but then she felt a current of dread run up her spine. The other shoe was about to drop. “You called Castaspella last night because you think she can help you contact Catra’s people.” It wasn’t a question. Adora inhaled. Her parents had heard that too? “I’m sorry kiddo, but that’s not going to work.”

". . . What?" Adora managed.

"Goldstone, where my sister works, is a dead zone. Any electric signal, like a phone call, can mess with the antenna receivers and disrupt the faint signals coming in from space. All radio emitters are banned there. It's why we talk with her so rarely."

Adora blinked. How had she never heard of this before? "But there must be a way to get in touch with her, right?"

"Short of going down there yourself? No." Micah said.

Adora felt like the ground had suddenly been pulled out from under her. The tone that he was speaking with felt so absolute, so final. The scowl on her brow deepened as she thought. "But-"

"You need a very strong radio source, don't you?" He continued. "That's why you called?" Adora nodded. "Then that's the game. Every place like Goldstone has the same restrictions."

He was saying that it was over. Something deep in Adora immediately and violently rejected that. It couldn't be over. She wasn't going to just give up that easily.

But even if she wouldn't, that didn't mean, "So, you're just going to turn her over." Adora muttered.

"We're going to contact the authorities and get her the help she needs." Micah corrected. "It's the best we can do for her."

Her frustration immediately reappeared. "Dad!" Adora threw her arms back and knocked a Sprite bottle off the shelf. It teetered, then fell. "Whoa whoa whoa!" She flailed and just barely caught what nearly became a sugary bomb. Shaking her head, she put it back on the shelf hard enough to rattle the metal shelving.

Micah watched her for a long moment. "Do you know how your mom got her military cross?"

Adora looked back up. “No.” Angella never spoke much about her service years.

“She got it carrying me twenty miles on her back through hostile territory.”

Adora’s eyes widened. “Oh.” She knew that they had met when they were both deployed, but not that they were on the battlefield together.

A small smile on her father’s face appeared and disappeared as harder and softer memories ebbed and flowed. “Joint command assigned a British platoon, your mother’s platoon, and mine a mission to take a strategic hill. We moved for it, but there was heavy resistance. We started taking wounded. Your mother said we had to retreat, that it was too risky. I disagreed; swore we almost had it. 600 yards, that was all that was left to go. So, I ordered my platoon to go for it, and that’s when I got hit.” He rubbed a spot on his abdomen, where Adora had noticed an old scar a few times. “Your mother carried me out of hell. I wouldn’t be here if she hadn’t decided to retreat. Glimmer wouldn’t either.”

“And me.” Adora said.

“You would have found another family.” Micah insisted. “But I’m very glad I got to help raise you.” He watched Adora silently war in her mind, and sighed. “Sometimes, there are battles you just can’t win. When that happens, you’re forced to make a choice that goes against what you believe in, because it’s the best you can make of a bad situation.” Quiet filled the aisle for several moments. “Do you understand?”

Adora realized this was about more than Glimmer and Catra. Her answer came out as a whisper. “You left me behind, Dad.”

“I know.” Micah said.

“You all just left me!” Adora felt tears welling in her eyes, and she lowered her head to wipe them away.

“And I am so sorry Adora, for what happened.” They’d had this conversation before too, the first phone call after Adora had woken up and found them gone. It had been an awful one, all around. Almost as bad as only being sure her whole family wasn’t messing with her when she saw that Glimmer’s Snapchat Map was at the hospital. But there was one question Adora had been too scared to ask then. One that had been festering in her mind this whole time. She gritted her teeth and realized she needed to ask it.

“If it had been me,” Adora said, lifting her eyes to meet Micah’s. “would you have taken Glimmer?”

Devastation wrought across Micah’s face, and he took a long time to answer. “Hypotheticals are infinite, Sunbeam. We can only do the calculation with what we have in front of us. In that moment, I knew you were safe, and would be safe, because we can trust you to be alone, despite the . . . let’s call it the unexpected.” The ghost of a smile crossed his face. “If it had been you, I can promise we would have made sure that **both** our daughters were safe.” Adora looked down again but nodded. “I know you want to do it all. But sometimes life doesn’t let you. It’s not pretty, or fun, but it’s an important lesson of growing up. I know you’re strong enough to understand that Adora, and see this through.”

“When I was alone: I’d never felt like that since-” Adora admitted. “I can’t let someone else feel like that because I sat by. I need to try!”

“I’m not saying to abandon Catra,” Micah insisted. “I’m saying you need to focus on what you can do right now. And what that is, is help your sister.”

“But-”

“This isn’t up for debate.” Micah’s voice hardened, and Adora felt her heart plummet. “I know you and Glimmer haven’t always seen eye to eye, but please Adora, I need you to make an effort here. The kind of connection you could have with her is more valuable

than you can know. But you have to make it soon. Or else you'll blink and suddenly be as old and with as many regrets as me." Adora felt her shame heat up her neck as her father and his - now definitely old man - wisdom was laid on her like she had just gotten a bad report card. "I want you to apologize to her." Micah concluded.

Adora exhaled, trying to hide her shaking with a nod. "Okay . . . okay yeah. I'll apologize when we get back." Adora looked up.

"Good." Micah stood, offering Adora a hand up. When she didn't take it immediately, he exhaled.

"You're not going to call them right now, are you?" She asked.

"It's been a long weekend for all of us, and we don't exactly have any presents for Catra for Christmas." He replied. Adora didn't find that funny. "The U.S. isn't a dictatorship. She'll be treated well." The pit in Adora's stomach grew deeper regardless. "Sometimes you gotta trust the system."

"Okay." She replied and managed to not make it sound like she was spitting venom.

"Good. Now come on, let's get back. Razz has probably talked her ears off by now."

They found Micah's guess to be spot on. Razz was picking out rhubarb while Catra tried to look interested. "And that was when I met my friend Mara!" She beamed. "Did you ever meet Mara, Adora dearie?"

"It's Catra." Catra repeated for what didn't sound like the first time.

Grannie Razz looked up and adjusted her thick glasses on her nose. "So, it is. Hah, the ears."

Catra reached up to make sure her beanie was still on before said ears caught their footsteps approaching. Catra pulled her mask

down briefly. ‘Help me.’ She mouthed, and that brought Adora’s smile back, only for it to curdle again as they went to check out. “So, I brought some of these.” Catra said in the checkout lane, holding up a slip of gold . Adora’s eyes went wide, and she pushed it down, wanting to laugh but feeling nauseous at the idea. “What? You said it was valuable!”

“It doesn’t work like that.” Adora insisted. They paid for their groceries. The cashier only gave Catra a quick glance. If anything, they seemed more interested in her highlighter nightmare of a jacket than anything else about her. Well, the disguise worked at least. Not that it even would matter. Leaving the store, Micah put his hand on Adora’s shoulder tenderly before walking over to the far end of the parking lot and pulling out his phone. Adora felt her blood turning cold in her veins as she climbed into the driver's seat of the truck, Catra using the opportunity to take shotgun. Grannie Razz got into the back.

It wouldn’t take long. By the end of the day, police cars and black vans would be at the cabin. The men in suits would walk up and grab Catra by the arms, and her head would whirl around, landing on Adora.

Her parents would not want her to mention anything of this to Catra, so she wouldn’t run off into the cold. They would spend the entire day convincing her not to talk, and they would convince her. She knew they would, they always did, but for the first time in her life, Adora was disgusted with herself knowing that they could. There was no reason this had to be her responsibility, they would say. Even if she had made a promise. She would be treated well, Micah had said. So, Adora would deflect using the excuse that Aunt Casta was onsite: tell Catra that they just needed to wait a little longer.

Maybe if she was human she would be treated well. But she wasn’t human. Catra was a person, but the government wouldn’t see it that way, she suspected. They often didn't even treat other humans well, to begin with.

She pictured Catra’s face the moment she realized that Adora was just going to stand there and let her be taken. The way that shattering of trust would look. Instantly she was sure that even if she ever got to see Catra again after that, Catra would never want to see her.

As the moments Micah was away ticked by, Adora’s worry and fear and disgust at herself mixed into a horrible swill that made her feel sick. She stared into the middle distance, not sure whether or not she was going to throw up.

There was one option left. One really really stupid way to do this.

Grandma Razz leaned forward between the seats, one knobby hand reaching up to cup Adora's cheek. "Be safe, Dearie." She smiled at her before getting out of the truck.

Adora's foot tapped against the dead pedal so fast it blurred.

She liked her life right now. She had her family, and the wilderness, and Glimmer. Sure, it wasn't perfect, especially right now with her relationship with her sister, but it would get better. Adora would meet new people to connect with eventually too. People like Catra. Yeah. They would be fun, even if they weren’t her. Why not listen to her parents? It would be easy. Why risk any of it? She could just enjoy the gift she was so lucky to have gotten. The one so few foster kids did. The only cost was Catra. So, why was the thought of paying it so awful?

Because you would always regret it. The plain answer came back, and with it the boiling lake in her stomach settled, replaced with clarity. As with any argument, you could keep debating in circles for hours, but it was clear that now, after the crux of the matter had been found, anything else would all just wrap back around and point at that simple fact. If she didn’t help Catra, what kind of a person did that make her?

No. Her last words to Catra would not be ‘I’m sorry’.

Grannie Razz walked across the parking lot towards Micah. Adora watched it in slow motion. One of Catra's hands went to the door handle to let herself out. “What’s going on?” She asked. Adora grabbed her arm to stop her.

Her heart was hammering.

Razz tapped Micah’s shoulder. He turned as Adora turned the key. The engine roared.

Catra looked at her. "What are you doing?"

Adora shifted into gear. "Getting you home." She slammed the accelerator.

Chapter End Notes

> TWs: Discussions of a suicide attempt, familial strife, biological child favoritism
>
> Hey all! First time I’ve broken with the schedule, but this is a big important chapter, and I needed to take some extra time to make sure it was really great before posting.
>
> Also, I know I’ve taken a big swing on one character in particular. Glimmer fans please don’t riot yet!
>
> Also also, I’m picturing something like this for Catra’s 90s drip. I don’t think I can overstress how much I’m absolutely obsessed with the idea of her wearing a stupid jacket like this.
>
> Also also also, two tiny additions were made to Chapter 4. A sentence referencing Adora being a heavy sleeper was added to foreshadow the reveal that she slept through the Brightmoons leaving, and a piece of a sentence later mentioning the ‘80s’ explicitly to make Glimmer’s ‘inside jokes’ comment make more sense. Hopefully, these edits should stop now that the setup is out of the way, but I’m going to

tweak if I have to tweak to make the whole work feel more cohesive. Thanks for understanding!

Chapter 6: Run Away With Me

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The wheels spun wildly on the icy parking lot.

"Whoa whoa whoa!" Catra jerked with the lurching of the truck as they gained grip. "Didn't you say you weren't fully qualified to, you know, operate this thing!?"

"Drive." Adora told her the word. "Drive this thing. And yeah! . . . yeah I'm not." She jerked the steering wheel right to turn towards the exit, and the back end of the truck swung out in a huge drift. Her learner's permit required an experienced licensed driver in the car with her. She glanced in the review mirror, just catching the moment Micah's confusion became horror.

"Adora!" She heard his muffled shout. Focusing on the road ahead, she flew out of the parking lot onto the unplowed side road. Her knuckles were tight on the wheel as she felt snow drifts break on the bumpers, threatening to throw them into the ditch on one side or the other. Adora didn't slow down.

The turn onto the main road was a left. It was a hard left.

She took the corner sharply, blowing past the stop sign. Once again, the back end swung out. Catra, not holding on, slammed against the door. "Oof!" She heard the wind fly out of her lungs, and she crumpled forward, half falling out of the seat.

"Put your seatbelt back on!" Adora gritted her teeth, trying to focus. The main road was clearer. She could go faster.

"What's a seatbelt!?"

Jesus, she'd never told her to put one on when leaving the cabin. "This thing!" Adora cried and fumbled to put on her own,

searching for the buckle. Click. Ah, there, now she wouldn’t get herself killed in a completely preventable way. Not that that wasn’t what she was doing this very second. Another look back - the second of what was going to be many, she realized - confirmed there was no one in pursuit, yet.

Catra was hauling herself back up into a sitting position, claws sinking into the seat fabric as she clung on for dear life.

"Ahh, watch the upholstery!" Adora begged.

“Watch the road!” Catra screeched back as she managed to get up, sit, and figure out her own seatbelt.

Adora somehow made it out of town and on the road south towards the Magic Valley before she had to pull over. Her hands were white on the wheel. Her shoulders were so tense they were hard as the stone of a statue, muscles carved in alabaster anguish. Her breaths came ragged and uneven.

"Adora?" Catra asked.

"I can't . . . I can't believe I just did that. I can't. I-I can't." She shuddered. "I . . ." Words caught in her throat. She was fucked. There was no coming back from this. Thief. Street Rat. Thug. All the worst words howled in her mind. "Why?" Why did she just throw it all away!?

"Adora!" Catra said more firmly, and her eyes moved over to her. Catra looked worried, confused. Catra needed help. Catra was why. If she hadn’t done this, they would have put her somewhere where the sun never shines, and she would never go home.

Catra was why.

"Sorry." Adora pulled the column shifter down, back into drive. "Sorry. Just . . . needed a second."

"Right."

The look on her fath-Micah’s face when he realized what was happening flashed in her mind and made the tide come rushing back in. “N-Nope.” Adora shifted back to park, unbuckled her seatbelt, and stumbled out of the car.

“Adora!” Catra's voice was cut off by the door closing behind her. Adora tried to step forward, but her legs were jelly. She rocked, slipping back against the truck. Puffs of fog appeared in front of her face as she clasped her numb and shaking arms around her chest tightly. Everything was shaking. She needed to stop shaking. Was her heart doing that? It was beating so fast. The sound of blood in her ears was so loud she didn’t hear Catra get out of the car and approach. She couldn’t hear anything. She couldn’t think; her brain felt retracted from her body. Every extremity was full of pins and needles. She felt out of control, and she hated it.

“Adora get out of the road!” Catra dragged her away, though to where she didn’t know. “Hey!” She clasped her upper arms, running them up and down her sleeves. “Hey.” Adora managed to lock onto her mismatched eyes. “Focus on me. Breathe. Breathe, okay Adora?” Adora managed to nod, concentrating on her lungs expanding and deflating. “Now, you’re going to be okay, alright?” Catra’s voice had changed again. It was like when she had dislocated her shoulder. The innate confidence that normally radiated off her so casually was now directed into a kind of comforting authority. The kind where you believed what she told you. “Repeat after me, okay?” Her hands continued to massage her arms. “My mind is the face of the universe. My mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed. My mind is magic.”

“What?”

“It’s an alien thing.” Catra scolded gently. “Say it with me. My mind-”

“M-My mind is the face of the universe.” Adora incanted, trying to understand the strange words. “My mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed. My mind is magic.”

“Good.” Catra smiled without teeth. “Now just repeat it. Come on . . .”

“My mind is the face of the universe.

My mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed.

My mind is magic.

My mind is magic.

My mind is magic.”

Adora felt the panic in her body dissipate as she repeated the words, her mouth moving in a pattern like meditation. The jagged movement of her lungs evened, and the tears pricked in the corners of her eyes were stymied. She lowered her arms. That had been a panic attack. No debatable close calls this time. Adora exhaled a tranquilizing breath, swallowing the lump in her throat. “You’re good at that.” She said, just to say something. “In situations like that, emergencies. You’d be a good, like, EMT.”

A wan look crossed Catra’s face, but when she spoke, the causal sass was back. “You’re welcome.”

“Thank you.” Adora replied with all the heart she had. Catra inevitably let it glance off her by looking away, turning to the landscape. They were at the top of the gentle ridge that separated the northern valley from the primary Snake River plain. From this elevated spot, they could look south down into it and see, on a clear winter day like today, nearly thirty miles. There were no other cars, no buildings, no trees, not even any fences visible, just frozen prairie to the horizon. The world beckoned. "C'mon," She called. "let's get going." They needed to move in case the local sheriff had been called and was chasing after them.

They crossed the Perrine Bridge into the city of Twin Falls. The slender arch over the Snake River gorge was an icon of the local

area, and Adora had to state the facts that everyone did when someone new came to town.

“It’s the eighth-highest bridge in the country.” She said while glancing over the edge, still unnerved by the nearly 500-foot drop despite having lived within spitting distance of it for nearly half her life. “And it’s also the only manmade structure in the United States that you’re allowed to base jump off of whenever you want.” Catra’s eyes looked at her with very deep concern. “With a parachute of course.” She amended.

“So that’s how you primitives have fun.” Catra deadpanned. Adora smiled and assured her that she had never tried it.

They weaved through downtown then the burbs, Adora’s fearful eyes lingering on every police car. But despite a nearly exploded heart, they passed each by without being stopped. She didn’t know what her family was doing to react to her sudden . . . actions, but her phone had been blowing up until the moment she turned it off. Certainly, they would call the police to report her missing. Send someone to chase them down, right? Maybe the call just hadn’t gone out yet.

They pulled into the Brightmoons’ driveway. It was an ordinary suburban pattern-build. Grey siding, lavender shutters, two stories. There was an old paper birch in the front yard; its speckled white branches stark against the pale blue sky. “We gotta be quick and quiet.” She told Catra as she shut off the truck. “A neighbor comes by twice a day to check the place.” It was a little before noon, so they should be well between visits, but still. She didn’t know how much the Snows knew about the current situation. Even the family truck showing up at the house might raise enough suspicion to summon curious eyes.

Adora shut the front door behind them but didn’t turn on the lights.

"This is your house?" Catra looked around.

Adora felt like a sword was being rammed through her chest at the word ‘your’. “Yessir." She still replied as happily as she could, habitually tossing the keys into the bowl. "Come on.”

"How many people in your family are there?" Catra turned in a circle as she walked.

Again, the simple phrase was gutting. "The five of us." Adora replied, "Well, plus Swiftwind."

"But." Catra gawked at the open concept and fourteen-foot ceilings. "It's huge!" She said louder, voice reverberating.

“Quiet, remember?!” Adora hushed her. She knew the house was fairly big and spacious, but it wasn’t exactly unusual or opulent for the area. This was the West, there was plenty of cheap empty land to build big houses on. She headed upstairs, opening the door labeled with her name on a wooden sign.

"THIS IS YOUR ROOM!?" Catra practically screamed.

“Shhh!” Adora glared at her. “Yes! But please.”

Catra put up her hands in surrender, but still couldn’t hide her shock. “But . . . Adora . . .”

“Mmm?” She went for her dresser and started grabbing changes of clothes. Four should be plenty, for there and back.

"It's . . . it's . . . Adora."

"Still here." She shut it and assaulted her closet, retrieving her spare duffel before remembering Catra needed clothes too and went back for the dresser. Smaller and looser stuff for Catra. Stuff that would hide her skinsuit. Plus jeans, she could roll up the cuffs for her shorter legs. That was in style right now, right?

"How many people share it with you?" Catra asked.

"Umm . . . none." Adora said.

"Stars." Catra whispered.

Adora’s room was pretty typical for a girl her age, she thought. Just 150 square feet of beige carpet, light blue walls, a nook to read in with a window, some dressers, and a full-size bed. The only thing notable for her a girl her age, if she was to be a little proud, was that it was all immaculately clean. Her bed was made and there was not a dirty shirt or empty chip bag to be found (Glimmer’s room was always a disaster by comparison). Posters covered most of the open spots on the walls. Sky maps with constellations, bands, national park WPA art, a corkboard filled with movie ticket stubs, doodles on scraps of paper, and a printed-out photo of her, Glimmer, and Bow standing in front of Balanced Rock. She paused to glance at the picture more closely: Adora’s face was squished between Glimmer’s bright eyes and Bow’s winking ones, a peace sign held up with the other hand. It all seemed so normal, which made the alien currently wandering through it all seem even more apocryphal. Catra grabbed a hockey stick from where it was leaning against one wall. "This is a very ineffective-looking spear."

"It's not a weapon." Adora laughed, then hesitated. "Well, it can be used as one but you're not supposed to. It's for a sport I play.” She walked over and grabbed a puck from her gym bag in the corner, tossing it to Catra. "You use it to hit this into a net.”

Catra turned the rubber disk in her hands. “Does this involve snow?”

“Yeah, actually.”

“Figures.” Catra tossed it over her shoulder.

Adora shook her head and finished packing. Right before leaving, she considered grabbing the first of the Good Witch Azura series from her bookshelf, despite knowing that there would be no time for her to read it. It was a dumb series: with more YA fantasy tropes than you could shake a stick at and a stuffy writing style. But she’d devoured it at eleven, and over the years had reread the

whole series half a dozen times. It was familiar, and as she stepped out of her room for what might be the last time, knew she wanted something familiar in her life right now.

Catra more or less drifted behind Adora as she went through the house like a solar storm. In a short time, she had been given a whole new wardrobe, toiletries, winter boots that actually fit her, a beanie that better covered her ears, and a pair of larger 'aviator' sunglasses for her eyes. After that, they grabbed lots of snacks and retrieved a plastic box called a 'cooler' and started loading stuff into it. "There's not much fresh food here, 'cause vacation, but we can grab these gogurts and cheese sticks." Adora said. "Let's take this to the garage, there's another fridge in there with drinks."

The garage was just like the one in the cabin. Concrete floors, minimal insulation. But as soon as Catra entered, her nose and ears twitched, and she stopped. "Catra?" Adora noticed her narrowed eyes. Sniffing, she glanced left and right, then heard a soft scrunching noise. She zeroed in on the disturbance: a pair of eyes watching from under a pile of stuff. Adora followed her gaze. "Maui!" She suddenly shouted in a high-pitched voice, and the small four-legged animal ran out, trotting towards Adora. Catra stiffened, ready to yell at Adora for not letting her know about **another** Swiftwind, but held her tongue when it didn't start screaming. "Here we go!" Adora crouched down and let the animal rub up against her leg, and to Catra's great surprise, it started purring. "Catra, meet cat!" Adora was very delighted to say that. The black and tan animal finished greeting the human and walked over to Catra, sitting in front of her. The two stared at one another, and Adora watched them both blink slowly with a stupid grin.

Huh. "Hello."

"He's such a sweet boy." Adora reached over to stroke his back, and he stood again, spine arching where she touched. "Mom doesn't want him inside, 'cause he's sort of a stray, but that just

seems so cruel. He wouldn't hurt a thing. Wouldn't you?" She tickled his face, which he seemed to like.

"Stray?" Catra asked, eyes not leaving the animal.

"Yeah, he just comes and goes as he pleases." Adora explained. "But we leave out food, water, and a bed for him. He spends most of the winter in here. Our little man is always welcome."

Catra slowly sat in the doorframe as she talked, and the animal's eyes started to follow her tail as it whisked back and forth. She raised an eyebrow and started to flick it deliberately, smirking as Maui's eyes went wide and he started darting back and forth after the limb. She hung it above his head, watching as he jumped up, claws out.

As Catra played fishing for Maui, Adora went around and grabbed drinks from the fridge. "Is this weird?" she asked as she loaded up the cooler.

"Would it be weird if there was a tiny naked human that ran around and grabbed stuff?"

Adora chuckled silently. "Oh, we have those, they're called monkeys. They're pretty cute until they try to rip your face off." Maui nearly caught Catra's fleet tail. "Guess that's true for this guy too."

Catra nodded, leaning forward to let Maui sniff her hand, then scratched behind his ears. "Can we get moving?"

"Right." Adora stood straighter, picking up the cooler. "Sorry, let's go." She turned and beelined out of the garage, not noticing that Catra hung back and pet the little creature for a few more moments, stroking him and enjoying the funny sounds he made. He was like a kitten to her, which was charming in that stupid way that made her care about him. "Yeah, she's a bit of a dork, isn't she?" She said to him. A tenacious one, but definitely a dork.

Twenty neighbor-free minutes after stepping into the house they were all packed and the truck was loaded. Portable chargers for the phone, tons of snacks for not stopping very often, a couple changes of clothes for both of them, a few blankets, and some **borrowed** money in cash from the safe, all accounted for. From the instant she'd left the cabin, Adora had been planning out their journey in as much detail as she could. She figured that if she drove liberally, they could make the journey in a day and a half. If they slept in the car on the side of the road in Nevada, they could be through Vegas in the AM tomorrow on the 23rd, and at Goldstone by sunset. Home by Christmas . . . barring she had a home to return to at all.

She shook her head to dispel that train of thought, asking Catra as she settled back in. "Ready for a road trip?" Adora moved her hand to start the car. But her fingers hovered over the key. She clenched them into a fist before Catra could see them trembling.

"Hey." The alien said, clearly not happy about the return of this flavor of Adora.

Adora sighed. "It's just . . . I've always been a good kid. I've never done anything like this. And this is like, the last chance to turn back, and maybe we could-"

"Hey." Catra interrupted the rambling. "This," She gestured at Adora. "has to stop. You're not used to being yelled at, so I get it, but take it from someone with loads of experience. Whatever they say to you? Whatever they do to you? It's not a big deal. You get used to it."

Adora took a deep breath. "I don't think I can. Catra, they're my . . . they're my parents."

"And they didn't listen." Catra stressed. "Parents? Adults? They never do. I saw you try **so hard**, but it didn't convince them."

"Then I didn't do a good enough job!" Adora cried.

Catra looked her in the eyes. “Trust me, nothing ever will be 'good enough'.”

Adora swallowed heavily, then whispered. “Then what do I do?”

Catra's eyes softened. “You’re already doing it, Adora.”

Adora felt a heat rise in her cheeks, and she looked down at the key just beyond her fingers. Catra was why. She started the truck. Sixteen hours of driving, here we come.

Sixteen hours turned out to be wildly optimistic. While Adora had managed to grab just about everything they needed from the house, she had forgotten one tiny detail. One massive detail. The damned weather.

“That looks really bad ahead.” Adora muttered, craning her head to look up and see the top of the looming snowstorm. They were on Route 93, about an hour south of Twin, and nearly at the Nevada border. All around the quiet two-line highway was more empty prairieland. There was nowhere to turn off and stop them from heading straight into a white monster. Why now nature?

“There’s a big splotch of dark blue,” Catra turned Adora’s phone towards her. “moving north. Starts just before a place that’s labeled . . . hook shape, circle with little tail on top, sideways half circle, vertical line with-”

“Jackpot.” Adora knew the town. Also, she needed to teach Catra to read. Jackpot was literally just over the border. Back when gambling was illegal in Idaho, an enterprising guy named ‘Cactus Pete’ had set up a casino in famously sinful Nevada, hence the colorful name. There was virtually nothing else there. It was all very Idaho, despite being over the state line. But trivia wouldn’t stop the storm, Adora chided herself.

"So, what do we do?" Catra asked. What could they do? Going through was a stupid idea, obviously. So, they could either stop and wait, or turn around. Neither was appealing. The nearest

alternative route would mean going all the way back to Twin Falls, then east to follow I-84 to Salt Lake City. That was 200 miles the wrong way. Waiting meant sitting still in the open, for either the weather or the police to catch them. For the latter's benefit, Gimmer knew they were going to Goldstone, and this road was the quickest way there. Police could be following right now. Car thieves went to jail when they got caught.

No, they couldn't stop, and from the perspective of pursuing police, turning around only saved their patrol cars gas. Besides, Adora had already made one stupid decision, what was one more? "We keep on." She decided, determined.

The snow started light but quickly grew heavy in the air. In the cold, it stuck immediately, and the pavement became spotted, then overwhelmed. Adora felt the change through the steering wheel, first lightly, then more dramatically as her subtle motions to stay in the lane started to make the wheels slip. Oh boy. She remembered what Micah had told her in the morning. Look far ahead. If you skid, look where you want to go. And . . . something else . . . she couldn't remember. That lesson felt like a long time ago. The snow grew deeper, and she was forced to slow down, carefully feeling for bumps and losses of grip.

Time seemed to slow as Adora had to keep all her focus up. She glanced at the clock after a while, wiping a sweat drop from her forehead. They were 30 minutes into the storm. The conditions outside had only gotten worse. She could hardly see 50 feet in front of them, and the snow was several inches deep now. They were only going 25 miles an hour. No other cars had passed for quite a while.

"Are you sure this is okay?" Catra asked during a particularly large skid.

Adora pressed the brake gently, turning against the stomach-churning sensation until she felt the wheels catch again. "We're fine." It was only like another hundred miles to the other side. She could do this for four more hours. "You were there this morning."

“You nearly sent us in the ditch this morning.” Catra replied.

“I learned in summer, okay?” Trial by fire, right? That was a thing. A good first test. If she could make it through this then she could make it through anything. Adora wanted to look at Catra to assess how skeptical she looked.

Speaking of summer, this felt like the beginning of the last day of school before summer. Dragging and dragging in that worst way where you knew you had to concentrate and finish all your tests, but also that freedom was so close, and yet so far away.

The snow closed in closer. She could hardly see ten feet off the hood. The headlights cast two ominous cones into the haze, lighting big flakes. Sharp winds buffeted the broad sides of the truck, Adora fighting when gusts came. She could hear the crunch of the snow through the tires. It was only a matter of time before everything came together at precisely the wrong moment.

A huge gust came at the right side of the truck, and Adora felt all the wheels skid left in the snow. She went for the brakes, trying to correct, but the skid only grew. She turned the wheel, but nothing changed. The back started to swing out. Come on. She turned it further and suddenly felt grip. The truck jerked right violently. “Shit!” Adora twisted the wheel the other way and promptly overcorrected. Look where you want to go! Adora begged, but it was too late. Swerving left, they crossed the centerline of the road. She felt the jolt as they went off the pavement, then the lurch in her stomach as they jumped down into the ditch beside the highway.

Adora’s face smacked the steering wheel when they stopped with a crunch, and she groaned. Smooth movements. Adora remembered Micah’s final piece of advice. Thanks brain. She shook her head, wiping the daze away. Oh . . . oh god. They’d gone off. “You alright?” Adora asked her passenger.

Catra was trying to get in a position where her seatbelt wasn’t choking her. The truck was sitting at a thirty-degree angle or so,

nose down. The alien managed to press her feet against the dashboard and push herself back into her seat. “Not my worst crash.” She joked.

Adora switched into reverse to confirm what she already dreaded. The wheels just spun. They were stuck. It was lucky the airbags hadn’t gone off. She took a deep breath, scowling. One step at a time. Don’t freak out. “Come on.” She unbuckled and unlocked the car. “Let’s see if there’s anything we can do.”

Adora and Catra trudged through the foot-deep snow around their impromptu beaching. It didn’t look good. The ditch was six feet deep. The truck was like the sinking Titanic, its tail sticking up out of the trench like it was in the middle of being swallowed by the earth. The highway was barely visible now, and the storm buffeted them like ragdolls. Adora tried to start digging them out with the shovel in the back. But it was accumulating so fast. Even if she could unbury the tires, she doubted they could drive out. Catra tried to push the truck, but even her alien strength wasn’t enough to move it. Adora could only stomach a glance at the front bumper. But it was enough to confirm it had been pretty crushed when it hit the ditch.

Back inside the cab, Adora slumped forward with the angle of the seats. Snow everywhere. Middle of nowhere. Nobody to call. They were only a couple of hours in! Was it too much to ask for the first part of the journey to be easy? “Stars.” She muttered Catra’s curse. Driving that carefully for so long, constantly fidgeting the controls. She was exhausted.

“Now what?” Catra asked carefully.

“I DON’T KNOW, CATRA!” Adora shouted, pressing her head forward against the steering wheel until the horn started the blare. She let the noise rattle through her brain for a good ten seconds before lifting it again. “Sorry.” She exhaled. “Just . . . shit . . . we gotta wait for somebody to come by and see us. Hopefully, they’ll have a winch.” Dammit that was the only way, wasn’t it? She couldn’t even call AAA. She wasn’t the owner of the

vehicle, and they would find out that she wasn't licensed. "We just gotta wait."

It took two hours. They resorted to playing poker using the cards in the glovebox for both of them, but only during the second did they shiver when Adora had to shut down the engine to save fuel. With coats and blankets on, Adora and Catra traded hands.

"Well, there are worse angles we could have landed at." Catra said as she moved two granola bars from her pile into the pot. "Raise."

Adora glanced up from her cards. Catra had leaned her seat all the way forward and was lying prone on the back of it, arms hanging with her cards. "I'm starting to think you're not taking this seriously." Adora said. "Call." She grabbed a silver pop tart bag and set it on top of the bars.

"A pop-tart is not worth two granola bars." Catra decried. "And I am."

"A pop-tart is totally worth two granola bars!" Adora snapped back. "If anything, it's worth more!"

"Do you really like those things that much?"

"You don't? When did you even have one?"

"Middle of the second night. Didn't like it. Too chalky."

Why was she even up that late? Adora *chalked* it up to cat reasons. ". . . Whatever. You're joking in a time like this!?"

"Always so dramatic with you, Adora." Catra replied, unphased by the harsh tone.

"Ugh!" Adora crossed her arms in a huff which Catra seemed to enjoy. "What do you have?"

Catra laughed that hiccupy laugh, tossing her two cards onto the center console. "I got uhh . . . the three-and-two one."

“Full house.” Adora noted. Eights full of sixes. “Damn.” She threw down her cards. “Two pair. Take your chalky prize.”

“I will, but only because you like them.”

Their eyes met, and a staring contest began, Adora looking down the smile the alien had leveled at her. The storm whirled as they sat at awkward angles. Adora was about to break when Catra suddenly stiffened, ears twitching. “You hear that?”

Adora shook her head, and Catra put up a finger. Nearly a full minute passed, then Adora heard it, the low rumble. “Someone’s coming!” Adora lit up and jumped out of the truck. Two beams of light were approaching from the north.

“Hey! Hey!” They ran up the ditch together, waving their arms. Adora glanced at Catra. “Your hat!” Catra touched her ears, then put her hood up right as a huge government snowplow squealed to a stop in front of them. Adora trudged up to the side of it as the window rolled down.

“Aww Jesus Christ.” The balding man behind the wheel appeared to be in his fifties. Tired-looking, which was unsurprising being on duty on a day like this. He stared at the pair of them, then at the half-buried truck. “What the hell are you damn kids doing out here in this weather!?”

Adora shrugged awkwardly. “Leaning why we shouldn’t drive in the snow?” The plow driver sighed beleagueredly. “Could you please help us get out, sir?”

It took a second, but he eventually nodded, head hung. “Yeah yeah.” He muttered. “I got you. Lemme just clear some road around your car and we can winch it out.”

“Thank you!” Adora beamed.

It took fifteen minutes, but Adora gave a deep sigh of relief as the huge truck easily wrenched their chariot from the ditch. As it lurched back on its tries and snow sloughed off the dented and

twisted bumper, she waved the man to stop. Catra quickly jumped in and confirmed it still turned over. Adora thanked the driver again, then passed him fifty bucks from their limited funds. She could work the upcoming summer to pay back whatever they spent, and the damage to the car . . . and the gas.

The plow driver seemed to appreciate the tip. “So, tell me, where are you going on a day like today?”

“We’re going to see my friend’s family in Southern California.” Adora pointed over her shoulder at Catra leaning against the truck. “It’s very urgent.”

“Well, regardless of how urgent it is, you’re not getting through all this. The storm and the plows should have the road open in a couple of days though. If the reports about three feet are accurate.” Three feet!?

“What? Two days!? We can’t wait that long.”

“Well then, I’m sorry but you’re going to have to find a different highway. You can go east through Salt Lake, not too far out of the way.”

“No, sir. I’m sorry but, we just have to get through.” Adora chopped her hand down into her palm to emphasize, but the point fell a little short when he laughed at her.

“Well then maybe I’ll see you in another ditch a few miles down the road. You’re a kid, kid, so I know you don’t have much experience in this weather. Take it from an old man. You can’t make this drive.”

“Adora.” Catra pushed off the truck and came up to her.

“No! We can’t go back!” She jabbed at her with a finger.

“Adora.” Catra put a hand on her shoulder, looking her in the eyes. Snow swirled around them.

Adora met her gaze for several tense seconds, then capitulated. It was impossible to go this way. “Okay.” She shook her head. “We go the long way.”

“Wise decision little lady.” The trucker tipped his head, gave a two-fingered salute, said, “Dive safe now.” and disappeared into the white haze.

“Damn mystical plow men speaking reason.” Adora grumbled, then realized Catra was still touching her. “Umm . . . Catra?”

“Sorry.” She lifted her hand, and they both stood there awkwardly for a second. “Soo . . . should we?” The alien jabbed at the truck.

“We should go.” Adora agreed.

“Yeah. We should go.”

They went.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Major panic attack

Making up for the three-week delay last time, I got this one out early!

Also, we’ve broken 1000 hits! Thank you all so much! The big 1K was my secret goal for this whole story, so to hit it after only five chapters is just so humbling and gratifying. I love all you guys who have given it a chance and have been leaving such nice comments.

Chapter 7: South by Southeast

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They ran from the storm, but it chased them north. The way out was barely better than the way in. Adora white-knuckled the wheel until, blessedly, they reached unsnowed road again. The grip increased with Adora's stress. She used backroads to get from their north-south route to the I-84 heading east, passing farms instead of having to cut through downtown Twin Falls again. They made it to the highway without being pulled over by red and blue lights, and on it, Adora made sure to keep her driving casual and her speed down, doing double takes at every white and black car that appeared in her peripheral vision. Somehow this crackpot scheme was still working, even after losing six hours of driving. The afternoon was getting long and they were halfway back to where they'd started.

So, they subsisted on snacks and chewed out the miles, following the Snake River until it curled north towards its headwaters and the highway south towards Utah. The terrain grew hillier as the sun dipped lower, and with it, Adora's eyes did too. She was exhausted before; now she was on the verge of collapse. Her inexperience was taking its toll. Each truck that roared by at 20 over the speed limit was muscle-locking terror. She kept drifting over the centerline, having to jerk the wheel back each time. Her knee was sore from constantly trying and failing to adjust the accelerator and maintain a constant speed. Risky became dangerous as her focus began to slip. She overtook a slow-moving RV and only realized after she'd pulled out that she hadn't checked her blind spot. That easily could have been a sideswiped car. They crossed the state line. "We should find a place to sleep soon, if we can." She said. Sleeping in the truck was still an option, but after the day they'd had, it was now definitely only if they had no other choice. Almost on cue, they came around a

bend in the road and passed a sign reading milage to the next few cities. Adora was so tired she laughed.

Snowville – 37 mi.
Ogden – 109 mi.
Salt Lake City – 144 mi.

"Ain't that the truth." She muttered.

"What?" Catra's attention lifted up from Adora's phone. She had become completely engrossed in Bejeweled over the past few hours.

"Looks like we're staying in Snowville tonight. Can you look up if there's a motel there?"

"Can you teach me to read?" Catra replied.

Adora tried to roll her eyes hard enough so they sighed for her. She ended up yawning instead. "Not in 37 miles. Open the app on the bottom row, second from the left."

"Yuh-huh."

“Now, top bar."

"Mmhmm."

“Did the keyboard come up?”

“Yep." Catra clicked her tongue.

“Okay now: press the key that looks like two spikes connected, pointing up.”

"Gotcha.”

"Then the circle. Then the cross. Then the kinda . . . curled tadpole-looking thing."

"What's a tadpole?"

Adora furrowed her brow. This was harder than she thought. Like trying to explain the internet to Grandma Razz. "Okay . . . it looks like a squashed-up circle on top with a curly bit beneath it.

“Got it.”

“Then the vertical line.”

Catra searched. “There’s one ahead on this road. Town is labeled: curly back and forth shape, hump shape, circle shape, double pointy tooth shape facing down, single pointy tooth shape facing down.”

Adora pictured the letters in her head. She really needed to teach Catra to at least be able to guess what words sounded like. “Yep, that’s it. Awesome. I hope they have a room.”

“They better, doesn’t look like there’s much else around.”

They got there just after sundown. Catra had implied the place was tiny, and she hadn’t been exaggerating. The truck’s headlights caught the ‘Welcome to Snowville’ sign on the way in. Population: 167. The motel was on the main – that is, only - intersection in town. It was a depressing-looking L-shaped two-story concrete box, with metal staircases and a concrete walkway the only access to the second-floor rooms. Adora pulled up near the only bright window in the building.

“You sure stopping is a good idea?” Catra asked.

“It’s not ideal,” Adora admitted. “but the fact we’ve crossed state lines - and that we had to detour - should throw the police off our trail. Plus, sleeping in a motel isn’t very different than sleeping in the car.”

“I could drive while you rest.” Catra offered.

Adora actually considered it. It was no more illegal than herself driving. “As much as I don’t know the rules of the road, you absolutely don’t know them.” She decided, thinking of Catra

jumping the snowmobile two days ago. Yeah, letting her behind the wheel was a bad idea, and she voiced as much.

“More complicated than flying a shuttle through a planetary ring system?” Catra challenged. “Doesn’t look hard considering what I’ve seen.”

“A lot of it is edge cases.” Adora sighed. “Look, I could explain it but . . .”

“The princess needs her beauty sleep, I get it.” Catra dropped it and got out.

The pair scurried inside the reception area before the prairie chill could soak through their coats. A tried woman, past middle age and with hair streaked with grey, was sitting behind the peeling old particleboard desk. Wood paneling dominated the walls. The ceiling was drop-tile, split with fluorescent lights. Not exactly The Ritz, then.

“Good evening.” The woman looked up from a cigarette and a crossword puzzle, eyes lingering on Catra and her hat, mask, and the fact that she was wearing sunglasses at night.

“Hi.” Adora greeted. “Would you happen to have a room open for tonight?”

The woman seemed to find this very funny, a long belt of gruff laughter splitting the hum of the lights. “Honey, you have your pick of the litter.” She gestured to the sixteen metal keys hanging on the wall. One for every hook. Adora and Catra glanced at one another, realizing just how dead this place was in winter. “Which you want?”

“Umm . . . surprise me?” Adora shrugged and was given the key to room thirteen. Loveably unlucky, Adora thought as she palmed it. She signed the book on the counter with a fake name; then it was a quick drive to move the truck nearer to their room, then a cold walk up the stairs with Adora’s and Catra’s shared duffel. The key fit loose in the lock, and it took her a few good seconds of

fiddling to get it to catch. This success revealed an . . . acceptable way to spend one night. It was everything you expected of a cheap motel room. Two queen beds with ugly floral sheets, bedside tables with lamps between, a desk no one would use, and an old CRT tube television that probably weighed more than the stand it was sitting on.

"Well, this looks . . . fine." Adora said as she walked in, sitting on the very creaky bed. Catra tipped her head in agreement just as there was a pattering flash on her legs, looking down to see a huge black cockroach skitter over her boot. She jumped two feet in the air, and Adora screamed.

Fifteen minutes of pulling off sheets, moving furniture, Adora jumping on desks screaming and pointing frantically as the Catra swung the broom they'd found in the closet with a murderous gleam, and the last of the gooey broken carapace pieces were swept into the cold. A sigh of relief escaped from both of them. A thorough inspection of the baseboards found that there was seemingly no other way for more roaches to get inside, so long as they stuffed towels under the doors. Catra made sure to jam each in very very tight. No bugs on spaceships, she had said.

"This has just been . . . just a sucky day." Adora collapsed spread eagle on her lazily redressed bed. "Just a really really long sucky day." Despite the possibility of getting a case full of gold and diamonds for doing this, it really felt like she deserved some kind of extra reward for going through all the trouble. It was a selfish thought that Adora didn't like herself thinking. But just . . . oh my God she was exhausted. She had NEVER been this exhausted. Like her muscles were so tired they were just gone, vanished into some other universe.

"You survived." Catra walked over, now dressed in blue PJ shorts patterned with clouds over her skinsuit. "Shoulder?" She extended a hand.

Oh. In the insanity, Adora had completely forgotten about her injury and the cast on her shoulder. She supposed that meant it

had done its job. She sat up, and with a blush that showed in her shoulders, pulled off her t-shirt in front of Catra once again. “Need your other sleeve back?” Adora asked, trying to sound confident. She wasn’t sure she pulled it off. Catra’s left arm had a sleeve that went down to her wrist, whereas the right cut off just above the elbow. “Is that how it even works?” She asked, realizing she had no idea how it did.

“Yes, and yes.” Catra replied, adding. "Shadow Weaver doesn't let uniform violations slide."

“Ahh, she likes the crew to match?” Adora asked as Catra reached out and clasped her shoulder below her bra strap.

“She likes whatever makes her look good, whatever helps her, and nothing else.” She spat as the cast rippled off Adora’s shoulder and back up Catra’s arm, reconnecting to the rest of her suit as if it had never been gone.

Adora pulled her shirt back on. Catra’s face had regained the look of a hard mask, as immovable and unconquerable as the strongest fortress. “Sorry for asking about it.” Adora said.

“It’s alright. Shadow Weaver, she . . .” Catra said, then looked around the room, as if the mere mention of her name could summon her. There was a breath of silence, the only noise the muffled sound of the winter wind outside the thin walls. Then Catra suddenly stood with a snarl and began to pace. It was a slow deliberate walk, and as she moved, she reached up and held a hand over her face, set her shoulders back, and began to speak with a deep smooth tone. “Ah, Force Captain Catra, I see you survived your ordeal on the planet below, how unfortunate. I was most looking forward to the opportunity to fill your position with someone more motivated than you, despite the fact you have carried out every order I have ever asked of you with distinction. Your replacement shall be your better by the mere fact that they are not you and that they will let me pass off all blame for any mistakes I make onto them. Not by lying, no of course not, but I’ll twist my words around and around again and again until the

stooge believes they are getting praised when all the punishments land squarely on their shoulders." Catra pulled the hand off her face with a scowling swipe. "Spooky hag." She hissed.

"I think I'm still sorry I asked about it." Adora said. "But I guess it's interesting to know that shitty bosses are universal." Though that almost sounded like an understatement. Language like that was downright abusive. "She must be quite the pariah." She voiced.

Catra shrugged, not saying anything. You idiot, Adora, she thought. You're too tired to do this tonight. She really needed to get to sleep before she stuffed her foot further into her mouth. Besides, the sooner she did, the sooner they could get moving again. But the thought of getting up to change and brush her teeth might as well have been climbing Mt. Everest.

One more push, Adora. Do it for you. She managed to sit up and start to move out of bed, but in her laziness, didn't quite pull her back foot high enough to escape the covers. "Aah!" The foot stayed behind, and Adora hit the carpeted floor in a heap, face down. "Ow." Of course, Catra started laughing. "Noo . . . c'mon Catra."

Catra only barely restrained her cackles as she sauntered over and freed Adora's foot. Adora sat up and pushed her hair from her eyes, pouting as Catra snatched her phone from the side table and went back to Bejeweled. The flashing lights of the game reflected off her features, off her sparkling focused eyes, the gentle upward slope of her nose, and off the fur on the edges of her face. That fuzz blurred the light and gave Catra a softness, like Adora was seeing her through a dream. She still wondered if, at any moment, she would wake up and find out that all of this: Glimmer at the hospital, Adora alone, Catra, was all some bizarre fever dream cooked up by her brain. But now, as Adora watched the muscles in Catra's back tensing through her skinsuit as she crossed the space between the two beds, tail swishing with the rocking of her hips, every inch of her so confidently casual yet so strong, so comfortable in strength, she felt guilt.

For if this was a dream, Adora was no longer sure she wanted to wake up.

She shook her head as if to clear her ears of water and stood to perform her nightly rituals, then retreated under the covers with rapturous euphoria. She was so exhausted she didn’t care that there were probably still a few roach legs in here with her. She just shut off the lights and snuggled up with a pillow.

But just before Adora fell asleep, she heard rustling on the other bed. Adora opened one eye, seeing Catra's casting two little lights that slid around the room. She was walking over to the front door, on the way quietly picking up the key to the room, then started slipping on her boots.

"Catra?" Adora sat up a little.

Catra's eyes darted at her, causing Adora to squint at the sudden flash of blue and yellow. "Yeah?" The alien asked as she put on her super 90s coat and beanie for her ears, then kicked the towel out from under the door.

"Where are you going?"

"Just . . . outside. I need to get some air for a minute."

"Oh. Okay."

"I'll be careful." She said.

"I know." Adora replied, and Catra disappeared into the cold clear night.

Adora laid back down. Obviously, the conversation about Shadow Weaver had upset her more than Adora realized. Stupid stupid stupid. Adora added that apparent bitch to her mental list of subjects to be careful asking Catra about. At least this whole mess was like a break for her from said shitty captain. Like a super bizarre stressful vacation where Catra was stuck with her instead of Shadow Weaver.

That was another thought. Maybe Catra just needed some space from her for a minute. They had been basically touching each other for five days straight. She could hardly think of the time when they were furthest apart. It was the hilltop calls; she knew as soon as she wondered, then tried her best not to picture them touching each other. Don't be weird, Adora.

Not that Catra seemed to need personal space. Considering how she reacted to the size of her house and her room, it seemed obvious she didn’t get much of her own. A little worm of worry wriggled its way into her brain. It was weird she was going out now, right? In the bitter cold, dressed without weather-appropriate pants over her skinsuit. How upset did she have to be to warrant this? Or worse, how awful was Adora to be around that she just couldn't stand it any longer? Adora was concerned, but not worried until Catra didn't come back for nearly five minutes. She was about to get up and go find her when the door opened again. Catra slipped in, shut it quickly, tossed her coat on the chair, and restuffed the anti-roach towel.

She walked over, rubbing her hands on her arms. "What's that thing you people say? Jesus Christ." But then, surprising Adora, Catra stopped at Adora's bedside instead of her own. "Open up." Was the demand.

"Wha-?"

"I'm freezing. You're warm. Do the math."

Adora froze in surprise, but lifted the blankets. Catra slid in behind her. As soon as the blanket was down, Adora felt a frigid body touch her back. Toes lightly tapped Adora’s heels. Thighs came to rest on the back of Adora’s thighs. Aaaand they were touching. No, worse. This was borderline cuddling. Well, the whole 'not thinking about this' plan had failed.

"Catra." She managed. "You're touching me?” If her goal was to get Adora to heat her up, then it was working. She could feel her neck blushing.

"Oh, am I?" Catra wiggled her spine and everything connected to it, of which Adora felt all too clearly. "Hahaha." She cackled softly in her ear but mercifully slid away six inches before Adora spontaneously combusted. "Your species is so funny with the personal space thing."

Adora was glad it was too dark to see how red she was. "I'm guessing yours isn't?" She squeaked.

"I wish I had a choice." Catra answered, and Adora frowned. Silence filled the motel room. She rolled over, but Catra had also turned to face away, lighting the far wall with her eyes.

"You okay?" Adora asked.

"I'm fine, Adora. Don't worry your pretty little head. I can take care of myself."

"I know." Adora pursed her lips. "But it's not like, me, is it?"

"What?" Catra flipped back over, staring at her with a confused look.

Adora felt her face heat up again. "I don't like, smell or anything right? Like my species smells weird to yours?" Catra started laughing. "Hey! Stop! I'm serious." Adora reached up and twisted a tress of her hair in her hands, pulling the roots.

Catra had to wipe her eyes. "Stars, Adora. Here, if it'll help you sleep." She leaned in and took a huge inhale right in the crook of her neck. Adora felt goosebumps rise as she did. "You smell fine. Like sweat or whatever, but fine. I assume that's just what humans smell like." She seemed to notice that the human wasn't quite convinced by that. "It's not bad."

"Okay." Adora exhaled, stupid little insecurity sated. "But you're still like, okay? Nothing you want to mention? Comments or concerns?" No. Stop talking. You sound like you're asking for a review.

"No." Catra said, and by the tone, it was clear she was done with this conversation.

"You sure?"

"I'm good." Catra closed her eyes and the room darkened again. Adora felt her beginning to curl up into that little ball shape she slept in.

"For real?"

"I'm. Good. Adora." She repeated, the edges of the words sharpening.

Adora cringed. "Alright. Have a good night Catra."

"You too, Adora."

The alarm went off far too soon. Adora groaned over the blare. She fumbled for her phone; bleary eyes sandy in the corners. Silence returned after finding the numbers for '5:00 AM' in the dark. She sat up. Catra was already awake, sitting on the edge of the bed. Like a zombie, Adora shuffled to her feet to begin the day, heavy eyes roving for clothes and toiletries and everything else. She took a precious five minutes to shower. Even though the showerhead was too low, and the tub slightly moldy, it was miraculous how much better she felt after wiping all the grime adhered to her skin over the length of yesterday by sweat and stress.

Afterwards, Adora dried her hair using the wall blow dryer (which barely worked), brushed out the still-damp sand-colored knots into sheets of pale gold, then did battle with a particularly ugly zit on her forehead. She had forgotten her acne cream on the whirlwind trip through the house and now resorted to squeezing the hell out of it until it was way redder and more noticeable than it had been before she touched It. Mission success?

Adora looked down at her hands resting on the sink, two fingertips still tinged pink with blood, then up in the mirror, at her clouded face through the steam. The mist dewed down the silver surface, drops coalescing as they slid. Adora clenched her fingers until they were as white as the porcelain.

Pulling the room curtains aside, the day hadn't yet begun. There was a fringe of light on the horizon, the first touch of dawn. Just enough light to see that while some snow had fallen over the night, it was only a dusting on the parking lot and roads. They could work with that.

After writing a quick cheat sheet with Catra matching alien letters to Latin ones on a sheet of paper, Adora sent her to load and start the truck while she went to return the room key. Setting it on the front desk, she turned to notice a small side door that had been closed the previous night. Inside she saw fruit and a coffee machine. "This place has breakfast?" She asked the receptionist woman who, amazingly, was the same person they had checked in with. Did she just spend all day and night here?

"Help yourself honey."

The room was little more than a counter and two small round tables with chairs, all unoccupied. There was a TV playing for the empty seats. Adora turned to face the breakfast station, which was even more depressing. Besides the coffee machine, there was a toaster, a single sleeve of onion bagels, and a bowl of individually prepackaged muffins. The fruit she'd seen was completely uncontained, just a messy pile of very mealy-looking apples and oranges. Adora sighed, unsurprised, and glanced in the direction of the front desk before discreetly shoving as many muffins as she could into her jacket.

She was about to turn to go when she heard the bell on the main door ring. She glanced over and felt her world crack. It was a police officer. Adora took a panicked step to slip out of sight, hoping that they hadn't seen her.

“Howdy.” The policewoman greeted the receptionist. She had a notable Western accent. “Got any guests this morning?”

“Why d’ya wanna know?” They replied.

“We’re investigating a missing persons case.” The cop said. “We’re looking for a blonde seventeen-year-old girl named Adora Grayskull. Think she might’a stopped here.”

The cracked world shattered. Fuck.

Adora considered running. But the chances of getting past the officer without getting tackled, and then out of the parking lot without starting a newsworthy police chase were slim. Even if she did manage both, the truck wasn’t exactly her first choice for running from the cops. It wasn’t a sports car.

Not that even a sports car could run a thousand miles while being chased by the police. No, she needed to sneak out of here, right now.

Adora pulled her hood up and tightened it to hide her hair, then, moving as quickly and quietly as she dared, left the breakfast room and headed for the exit. Don't notice me don't notice me don't notice me. She made it two-thirds of the way there.

“You there.” The policewoman called.

Fuck fuck fuck. Adora stopped. “Yes?” She glanced back.

The woman studied her face. She was a state trooper, with brown uniform and smokey-bear hat. Adora hoped she wasn’t sweating as she tried to control her breathing. “Where are you from, ma’am?”

“. . . Idaho.” She said as pleasantly as she could.

“Really? Twin Falls?”

Adora bit her tongue to stop herself from answering honestly. “No . . . Boise. Why do you ask? Do you know someone from there?”

The cop sighed, suddenly looking very tired. “Unfortunately not: a girl’s gone missing. Run away from home. Apparently, they think she’ll pass this way.”

“Really? I hadn’t heard. That’s sad.”

“Mmm.” The cop thumbed her chin. “What’s your name ma’am?”

“It’s Diana. Diana Stevens . . . son . . . Stevenson.” She gave the name she’d used last night, dying inside with how fake her delivery sounded. Stevens-son!? Diana!? Adora definitely did not look like a Diana. The cop nodded but didn’t show any signs of dismissing her, so Adora asked. “What’s hers?”

“Adora Grayskull.” She said, then repeated the description she knew from every mirror. “She was also with another girl: 5' 4", Brown hair, mismatched eyes.”

“I see,” Adora said, and there was another tense silence.

“I’m sorry ma’am, but just to gather some information, I’d like to ask you a few questions.”

Terror clashed with her upbringing. She'd always been told: be polite, be accommodating. “Of course, officer.” She nodded as she tried to lock down the fear. The cop gestured to the breakfast room with a hand. She was led inside and after the trooper started a K-cup of coffee, they sat across one another. “What do you want to know?" Adora asked. "I haven’t seen anyone that looks like that recently.”

“An absence of knowledge can still be useful.” The cop said, pulling out a pen and a small pad of paper. “We don’t know quite which way she’s going, so eliminating possibilities would be helpful. Where have you come from? Where are you going this close to Christmas?”

Adora told the same story she told the plowman last night, with a new ending. “We’re going to umm . . . Palm Springs, together. Her family lives there.” She finished.

“You’re not staying with your own for the holiday?”

“Well . . . we don’t . . . don’t celebrate Christmas.” Adora lied.

“Oh?” The cop looked up, expectant. “Not even secularly?”

“No.” Adora smiled. Oh, crap she needed an actual reason. “We’re . . . umm . . . Jewish?” She smiled again. She was Jewish!?

“Ah.” The cop smiled. “My husband is too. We do both. Do you do gifts for Hanukkah?" She smirked at Adora. "Did you get anything good?”

“Umm . . . yeah.” Adora nodded, not believing she believed that. “I umm . . . got a cat.”

The cop wrote something down. “You look warm.” She said. “You want to remove your hood?”

Adora swallowed. “I’d prefer not to.” She answered cordially. “It’s still pretty cold in here.”

The cop nodded, an inscrutable motion. “The car these runaways are using, it’s a white dual cab Ford pickup. Have you seen any like it since you been driving? Heading east or west?”

“I . . . don’t think I have. There aren’t many cars on the road with the weather, and this far from everything . . .”

“Really? It’s very similar to the only truck parked in the guest lot. That one’s yours, right?”

“It . . . umm . . .”

“Idaho plates too.”

“I . . . no, we parked across the street . . .” Adora’s eyes fell to her lap. The coffee machine rumbled.

“Why?”

“We didn’t . . . we ate at the diner there.” She thanked her memory of noticing that establishment on the way in last night.

“Are you lying to me?” The cop asked, and Adora’s head snapped up. Under the brim of the hat, the officer's look had hardened.

“N-no . . . ma’am.”

“Really?” She used her pen to flip back to the last page of the pad. “Because I spoke with the waitresses there before coming over here and they said that no young women came in for dinner last night. And the book you signed in on says you arrived at 7:04.”

Adora opened her mouth, but no sound came out.

“The plates on your truck match the APB.” She finished. The coffee machine burbled and beeped, and the cop stood to retrieve it. Adora stumbled to her feet as her back was turned. As the chair clattered, the cop turned and saw desperation. Her eyes and voice softened and she raised placating hands. “Whoa now. Whoa.” She eased. “Now . . . I know this must be frightful Adora, but your parents are very worried about you.” Adora took a step back. “But there’s no reason to be scared. I’m here to help you get back . . . get back . . . . . .”

Adora’s heart was beating so fast that it took a moment for her to realize the cop trailing off wasn’t because time had slowed from adrenaline. The trooper had actually had frozen. They were just standing there, mouth slightly agape.

“We going or what?” Called from behind her. Adora turned. Catra was in the doorway, smiling under her sunglasses with a small shining object in their hands. A shining object that Adora found very difficult to look away from. “Ah, I see.” They said of the

scene, stepping forward. "It's 'or what' then." Adora's eyes unwillingly followed the flickering object as she held it out over the table between her and the trooper. It was a shard. A piece of crystal. A piece of the broken subspace radio lens. Catra dropped it, and it stopped falling before it hit the table, landing in midair with a clink that echoed to a sound unlike any Adora had ever heard. Catra covered Adora's eyes with a hand. “Now, let’s go.” She said through the darkness.

Adora inhaled a shaky breath and nodded. With a hand on her wrist, she was pulled with eyes closed away from the officer and towards the cold morning. “What about the receptionist?” She asked as they passed by, twisting her head left and catching just a peek of her being equally transfixed on her own little alien fragment.

“Don’t worry about it.” Catra said and pushed her forward out the door. She released her eyes and in three steps Adora had found her footing as they ran across the parking lot towards the already running truck.

“You’ve had the lens on you this whole time!?” Adora yelled, not looking back. Why didn't she tell her? When had she grabbed it? All the way back at the house?

Catra flashed the entirety of the glass tube for a fraction of a second before tossing it to Adora. She yelped as she caught the hypnotizer, only saved from tripping over herself by the fact that Catra had wrapped it in the sleep shorts she'd worn last night. “It came in handy, didn’t it?”

Adora couldn’t deny that. “Thanks for the save.” She said breathlessly.

“Aww, no prob." Catra waved a hand at her, disappearing behind the passenger side of the already-running truck.

Adora jumped in the driver's seat. Catra was already buckled. “We good?” She asked. Adora looked in the rearview mirror. No one

was following them out of the motel. “Adora?”

“We can’t just . . . hypnotize police officers, Catra!” Adora said to her as she shifted out of park. “How are they going to get out of that!? They won’t just stare until they starve right?”

Catra blinked, surprised. “I don’t know.” She admitted. “But people fall asleep . . . eventually.” Adora clamped a hand across her forehead. “We’re doing what we have to do.” She justified.

Adora bit the blade of her tongue and pulled out of the parking lot, rejoining the highway. “We have to be careful in public from now on.”

As they turned south, hills and then mountains rose up on both sides of the highway, boxing in flat barren prairies, within which civilization began to creep back in. The greater Salt Lake area began with farm towns, then small cities like Twin, then swiftly became suburban sprawl as the highway curved around the eastern shore of the eponymous lake. Adora glanced over Catra to see it as they drove, remembering from the time she and the Brightmoons had vacationed here when she was twelve, and how ugly the body of water was. Foamy crusty shores were lapped by stagnant waters. Huge stretches of dried salt pans extended for miles from years of droughts, and it was very hard to tell where the lifeless saline desert ended and the lifeless saline water began. Adora rolled down the windows briefly to catch the putrid briny air on her nose, wondering if the ocean smelled this bad. She hoped it didn’t. The lake was much saltier than the ocean, and she didn’t want to be disappointed when she finally got to see the real thing someday.

Catra sniffed the air, nose curling. “What’s this place called?”

“Salt Lake City.”

“Wow, real creative.”

Indeed. At least in winter, the brine flies were much less of a problem.

They tried the muffins Adora had gotten. They were terrible. Adora finished one anyway.

They stopped for gas on the outskirts of the city proper. Adora jumped out and grabbed some of their borrowed cash. “Stay close, I gotta go pay inside before we can fuel.”

Catra nodded as she got out, fully disguised.

Adora felt her dread build up as she got through the doors and realized there was a line. Pulling her hood up and slipping her ponytail inside once again, she walked to the end. Halfway there she tripped, stumbling to a sprawl on the tiled floor. “Ow.” Adora grunted out, feeling the staring eyes of the people around her. Yeah, stay nice and innocuous, Adora. She thought. Good job.

A dress shoe stepped into her vision. Adora followed the leg attached to it up to find a black woman in a full black suit and tie with a hand down to help her. She was tired-looking, with aqua-blue hair held back in a loose braid.

Adora took the offered hand and was pulled up. “Thanks.” She muttered.

“Yeah, don’t make a big thing out of it.” The woman replied, monotone and flat. “It was kinda my fault anyway so like . . .” She turned around to retake her place in line, only to find it closed. The man who had shuffled forward just shrugged at her. “Ughhh.” She groaned out, fists clenched. “My reward for helping . . .” She stalked off towards the back of the line and Adora followed, awkwardly getting in behind her. It moved slowly, the singular cashier having to redeem lottery tickets, pull cigarettes, and check IDs. Adora’s fists clenched and unclenched, her palms sweaty. “So, what brings you to this dump this time of year?” The suited woman spoke again.

“Oh?” Adora looked up to meet one of her light brown eyes glancing back over her shoulder. It was marred by a dark circle underneath. “I’m heading home for Christmas with a friend.” She told a simpler lie to avoid some of the questions from her last conversation. But why was this lady asking? Just to be social?

“Cool cool.” The woman nodded, seashell earrings flashing in the fluorescent lights. She was probably in her mid-twenties.

There was a pause, and Adora knew it was best to shut up now. But, “I like your suit.” came out regardless. Nooo stop being polite.

“Thanks.” She replied, not sounding enthused. She turned around. “Mermista.” And now introductions. Stop, Adora. Stop.

“I’m Diana.” Adora replied, and they shook. “What are you doing so well dressed in this place?”

“Just part of the job.” Mermista shrugged. “Trust me, if I could wear sweatpants every day I would.” Adora chuckled awkwardly as Mermista inspected her fingernails, which were painted to match her hair. “So, where’ya going with your girlfriend?”

“Oh . . . well . . . umm . . . she’s . . .” Adora shut her mouth before the ‘she’s not my girlfriend’ could spill out. “California.”

“Ooo, by the ocean? Nice.”

“It’s umm . . . more in the desert.” Adora hadn’t told Mermista she was traveling with a girl.

“Very Christmassy.” Mermista nodded, and the line moved forward enough so she could pay for her gas. But, transaction completed, she conspicuously stayed nearby while Adora did the same, and tried not to freak out when she followed her back to the truck. There, the worry grew further. Catra was giving blunt answers to a man asking her wordy questions from the pump across from theirs. He was also dressed in a black suit. “Uuughhhh . . .” Mermista groaned as they approached.

“Ah! Mermista!” The man lit up when he saw her.

“Just start pumping the gas.” Mermista demanded of him, then leaned in and said something quietly in his ear.

“I was merely trying to be sociable, dearest!” The man replied very loudly.

“Not your dearest.” Mermista replied immediately.

Instead of doing what he was asked, the man stepped over towards Adora. He held the gas nozzle across his chest with one hand as he daintily took one of Adora’s with the other, bowing and kissing it with dark eyes looking up at her. “It is a pleasure to meet you, as it was meeting your friend. Seahawk, at your service. It’s quite exciting to hear about the **adventure** the two of you are on!” He emphasized the word ‘adventure’ almost to a shout.

Mermista? Seahawk? Those couldn’t be their real names, right? Surprised and made uncomfortable by the gesture, Adora grimaced at Catra, who shrugged with a scowl, then took the man in. She supposed he was . . . umm . . . dashing? Around the same age as Mermista and also dressed to the nines. His suit however was worn without a tie, with the top three buttons of his dress shirt undone, and with black boots instead of dress shoes. These points, plus his broad chest, chiseled jaw, and a thin mustache that would look more in place in an old Errol Flynn movie than anywhere in the real world, made sure he cut an interesting and bizarre swashbuckling figure.

“Thanks?” Adora pulled her hand away.

Mermista rolled her eyes. “The pump, Seahawk!” She repeated, grabbing the hose attached to his nozzle to yank him away.

"Very well very well!" Seahawk laughed, positioning the nozzle like a pistol in front of him as he strutted away. "To refueling! Perhaps I can pour the gas in from two feet away this time!"

Mermista looked like she wanted to strangle the man. “I swear if you set another one of our cars on fire, I am going to strangle you.”

Adora looked between the pair. This was all very weird.

"Worry not, my lady!" Seahawk eased. "We shall be on our way post haste!” He began filling their unassuming black sedan by holding the nozzle six inches from the gas cap, the yellow arch of fuel perfectly landing in the funnel. Adora noticed the car's Nevada plates only because they had oddly few letters on them. Just: ‘DD3’.

Adora backed away from that fire hazard and started pumping their own gas, watching the pair until they were blocked from view by the truck. Catra stuck close. “What did you tell him?” Adora whispered.

“Barely anything.”

Adora nodded. Good. “These guys are suspicious, right?”

“No doubt.” Catra rumbled.

“Wow, rude much.” Mermista appeared around the front of the truck.

Adora jumped. “Oh! Umm . . . no, we weren’t talking about you just now! Nope! Definitely not.” She smiled.

“Uh-huh.” Mermista droned. “Look, I know we just met or whatever but are you two like . . . okay?” She stuck a thumb at the front of the truck. “You’ve got a dent there.”

“We’re fine.” Catra said sternly.

“Yep!” Adora added with a much peppier tone. “No troubles! It looks worse than it is.”

“You’re sure?” Mermista pushed, and Adora's instincts told her that they needed to get out of here.

“Yep.” She repeated, stopping pumping even though the truck wasn’t close to full.

Mermista nodded and sighed. “Alright, but if that ever changes, we might be able to help.” She reached into her inside suit jacket pocket and pulled out a matte-black business card, passing it to Adora. “Just give me a call.”

The card gave no name, no job description, no email address or Twitter handle. Nothing but a seven-digit phone number printed in a plain white font. Adora racked the pump. “Umm . . . thanks.” She said to Mermista. She was definitely not going to ask how they could help her if they didn’t know where they were going other than ‘the desert of California’.

Mermista nodded. “Good luck with whatever you’re doing.” She said, then turned and went back to her car. Adora heard the bickering between the two . . . men in black . . . mafia goons . . . whoever they were, restart immediately. Catra nudged her on the shoulder and they shared a look, then together they ran on.

Seahawk looked away from the white truck as it headed south, turning to Mermista as she finished the call. “Yes. Right. We understand sir.” She paused to listen to the boss-man on the other side, sighing silently and bracing her fingers against her nose. “We won’t let them get far. Yeah. Yeah. Roger that.” She hung up and looked at him. “Ready?”

“Oh dearest,” Seahawk beamed, twirling the keys on his index finger. “you know too well that I’m always ready for an **adventure!**”

Traffic picked up. The Salt Lake City morning rush hour clamped down around them as they headed nearer the city center. It was

nearly stop-and-go when Adora’s phone rang. She jumped at the sound, surprised. Had she not blocked everyone that was barraging her?

“I got it.” Catra said, grabbing it. She looked at the ID, then lifted up her alphabet cheat sheet. They had been going over it during the drive. “Why do you have to have two different shapes for every sound?” She muttered as she scanned it. “From a . . . uhh . . . Bee . . . Ohh . . . Double U.”

Adora’s eyebrows shot up. She hadn't blocked him because he hadn't messaged her. “Pass it here.” She put the phone on speaker. "Bow?"

"Hi, Adora." Her friend replied, and she noted he sounded a little lost. "Umm . . . quick question?”

"No, I'm not coming home yet, Bow. Even if the Brightmoons have roped you into this."

Bow chucked. "Not what I was going to ask."

"Wait, really?" Adora said. "Do you know what's going on?" Had Glimmer not called him since their last conversation together? "I didn't mean to assume you were-"

"Adora." He cut her off. "Can you come pick Glimmer and I up at the airport?" Adora blue-screened. For several seconds she was completely silent. The car in front of them moved forward, but Adora didn’t release the brake. A car blared its horn at them, forcing her foot off the pedal. "Adora?" Bow asked.

“Bow?” Adora answered. “What did you say?”

“Can you pick us up?” He repeated, then explained. “We just landed in Salt Lake City.” Suddenly Adora understood the noise in the background. People talking, overhead compartments being opened, and the hum of an airliner’s air conditioning. “You should be able to be here right around when we get our bags.”

Adora and Catra’s eyes met, all four were wide. Wait, they knew where they were. "How the f-" She fell silent. "Oh. Oh shit."

"Love you Adora, but you're a bit of an idiot." Bow eased.

Her goddamned Snapchat. She had forgotten to turn off location sharing. Bow and Glimmer had been tracking her this whole time . . .

Adora immediately considered hanging up. But they had flown all the way to Salt Lake City? Why? Just to hope to catch them? “It’s just the two of you?” Adora gave them a chance.

“Yep.”

“And the cops? The men in black? You haven’t given them our location?”

“Nobody but us knows.” Bow confirmed. “Men in black?”

What? Adora had one question then. “Why?”

Adora heard Bow's smile through the phone when he answered. “We’re here to help you, Adora. To help Catra."

What!? Adora was silent for a long time. She could just hang up. Pass them by. This was her promise to fulfill, hers to follow to the end. Being the only human involved meant she was the only one who would get in trouble for it. Were Glimmer and Bow really here to help, or was this a scheme? All lies to get them to turn themselves in? Even if they weren’t, she didn’t want either of them to stoop to her level and run away from home for this.

“I know you're gaming it out right now, Adora.” Glimmer’s voice came out of the phone. “But he’s telling the truth. There’s no tricks.”

Adora clenched her jaw. If they were telling the truth, they’d be a big help. Bow had a real driver’s license, and the two of them

could drive in shifts. Adora looked to Catra, who did not look enthused about this. She shook her head no.

Adora clenched her jaw, knowing that Catra was probably right. But then she thought of when Glimmer chewed her out in the cabin. For never listening to her, for never trusting her.

Adora had made more than one promise in the last few days. “We’ll be there.” She made one more.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None

Welp, I did not want this chapter to take three weeks, but multiple scenes just kept not working right.

And what, did you think we were going to go this whole story without having the Best Friend Squad together? Of course not!

Chapter 8: Baggage Claim

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“This is a bad idea.” Catra said as they pulled into the very busy arrivals loop of Salt Lake City International Airport.

“Maybe.” Adora admitted. All around, traffic and weary passengers thrummed. Shuttle buses jockeyed for position. Mothers embraced children. Grandparents were led into their family’s cars with stories of the adventures they had missed.

“Then why are we doing this?”

“They can help.”

“You said we’d stick together.”

“We are.” Adora assured of her promise. “We will.”

“Even if they want otherwise?” Catra asked.

Adora tried to stop her own wit from biting, but the bait was too good. “If you’re jealous I won’t be able to give you all my attention anymore, then you can just say it.”

Catra growled lowly. “This is serious.”

Adora cringed. Yeah, she knew. “Sorry.” Catra’s tail flicked sharply. Adora reached over and gently pressed it below the line of the windows, out of sight. The fur was soft but raised on-end in her palm. “They’re here to help.” She repeated.

“So they say.”

Adora frowned. “Do you trust me, Catra?”

“What?”

“You heard me.” Adora said. She spotted pink hair a ways ahead and pulled over. The truck in park, the human and alien locked eyes for a long moment. “If you trust me, then you should trust me when I say **I** trust **them**.”

“Your sister-” Catra began.

“will see what I see.” Adora finished for her. “They both will. Just give them time.”

Catra grumbled. “Fine.”

“Fine?” Adora double-checked.

“I trust you,” Catra assured. “asshole.”

Adora smiled. “Right back at ya.” She jumped out of the car, heading towards the little streak of pink ahead. Bow and Glimmer were standing with a backpack and a suitcase each. Adora stopped a few feet away from her sister and her friend, hesitant. Her promise to apologize filled her mind.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Come here.” She called. Adora rushed forward and they all crushed each other in a three-way hug.

“You guys are crazy.” Adora squealed. But when she tried to lean back and look them in the eyes, she was dragged by her arms away and behind a nearby pillar, out of sight of everyone. Adora’s back was slammed into the wall. “Whoa!” She gasped, fighting their hands. “What are you doing!?”

Together they held her in place while Bow asked. “Are you safe Adora? Just say the word and we’ve got you out of here.”

“What!?” Adora cried, then lowered her voice to not draw attention.

Glimmer looked her in the eye, searching. “Is the alien forcing you to do this? She’s like . . . brainwashed you or something, right?”

“What!?” Adora shook her head. “No. Glimmer . . . No. I’m alright. I’m doing this because I-” Have to? Want to? “need to. I thought you realized that. You said you were here to help!”

Bow and Glimmer glanced at each other. Adora’s terror rose with the realization that Catra had been right. There weren’t here to help, there were here to ‘rescue’ her. “I told you it might be like this.” Bow said to Glimmer.

“Don’t start again.” She replied.

It was at that moment that Catra appeared, pushing through the crowd around the pillar, disguised and with claws drawn. “Back off.” She snarled.

“You.” Glimmer rumbled.

“Guys.” Adora tried to stop this from spiraling. “Guys, let’s just relax for a second.” She stopped trying to fight her friends off, and they loosened their grip somewhat in return.

Catra said to Adora. “I told you so, by the way.”

Glimmer dropped Adora, marching over to Catra. “Give me one good reason why I shouldn’t kick your teeth in.” She spat.

Catra looked Glimmer up and down. “You’d lose more.”

“I warned you.” Glimmer’s voice was deadly cold.

“Guys!” Adora pushed Bow’s arms off her and ran between them. “Stop!” She put her arms up. “You’re going to get security on us!”

Glimmer grabbed Adora’s wrist and tried to pull her away from Catra. “Adora, we’re here to help you.”

“Then prove it.” She pointed at her sister. “I’m safe. I’m of sound mind. Catra did not force me to do this. If you trust me at all anymore, then help us.”

“She’s right, Sparkles.” Catra said, claws still up. “I was just as surprised as you when Adora here decided to kidnap me.”

“Okay, I did not kidnap you.” Adora protested.

“Semantics.” Catra waved off.

“I told you not to call me Sparkles.” Glimmer glowered.

Bow approached the group, putting a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder to stay her. “You really are an alien.” He said to Catra.

“Yeah.” Catra lifted her sunglasses briefly to show him her eyes. “Take me to you leader and all that.”

“A real actual alien.” Bow whispered. “Glimmer.”

“No, Bow.”

“She hasn’t hurt us yet.”

“And she won’t.” Adora stepped in again. “Unless you give **us** a reason to.” She looked at her sister. “Glim, I know it’s hard to believe, but I chose this. She’s my friend. Aunt Casta can get her home. So, I’m going to do whatever it takes.”

Glimmer looked her in the eyes and finally seemed to believe how serious she was. “Why?”

“Because it’s the right thing to do.” Adora said simply. “Isn't that why you came all the way out here? To do the right thing?” She couldn’t think of a better reason, but Glimmer didn’t reply, so Adora looked at Bow. “Bow, isn’t that why you’re here?”

Glimmer answered before he could. “I came to stop you from getting yourself killed.” She declared, glaring at Catra. “Bow insisted he come along.”

“That’s not exactly how it happened.” Bow protested.

Adora shook her head. “And that convinced the adults to let you do this?”

Bow chuckled. “Well, I sort of . . . didn’t tell my dads until we were already on the plane.” Adora blinked. That was simultaneously so like and unlike Bow. His dads were nicest damn people on the planet, and he loved them, but they were overprotective of their youngest, always trying to box him into studying. Also, they didn’t like it whenever he got his inventing hands on anything more dangerous than a pool noodle.

“And Angella and Micah?” Adora turned to Glimmer.

“Umm . . . I’m a rebellious teenager?” She said. Adora gaped in disbelief. No. That couldn’t be right. They had both run away?

“Ugh!” Catra suddenly growled, making Bow and Glimmer jump. “We don’t have time for this! Adora, was this your idea and I had absolutely no say in it beforehand?”

“Well technically yes, but,” Adora began but was cut off.

“Good, and you two.” Catra turned. “Are you actually here to help us, or are we leaving you on this curb right now?”

Bow looked at Glimmer, raising his hand in a silent question. Glimmer in return bared and gritted her teeth, thinking for a long moment. “This is crazy.” She muttered, then ground out a short. “Fine.”

“Yes!” Bow pumped his fist excitedly. “I’ll get the bags.” He ran for the suitcases.

Glimmer ran two hands down her face before following. She stopped by Catra on the way by, lifting a finger towards her nose. “A single reason that I don’t think we can trust you, and you’re left by the side of the highway. Even if I have to knock these two idiots out to do it.” She gestured at her fellow humans.

Catra nodded and followed Bow. Adora breathed for the first time in a while. “Thank you Glimmer, for coming. It’s so good to see you both.” Her sister punched her in the side, hard. “Ow!”

“That’s for being an idiot!” She cried. “Don’t you dare do something this stupid again! You hear me!?”

“Ahh, yes! I hear you I hear you!” Adora begged.

“I don’t think you do.” Glimmer scowled, looking dangerously close to crying. “I swear to God, Adora . . .”

“I know.” Adora exhaled. “Glimmer I . . .” She began, but Glimmer marched away towards the truck. Damnit. Catra was right. There were a lot of people around. People who could mention their whereabouts. Her apology would have to wait. Adora followed, pulling her hood lower on her head. They really did need to move.

Glimmer rounded the front of the car, then did a double take and backed up. “What happened to the truck!?” Came the shout.

"The ditch came out of nowhere!" Adora sputtered. "There wasn’t nothing I could do!"

Bow laughed from where he was loading the suitcases into the backseat but cringed when he came to see what the fuss was. "This is part of why you had to turn around yesterday, wasn't it?"

"No!" Adora blushed and got two stares in return. ". . . Yes."

A car honked behind the truck, and a security guard was eyeing them sternly. Yes, need to move. “Mom’s gonna kill you.” Glimmer said.

At this, Adora felt her heart drop out of her chest. “Yeah.” She nodded. “Yeah, she is.”

They jumped in, Adora and Catra in the front, Bow and Glimmer in the back. They pulled away a quartet, and once back on the highway, Adora glanced back to confirm that Bow and Glimmer –

BOW AND GLIMMER! – were actually sitting there. The former looked eager but nervous. The latter was trying to burn holes through the headrest in front of her.

“So,” Catra broke the muggy tension. “You two gonna own up to your original plan or stick to the lie?”

Bow’s eyes widened as Glimmer’s narrowed. “We didn’t lie. We just knew we probably couldn’t convince you to turn around over a call.” Bow said. “So, we came to see what we could do. If you were like . . . brainwashed then it was going to be dragging you home, Adora.”

“Wow. What a twist. I’m shocked.” Catra deadpanned.

“But, obviously,” Bow continued. “things aren’t like that. I thought it might be this way, so we made a backup plan.”

“To help us?” Adora asked.

“That’s one reason.” Bow nodded, then leaned down and began fiddling with his suitcase, unzipping it to grab something. “But it’s also a chance to live out my 80s teen adventure movie dreams!”

“You brought your archery stuff?” Adora asked incredulously as he pulled out his bow.

“There always comes a moment when the kid with the gadgets gets to shine.” Bow beamed. “Let me live it!"

“Like in The Goonies?” Catra asked, eyebrow raised.

"Exactly like the Goonies!" Bow practically cheered. “Adora, yes!”

“Alright alright.” Adora laughed.

“Glad you all are having fun.” Glimmer said, crossing her arms. “I guess we should enjoy this, considering the three of us are grounded for life.”

“I presume ‘grounded’ means the same thing here as it does in space?” Catra asked.

“Probably.” Adora said, frowning at Glimmer’s tone.

Bow leaned forward between the seats. “I still can’t believe you’re a real live **actual** alien!” Catra sighed. “I have so many questions! What’s your home planet like? What does your civilization use as propulsion through local and interstellar space? Is it the same thing? How many species of aliens have you met? How many planets have you been to?”

“I should have realized you’d all be nerds before this moment.” Catra mumbled before listing off the answers on her fingers. “Humid. Subspace-enhanced chemical rockets for local space and warping spacetime for relativistic speeds. Forty-one. And I don’t know . . . thirtyish?”

“Whoahh . . .” Bow exhaled, eyes full of stars.

Adora smiled at his cute awe, and the tension in the car seemed to ebb. “I really am glad you guys are here.” She said. “That we’re in this together.”

"Heck yes!” Bow cheered. “Best Friends Squad . . . plus one," He gestured at Catra excitedly. "on our biggest adventure yet!"

"Really?" Catra asked. "Best Friends Squad?"

Glimmer sighed. "We tried to talk him out of it." Adora chuckled, not liking it much better. She was just happy Glimmer answered Catra without sounding like she wanted to kill her.

"You people are terrible at naming things on this planet. Also, a bow and arrow? Doesn't your planet have better ways to defend yourself?"

"Yeah, but this is what I like." Bow defended, unashamed.

"Bow likes bows.” Catra said. “Do I want to ask?"

The story came easily from Bow’s lips. He had told it a thousand times and managed to get it down to the minimum possible words. "My name's actually Robert. But that's one of my dad's names, so people called me Bobby.”

"Old man's name." Glimmer smirked quietly.

Bow leveled a gaze at her. "Then when I got obsessed with archery people started calling me Bow."

"W optional." Glimmer appended with a smirk.

“I shouldn’t have asked.” Catra noted.

Adora reached down to rummage through the center console. “So, you guys hungry? We got muffins.” She found one of the pre-packaged ones and tossed it back there, not seeing who caught it.

There was rustling of the package being opened. “Uff.” Glimmer gagged with muffin in her mouth. “Adfora thiph is disghusting!”

She cringed. “Yeah, they’re pretty bad.”

“When was the last time you two ate?” Bow asked.

“This morning, obviously. Muffins.” She grabbed another one and held it up.

“And before that?”

“We grabbed some bars from the house.” Adora said.

Bow sighed. “When’s the last time you had ***real*** food?”

It took a second to remember. Way too much had happened in the past twenty-four hours. “Umm . . . before we left the cabin.”

The back of the car exploded into incredulous shouts. Adora heard her name from both of them, along with an assorted set of angry remarks about how she could be so stupid. It was capped by

another smack on the shoulder from Glimmer. “Ow!” The blonde flinched. “Driving!”

“Serves you right.” Glimmer said. “So, regardless of whether we’re hungry or not, we are getting food for you two bozos.”

“Bozos?” Catra bristled.

“Yeah, bozos for barely eating for a whole day.” Glimmer assured, seeming to enjoy insulting Catra. “Now, where do we want to eat?”

Adora was about to suggest fast food when Bow gasped. “Glimmer! We're in Salt Lake City!”

“. . . So?”

"The state that just so happens to contain the best burrito I’ve ever had. We need to go there!” He pulled out his phone and started typing.

“Oh God, foodie Bow.” Adora chuckled.

“What's a 'foodie'?” Catra asked.

“Listen Catra,” Bow leaned between the seats. “the flavors of this world are as varied as they are delicious.”

“Okay. And a burrito is a
food?”

Bow’s eyes went very wide, and he whispered. “Oh my god, and you haven't had ***any*** of them before. You have a virgin mouth!”

"Please never say the phrase ‘virgin mouth’ ever again." Glimmer shuddered.

“It’s amazing!” Bow insisted. “The tastiest ingredients rolled together into the most ergonomic food.”

“Bow, I’m sure it’s amazing but we’re kind of being chased by the cops here.” She explained their two encounters in the morning. “Driving back into the city? Probably not the best idea.”

“That’s what’s so great. It’s way out in the southern burbs, basically on our way!”

“I could go for a burrito.” Glimmer said. “Come on Adora, we’ll get it to go . . .” She turned on her puppy dog eyes.

It took a lot of cajoling to get Adora to agree to sit and eat once they got their food. “Eat fast.” She ordered as they did, grouchy-faced. Glimmer took the little victory; she unwrapped her burrito and with the first bite knew Bow was right. This was the best damn one she’d ever had. Bow’s white whale was a tiny hole-in-the-wall place, the out and insides of the building painted with sugar skulls and raucous color in what otherwise looked like just another dull Mormon town. That had been promising. The smell and shouting in Spanish behind the counter even more so. Bow had chatted with a server when they were pointing out toppings for them to add. One was the owner’s son, and they were from the west of Mexico, and still got a lot of their ingredients from there. That hyped Glimmer up even more, yet the results still impressed her. Adora scarfed hers down like an animal, but couldn’t hide the reactions on her face. Even Catra, despite having put no cheese or hot sauce or much or anything on her burrito, was unable to completely hide the joyful sounds escaping her mouth.

“So,” Bow started between bites. “what's our game plan?" He looked around the table. The place’s sitting area was empty, but despite that, he kept his voice low. "Adora?"

"Whumh?" She looked up, burrito in her mouth.

"Our gameplan." He repeated. "We're in this with you two now so, how do we get Catra home?"

Adora chewed and swallowed. "We get to Goldstone." She said, voice lowering to match. "Without getting picked up by the cops. We call Catra's people. Then, you know, big *Close Encounters* moment."

Bow looked as unimpressed as Glimmer felt. "What are we even going to do when you get there?" She asked.

"Find Aunt Casta." Adora counted on her fingers. "Get her to point the antenna thingy in the right direction and go . . . Pew . . . Whuwowhuwoehuo . . ." She wriggled her fingers like radio waves.

"You have no idea how space communication works at all, do you?" Bow asked.

"No." Adora admitted, deflating. Glimmer shook her head; she should have expected this. Her sister could name constellations and nebula far better than sections of the electromagnetic spectrum.

Bow looked at the alien. "Catra? Your people can pick up radio transmissions?"

"Yes." Catra was sitting sideways in her chair, back leaning on Adora's shoulder and feet up on another chair. God, she was so touchy with her. Disguised in hat and glasses, tail tucked into her bright bright coat, nobody who looked quickly would notice anything amiss. After Adora had run off and nearly given them all a heart attack, she and her dad had gone out to see where Catra had crashed. The spaceship she'd come down in was still there, so Glimmer had no doubt she was actually an alien. And while she was pretty sure she didn't deserve to be trapped here on Earth, that didn't stop her nerves from spiking every time their eyes met, or the persistent thoughts that she'd prefer literally anyone else but them be helping her get as far away as possible.

"Do we need a specific frequency?" Bow was still talking.

"Probably not. We scan for everything."

“Well, there’s that at least, will they be able to tell we’re talking to them?”

“Probably not, your local space is jammed full of radio garbage.”

“So, we’ll have to devise a calling card of some kind.” Bow noted. “The Arecibo telescope did something like that once, they sent a pulsing signal that could be decoded into data. Catra, do you know anything like that we could use? Or an emergency SOS?”

“I wasn’t a communications officer.” Catra said, head tipping back on top of Adora’s shoulder and adjusting her sunglasses. Her hat pressed into Adora’s cheek and her sister smiled. So touchy . . . “Gimme some time, I bet I can remember some kind of code.”

“If not, we can work on one together, I have some audio software on my laptop.” Bow offered. “Now we just need to know where to point.”

“Standard rendezvous is at one of your planet’s gravity balance points.” Catra said.

“Gravity balance points?”

“Yeah, like where your planet and your star’s gravity balance out, so you can just sit there stably. There’s five of them.”

“Lagrange points?” Adora asked. Bow started googling. He turned his phone to show a diagram.

“Yep.” Catra pointed a finger gun at him, then leaned forward and indicated which point they should look towards. “Nice job, Arrows.”

Glimmer was quickly getting worried about Bow’s eagerness here. “Umm . . . guys?” She interrupted. “I feel like we’re overestimating Aunt Casta’s ability to get us access to really expensive government equipment here. Are you sure we can do this?”

“Aww, come on Glim,” Adora waved the concern away. “She knows us. Plus, we’re not terrorists. We’re just trying to help someone.”

“**We’re** just four kids, is all I’m saying.” Glimmer went in for another bite while shooting a poignant glance at Bow.

Bow rubbed the back of his neck. “That is true, Adora.” He admitted. “Are you two sure this is the only way to do this?”

Adora’s defenses snapped back up. “Guys.”

Glimmer pushed anyway. “Adora, she works for the government. Who says they’ll take time out of their schedule for us? Or, even better question: won’t they notice us using their assets for something like this? They’ll be questions.” Adora’s frustration turned into a scowl. She opened her mouth to answer, but the door to the restaurant opened and a young woman walked in, eyes double-checking their hushed conversation. Catra pulled her hat a little lower.

“This is exactly why we should have had this conversation in the truck.” Adora said, wrapping her burrito up and standing. “Come on.”

Glimmer exhaled, rubbing her forehead but doing the same. They began the chilly walk back to the truck, and halfway there Adora came up with another theory to drive her insane quest. “If Casta won’t let us use the dish then we could maybe build our own? Or buy an old satellite dish?”

“We could get some steel and chicken wire.” Bow brainstormed. “Tie to my HAM.” No Bow, please don’t encourage this . . .

“We’d need something powerful.” Catra said. “But, regardless of whether it would work, this relative of yours is probably the best person to ask about it, right?”

As they arrived at the trick, Glimmer saw the exact moment Adora decided that that was the correct answer, and intervened before

she could say as much. “And if she can’t help us? If no one can?”

Adora took a breath but didn’t answer.

“Want me to drive?” Bow filled the silence.

“Please.” Adora said desperately, lifting up the keys. He chuckled as he took them. "Thank God." She deflated. "I was gonna have a heart attack if I had to keep driving illegally."

"Well technically you're fine to drive now that I'm here, I've had my license for six months." He said as he climbed in.

Her sister turned to Catra. "Mind if I sit in the front?"

The alien glanced at Glimmer, then nodded. Real subtle plan to have us get along, Adora.

As Glimmer climbed up into the old white pickup next to Catra, which she had so recently seen galumphing away from the cabin, she noted how she didn’t feel like she was in Salt Lake City, or even that today was today. Time, of late, had taken on an odd dreamlike quality. It was as though her body had leapt ahead of her mind. Bits of her lingering in the places she’d been, like breadcrumbs being torn off a loaf. Some pieces were still in the cabin, some in the hospital, and many, many, in the deluge before.

As they started out again, desperation sought a silver lining. “Honestly Bow, if this is the only thing that happens on this trip then It. Was. Worth it.” She said, patting her stomach.

“Glad you liked it!” Bow smiled in the rearview mirror.

“Plus,” She realized. “Our next stop is Vegas, baby!” She hoped her jubilant voice sounded convincing.

"What's Vegas?" The alien beside her asked.

"Sin City, Catra." Glimmer took her shoulder, sweeping an arm towards the horizon. "Miles of casinos, shows, and all kinds of things just on the cusp of illegal."

"Please don't touch me." Catra grumbled. Glimmer jumped away.

"Sorry! Should have asked." She put up her hands. "Just saw . . . with Adora . . ."

"It's not like we're going to be able to do any of the fun parts." Adora warned.

"I know." Glimmer said. "But it's still exciting. I'd like to walk around a bit, see the cool buildings, the shops."

"This isn't a sightseeing trip." Adora said seriously, and Glimmer's little-buoyed spirit sank again. Her sister saw the reaction. "I wish we could just go and have fun too." She admitted. "But we've got a mission."

A mission she called it. Oh, her sister was her sister alright. Glimmer watched Adora's focused expression as she helped Bow plug in directions, and knew that she was giving this her all. For all they bickered, Glimmer knew Adora, and could not deny her strengths. When she committed to something, she was the bravest, most determined, and stubbornest goddamned person she knew. Glimmer had held out hope that the situation here would be different, but Adora had chosen this. Which meant nothing could stop her.

God! It was just so frustrating! Here she was on a crazy adventure that should be exciting, and yet Glimmer felt . . . numb. She just felt so numb. She had thought coming here was going to finally make the difference. She would swoop in and save her desperate sister who was finally in over her head. She would catch her, and Glimmer could be proud. But now she was realizing that, despite the extreme circumstances, she was just along for the ride. Like always, it didn't matter if she was here or not.

Each day was like a tiny little knife. Each sliced her skin, and her soul, stinging, stumbled. She felt like she had been stumbling so much recently. Feet slipping on miry uneven ground, falling face first into cold brackish mud that burned each of her thousand cuts. Glimmer sighed; this was a messy metaphor. She didn't know much of anything about briny water anyway. She had never even seen the ocean.

Each time she fell, Glimmer had laid there in the mud for a time. It was in this wallowing that a little voice lifted up from some part of her brain that felt different and called to her, quiet.

Don't give up. You can do this. You don't have it as bad as everyone else. You're not poor, or an orphan, or have any kind of disability. You can do it.

Some part of her knew, deep down, that she was depressed. Her happy thoughts wouldn't be so pitiful otherwise, surely. But another part was convinced that somehow this was all wrong. That she shouldn't feel so broken for such seemingly stupid privileged reasons. Other people had it so much worse, and yet. The little voice still had to talk before she moved, and before she did, it always came to say the same eight words about the future. It would whisper:

It would be a shame to miss it.

So, Glimmer would put her arms beneath her, and shove herself to her feet, pressing the slimy, entrenched mud away. She would stand, and try to walk, away, out of the low dark swamp. She'd make it a few steps, heading uphill, then inevitably slip again, and slide back to the bottom, and the voice would whisper.

It would be a shame to miss it.

She'd stand, walk, and stumble.

It would be a shame to miss it.

Stand, walk, stumble.

Each time she rose, a little more mud clung to her, weighing her down. Each time she lingered, she feared the mud was becoming more comfortable to remain in, having sapped heat from her body. Each time, she didn’t make it quite as far. Each time the voice whispered all the same.

It would be a shame to miss it.

What had scared her most about her . . . suicide attempt – call it what it was Glimmer - had not been the act itself and the aftermath: though it had been terrifying to suddenly be thrust so close to a precarious edge with nothing but dark water below. No, what had been scariest was how quiet the voice remained. Glimmer had expected that, so close to the precipice, it would scream at her, roar and beg and shame until her mind could hear nothing else. But it had spoken just as softly and as tender as ever. *Don't give up. You can do it.* Like a whispered oath. Like a promise.

It would be a shame to miss it.

But the other voice was so much louder. The one that asked: why should she want the future? What was even the point? She was nothing more than one mildly intelligent ape on a moist rock flying through space. Apes that were horrible to each other, killed and persecuted each other. She was in a huge pollution-spewing machine built from metal mined in an authoritarian country that oppressed its people, burning gas pumped from Alaskan wilderness stolen from native peoples, using it to drive some stupid teenagers across a continent, all the while constantly putting themselves and pedestrians at risk. For what? For this alien?

Glimmer didn’t know how to mute those thoughts, the noise, the horror. Species perish, the Earth screams for help, and yet humanity goes on blissfully; thoughtful only of their own comforts, unquestioning of the horrible values instilled by their elders. How do you fight that? Inertia on the scale of the Earth. She couldn't

even fight the inertia within herself, holding her in the mud. So why even try?

Adora seemed to think one person could make a difference. Why couldn’t Glimmer believe that she could too? Was it just easier to just be cynical and dismissive of it all? Write the whole human experiment off as a blight? One that, in the far future, when aliens like Catra would come down and tisk tisk tisk at the rubble, saying: It's a good thing we weren't like them.

Was any reason enough? Like mud, her depression was amorphous and fickle. Trying to grab and strangle it off her just led to it slipping through her fingers. God, she wished it were simpler. She wished there wasn't an Instagram notification on her phone of Rebecca Jones at a party in Sundown like she was already in college drinking and getting laid. She wished her parents hadn't gotten a call after leaving the hospital from the homeless shelter about how good it was to have beautiful perfect Adora around to help. She wished studying made her grades go up. She wished her other ‘friends’ from high school had invited her to the movies three weeks ago, not just Bow. Bow hadn’t gone because of that. They apparently said some not-very-nice things about her to boot.

She wished things could be simple. She wished there was an enemy to fight that was truly evil, and they were legion against a small band of do-gooders she was a part of, sworn to fight them. She wished that fight would be loud and impossible to ignore so that her actions could prove her bewitching mind that it was wrong. That she was good. That she was enough.

Glimmer knew that those wishes were probably selfish. She knew she was just waiting for things to get better. She could go help Adora at the homeless shelter. She could study even more. She could invite Bow to the movies, instead of the other way around. But she just felt so numb. So tired. She hated how much she hated her own inaction, and how much that hate did nothing to get her to move forward.

So then, maybe it was too much to ask for just one day focused on her. Maybe she wasn't good enough to deserve that, and make any of those wishes come true. She was never like Adora, who couldn't stop. God, she wished she could be like her. Maybe then she would be able to do something that actually made a difference. Give something for once.

Laughter filled the truck. Glimmer looked up. Adora had tried to eat some of the ice from the bottom of her soda she'd gotten at the burrito shop, pulling off the lid and tilting it back. She'd promptly got a face full of little ice cubes, which were now soaking into her shirt. Adora, one part embarrassed, one part finding it funny too, was awkwardly trying to sweep them somewhere that wasn't her clothes, going for a plastic bag that no doubt would end up filling some landfill somewhere, lingering for little good reason.

Glimmer looked over at Catra, mirth on her lips. She was the reason she was out here to begin with. A real alien. She wasn't a part of all this nonsense humans had invented for themselves: Instagram, pickup trucks, and plastic bags. She was apart.

Maybe she was wrong about Catra, and she would get to leave this pitiable place they called home and go back to her own. Apparently, from Catra's stories, things were better there. Maybe this could be that something: helping here. Regardless of why she came in the first place, regardless of whether she was thanked.

It was hard, so hard, to fight the mud, and the numbness, her nerves and reservations, but Glimmer stood up again and opened her mouth. "So Catra, you got a space boyfriend?"

"What?" The alien turned to look away from Adora's debacle.

"You know, a boyfriend, but like, in space." She clarified, and Adora suddenly got a very focused look on her face. Glimmer's smile returned at her sister's reaction and Catra's indignant answer - after an explanation of the term - that no, she did not have a space boyfriend. Glimmer took that as an opportunity to

tease. “What there isn’t a space Tinder for you to use?” She glanced at her sister. “You probably wouldn’t do too bad on Earth.” Glimmer supposed the cat was attractive, in a sharp kind of way. Bow beat her to the comment about furries, however, which went right over Catra’s head.

“Why don’t you bother your sister? Ask her how her love life is going.” Catra retaliated, trying to deflect. Oh, she wasn’t going to get distracted that easily. Adora however-

“Hey!” Her sister complained. “You don’t know if I have someone. I never told you.”

Catra laughed. “Oh, like the fact that you don’t wasn’t completely obvious?” The laugh that bubbled up out of Glimmer surprised even herself, but she absolutely cackled at that, even having to wipe a tear away from her eye.

Glimmer tried to walk out of the mud. After all, it would be a shame to miss the next laugh.

To distract from the mundane drive through the southern half of Utah, Bow took to interrogating Catra on the technical details of spaceflight. Catra, as much as she insisted that she wasn’t an engineer, tried to give her best answers. But how does your starship travel faster than light?” He asked.

"Warping spacetime." Catra answered.

Bow nodded, as though secret knowledge was being given to him. "But how do you do it? What's the mechanism?"

"Energy with higher dimensional vectors can simulate negative mass." She replied casually. "How else would you do it?”

"Wormholes?" Bow offered.

Catra laughed. "Wormholes are a death trap. Every time somebody's tried they end up on the wrong side of an event

horizon."

"I thought you said you weren't an engineer?" Adora asked.

"I'm not uneducated Adora." She replied.

An hour of very dry very technical conversation later, Adora spotted something ahead of them. "Hey look, antelope!" She hollered, pointing.

"Pronghorn." Bow replied instinctually. Catra looked up from Adora's phone to see a different kind of four-legged white-rumped horned animal in the plains to their right. These ones were much skinnier than the bighorn and were white and tan instead of white and gray.

"Everyone except you calls them antelope, Bow." Adora noted with a smirk.

"It's scientifically inaccurate!" He cried. "Pronghorn aren't closely related to antelope. If you want to generalize you should call them giraffes, that's their closest relatives."

Glimmer just said. "Looks like a duck, quacks like a duck."

As the car drew closer to the herd, the nearest ones to the road saw them and bolted, running at amazing speed over the snow. "Fast." Catra noted.

Glimmer nodded. "Fastest animal in North America."

"They have to outrun something?"

"Wolves mostly. Though they're still pretty rare. You wouldn't like them."

"Actually, they evolved to outrun American Cheetahs." Bow chipped in. "But they're extinct now."

Glimmer and Catra rolled their eyes in unison at the nerdy quip, both noticing the other after they'd done it. "Mountain Lions too. But they ambush." Glimmer continued, eyes on Catra. "You'd like those."

"Would I?" Catra asked.

Glimmer searched something on her phone and brought up a picture of a tan animal that looked very much like the pet in Adora's house, only ten times the size. Catra noted the resemblance to herself, and the fact Glimmer chose to pick an image where it had blood all around its mouth, fangs glinting scarlet. "I bet you'd get along." She hummed innocently.

Catra said to Glimmer. "I think you're projecting a bit here. You seem quite the predator yourself, Sparkles." It was another one of her backward compliments, Glimmer noted.

"Guys." Bow warned gently. "Be nice."

Glimmer huffed. "Bow."

"What?" He asked. "We're on the same side here."

"Yeah Sparkles, teammates." Catra smirked, but then her voice lost its sass. "You know, I ran into something like that thing on a planet once. Of course, it had tentacles in front of its mouth instead of whiskers but: it hunted us for three days. It was starving, I think. Desperate. My team was talking about if we might have to put it down before it attacked one of us. So, before we did, I went out one night with rations and a light. It found me, but I gave it the food and it never came back."

"Wow!" Bow said. "You're an expect on wrangling wild beasts too?"

"Not an expert." Catra assured. "It was just one good thing."

Glimmer's head turned to Catra. "What?"

“One good thing, you know? If I did nothing else good on that planet then at least I helped that animal.” Glimmer looked at Catra, really looked at her. “What?” The alien stared back.

“Nothing.” Glimmer assured, and looked down into her lap, only realizing after she’d done so that she hadn’t been afraid when they locked eyes.

"Hey look!" Glimmer jumped up another hour later, interrupting Adora reading Catra’s missing person’s report that had come out with her own. "Buffalo!"

Adora turned to look. "Whoahoho! Look at them all!" To the right side of the road, there were nearly a hundred huge brown beasts scrounging through the snow.

"Bison." Bow exhaled deeply.

The song in the car changed again, and Catra’s ears perked up at the hard drum beat that opened it.

"Hell yeah!" Adora exclaimed and turned it wayyy up.

"Oh my god, Adora." Glimmer grumbled from the back. "You're so old."

"One:" Adora defended herself. "it's a classic. Two: you know you love it too." Glimmer rolled her eyes as the lyrics started and Adora immediately began singing along.

"In the day we sweat it out on the streets of a runaway American dream.
At night we ride through the mansions of glory in suicide machines."

Catra had never heard Adora sing before. "Wait what is this?"

"It's Bruce Springsteen." Bow explained, “This song is about fifty years old, but it’s still really popular . . . Sprung from cages on Highway 9. Chrome wheeled, fuel injected, and steppin' out over the line.” He sang along quietly.

“C’mon Bow!” Adora jeered and nudged him on the shoulder. “You can do better than that!”

He smirked but raised a finger at Adora and held it in place for a few seconds. Dramatic effect acquired, he dropped it and started to sing. “We gotta get out while we're young!” He opened up his voice much more thoroughly, and Adora beamed, joining him on the second part of the couplet. “Cause tramps like us, baby we were born to run!”

Glimmer shook her head, and after throwing a scrutinizing glance at Catra, joined in for the second verse, and the impromptu concert grew louder and more exuberant as the song built. Horns and what Catra thought was some kind of electric key instrument added into the mixing. But despite their passion none of the humans were . . . very good: not in harmony and sometimes missing words. But it was no worse than some of the ship hymns she remembered reciting alongside her comrades aboard the Fright Zone. It should be a crime for some of that lot to sing.

Yeah, in comparison, they weren’t so bad.

Following the third verse, there was an extended instrumental section, then the singing came back with a vengeance.

"One, two, three, four!" The trio shouted in unison and jumped up a key.

"The highway's jammed with broken heroes on a last-chance power drive!
Everybody's out on the run tonight,
But there's no place left to hide!
Together Wendy we can live with the sadness
I'll love you with all the madness in my soul.

H-Ohh, someday girl I don't know when
We're gonna get to that place
Where we really wanna go,
And we'll walk in the sun.
But till then tramps like us,
Baby we were born to run!"

Catra stared as Adora sang her lungs out, vivid and just so alive. Like there was so much light inside her it was overflowing, spilling out as joy and laughter and little tears in the corners of her sparkling blue eyes. When had Catra last been that happy? Had she ever been that happy?

"Oh honey, tramps like us,
Baby we were born to runnn!!! Catra!"

Catra blinked out of her trance at being pointed at by Adora. "Umm." She hesitated.

"Yeah, Catra!" Bow parroted.

Catra glanced left and right, finding Glimmer, who raised an expectant, judging eyebrow. Catra refocused on the song. The notes for the final chorus were repeating. She wasn't sure why she didn't hesitate, but maybe it had something to do with Adora's smile.

“Oh honey, tramps like us," Catra sang, loud but not as confident as the others. "Baby we were born to run!"

"YEAH!" Everyone else, even Glimmer, cheered.

The landscape changed the further south they went. The snow thinning and exposing more of the increasingly dry and arid lands of the Great Basin. From the passenger seat, Adora watched it go by. Wherever there weren’t fallow fields there was flat pale compacted earth, interspersed with dry hardy shrubs, succulents, and tumbleweed. Mountains continued to flank them, but they were growing steeper, more rounded, and striated with streaks of

increasingly colorful rock: veins of ruddy orange and bold white sandstone. It would be real desert soon. Western movie lands; all red buttes and herds of mustangs.

“Adorraaaaa . . .” Glimmer leaned forward between the seats, voice sing-song.

“No.” Adora replied, throwing her sister off.

“Aeh!? I didn’t even ask for anything!”

“You were going to though.” She knew. “You only use that tone when you’re trying to get something.”

“I do not!”

“Mmmhmm.” Adora nodded. “Spill.”

Glimmer exhaled through her nose loudly. “Fine. I was wondering if maybeee we could make a quick stop somewhere?”

“Somewhere?”

Glimmer hesitated, and Adora glanced back to see her nervous face. “Zion National Park!” She blurted out.

“What!?” Adora balked. “NO!”

“Adora!” Glimmer groaned.

The blonde sighed. “Glimmer I get it, but we can’t just bring Catra into one of the busiest national parks in a stolen car.” Dammit it why now!? Glimmer never cared about National Parks.

“The truck’s not stolen.” Glimmer insisted.

“That’s debatable at best.” Adora replied.

Glimmer pouted. “It’s the middle of winter, it won’t be busy.”

“You’re going to want to hike Angel’s Landing.” Adora knew. She knew because dammit she wanted to hike it! “We can’t hike Angel’s Landing in winter.”

“We won’t unless we try! Come on Adora. I know we need to help Catra, but we're driving right by, and shouldn’t Catra see some of the sights before she leaves?”

“We’re fugitives!” Adora stressed.

“We haven’t seen anybody since you got us. Besides, making a detour like that for a couple of hours will throw off anybody after us.” Glimmer offered.

“Can someone explain what’s going on before I get dragged into it?” Catra inserted herself into the conversation.

Bow obliged. “Zion National Park is a nature preserve famous for being super scenic. Is Angel’s Landing that view that everyone takes pictures from?”

“Yeah.” Adora sighed longingly. She could picture it in her mind perfectly. “But it's crazy dangerous in winter. You gotta hike up this narrow switch-backing path with nothing but a metal chain to hold on to. It’s a thousand-foot drop on both sides!” Her outdoor nerd was showing, but she felt it was important to be clear.

“Lovely.” Catra deadpanned.

Glimmer was undeterred. “Then we stop partway up, no big deal. Let’s at least go and get some pictures.”

“No.” This was an awful idea. She'd already been convinced to sit down at lunch.

“Come on Adora . . .”

“No.” A really really awful idea.

“You know you want to . . .”

“35 dollars for the day.” The ranger at the front gate of the park said when they pulled up.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Discussions of suicide and depression

Chapter 9: Zion

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The ranger collected the money from Bow, split three ways, before Adora begged them to, "Please convince my daredevil of a sister that we can't hike Angel's Landing today."

"You can't hike Angel's Landing today." The ranger replied, green smokey-bear hat shaking in a motion that said 'I've done this a hundred times but need to be damn sure you understand I'm still serious.'. "I can't stop you, but you really shouldn't. The snow up there's been trampled down into ice. People have been but even with equipment it's - and I quote - damn scary."

"Adoraa." Glimmer wined from the back.

"Shush, the adults are talking." Adora replied. "How about the Observation Point Trail?"

"It's rough, but more doable, just know that you probably won't be able to make it there and back by sunset tonight. It's 8 miles round trip."

Adora frowned. "How about East Mesa trail?"

The ranger nodded. "Should be able to."

"Sweet. We're doing that." She announced, taking their park map and giving Bow directions to the trailhead. The drive was up a long dirt road into the high country surrounding the center of the park. They parked amidst a small group of snow-covered campsites, piling out to stretch stiff muscles and relace boots. Adora covered their license plates by piling snow on the truck's bumpers.

Looking around at the nonexistent people nearby, Glimmer sassed. “I don’t think anyone’s going to notice us, Adora.”

“Well then, you can stay here and get picked up by the police.” She answered.

Glimmer rolled her eyes and started down the trail. Bow watched her go then said. “No reason not to be thorough.”

They hiked over the mesa. For the majority of it, they couldn’t see the famous cliffs and valleys, but that didn’t detract. It was beautiful out. The white snow was dusted over orange rock, from which grew scraggly evergreen trees that reached up towards an impossibly blue sky. White and orange and green and blue: everything was one of those colors. Well, everything except Catra's stupid neon jacket. It was a charmingly painful interruption of the natural landscape that surrounded it.

Adora pulled down her scarf, watching her breath fog up. It was cold. She was trying to walk fast, partly to warm herself up but also to get their detour over with. This was so stupid. If any police had even the faintest idea of where they were, they’d be picking them up at the park entrance. But Glimmer knew well how to convince Adora, and it was working. She loved national parks, and Zion was near the very top of her bucket list.

She tried to banish these thoughts and focus on the stunning moment-to-moment, but it was difficult. The short and long-term consequences of the past days kept sneaking into her mind, slithering with unwelcome dread. She shook her head to dispel them, pom-pom atop her hat whisking. There was no point! That chapter of her life was gone, out of reach. No reason hoping now, even if Bow and Glimmer had risked joining her on this ridiculous quest. Actually, yeah, focus on that. Bow and Glimmer were here with her. Regardless of expectations, no matter her future, she had found herself in a beautiful place by actions she couldn’t quite regret, with friends she loved ferociously. If she could somehow go and tell an alternate universe version of herself this story, one

that had never met Catra, or never dared to run away with her, she knew that that Adora would be sad to have missed this.

Because this was **the** adventure, wasn't it? That seizing of something young, reckless, and foolish. The one you tell your nephews or your kids about when you're old? Like Angella and Micah's favored story of jumping in a car to chase some little-known rockstar across the country in the 90s, what was his name? Mr. Galaxy?

Yes, despite the ruins to come, Adora's restless soul felt good, and she was happy she hadn't missed this.

"You alright?"

Adora looked up to find Bow walking next to her, smiling. "Yeah." Adora nodded. "Just thinking."

Bow nodded. "Glimmer wasn't totally wrong, by the way. I tagged along." Glimmer was walking fifty feet ahead, out of earshot.

"Really?" Adora confirmed.

"Well, yeah." He said, as though it were obvious. "You can't imagine how panicked she was when she called me." He laughed. "No hello, just BOOM talking a million miles an hour about how you were kidnapped by ALIENS and that the police were going to arrest you!"

Adora smiled thinly. "Yeah."

"She was really worried about you."

Adora huffed through her nose. "Yeah." She repeated, tone very different. Bow gave her a concerned look for that. Adora said next, "You're a good friend to her."

"I came for you too." He returned. Adora's surprise must have been obvious on her face. "Best Friends Squad, remember?"

Adora didn't say it, but that was very nice to hear. “Really?”

“Of course.” He insisted. “You’re my friend too.”

Adora looked off towards the horizon. The sun was getting lower, and they were beginning to see peeks of the main canyon, areas where the flat-topped land suddenly dropped away into startling red valleys. She must have been feeling vulnerable, because she admitted, “I always figured you guys just . . . put up with me.”

Bow’s jaw dropped in shock. “Adora, we’re always asking you to come with us to stuff. Remember ice skating before break?”

Adora did. “I had to help Angella with FFA.”

“So you said, and I’m glad you want to help your Mom. I respect that-”

“But.” Adora said it for him, feeling the pit in her stomach growing deeper.

“But.” Bow confirmed gently. “There’s always an excuse. We love being friends with you, Adora. It just . . . sometimes feels like you don’t want to be friends with us.” Adora swallowed, hating how blunt Bow was being. She thought back to the dozens of times she had hockey practice, or homework, or volunteering, or chores with Angella or Micah, and how she had said no to whatever bizarre thing Bow and Glimmer were running off to. She hated looking back on those scenarios, realizing she couldn’t possibly imagine herself going with them. “Adora, we’re 17.” Bow continued. “Don’t you want to have fun?”

“Of course!” Adora assured, but then couldn’t think of a single time when she had gone out and done something like what Bow and Glimmer offered. At the time it had seemed obvious she couldn’t make that frivolous irresponsible choice. She had more productive uses for her time. But now, imagining it from Glimmer’s perspective, what it must have looked like, “No wonder she hates me.” Adora said, face pale.

“She doesn’t hate you.” Bow assured.

“I’ve screwed up, Bow.” She conceded. She’d been screwing up for a long time, but especially recently. “Like you said, I’ve never been spending time with her, never been putting in the effort. I never saw how much Glimmer has been hurting.” She took an unsteady breath. “And then Catra came and suddenly it all went crazy. Like you said: a million miles an hour . . . gah. I’m sorry, that sounds like an excuse. It’s not a good one, it's just . . . before we left, Glimmer and I . . . we had a fight. I promised I would apologize, and I still haven’t done it.” She put her face into her hands, heart aching.

“Neither of you are perfect.” Bow eased.

“I know but . . . what do I do? What do I say?”

“Communicate.” He answered immediately. “Be present.” How obvious it was to him felt like a blow. “Be honest. I-” He lowered his voice, which was so often louder than privacy or secrets could be. “She gets frustrated with how focused you are on seemingly everything but her.” Adora paled, her worst fears confirmed. “Some of that is observation bias but . . .”

“She’s still right.” Adora slumped, feeling even more horrible.

“She’s going through a hard time.” Bow corrected. “Don't take it too personally. Newton’s first law, you know?”

“What?”

“An object in motion stays in motion, unless acted upon by another force. Sometimes you have to have to hit a wall before you can move in a new better direction.”

Adora chuckled at his nerdy philosophy. “It’s that simple?” She asked. Bow smiled a patented Bow smile. Adora’s resolve rose. She started to move ahead towards her sister but paused to look back and say. “Next time I get the chance, I’m coming with you guys. No matter what’s going on.”

“Even aliens?” Bow asked cheekily.

Adora rolled her eyes. “Even aliens.” She insisted, before jogging forward.

Walking between her and Glimmer was Catra. As Adora came alongside she watched her ears twitch to follow the birds above, her hands in her pockets, head craned up slightly. She grabbed her attention with a little smile. "Hey. How you doing?”

“Fine.” Catra replied curtly. Adora frowned. She’d been quieter since picking up Bow and Glimmer, rarely speaking unless spoken to.

“You alright?”

Catra looked at her like she was an idiot, then mumbled. "Well, you know, four quarks in a meson and all that." Adora didn't, but assumed it was an expression similar to 'fifth-wheeling'. She wasn’t sure how to respond, so just walked alongside in silence. After a minute, Catra broke it with, “You’re just using me to delay talking to your sister.”

Adora blushed. “Whaaat?” She coughed into her hand. “No, I’m not.”

Catra flicked her ears once. “I heard that whole conversation, Adora.”

Dammit, gotta stop forgetting about that. “I’m not good at this part.” She said.

“No kidding.” Catra drolled. They scrambled over a rock in the path. “Don’t let her walk all over you.”

“What?”

“Your sister, you’re too accommodating.”

Adora tried to protest. “But she’s-”

“She’s being a shit.” Catra interrupted, making Adora’s eyebrows shoot up. “She has a good reason. But she has to respect you too.”

“But,”

“Just go.” Catra gave her a hearty shove forward. Adora stumbled but managed to land on her feet. She looked ahead at her sister and felt the fear climb up again. What was that phrase Catra told her to say?

“My mind is magic.” Adora whispered, hoping it invoked luck or strength or something before jogging up to Glimmer. They shared a quick glance. Despite the incantation, the desperate need in her head, and the tug in her heart, Adora found she still didn’t know how to start this conversation. How could she begin to repair the relationship that she had accidentally allowed to become so broken? She wondered if she ever would figure out how to break that intangible barrier between them, the one that separated her from other people. It wasn’t real, made up by her fear, shame, and society, yet it weighed her tongue. She wished desperately that there was an easy way through it. A cheat code that let her jump the awkwardness between silence and connection. Adora considered mentioning the weather and cringed. God, was this why adults talked about the weather so much? She often wondered why they did. Surely it wasn’t something they really considered interesting. There were ten thousand more engaging topics to cover. She and Catra had talked about the world and the stars and just how big the universe was. It was amazing. Adora feared the meteorological obsession was because older folks were so beaten down and closed off to the world, that they couldn’t relate to anything more interesting or personal. She hoped that wasn’t the case.

Why had this been so easy between her and Catra? With them, there had just been this **connection**. Was it because they knew nothing about each other, so there were a lot of questions to ask? Or was Catra just good at carrying a conversation? Maybe they were just compatible in that way.

Adora pulled off her hat, stuffing it in the nearest pocket so she could use both hands to run through her hair, checking her poof and pony for any loose locks. “Glim?” She asked. Her sister hummed in response. “Why did you want to come here? I mean, you never really cared when we went to Yellowstone and Glacier.” There. That wasn’t about the weather.

Glimmer considered for a second. “I like the outdoors too Adora, even if I don’t put it all over my walls.”

“Oh.” Adora said, annoyed at herself for finding that surprising. Was she really so blind to her sister’s interests? “But-”

“I’d have preferred we go to Disney World or something, is all.” Glimmer finished, short.

Adora cringed again. “Right.”

There was a long silence. “I’m keeping Swiftwind when Razz goes back to Arizona.” Glimmer announced.

Adora had noticed the pair had been close at the cabin, but this was still a shock. It had been Glimmer’s and Adora’s cute 12-year-old pouting and promising that had gotten them Swiftwind. But Glimmer had never really taken her fair share of the chores. “Good.” Adora said. “He’ll like that.”

“I thought so too.” Glimmer said. “He just stuck to me, when we got home. Barely left my side the whole time. Then in the car ride up, his head was right on my lap. He’s a sweetheart.”

“Yeah, and a ham.” Adora added.

Glimmer smiled. “And a ham.” She conceded.

“So, are you gonna take over poo patrol then?” She asked, referring to her least favorite household chore. Glimmer sighed instantly, and Adora instantly regretted her choice of words.

“I know it’s hard, Adora. I know we’re different people, and we both have our own struggles. But . . .”

Adora clenched her jaw so much it hurt. “I know I just . . .” She began, then swallowed the excuse. “But I didn’t mean that as hurtful. It was supposed to be a joke.”

“Well, it wasn’t funny.” Glimmer replied.

Adora exhaled. “I’m sorry Glimmer. For yelling at the cabin.”

“Mom and Dad told you to say that.”

“That doesn’t mean they weren’t right.” Adora admitted.

Glimmer hummed. “And yet they still needed to say it.”

Adora nearly chuffed at her attitude, suppressing it with a frown. “I’m trying here.” She looked at Glimmer, who didn’t say anything. “I’m trying but you have to try too.” Glimmer still didn’t say anything. “Why are you even here, Glimmer?” Frustration bubbled. She didn’t want to fight again, but she wasn’t getting any closer to fixing this! “Why are **we** here, in Zion?” Adora pushed harder.

“I . . . don’t want to talk about this right now.” Glimmer replied. Her tone was quiet and sad.

“Glim?”

“How about this?” Glimmer offered. “Just let me have this and I won’t ask for anything else on this trip, okay? Let’s just try and have fun.”

Adora considered this for a long second. “Okay.”

Glimmer took a deep breath, shook her head as if to dispel a cloud from around it, and a smile appeared on her face again. She pointed ahead. “Look, I think I see the lookout spot!” She began to run for it. “Last one there’s a rotten egg!”

Adora blinked at the sudden change of mood. She stopped walking as Bow stumbled past her, rising to a sprint. “Just be careful!” He begged. Catra caught up to Adora. Her eyes asked if she was okay.

“Not good at this part.” Adora echoed. She had apologized, technically, and yet she felt like nothing had changed. Just have fun? With switching on a dime like that, was that really what Glimmer needed right now? Adora wasn't sure, but if it was what she was asking for then she could provide it. She bumped Catra on the shoulder and started running. “You heard her. Last one there’s a rotten egg!”

There was an indignant shout behind, and Adora laughed as she tried to catch up with her sister. Together the four of them raced over the compacted snow to the end of the trail. At its terminus, the flora parted and revealed a truly epic vista. The main valley of the national park extended out in front of them, flanked on both sides by near-vertical cliffs 2,000 feet high. Some sections were so square and so sheer, it looked as though some great giant had pulled the halves apart, ripping open the wintery green gorge below, itself a frame for a meandering silver river far far below.

Glimmer won the race, stopping on a wide flat rock near the edge, foggy breaths coming fast as she stared outwards. Bow was hot on her heels, and to Adora’s great annoyance, Catra passed her and came third, her smile cocky at her as she rocked up last. “How are you so fast?” Adora huffed.

"I lived on a hot cramped high-gravity spaceship for years." Catra replied. "This planet is like running through a dream!" She jumped into the air, easily soaring three feet off the ground.

“Figures.” Adora huffed, then turned to take in the view. For several seconds, it was quiet, the only sound was their breathing. Adora was here. Adora was in Zion, for real, and because of Glimmer of all reasons. She had a poster of this exact view in her bedroom and had fallen asleep looking at it for years. Adora had wondered if it was something about the name that made

goosebumps rise up on her arms. Zion. Such a simple evocative word. Was it because of the vaguely religious significance she ascribed to it, or did those four letters arranged in that order simply possess the quality to make her shiver? At this moment, she decided it was simply because it was so heart-stoppingly beautiful.

Directly ahead was the narrow blade of Angel's landing, jutting into the center of the canyon, snowcapped and nearly a thousand feet below them. Way down from the peak, Adora could see the last switchback, where the tiny shapes of the bravest hikers considered whether they would be trying the final terrifying climb up its spine to the greatest view in the park. Adora was very happy to be scampering where there was plenty of ground on all sides.

After sufficient gawking, Adora fished into her pocket. "Human thing!" She lifted her phone up and gestured for all of them to turn and crowd in for a selfie. They did so, Catra being unceremoniously squished between Bow and Adora. She grumbled but looked up into the camera as Adora struggled to get their faces and the canyon in frame without the glare of the rapidly setting sun, but Adora couldn't quite get it to look good.

"Wait!" Glimmer called, pulling her new DSLR camera and a small stand from her backpack and setting it a little ways away. Setting the timer, she ran back and squeezed them all together with a hand around Adora's waist.

"Everyone say, 'Teenage rebellion'!" Bow cried.

"Teenage rebellion!" They all cheesed, except Catra, who just smirked and was caught in the middle of rolling her eyes.

"Aww come on, Catra!" Glimmer glared at the result. Catra stuck her tongue out at her.

Adora twirled a strand of her hair with a finger when she was shown the result, smiling at it. "I think it's perfect."

“And to think that we can’t even upload these to Instagram!” Bow’s voice filled with emotion.

“Sorry Bow, no aliens on the ‘Gram.” Adora chuckled, wishing she could set it as her phone background. Meanwhile, Catra wandered up to the edge of the lookout. She passed an ancient twisted juniper tree on the way by, running her palm over the deep linear grooves in the bark that looked like the pages of a book. After jumping onto a taller rock, she stared, then sat.

“Hey, Bow, think that spot down there would be good for watching the sunset?” Glimmer pointed at a ridge down a little from where they were standing, nearer to the cliff edge.

“Probably.” He shrugged, then tensed when she started for it. “But be careful!” Glimmer glanced over her shoulder and winked at him, then kept going. “I should go after her.” He said to Adora.

“You should go after her.” She concurred.

“So you can spend time more time alone with Catraaa?” He fluttered his eyebrows at her.

Adora squinted at him. “Wait, what? What’s that voice?”

Bow laughed. "It's okay Adora, really. I see it."

"See what?" Adora blinked.

Bow smiled like he knew a secret. "The way you look at her."

“I . . .” It clicked in her mind. “Oh! Bow!” She balked. “It’s not like-! Wait a second!”

Bow chuckled. “Go on.” He said lightly, nudging her in the back a few times.

“Mmm.” Adora pouted with red cheeks but did so as Bow clambered down to join Glimmer. She exhaled, trying to settle her suddenly hammering heart while climbing up to join Catra.

“Thoughts?” Adora sat beside her. Not often you got first impressions on a landscape like this.

“Haha.” Catra glanced at her, but then their gazes lingered. The sun was just a palm’s width above the horizon now, and with the winter solstice just a few days past, was setting nearly perfectly parallel to the canyon walls. So low, it dipped the entire landscape in a vivid kinetic crimson that seemed to lift the redness up out of the rocks and throw it into the sky. In this staggering light, Catra’s eyes were somehow even more extraordinary. The sunbeams pooled in them, tinging her blue eye violet, and her yellow one orange.

Catra’s cleared her throat, and they returned to the view before them. Adora forced herself to focus on it. Huge puffy clouds towered above them in all directions, the evening casting gradients traveling from dim purple shadows on their undersides to fiery hues at their summits. The wind made the juniper trees rustle, and in the evening, Adora could swear the land was alive. She pulled out her phone and took a few pictures of her own, but was disappointed in them. The beauty couldn’t quite be captured in the screen.

“Well, I’ve seen taller cliffs.” Catra said.

“Of course you have.”

“But I’ll admit it: it’s beautiful.” She finished, and despite the tone, Adora knew it wasn’t sarcasm. She set her phone back in her lap and let her hand rest down at her side, only to jerk it away when she felt it touch Catra’s. “Sorry.” She said gently.

“It’s alright.”

Adora nodded, swallowing, and put it back down, feeling the cold stone beneath her ungloved fingertips. She flexed them to keep the feeling, brushing Catra's little finger again. “It is beautiful.” She agreed, looking at but not focusing on the sunset.

Slowly, with red sand under their palms, Adora slid hers closer, in sync with Catra, and hooked her pinkie around hers. The pads were calloused, and the fur on top soft. It felt silly to think about, but it was the most intense and intimate thing Adora had ever done with someone. Excitement and terror crashed together like storms. Her heart palpitated as her chest shivered. She didn't dare look at Catra, but as minutes passed, the fear was slowly replaced by a warm sensation deep her in chest, one she couldn't quite name and didn't fully understand.

Though somehow, Adora knew that even if her future beside Catra would be as ephemeral as this violet sky, until then; that tiny point of contact between them was all she needed to know.

The walk back to the car was in better spirits than the one out, the atmosphere above them warming the one between. They traded school things they were not missing during break. Catra decried their entire education system as stupid. Glimmer chuckled at that, and Adora was happy she was warming to her, if only a little.

But at the trailhead, they discovered that their truck wasn't the only vehicle in the parking lot. Next to them, a sedan was parked, not particularly interesting by itself, but the windows were tinted so dark she couldn't see inside. Adora and Catra stopped, and the others noticed.

"Adora?" Bow asked.

"That car." She said. "It wasn't there before."

"So?" Glimmer shrugged.

"The campsites are closed. It's late, snowy, really hard to get a car like that up here. Plus, we didn't see anyone else on the trail going the other way." She stared through the windshield, but couldn't tell if anyone was sitting inside.

“Maybe they took another trail.” Bow suggested. Adora wasn’t sure there was another trail. “Come on.” He urged them forward, and Adora, with adrenaline spiking, slowly followed, eyes watching the car until it was out of sight behind them. No one jumped out. No one shouted “POLICE!” and tried to stop them. But something was familiar about the car, she just couldn’t put her finger on what until just before it disappeared over the hill, and she saw the vanity license plate that read: DD3.

Dinner was a really cool hotdog stand in an empty lot not too far outside the park. Adora’s head was spinning from the car and the bizarre things she could order. Reindeer, wild boar, and pheasant were all apparently things you could make hot dogs from. “Come on Adora, go for it!” Bow encouraged. Adora ordered the rattlesnake.

They sat in the Adirondack chairs surrounding one of several crackling firepits ringing the food truck to trade reviews. Glimmer liked her wild boar dog. Bow ate the apparently just alright rabbit, and Catra had a normal beef brat. “So?” Glimmer asked as Adora chewed.

She swallowed, considering the flavor. “Tastes like chicken.” Adora announced and got some boos. “What!? It does!” It didn’t taste exactly like chicken, but it was good. She ate, commenting between bites at Bow’s latest escapades trying to create ‘trick arrows’.

“In the end I only got it to fly about twenty-five feet. So now I’m thinking if I make a more pointed boxing glove, it’ll go further!”

“Bow, doesn’t that just make it like . . . a really big arrow?” Glimmer pointed out.

“No! It’ll still be soft! Just enough to knock you out, but you know, with style!”

“Bow.” Glimmer snickered. “The persistence is cute, but your methods and goal . . . ehhh.” She waggled her hand.

“Laugh all you want. I brought a few of my prototypes with me. You’ll see that they’ll come in handy. Grappling line arrow, expanding foam arrow. Sonic arrow!”

“Taping a Bluetooth speaker to a stick does not make it a sonic arrow!” Adora bristled at the return of this idea. If anything, it was just a great way to **literally** throw away fifty dollars.

“Why do you insist on using a weapon that your species made obsolete a thousand years ago?” Catra asked.

“It’s more than just a weapon, Catra. It’s an art form.” Bow explained. “It takes skill to be able to shoot well, to feel how the wind and the wood will take the arrow. Humans have been learning for tens of thousands of years. I’m another link in the chain carrying on the tradition.”

“Then you’ve wasted your time.” Catra said seriously. “If you ever get into a fight, someone with a gun will always win.”

“Come on, Catra.” Adora eased. “There probably won’t be a situation where Bow has to duel someone, those things don’t happen here. Also, I bet he knows more about guns than you, Miss Science Officer.”

Catra didn’t seem to find that jab funny. On the contrary, she seemed almost struck, and everyone noticed. She gave Bow and Glimmer’s curious gazes a hard one back, and after ten seconds of staring, she snarled and tore her eyes away.

An awkward silence descended. Adora reached over to touch Catra’s arm. “You don’t have to say anything. We’ll drop it.” She offered.

Catra considered for a long moment before speaking. Her voice was quiet so the couple sitting two fires over couldn’t overhear. “No, it’s . . . you all should know something. Before I was

assigned to the Fright Zone, I was a soldier.” The silence filled several breaths. Adora’s eyes went very wide. “I know I’ve been making out the universe to be some utopia Adora, but the truth is it can be a rough place for strays like me.”

Adora stared at her. “Catra.” She whispered.

Catra shook her head at the sentiment. “Enlisting was my best option.”

"Who were you fighting?" Bow asked.

Fear flickered in Catra's firelit eyes. "Horde Prime."

"Horde Prime? But I thought your people were called The Horde?"

"I- They are." Catra admitted. "I'm a part of The Horde Rebellion. Horde Prime: he is the True Horde.” Shadows danced across her face, lips flashing as embers rose. “Fleets of identical white starships, empty, sterile, save for clones of himself, only himself. Horde Prime. An ancient being, the last of his species. He carves his way across the galaxy, sterilizing worlds and resettling the ashes. Clones to run factories, shipyards. A million worlds with his face.

But his clones weren't perfect. One didn't believe in his Master's designs and rebelled, claiming that other beings had a place in the universe. He barely escaped, but when he did, Hordak founded a coalition of worlds to destroy Horde Prime. He is the immortal ruler of The Rebellion, the only one with the vision and the foresight to see a way in which we, the free peoples of the galaxy, can win."

"How long did you fight?" Glimmer asked.

"Two years before getting transferred. Just a twelve-year-old kid with a too-big gun. Things . . . well they could be worse but . . . we're not exactly winning."

Sparks from the fire lifted up into the sky, creating impermanent stars. Adora suddenly felt cold. The aweing light she had basked in, learning of Catra's vast interstellar civilization, revealed its shadow. Somewhere out there, a genocidal man with power surely beyond her imagination was working to snuff out that light. "And Earth?" Adora asked.

"Be glad he's far away." Catra replied. Adora shuddered. No one was safe.

"I'm sorry." Bow said. "War is . . ."

"War is war." Catra nodded. "After I kept surviving, they noticed me. I was scrappy, learned fast, could fit into small places. Saved a guy once, when he was sure to die. That got me promoted to field medic. Made sure an extraction mission in a dangerous debris field went right. That made them figure I would be better used in deep space. It got me away from the battlefield. The orbital bombardments. The fallout. It was a no-brain choice."

Catra had been so reclusive with her past. Deservedly so, Adora now thought. With her family seemingly not in the picture, only to leave her homeworld and be thrust into a cosmic hell at twelve years old. The existential fear in her eyes when Adora had hurt her shoulder. How good she was at calming her down during her panic attack. A field medic then. She stood and walked over to Catra's chair.

"Can I hug you?" She asked. Catra's eyes rose, hard. Adora had thought she was just being prickly before. Now she saw some of those glares truly were: watching to see if Adora was going to hurt her, make fun of her like soldiers did. There was little room for gentleness in armies, Angella had once said. Catra nodded. Adora leaned down and enveloped her tightly. "You're stronger than I could ever be." She whispered into her hat-covered ears.

She felt Catra tense, then heard her begin to whisper under her breath, barely audible. "My mind is the face of the universe. My

mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed. My mind is magic."

No one was very hungry anymore, and after a debate over the dwindling pool of cash they had between the three of them, Adora capitulated to staying in a hotel Bow had found. Everyone was too tired, and besides, they would make it to Goldstone tomorrow even if they slept tonight. Adora nearly cried when they arrived. Being in the glorious situation of having multiple options, they rode an elevator (yay) to a room that was clean (double yay) and was definitely roach-free (rapturous). Everyone showered in turn: Glimmer, Bow, Catra, and herself last. When Adora emerged, she found the other three all chatting in pajamas about a *Star Trek: The Next Generation* rerun they'd found on the TV. Bow and Glimmer were on one of the beds, Catra on the other.

"I'm just saying, your species doesn't have a clue on how space works." Catra was chewing on a bag of jerky bought at the gift shop downstairs. That was supposed to be for tomorrow. "Lasers don't work like that."

"They're phasers, Catra!" Bow was taking the role of the aggrieved fan again. Glimmer had eventually broken to his insistence to binge the series together a few years ago, and Adora had sat in on quite a few episodes. "They work using science beyond humanity's current understanding."

Adora chuckled silently at them as she rubbed her towel through her hair, then quickly spiraled it up into a wrap. "Which bed are we taking, Glimmer?" She asked in a lull in the debate.

Glimmer looked up from her phone. "I was going to sleep with Bow."

"Oh, wait, really?"

"Yeah, I mean . . ." Glimmer glanced at the white alien elephant in the room. "You know her better."

“Thanks, Sparkles.” Catra jeered, rolling over onto her back and letting her head hang off the end of the bed.

Adora rubbed her arm gently. “I just thought that cause we were sisters we would . . . but it’s okay!” She assured. “If Bow is comfortable with it.”

“I don’t care.” Bow shrugged. Adora mentally facepalmed. Come on don’t be an idiot, they were already lying next to one another.

“Cooool.” Adora managed awkwardly.

“Stars, you humans and your personal space hang-ups." Catra laughed. "Come on Adora, you know I don't bite. It'll be just like last night."

Adora went beet red. "Don't just reveal that!" She cried, hands going up towards Glimmer and Bow to start damage control.

"Umm . . .” Bow's eyes were very wide.

"It wasn't like that!" Adora tried desperately. "Catra, stop laughing!"

Glimmer sat up with a smirk, clasping her hands together and pressing them close to a cheek. "How romantic!"

"Stoppp!" Adora wined, walking up to Glimmer to try and cover her mouth, and rapidly the confrontation devolved into slapping hands and playful shoving, the former scowling fiercely, the latter trying to focus through her laughter. Eventually, Glimmer yielded, collapsing back into what was now firmly her and Bow's bed.

Annoyingly smiley after the bout, Adora wandered over to turn down the heat from the HVAC unit mounted under the window. With four people in the room and two of them doing such strenuous battle, she was sweating. That wasn’t allowed in winter. But as Adora reached down to press the buttons and lower the temperature, the room suddenly went dark. The lights and the TV

flashed to black. All three humans yelped. The whir of the AC faded into an eerie silence.

The sound of their breathing and distant highway cars filled it. “What the hell.” Glimmer spoke first. “Jesus.”

The only light in the room besides Catra’s eyes was now the uneven gossamer glow filtering through the thin curtains from outside. As their eyes adjusted, the space became a barely visible greyscale world, colors swallowed by the darkness. For thirty seconds they all stayed silent, waiting to see if the power would come back. But as the blackout lingered, Adora felt the hairs on the back of her neck rise. She began to watch the shadows.

“Human technology.” Catra huffed.

“Should we go to the front desk?” Bow asked. “Is the whole hotel out?”

“Shh.” Adora hushed them, looking around. For a moment, nothing. Then by the front door, a ripple. Something moving. Adora locked onto it and blinked her eyes several times to try and discern if it was the reflection of distant headlights or something more. The strange mirage vanished. But the anxiety in some primal part of herself remained alert. The feeling of being watched. “Something’s-”

The silence was split with a roaring hiss, and terror silenced Adora. The old TV had come back on and was now playing loud static into the room. The grey haze lit all their faces, the pattern so unfamiliar in the digital age. Adora’s brain reminded her of old days playing Wii with Glimmer; the video cable would occasionally come out and reveal the strange gray noise that was always around them. Adora was comforted by that memory.

Then the static peeled off the screen, and everyone screamed.

Chapter End Notes

Welcome to the halfway point (probably)! To everyone who’s gotten this far, you’re all awesome.

Also, another mid-week update, which I don’t love. But my life’s been very busy lately, (un)fortunately! Among other things, I’ve started a new job, and it turns out that’s a tiring time-consuming process haha. So, in a way, it's been nice to edit this and get the chance to wax poetic about nature. I haven't been to Zion yet, but I was at Arches and Canyonlands this summer, which I hope is a good reference!

Chapter 10: Second Contact

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A rippling outline peeled away from the screen and the dark space around it, rushing towards Adora with frighting speed. She jerked back as her eyes were dazzled. There was static and oily rainbows charging. Flickers of light like green stars flashed and twisted in the air. Then the blow came.

It was hard, sharp, and strong, striking the shoulder Adora had dislocated. Pained exploded through her body. She screamed and stumbled backwards, managing to throw a reflexive punch back into the dark. She felt it just miss a hidden body, the air rippling as her fist passed. Then the mirage tried to grapple her.

Adora felt the touch of cold hands on her shoulders. She threw her knee up, and this time connected.

The assailant was knocked away, and for an instant their silhouette was revealed, misaligned with the rest of the world. An instant was all he needed. A thwip crossed the room, followed by a thunk. The illusion shattered, revealing a long slender figure standing between the four of them, an arrow lodged in its abdomen.

“Bow!” Adora gasped with relief, clutching her shoulder.

“80s adventure movie dreams!” The archer, weapon in hand, allowed himself the briefest smile before demanding, “Who are you!?” as he nocked another arrow.

The new alien - because that was surely what they were - was tall, lithe, and lean. Humanoid, green-skinned, wearing a skintight suit. In the noisy light, their curling muscular lizard-like tail and long pointed ears were drawn in sharp relief. It looked down at the wound in its abdomen, crying in English. “Ow! You actually

shot me!" They grabbed the shaft with a clawed hand and pulled it free. The flesh rippled starry black around the wound as they did. The metal tip dripped green blood on the carpet. Then it smiled. One too wide, and filled with pointed triangular teeth. "I'm impressed."

It moved at Bow, lunging with inhuman speed. He flinched, taking a step back and drawing for a second shot. He released. The string snapped forward. But there was only an arm-rattling twang. Bow's eyes went wide in the static as he realized he'd only shot air.

"Hmm . . . composite arrow." The alien inspected the projectile, swiped before it could fly, and the fingernails on the hand holding it at the same time. "Not bad, for savages." They twirled on their toes hitting Bow across the jaw, first with their foot then again with their long tail. Bow crashed face-first into the wall, landing awkwardly on the dresser. He grunted, rolled down onto the floor, and didn't get up.

"Bow!" Glimmer cried, taking a step towards him to check if he was okay. But the alien leered closer in return. "Stay . . . stay back!" She demanded. The alien didn't, prowling closer.

A body rushed between them. "Stop!" Catra demanded. The alien didn't. Adora watched, frozen in shock and disbelief, as the pair began to fight. Blows and scratches, kicking and bared fangs. It was so fast their motions blurred, but as Adora realized this was really happening, she also realized Catra wasn't winning. No, it looked like Catra was trying to fight mud. She would grab the alien's arm and lever it, only for it to ripple, turn black, and lose all rigidity, slumping as if boneless. What the hell was happening?

Catra threw a body blow. Her fist landed on, then sank into, the alien's body up to the wrist. She tried to pull away but was held fast by the moving liquid flesh. With a sharp sinuous motion, Catra was yanked forward then slammed across the jaw and shoved. Such released, she tumbled back into Glimmer, whose hands just kept her from falling.

Catra growled as she righted herself, saying, “Stay behind me, Glimmer.”

“But-” Glimmer was backing towards the door, the room's only exit.

“Do it!” Catra used her soldier voice, and Glimmer stayed where she was. “And be ready.” Catra’s fur was raised on her ruff and tail. Her ears were low and back. She was ready with claws extended when the alien attacked again. It moved like water, turning back into a starry shadow painted on the world and bending out of the way of each of Catra’s slashes with unnatural flexibility. After each dodge, it riposted with a stabbing blow, hand morphing into an oily spike Catra just barely avoided being run through with.

Adora realized two things simultaneously. First, it was some kind of shapeshifter, and second, Catra was right. They were in real actual danger, and she needed to be ready. This snapped her from her paralysis. She looked for something, anything to defend herself with. Taking quick glances away from the melee, she confirmed her fears. There was very little to use. Nearby she had her phone, a pillow, the too-heavy armchair and bedside table, nothing good. Wait, except. Adora ran for the gaudy brass-plated lamp atop the bedside table and yanked, but the plug was in the wall, stuck low behind the furnishment. Tugging, she looked back to see Catra being punched off the ground by arms expanded into huge battering rams. She was slammed into the TV. It shattered and turned the static into shards of angular chaos.

The alien casually bypassed a gasping winded Catra, and once again stalked towards Glimmer. Adora yanked on the lamp plug harder, trying to jiggle it loose. “Stay back!” Her sister repeated, lifting her hands into shaking fists. Adora had never seen Glimmer throw a punch before the one she'd landed on her that morning. The alien seemed to recognize this and laughed, a derisive noise. They mimicked her stance.

“Come on girlie, show me what you got.” They bounced on their toes. Glimmer’s face revealed her panic, but she stepped forward, trying to throw a punch. The alien lazily side-stepped it, laughing harder as they seized her wrist. With a smile, her sister was lifted off the ground with one arm. Adora, desperate, grabbed the bedside table and flung it onto its side, yanking the plug free and grabbing the lamp.

“Augh! Eugh! Hyah!” Glimmer flailed in the shapeshifter’s grasp, but her stocky limbs were too short to reach their slender body.

“Wow, what a little spitfire!” The alien said gleefully. “I like feisty, but it’s just sad when there’s nothing to back it up.”

“Let go of me!” Glimmer demanded.

“Ah! You’re wish is my command.” The alien dropped her, and Glimmer hit the ground with an ‘oof’. She looked up to find the alien’s hand, shaped into a wicked hook, plunging down towards her. Glimmer screamed.

Adora slammed the lamp into the alien’s back. It had been a hurried swing, desperate, and hitting them with the shade instead of the heavy metal end. The alien didn’t even flinch. No, instead, it froze and slowly turned to face her.

Oh shit. She had its attention.

Lurid yellow eyes bored into her panicked blue ones. Their pupils were tall narrow slits.

“I said, stop.” Catra coughed, pushing off the TV and nearly falling to her knees. Broken bits of the screen rained down onto the carpet as she gasped and tried to grab the alien. They bent out of Catra's way easily, pacing towards Adora. Adora swallowed, lifting the lamp in her hands again. The bent-in shade made for a pathetic-looking club. “Hey!” Catra gasped a shout. “I said stop!”

The alien didn’t. Adora’s eyes darted between her injured friends and the alien. Her friends. The alien. Her friends. THE ALIEN!

“Don’t blink.” The alien said gleefully, suddenly a lot closer than they had been an instant before. Adora yelped and swung. The alien’s body flickered black. Their torso flowed away, out of the path of the blow. Adora swung again to the same effect, then again and again. On the fourth pass, the alien caught the lamp with a clawed hand. “Too slow!” They determined gleefully, then twisted to dodge Catra's leaping attack from behind. “For the both of you.” The action ripped the lamp from Adora’s hands. She looked up just to see it being thrown back at her. Adora ducked, but it clipped her bad shoulder before slamming into the room’s window with the sound of shattering glass.

The sound played in slow motion in Adora’s brain. The pain burned in her shoulder. The static was flashing strobe on her pinprick eyes. Her socked feet felt unsteady on the carpeted floor. None of it mattered. Adrenaline was flooding her brain. Making the breaths sharp and deep, the details sharper, the shadows deeper.

Adora knew when it loomed close again by how it blocked the broken light at the edge of her vision. Fight or flight. She lunged at the last possible second.

The first blow was with her good arm, but the follow-up strike across the jaw was with the bad, and even through the rush Adora's shoulder felt like fire as she laid it. It had been so long since she’d used these skills, but the primal part of her brain - roaring against the predator it had been presented with - was making them easy to remember.

But the shapeshifter had tricks she’d never countered before. One instant her opponent was there; the next they were gone, vanished. Adora turned in a circle, trying to find any ripples in the air, but didn’t notice anything until the alien wrapped their tail around her ankle and yanked her to the ground, laughing. Adora kicked wildly and managed to stand, turning only to feel a burning slash across her good forearm. Pain fueled panic. She threw a wild haymaker with the opposite arm. It connected with enough force

to knock the alien back for a fraction of a second and cause Adora to scream out her anguish.

Catra seized the opportunity. “Rush them!” She cried.

Adora’s legs moved on their own. She landed atop the shifting mass of alien with Catra. Then Glimmer was next to her. Then Bow too, shaking off a daze. Together they pummeled and held the alien down. Pain was just a signal. Adora ignored it as she pounded. Time stretched. It felt like a year they were atop the shapeshifter, but it was probably only two or three seconds before they turned green and black and exploded outwards. Tendrils of flesh threw everyone away. Catra hit a wall halfway between the floor and the ceiling before sliding down on her feet. Bow landed on one of the beds and bounced. Glimmer fell near the door to the room. Adora landed on the carpet and her back.

The alien rose up in the middle of the room, their features reforming. Catra lunged before they could finish, snarling and kicking, but took a blow to the face and was knocked off. She struck the floor with a yowl of pain. Adora saw red. She jumped up, ready to tackle them down again. Their back was turned.

The shapeshifter flashed to black. In an instant, the back of their head was the front. Eyes, a nose, and a mouth emerged from green flesh. “Ah ah ahh!” They waggled their finger before Adora could stop, and she crashed headlong into what felt like tar. Adora gasped, trying to pull free, but the amorphous alien’s body wrapped around her. It felt like the alien cast on her shoulder, only a hundred times more unsettling. She gulped air as the shapeshifter split down the middle, rolling over Adora’s sides and coalescing behind, holding her hands together in a blob of flesh. "And you." The shapeshifter lifted Adora’s hands above her head and twirled her like a dancer. When Adora was stopped, she was staring into their burning yellow eyes. “Tall, strong looking, and **that** was the best you could do? Honestly Blondie," They sighed. "I'm disappointed."

Adora inhaled sharply, and just as she did, received two more sharp blows, one to her neck and one to her stomach. Her breath caught in her throat before being driven out of her entirely. So winded, Adora was promptly dumped on the floor, where she collapsed like a sack of potatoes.

Through the haze of trying to right herself, Adora heard the noises of the fight. Bow grunted. Catra hissed. Noise and crashing furniture. The rustling of sheets. She was unbothered in the ten seconds it took her to get up once again. When she was, only one person was still standing. “You got them?” Adora gasped out the question to a wobbly Catra. She was clutching her stomach, but the snarl on her face was still fierce. Adora looked left and right for the alien.

“Yeah.” Catra said, taking a step towards Adora. Bow was clutching his leg between the beds, and Glimmer groaned face down near the bathroom door. They were both alive. That relief was sweet. Catra tapped her shoulder to regain her attention. “Boo!” She punched Adora in the face.

Adora stumbled backwards, clutching her nose, The gasp the blow elicited splattered blood from it into her palm. Shock turned to disbelief, then fear, then horror as Catra laughed, voice morphing as her friend’s body was remolded into a green reptilian one. It could mimic people too.

“Wow, and easy to fool too.” The shapeshifter mocked. “What a package.”

Adora wheezed, blood running down her throat and chin. Everything blurred. Adora liked to fight, the idea of a fight. But the thrill and safety of remembered ritualized bouts was frighteningly absent here. There was just a dark any-shaped hole looming over her, filled with daggerlike teeth. Fight changed to flight. Adora slid backwards, away, pressing with her feet and aching arms. The alien’s vicious smile widened to the edges of their face, and they slowly began to move towards her, tail flicking back and forth like a cat with a mouse. Adora whimpered.

A snarl filled the room. Adora watched through her hazy vision as Catra, the real Catra, leapt on the alien's back one more time from behind the far bed. In her hand, a makeshift metal shiv - some part of the metal bedframe – flashed. Weapon plunging, the shapeshifter didn't even try to dodge, instead simply opening a circular hole in their chest exactly where Catra was trying to stab. The knife flew through the hole, and as soon as it was out the other side, it snapped closed, clamping Catra's arm in place. "Tisk tisk tisk." The shapeshifter smirked, warping around to stare at Catra, who bared her claws, roaring to slash at their throat. Her fingers barely moved before they were entombed in an erupting tendril of flesh. An instant later, Catra was pinned up on the wall. One hand of the alien reached up and clasped her neck, yellow eyes studying her like one would a strange insect. "Tougher than I look?" They smiled that vicious smile, then squeezed.

Catra began to choke, desperately reaching with her free hand to break the hold, but then that too was locked against the wall. "What!?" She managed to speak in a gasp. "What do you want!?"

"All business, huh?" The shapeshifter looked bored. "Fineee. As much as I don't want to admit it, I was very happy to find you here. You see, I happen to know that Horde rebels tend to have subspace radios in their pods." They loosened their grip on Catra's throat ever so slightly.

Catra inhaled, trying to kick with her feet, but it was no use. Instead, she elected to spit into the shapeshifter's face. "What's it to you, freak?"

The alien wiped their cheek with their tail, frown crescent-shaped. "Rude, never any manners with your species. Tell me kitten, where is your lens?"

They wanted the lens?

Catra, of course, said nothing, and got a hard look from the shapeshifter in return. Catra started to choke again. Adora needed

to say something. “It’s broken.” She managed, blood dripping down over her mouth with the words. “You can’t use it.”

A narrow-forked tongue slithered out of the shapeshifter's mouth, licking their thin lips. They walked towards Adora, arms holding Catra up stretching longer to keep her in place as they did. Adora’s fear welded her to the floor as the shapeshifter leaned down near her face, eyes blinking with vertical lids. “Trust me Blondie, when something’s broken that just makes it all the easier to rebuild and get it to do whatever, you, want.” They annunciated the final three words with a kind of glee. “So, why don’t you be a good little girl and tell me where it is?”

It was in the truck. Adora stared up at this slithering creature looming over her, heart palpitating as she tried to think of a way out. But they were so strong. and Adora knew nothing about them. Who was this person? How long had they been on Earth? Were they stranded like Catra had been? Was that why they wanted the lens? “Tick tock.” The alien squeezed their grip around Catra’s neck tighter. “Your friend is running out of air.”

Even if this alien was going to use the lens for something terrible, Adora realized she couldn’t do anything to stop them. There was no choice. None other than to all be killed here and now. “It’s-”

“Hyah!” A clang split through the room as a metal pipe whistled into the shapeshifter’s head. The ringing sound unlocked Adora’s body, and she jerked away. The alien slumped forward, releasing a gasping coughing Catra onto the floor.

Glimmer, blood dripping down her forehead, was brandishing the shower curtain rod from the bathroom. The wet curtain was still attached, its ends were tangled around her feet. Screaming, she lifted her weapon and brought it back down for the alien’s head again and again. Clang! The metal pole rattled. Clang! Clang! Clang! Five times before suddenly hitting floor instead. The shapeshifter’s body turned into a flat puddle, which slithered along the floor and between their legs like an unruly oil slick. They reformed at full height in front of the door. The three Earthlings

and one cat clustered together, wounded but with fists and weapons raised.

“Well, this was fun.” The shapeshifter smiled, but it was a considerably weaker and more lopsided one. They clasped their side, wincing. “Tenacity comes cheap on this planet, I’ll admit it.” Catra snarled at them. Bow drew another arrow. The shapeshifter laughed. “What cute little heroes you all are. Well, if that’s the case, I suppose I should play my part too.” Their wounded joviality melted away, and a graver tone filled the alien’s voice. “It doesn’t matter how tenacious you are, against what’s coming. I will get that lens,” Their body shifted, yellow eyes disappearing into light brown ones. Glimmer appeared there, or a near-perfect replica of her. “and that arm won’t save you next time.” They said to Glimmer with her own voice before bowing and, in one fluid motion, left the room by morphing through the tiny gap under the door, like a misbehaving shadow. A shadow full of stars.

The TV finally quit. Darkness and heavy breathing remained. Adora was shaking, the seconds still dragging. The motion of Glimmer wobbling and sinking back to her knees passed in incredible slowness and clarity. There was blood on her sister's face, from a cut above her eyebrow. Adora could see the sweat and blood mingle and drip down off her brow and onto the carpet. How the fabric stained darker.

Bow dropped his bow, went up to Glimmer, and knelt, cradling her shoulders and wiping the cut with his shirt. His mouth moved, but the words didn’t reach Adora. Glimmer nodded, turning to sling her arm over Bow’s shoulders. They stood. Adora hoped neither of them had concussions.

A hand touched her shoulder. Adora gasped. Her head whipped around. Catra. The sound rushed back.

"-what the hell was that, Catra?” Glimmer was asking, voice hoarse from screaming. Catra didn’t reply, staring at Adora. For an instant, Adora saw the shapeshifter staring back at her. She took a step away and saw the crushing hurt in Catra’s eyes.

No, it couldn’t be the shapeshifter. It couldn’t . . .

Adora reached out her hand to Catra, who sucked in a breath and took it. She led Adora to one of the beds and treated everyone as she explained. Adora received stinging water through her cuts and a patch of Catra’s skinsuit on her forearm and her now reinjured shoulder. Glimmer got one on her brow, and Bow a band around his wrist from where it had been sprained.

"That,” Catra said. “Was a changeling. That one . . . they must work for Horde Prime." The already taught tension in the room spiked even higher.

"I thought you said Horde Prime was all clones." Bow said.

"He sometimes takes in agents, desperates and basket cases, makes them promises. Promises he never keeps."

“You’re sure?” Adora asked through the tissues over her bloody nose.

“They wouldn’t attack us like that otherwise.” Catra said.

"And it can do . . . that." Glimmer shuddered.

"Yeah, they can look like anyone, anything. Damn green freak.” She spat a glob of blood onto the carpet, then checked some of the shallow cuts across her own body. “I didn't think Horde Prime knew about Earth. I'm . . . I'm sorry."

"Oh my god." Adora realized the implications. “That’s why they want the lens.”

“Presumably.” Catra nodded.

“Wait, you know about that lens thing they mentioned, Adora?” Bow asked. Adora nodded. “What is it?”

Catra gave a brief explanation of the technology. “They must be stranded.” She surmised. “Like me.”

“Or else they’d have contacted him already.” Bow exhaled.

Adora's fear was confirmed. “But it’s broken, right?” She said. “Beyond repair?”

“I don’t know how Horde Prime’s technology works.” Catra stipulated.

Bow was right with her. “You think they could repair it if they got their hands on it.”

Adora looked at Catra, who was dead silent. “Is that possible, Catra?” Adora pressed.

Catra’s ears lowered and her tail curled up. “Yes. It might be possible.”

Terror seized the room. “So, what do we do?” Glimmer asked.

“We get me and the lens off-planet, as fast as we can.” Catra assured. “It’s the only way to keep you and your civilization safe.”

They needed to get back on the road.

Adora helped pack in a haze. The room was an utter disaster, with broken furniture and glass strewn everywhere. She hardly remembered leaving the hotel keys on the bed; instead wildly consumed with the worry that her cuts hadn’t been cleaned thoroughly enough by Catra. As if getting an alien bloodborne pathogen was more concerning than the fact that she had just nearly been killed.

They exited into the hallway less than ten minutes after the attack began. “Three to two.” Catra said to Adora as she shut the door. Adora was too terrified to insist they’d saved each other in there.

They took the stairs down to the first floor, then towards the lobby to slip out. She was in front when they turned the corner to the check-in counter. “Shit!” She hissed and backpedaled, pushing the others back out of sight.

“What now!?” Glimmer said, a little too loud as Adora corralled and hushed them.

“It’s them.” She said and peeked around a second time just to be sure. Yep, talking to the clerk at the front desk was the young suited woman and her mustachioed partner. Thankfully they’d both been facing away from them and hadn’t reacted.

Bow and Glimmer peeked too. “Those guys who nearly blew up the gas station?” Bow said.

Adora grabbed them and started everyone moving in the opposite direction. There must be a side door. “They’re following us.” She knew for sure now. “The car at Zion. It was the same car.”

“Following us?” Glimmer hissed. “Why?”

Adora didn’t have the brain space right now to try and figure that out. Everything was in the moment, moving through the hotel, getting away, keeping Catra – all of them - safe. They found a side door. Slinking out to the parking lot, they crept around the building to see the black sedan parked in the covered front unloading loop. Adora noted the Nevada license plate again: DD-3. Their truck was past it on the other side of the lot. The path they would need to walk between wasn’t in plain view, but it wasn’t entirely hidden either.

Which was why, of course, the mustache man, Seahawk, decided it was a great moment for a smoke. He sauntered outside, leaned against the sedan, and pulled a cigarette and lighter from his inner pocket. He took a draw, blew a perfect smoke ring, and then began to sing what sounded like a sea shanty, just loud enough for Adora to hear.

“William Taylor was a brisk young sailor
One who courted a lady gay
But on the day they were to marry
Pressed he was, and sent away.”

“That’s him.” Adora whispered.

“Give the bags to Bow and Catra.” Glimmer said, and they shuffled everything around so their strong arms could jump in the back seat with everything heavy. Adora would drive. Seahawk took another draw, then continued.

“Sailor's clothing she put on
And went on board as a man-o-war
Her pretty little fingers long and slender
They were smeared with pitch and tar.”

“Stick to that shadow.” Bow pointed to one cast by the building, pulling up his hood. “Keep low.”

“Don’t run.” Catra added. “You’ll just make more noise.”

“Quiet as a cat.” Glimmer said, levity like a tiny fire.

Adora watched Seahawk stop to take his next pull, watching for the perfect moment. He looked up at the loops' halogen lights and opened his mouth. “Now.”

“On that ship, there was a battle
She amongst the rest did fight
The wind blew off her silver buttons
Her chest was bared all snowy white."

By the time he’d finished his verse, they were throwing bags in the truck. Adora jumped in the driver's seat and started it. She looked over her shoulder as Seahawk jumped from his reverie and turned toward them. She saw the whites of his eyes. “Hang on!” Adora shouted as she screeched the tires. Thankfully, they’d backed into their parking spot and were able to fly right out onto the road.

No one spoke until they were on the highway again and hopefully several miles ahead of any police, men in suits, or alien shapeshifters.

“So, where actually is this lens?” Glimmer began. “Please tell me it's back at the cabin.” Catra rummaged through her duffel and

pulled out the shirt-wrapped rod. Adora forced her eyes to stay straight ahead as she unwrapped it for Bow and Glimmer, lest she send them off the road. The quiet in the car confirmed that they had the same entranced reaction to the thing as every other human. “Of course.” Glimmer muttered after she put it away.

“We’ll have to keep it on us at all times,” Catra said.

“Why not just destroy it?” Glimmer rebutted. "If it’s useless to us anyway, let’s just be done with it!"

"These are meta-materials Sparkles.” Catra rebuked her. “You can't just smash or burn them. They don't fully exist in our universe. All we can see is the sliver that intersects our reality."

"I don't understand." Glimmer said, and Adora was glad cause she had no idea either.

Catra sighed. "Stars, how do I explain this? It’s like if someone stuck their hand out from behind a curtain, and you chop it off. The rest of the person is still back there, and you can still go and pull them on stage, you just can't see them anymore."

That was certainly a morbid metaphor. “There’s no other way?” Adora asked, pleading.

“There’s no other way.” Catra insisted.

Adora found her resolve. “Then we get to Goldstone.” She reaffirmed to her comrades. “As quickly as possible.”

No further words filled the truck. Miles passed. Civilization disappeared as the snow thinned and finally disappeared completely, revealing a barren desert. The darkness outside was only broken by occasional big rigs passing the other way down the highway, headlights briefly illuminating Glimmer's pensive face in the passenger seat. Two hours in, her sister said. "I should have listened to you. We shouldn't have stopped today."

Adora glanced over her shoulder. Bow and Catra we're both out cold. She spoke quietly so as to not wake them. "No, Glimmer. We couldn’t have known. And . . . it was fun, really. Beautiful. I'm glad we went.” She took a deep breath, readying for the big moment. She had screwed this conversation up three times now and was very sick of getting it wrong. “I-"

Before Adora could get it out, Glimmer interrupted her. "But you were right!” She hissed under her breath. “That ***thing*** is following her, us! What if-"

"I've never been a good sister to you, have I?" Adora interrupted her right back. The silence afterwards was deafening. She glanced at Glimmer who was staring at her, pupils small. "Yeah, thought so." She furrowed her brow. “For a long time now, I haven’t been a good sister to you. I’ve ignored you whenever you asked me to hang out. I’ve been a bitch with you for not doing your chores. I’ve been putting myself, Catra, and how others see me above you, and even if some of that was unintentional, it was still wrong. Things have just been how they've been for so long that I-” She took a breath that didn’t calm her down. “that I didn’t understand how bad things were getting for you. I mean . . . I should have seen something! Noticed something! I'm the older sister.”

"Adora . . .”

She waved her hand. “I know that's a technicality, but I'm supposed to protect you. Support you! You should be able to talk to me! About anything! Even if it's bad, or scary.”

"Adora." Glimmer said firmly, to stop the direction of that sentence.

Adora let out a shaky breath. "Glimmer I . . . I am so sorry." Her heart felt like iron in her chest. "I know I can get tunnel vision on stuff sometimes, and . . . and I'm really worried that somewhere along the way you fell into that black border and never really came out. I . . ." She shouldn't be doing this while she was driving. Adora wiped the tears with a sleeve. "I mean . . . I'm so

lucky to have you. You're funny, charismatic, fearless! Dammit, I'm sure you've heard this a hundred times this week but I've never met anyone like you. I envy you."

Glimmer's voice was barely audible. "You do?"

"Of course I do." Adora exasperated. "Glimmer Brightmoon who can walk into a crowd of people and talk to anyone like you know them. Glimmer Brightmoon who just runs away from home **by airplane** at the drop of a hat, and manages to convince her best friend to come along with her. Glimmer Brightmoon who sneaks out to actual parties when I stay in and study, **after** Angella and Micah yell at you, and I just . . . I wish any of that were that easy for me."

"I'm not all that." Glimmer said.

"You are."

"No, I'm not. I'm not good with people. Hell, Bow is basically my only friend."

"But what about-?" She thought of the small gang she often sat with this year at the cafeteria. Bow had said they had met the group at a party. Adora had been badgered to go, but had refused. Loud cramped places like that weren't her favorite thing, but Bow and Glimmer would have made it fun. She wished she thought she could have gotten away with going.

"They're idiots." Glimmer muttered. "Well, there not. But they're partiers, and none of them are ever there for me at lunch. They hardly even talk to me."

"But I thought-"

"Well, you thought wrong." Glimmer spat out, lip curling. "Sorry." She immediately apologized.

Adora nodded, and allowed the quiet sound of the tires on the road fill the car for a bit. "I never had anyone growing up,

obviously, before, you know. I guess I've never really . . ." She flexed her fingers on the steering wheel, feeling the crinkle of the soft plastic. "stopped acting like that. Like I was still a" She hated saying this word. "orphan. In the system, you took and held on to whatever little you were given, or someone else would get it instead. And there was no room for mistakes, even if you got lucky enough to get a new family." She pressed down the tears to see the road. "I just didn't see how what was perfect for Angella and Micah was so terrible for you. I never acted like sister. I acted like a rival, trying to beat you at chores and grades. I threw you under the bus for that time we both drew all over the kitchen with permanent marker! Said it was your idea."

"We were ten, Adora." Glimmer replied, the tiniest chuckle coming up her throat. "And it was true."

Maybe so, but, "But it wasn't what a sister would do . . . markers or no." She assured, smiling sadly "Glimmer, I know things haven't been great, and hey, I'm so screwed now, doing this, so I know it's not like I have anything to lose but, I want to fix that. I want to be your friend Glimmer." Even if I can't be your sister for much longer, she didn't add. "I'm sorry it took all this for me to realize that."

Glimmer didn't say anything for a long moment. Adora figured pretty quickly that she'd screwed up somewhere in that confession, which was fine. Normal, at the least. But for what little time she had, however slim the chance, Adora decided that fixing this was something to chase. A promise worth keeping. Something good.

Glimmer took a deep breath. "I'm sorry too." She said. Adora nearly swerved them off the road looking over at her. Glimmer was crying. "I was a jerk after I came up to the cabin. I was mad at myself, and in pain, and I pushed that on you and Catra. I didn't listen to you; made a million assumptions. It was wrong of me, so I'm sorry."

Adora was crying too. She frantically wiped her eyes to see ahead. “Thank you, for saying that. I’m sorry too.”

“You already apologized.” Glimmer noted with a tiny smile.

“Yeah.” Adora laughed wetly. “I guess I did.”

“Adora, would you be willing to like . . . try again?” Glimmer asked softly. “Give this whole sisterhood thing another shot?”

Thrill couldn’t even describe Adora's reaction to that. “Hey, didn’t you say you wanted to go to Hot Springs last winter, but I had games and practices all the time?"

"Yeah." Glimmer perked up. “In like January.”

“Let’s do it, soon as we can.” Adora offered. "Just the two of us?"

"I'd like that." Glimmer smiled, and looked ahead down the perfectly straight road to where the dark mountains met the dark sky. A couple of miles later, Glimmer said. “You really trust her.” It wasn’t a question.

“Catra?”

“Yeah.”

“I do.” Adora affirmed. “Do you?”

Glimmer was silent for a long time. “I just might.”

They crossed the state line.

The stain of light on the horizon was the first thing Adora saw, between the ridges of distant mountains. In the cold desert night, all but vacant of humanity, it was like a coastal lighthouse, a scintillating signal of civilization ahead. It was amazing, that a city that big could thrive in a place so inhospitable. Adora had never

been to Vegas, but she suspected it was a place of contradictions like that.

She hummed softly in harmony to the nearly silent radio; Glimmer was asleep now too. The clock had rolled over: it was Christmas Eve. The music reflected it.

“It's Christmas time, there's no need to be afraid
At Christmas time, we let in light and we banish shade
And in our world of plenty, you can spread a smile of joy
Throw your arms around the world at Christmastime

There's a world outside your window
And it's a world of dread and fear
Where the only water flowing
Is the bitter sting of tears

And the Christmas bells that ring
There are the clanging chimes of doom."

Adora exhaled and tried to center herself, letting the next few lyrics pass by, before joining in on the main refrain.

“Do they know it's Christmas time at all?”

The truck broke down just inside the city's limits.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None

So much speculation on the cliffhanger last time! It was fun to watch all of you guess wrong mwahaha

And oh stars, a fight scene. New territory for this fic: I struggled with it and am still not super confident. But a big part of this is to learn, so here we go!

Chapter 11: Until Our Luck Runs Out

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The breakdown was heralded by a grinding sound. Adora tensed as the steering wheel started vibrating in her hands. No. No no no no no! Not now!

There was a bang, and everyone jerked awake as Adora pulled over to the side of the highway. Various panicked questions were shouted around the car. Adora let the now very loudly rattling engine answer before shutting it off. Sighing out the entire contents of her lungs, she leaned into the steering wheel and muttered. "Care to help me, Mr. Maker?"

Mr. Maker didn't know what was going on. "Everything seems fine on the outside." He said. "I'm worried something really buried broke."

"How buried?" Catra asked, huddled around the engine bay with the rest of them.

"Enough to have to pull the whole engine apart to fix it."

Catra growled low in her throat.

Adora braced shaking hands against her face. They had been close. So close! "Merry goddamned Christmas."

"We'll have to call someone." Bow concluded. "AAA?"

"Not AAA." Adora rebuffed. The truck wasn't in their name. "A shop?"

"They're all closed." Glimmer shut that down. She was scrolling through her phone. "Everything's closed."

“Then we need to find new transportation.” Catra determined. “And get moving, now.” She walked over to the side of the truck and reached in, grabbing Adora’s backpack and duffel and starting to move stuff around.

“Whoa, Catra.” Bow lifted a hand to ease her. “We can’t just run off without a plan.”

She glared back. “We can’t stand around either.”

Adora looked from Catra to Bow and Glimmer. A truck roared past, headlights illuminating their foggy breaths, and fear-filled faces.

The changeling’s warning. It didn’t take a soldier to know they were exposed here. At the side of the highway was a twenty-foot concrete wall. Hardly anywhere to run. Absolutely nowhere to hide.

“Alright,” Bow conceded. “but we need a plan.”

Catra focused on packing as she spoke. “Can we buy a new car?”

Adora would have laughed at that idea in better circumstances. “No, not with-”

“Hitchhike the rest of the way?” Glimmer interrupted, sticking her thumb out.

“Into the high California desert?” Bow questioned. “Doubt anybody would take us there. We should rent a car.”

“Don’t you have to be 25 to do that?” Glimmer asked.

“No, you just have to pay more if you aren’t. A lot more.” He answered, confidence fading. “We could just Uber.”

“The police can track that.” Glimmer shook her head. “What if we . . .”

“We can’t do any of these with what we have left!” Adora shut them all down. Paying for the hotel room had revealed that they now had less than 100 bucks in cash between them, and all their debit and credit cards had been frozen by their parents. It would have been enough to refuel in Vegas and make it the rest of the way, but now . . .

God damnit! They’d been **so close!**

Catra reached into her jacket pocket and flashed a slip of something shiny and yellow. Adora’s eyes went wide. In all the chaos, she had forgotten she had those on her.

“Is that gold?” Glimmer whispered. Catra nodded and pulled out more. She had brought four bars to the grocery store the morning they left.

“This is fantastic.” Adora said as she held one.

“Maybe.” Bow said with another, he and Glimmer looking at it in awe. “But to rent a car,”

“With this much gold, we could rent a private jet.” Glimmer noted in a whisper.

“But to rent a car or a jet.” Bow cut in again. “We can’t use gold bullion."

Catra glared at Adora. “You told me this stuff was valuable!”

“It is,” Adora assured. “But,”

“But it’s been nothing but useless so far.” Catra snarled.

“We need to convert it first.” Adora finished.

Catra shook her head. “How is your planet a primitive wasteland about everything except money? Can’t you just put the gold in a slot somewhere to get those stupid slips of paper?”

“An ATM for gold?” Bow noted with a tempered smile. “Not unless you’re in Dubai. Maybe a bank could do it, but that would take time, and an unlocked account, and a good explanation of where this came from.” He held up the slip.

They didn’t have any of those. Adora muttered a curse as Bow’s seriousness broke and he rambled with glee about the awesome weight of the metal. Adora looked down at her own slip, noting with a frown that it really was too heavy for its size.

Come on Adora, she thought. New problem, that means you need a new solution. She was sure that solution was literally in her hands this very moment, but what it was escaped her. Her mind felt like mush. She hadn’t slept in nearly 24 hours. Her body was bruised and battered. Come on Adora, think! Catra’s counting on you.

“A pawn shop.” Glimmer said. Adora looked up. Her sister’s eyes were confident.

“A pawn shop?” Adora asked.

“Yes!” Bow beamed. “They buy gold! Glimmer, you’re a genius!” Hope fluttered. “Please tell me there’s a pawn shop open somewhere.”

“Not sure remembering pawn shops existing counts as genius but,” Glimmer smiled as she typed. “This place is!” She said excitedly. “24-7, 365 it says!” She scrolled down and the smile dropped. “But it is four miles away.”

Research began to find a taxi to call, but Catra only was patient enough to endure five minutes of them looking for a company that was open before insisting they needed to keep moving. “Slow is better than sitting here like Kaveb nymphs.”

Bow looked at the others. “I guess we’ve got a walk then.” He said.

A three-hour walk to be specific. Not ideal, but Adora was still relieved. They still had a chance. She looked at Bow and Glimmer, thinking for a moment. “But you don’t have to walk.” She said to them.

“What?” Glimmer blinked.

With ample cash, it would take less than a day to get to Goldstone. But to get that cash, “Four miles.” Adora said. “We’re going to have to leave the car and the suitcases here. Pack light.” One change of clothes, just backpacks. The truck would, hopefully, just be impounded. “I’m just saying if you guys didn’t want to come after everything that’s-”

“Shut up, Adora.” Glimmer said as she turned away from Adora, opening one of the truck’s back doors and pulling her suitcase out, unzipping it, and rummaging for clothes to put in her backpack.

“Pass me mine.” Bow joined in. “And my bow.”

Adora nearly cried.

So, they walked. Along the highway, with the headlights of the cars and terrifyingly close trucks flashing on their backs. They went down the nearest exit ramp, then through blocks and blocks and blocks of ugly industrial estates and walled suburban communities. The roads were quiet, and the shadows of the streetlights deep. Catra’s glowing eyes flicked left and right, ever alert. She set a pace that the three humans had difficulty matching. Adora’s feet burned, but she pushed on, keeping up as every unusual sound made her jump. A distant car horn, a barking dog in a fenced yard, the echoing laughs of distant drunken friends: each made her nerves spark. She tried not to show it but . . . Adora had never been hunted before.

A hand touched her glove, and Adora spasmed, inhaling a shaky breath. “Whoa.” Catra eased.

Adora looked over at her, jaw trembling. “I’m scared, Catra.” She admitted, so quiet only her sensitive ears would hear.

“I know.” The alien replied in a nearly equally hushed tone.

“I’m really scared.”

“I know.” Catra reached closer again to wrap her fingers around Adora’s, squeezing once before retreating. “Don’t worry. You’re going to get me home, and until I leave, I’ll protect you.”

Adora had never been told that by someone before. “You promise?”

Catra swallowed. “I promise.” She said, pressing down the fur on the back of her neck. “We stick together, remember?”

Adora did, and that calmed her. “Yeah.” She exhaled. “Yeah, we stick together.”

After two and half hours of walking, neon poured out between the buildings ahead like sunlight. Catra lowered her sunglasses over her eyes. They’d reached the north end of The Strip.

Gaudy? Overwhelming? Adora wasn’t sure of the best words to describe the lurid spectacle that was Las Vegas. Hotels towered above them, cramming in the street between. Palm trees from far-off lands grew down the divided road, whose asphalt reflected a thousand colors from stoplights, shop signs, and the dozens of huge billboards looming above them. There were so many billboards. The LED screens flashed close-up slo-mo shots of poker chips landing on felt, cocktails of every wild color, and scantily clad girls dancing.

“This place is like a parody of itself.” Glimmer deadpanned. They needed to cross the street, so they went over one of the many concrete overpasses built across the strip. There was an escalator to get up to the walkway, exposed to the open air, rolling up and down empty and endlessly in the night. “I correct myself.” She noted as they rode up. “It’s a parody of America in general.”

They stopped briefly halfway across to take in the view. Just south, the Stratosphere tower loomed above them, flashing on the top. Further in the distance, the more famous casinos could be seen: pyramids, Roman temples, tiny Eiffel Towers and Empire State Buildings all huddled together.

"Where next?" Catra stopped the gawking. Glimmer pointed down the street, where on a sign for a strip mall were the words 'WE BUY GOLD!' in a bold yellow text.

"Never thought I'd actually find a sign like that useful." Bow chuckled.

The bell rang on the pawn shop door and the four walked inside. Adora's head was on a swivel immediately. There were trinkets of every kind filling shelves and cases. Adora spotted coins, electronics, instruments, old metal and neon signs, and power tools, but no other people besides the leather-skinned owner behind the counter. "Hey." He graveled out over the softly playing Christmas muzak.

"Hey." Adora replied. They came up and presented the alien gold. There was a long pause.

"I normally get jewelry." He finally said, looking up and them over. It sunk into Adora just how conspicuous they must look. They were four unsupervised unrelated-looking teenagers – one with a bow and arrows on his back, another with sunglasses, hood, and a facemask up - in a Sin City pawn shop at 2 AM, trying to sell unmarked gold.

"My family are preppers." Glimmer lied.

"Ah." The man nodded.

Adora looked at the others, trying not to show her worry. Catra slapped another bar on the counter. "Cut in half." She said to him. "If you need proof it's not plated."

The man looked Catra through her glasses for a tense breath, then took one of the slips. He pulled a magnet that read 'I <3 Las Vegas' off a spinning rack and ran it over the gold. When nothing happened, he set the metal on a precision scale on the counter. Adora's fingers rhythmed against the glass counter.

The upward tweak of his lips was so tiny. "You want to sell them all?" He asked, many ringed fingers flitting one of the slips from one hand to the other as though he already owned it. Adora nodded. She didn't like it, but he was right to be confident. These places preyed on desperation; they were the ideal clientele.

Glimmer negotiated as the man did a few final checks on the gold. Adora was happy to have her to haggle, she got 85% of what Google said it was worth. That was, hard to believe, a five-figure number.

The money, crisp banded stacks of twenties and hundreds, were passed over. Adora split it into four equal piles and distributed them, holding a stack out to Catra, who was studying a group of gaudy pistols inside one of the counters, hands in her pockets. "Hey." She called her eyes. Catra took the money without looking away from the guns. Adora grabbed her arm and gently pulled her away. The shop owner would call the cops himself if they looked any more suspicious.

Once in the parking lot, Glimmer shoved their new means at Adora. "Look at this!" She whooped quietly, before flitting through the money like a deck of playing cards, running it under her own nose, and fanning herself with the green. "Our *limo* driver will take us wherever we want when we make it rain all over them." Bow laughed with her, and the pair mimed brushing the bills over one another.

"Not if we get robbed for waving it all around." Adora pushed their arms down and the money out of sight, but she had a smile on her face too. It was impossible not to feel a little high with huge stacks of Benjamins stretching out her pockets.

“Right right.” Bow conceded, putting his cash in his bag. “Let’s find a ride.”

“Okay, but I don’t think I need to say that the car dealerships aren’t open right now.” Adora noted. “And calling a cab is harder than it sounds apparently.”

“We’ve seen cabs around.” Glimmer said. “Let’s find one and jump in.”

“Where? You said everything was closed.”

The phones came out. Bow found something first. “Fremont Street is right nearby. People probably get dropped off there.”

It was snowing on Freemont Street. Well, it wasn’t really snowing. Glimmer was quickly learning that copies were the currency of this city. Besides the tiny cynical versions of world monuments, as they entered under the massive LED screen that arched above the old Las Vegas street turned pedestrian tourist attraction, it was displaying falling digital snowflakes. She turned in a circle, watching the giant crystals fall down toward the massive twinkling Christmas tree standing in the center of it all. It was fake too, standing 50 feet tall and looking more like a cone of green than a real tree with branches. The needles extended all the way to the ground, and the whole thing was surrounded by velvet rope.

There were more people here, but not many. Glimmer noted that even if it was a city that never slept, it was a weeknight and the early morning of Christmas Eve. Most people had better places to be. There were one or two tourists, a couple groups of inebriates meandering back to their hotels, and a few very unhappy-looking businesspeople in suits. They all glanced at them, mostly at Bow and the quiver on his back. “You should put that at your side.” Glimmer said to him.

Bow nodded and did so, tying it to his belt.

“Where do we find a car?” Catra asked.

“We could wait by the side of the road there.” Bow pointed to where Fremont Street met the Strip, but there were currently no cars arriving or departing.

“For however long it takes until somebody shows up?” Adora asked. “You heard what Catra said, we can’t just wait around.”

“Well, you got a better idea?” Glimmer asked.

“I’m saying we need to get there as fast as possible!” Adora shot back at her. Glimmer leaned back in shock, but her sister’s frustration evaporated immediately. She gripped her brow and lowered her voice. “Sorry, I didn’t mean . . . I’m just . . .” A yawn overtook her, which she shook off fearfully.

Glimmer nodded. “It’s okay.” She admitted. “None of us are our . . .” She yawned too. “our best.”

“I don’t think we’ll do better anywhere else.” Bow noted. “At least there’s a little crowd here to get lost in. Let’s head over to the street and wait. Four pairs of eyes to look for cabs and the changeling.”

Glimmer wasn’t confident they’d see the changeling coming if they attacked again, but Glimmer had asked for better ideas because she didn’t have one herself.

Fifteen minutes of waving their arms and making calls led to squat. Between the date, time, that they would be paying in cash, and the fact they needed to go 200 miles into the middle of nowhere desert, no cab or limo company would take them. Glimmer felt the stress rise higher and higher in herself and the others with each passing minute. She tried to keep her eyes open, watching the strangers for an unusual ripple of light that would give them away as the alien in disguise, but drowsiness weighed her eyelids. Every time they closed, the image of the bladed arms of the changeling flying towards her in the dark, and she flashed them open. Sneaking out of the house at 4 AM last night did not feel like 24 hours ago. Somehow, she hadn’t yet woken from the

dream this whole ordeal felt like yet. Catra, Utah, Zion, and now the Changeling. It only kept getting stranger. Worse, it kept feeling more and more like a nightmare.

Then the nightmare got worse.

"Umm . . . guys." Bow called. Glimmer followed his gaze up. It took a second to register what was on the huge LED screen above them. She blinked, rubbing her eyes. Yep, that was her own face. She looked down and around, seeing it again, and then again. On half the TVs and billboards were pictures of Bow, Adora, and herself - as well as a police sketch of a human version of Catra - next to a newswoman. The Christmas music playing cut out.

"Channel Five Las Vegas, good morning." The newscaster's voice took its place. "We bring you an update on the multi-day manhunt that has been going on in the Western United States for the past four days. From Twin Falls Idaho these three teenagers were believed to be kidnapped by an unknown fourth individual described as a woman of a similar age. Their car," The screen cut to a helicopter shot of their beige pickup. "Was found abandoned less than an hour ago on I-15. Local authorities strongly believe that they are currently within the Las Vegas area. Members of the public are encouraged to report but not approach them if sighted, as it is believed the fourth individual to be potentially armed and highly dangerous."

Glimmer looked around as her face turned pale. Everyone around, tourists and businesspeople, was watching the strange broadcast, either on the ceiling or the other screens. As Adora, Bow, and Glimmer's names were read off, eyes began to rove. A few landed on them, then more, then more. Soon everyone was staring, including the lone police officer nearby who was watching the public space.

"What do we do?" Glimmer asked as her heart began to pound.

"Leave." Catra said. "Keep your eyes low." She started walking, and they followed, each frantically grabbed a bag from where

they'd set them down. The eyes followed them. The officer pulled out their radio and started talking into it. They moved around the corner onto the street and then started to run.

"How did that just happen!?" Bow asked. Glimmer had no idea.

"Screens don't just switch like that, not all at once, for a random news report." Adora said.

"Someone's after us." Catra said. "Someone who controls the screens."

"Who isn't after us at this point?" Glimmer asked as they ran, breathing heavily. This place would be crawling with cops soon, Glimmer realized. She looked at her sister, who looked terrified and devastated. She grabbed at her jacket collar as she ran as if the noose was tightening around her neck.

"No car, now this." She said. "How do we get out?"

"By splitting up." Bow said.

"What?" Glimmer and Adora asked in unison.

"They're looking for us in a group." He said.

"But," Glimmer started, but Catra stopped her.

"He's right." She said. "If we split up, we're less likely to be spotted, it keeps anyone following us' attention divided, and we can cover more ground looking for transport." They stopped at a street corner, and Glimmer saw the gears turning behind her sunglasses. "Once one of us finds a car, they can call the others and pick us up one by one."

"And the Changeling?" Adora asked. "They nearly beat all of us at once."

"Groups of two then." Bow suggested. Glimmer looked at his hard focused eyes.

“But,” Glimmer said again, and was once again interrupted.

“We don’t have time to argue!” Bow cried.

Silence filled the alley for a moment. “You’re right.” Glimmer realized, looking at Adora who nodded, then started moving towards Catra.

“No Adora, you should come with me.” Bow said.

“What?” Adora asked.

“They’re looking for us together, but also in pairs. They’ll expect you and Catra, Glimmer and I, like how we went missing.”

Glimmer looked up at the alien she was here to help, who in turn met her gaze. Now the glasses over the alien’s mismatched eyes became an inscrutable mask. Glimmer took a deep breath. “Okay.” She said, and Catra tensed for a fraction of a second before nodding. Was that shock breaking through?

“Southwest or southeast, Adora?” Bow asked her.

“West.” Adora said.

“Then we’ll go southeast.” Catra said. “Come on Sparkles.” She said. Glimmer nodded and turned to go.

“Wait,” Bow and Adora said in unison.

Glimmer barely blinked before she was engulfed in a hug from Bow. “Don’t get arrested.” He whispered in her ear.

Glimmer, despite her fear, smirked, holding him tight. “No promises.”

They broke, and Glimmer looked at Adora and Catra, lingering near each other. God. Glimmer shook her head. “Be safe.” Adora simply said, then hugged Glimmer. “You too.”

“Right back at’cha.” Glimmer said.

They parted ways and started to run again in opposite directions.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Anxiety

Well, this isn't what I intended.

For those of you worried, no I'm not dead, just very sorry for the delay! I have excuses (holidays, my damn ADHD paralysis, etc.) but truthfully, starting work on this chapter and what will become the next two was an intimidating process I kept putting off as they were/are the messiest and least complete part of the story. As I feared, it has become basically a complete teardown and rewrite. The good news is that that rewrite is now well underway and I'm happy with how coming out! I can at least promise the gap between chapters 11 and 12 won't be as big as the one between 10 and 11 haha

Thank you all for your patience!

Chapter 12: Gleam

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra walked fast. An aggressive pace Glimmer was suspicious was exactly as fast as the alien thought she could manage. Not that she was complaining anymore. Neither said anything as they moved through shadows, down backstreets and in the peripherals of drunken pedestrians' vision.

It had all fallen apart so fast. The bruises on her body, alien bandages over her cuts, and the aching in her feet all spoke to that truth. But despite the pain, Glimmer felt . . . she wasn't sure how she felt.

She was scared, she knew that on some level. Every minute their assailant from the hotel didn't show themselves, that grew. But that fear didn't reach her eyes, her lungs, her robotically moving legs. Her breadcrumbs still trailed behind her, and their source was growing small.

During the fight, she'd felt . . . real. So real for the first time in she wasn't sure how long. The attack had been terrifying, but new. She never wanted to experience anything like it again, and yet now her ghost once more felt like it was just haunting her flesh. Incorporeal, with metaphors the only way to see her: reflected in something . . . more. Her fear was the sweeping shadows of headlights. Her dread was the tense muscles in Catra's neck, always on a swivel. Her hope was the cold desert night biting her cheek.

She had wished for simplicity, an adventure, an enemy to fight. Now that old adage about wishing carefully felt very prescient. The reason she'd come on this spontaneous trip, Adora, wasn't with her. Instead, she was company to the alien that she had thought she could help, even if it was only a little.

Maybe that was why it was so ironic Glimmer now felt safer sticking close to Catra.

They wove through the bowels of the city. Catra checking every corner before they turned it. Until, around one, a bright light shone like a sunrise. Was it morning already?

It wasn't the sun, but instead a massive neon structure that loomed above them. Whoa. Glimmer leaned back to see it all. "The sphere."

The new globe-shaped venue, 400 feet tall and coated in LEDs. She'd heard about it, but not given it much thought. After all, it was just a concert hall. But now, glittering like a monument to everything tacky about this city - an opulent monument to excess - it was impossible to ignore.

In fact, as a giant image of the earth turned before her, Glimmer couldn't deny it was beautiful too. She watched Europe rotate by. Then the continents melted into crashing water and waves. Then the water shifted into swirling clouds of stars and light. Glimmer smiled slightly. "Remind you of home?" She asked Catra.

"Nebula don't look like that." Catra replied, sounding bored.

Glimmer didn't know where it came from, but she started laughing. Maybe it was the stress, or the exhaustion, or the absurdity of their whole situation, but Glimmer just laughed. She backed up and leaned against the building on the street corner, clutching her stomach as she fought the spasms, but couldn't stop.

Catra stared at her like she was insane. "What?" She asked. Glimmer opened her mouth to explain and took a breath, but as soon as she looked at the confused slightly off-put alien she fell right back into giggles. "What!?" Catra repeated.

Glimmer tried, she really did, to explain to Catra what was so funny about the fact that this alien had seen the universe and traveled thousands of light years just to become an unimpressed

tourist in Las Vegas, Nevada. She failed, clutching her stomach and having to sit down on her calves just to stop from falling over. Covering her mouth and trying to calm herself. She looked up at Catra several times and started to explain, but she just couldn't get it out. After a while Catra gave up, resigned to waiting for Glimmer to exhaust herself while shaking her head and muttering, "This planet."

When Glimmer was done, she wiped the tears from her eyes and pushed up to her feet again. "Sorry." She gasped out, giggles still fading in and out.

"You good?" Catra asked, eyebrow raised.

"Yeah." Glimmer nodded, and realized she didn't quite feel so numb anymore. She felt here, she felt present. It would have been a shame to miss this.

"We gonna keep moving then?" Catra asked. "I don't want to get spotted because a pink haired girl couldn't keep her mouth shut."

"You think my hair is gonna do that?" Glimmer cocked an eyebrow. "Look who's talking. You like you lost a paintball fight in that thing." She gestured at her borrowed 90s jacket.

Catra narrowed her eyes. "I don't know what that is, and I'm just saying you maybe should put your hood up."

Glimmer rolled her eyes and pulled her hoodie's hood up, yanking the drawstrings until she could barely see out a little hole in front. "Happy?" She asked innocently.

Catra humored her. "You look ridiculous."

"What do you know about human fashion?" Glimmer asked, sticking her tongue out through the hole, but got it caught on the fabric. "Gahk!" She coughed on a loose thread.

"If the alternative is choking on your own stupidity, we'll do fine with your hair out." Catra deadpanned.

"Nope!" Glimmer declared when she stopped coughing. "This is how I dress now." Adding some sassiness to her voice, she declared, "It's not a phase, mom! This is the real me!" Catra just looked at her. "That would have been hilarious if you were human."

Catra paused for a moment, looking up at the sphere as it turned back into the rotating Earth. "If I were human, you wouldn't be in this mess." She said.

Glimmer pulled her hood back open. "True." She admitted glumly, looking up at the lights. "But there's nothing we can do to change that." She pulled out her phone. "What we can do, is go shopping."

"What?" Catra asked.

"We need to find people to find a car. An open clothing shop will have a new coat for you and a cashier we can bother to see where we can find a car." She found exactly what she was looking for. "It's over . . ." She began, then trailed off as the globe changed one more time . . . to Glimmer's own face. Seeing her portrait turning slowly next to Adora and Bow's, she felt her heart race again. "this way." She finished, and they kept moving.

Ten blocks out from Fremont Street, Adora and Bow stopped jogging. This should be far enough. Adora almost fell into a nearby wall, hand bracing against the concrete. Exhaustion didn't even begin to describe what she was feeling. "So fast." She clenched her fingers into a fist against the rough surface. "It's all gone to hell so fast." The words weren't directed at Bow, or anyone really. Just a voice thrown out into the universe.

Bow replied anyway, hands on his knees. "I won't deny that."

She'd just wanted to help. Adora's eyes stung from how tired they were. And now, after everything she'd done, if it all just ended

with nothing accomplished . . . "How can I fix this?" She muttered.

Bow put a hand on her shoulder. "We can fix it, together."

Adora spun and knocked it away. "We nearly died yesterday, Bow!" She said, looking into his eyes.

"I know."

"Without your arrow at the hotel . . . I might have . . ."

Bow swallowed. "Yeah."

Adora shook her head. "How are you so calm about this?" They were being hunted *Predator* style and yet, there Bow stood, looking merely winded. "Your entire world has been flipped upside down this week, right?"

"Right." Bow said.

Adora lifted her hands and gestured around. "And?"

Bow didn't reply for a time. He looked up at the dark sky, starless and overpowered by lights. "I care about you more than I fear that . . . thing." He stated. Oh. Adora blinked, looking at her friend. "You think I'm not scared, Adora? I'm terrified. But freaking out won't get you . . . us anywhere good."

He was right, of course. "Thank you, for the arrow back there." She said belatedly.

Bow smiled briefly. "Sure." Adora took another long look at the boy, staring down the street, tense dark circles under his eyes, and a tight frown beneath them.

"Hey." Adora moved and took his shoulders. He met her eyes, and Adora hoped the sympathy in them was readable.

Bow looked away. "First time I shot someone." He said.

“Oh.” Escaped Adora’s mouth. Then, after a moment, she wrapped her arms around his big shoulders. He grabbed onto her tight. They held each other there on an ugly side street for a long shaky moment. “You’re my friend too.” Adora assured him.

“I know.” Bow mumbled into her shoulder. “That’s why you wish we hadn’t come.”

“And it’s why you came.” Adora returned. If this all ended up for nothing. If she ruined her, Bow, Catra, and Glimmer’s lives all in one fell swoop . . . Adora didn’t know what she was going to do.

“Best Friends Squad?” He asked when they broke, infection smile returning.

“Best Friends Squad.” Adora assured.

A few blocks down the strip, Bow spoke up again. “My dads . . .” Like Adora’s statement, she knew it wasn’t necessarily directed at her, just thrown into the universe.

“How do you think they’ll take it, when we get home?” Adora asked. If we get home. She didn’t add.

“I have no idea.” Bow admitted.

Adora nodded. She couldn’t count herself an expert, having only met George and Lance a few times at Fourth of July barbeques and the like. “They love you.” She did know though. “You’re their baby boy.” The golden youngest.

“But I’m not six anymore.” Bow exhaled in frustration. “They love that idea of me; they hardly know the real version. I keep half the things I’m working on in the shop at school so they don’t find it.” The frustration changed color; it became a shade of shame. “They just want another perfect little history or English major like all my brothers . . .”

Adora’s heart ached for him. But before she could find the right words, a new voice interrupted.

“Excuse me!?” They both jumped, realizing they hadn’t been watching the world around them. Turning with fear of alien eyes, they instead found a group of young women approaching, all three dressed to the nines in sequin and iridescent eyeshadow. “I love your cosplay!” One pointed at his bow. “Could we get a picture?”

Bow blushed and muttered out a, “Sure.” The girls squealed in excitement and wobblily crowded around him. A phone was thrust into Adora’s hands. She tried to focus on taking the pictures rather than the girl’s legs and low-cut dresses. “I think we’re good.” Adora said after a few, the last one with Bow posing like a marble statue - arm outstretched and the three girls hanging of him off him like nymphs.

She wondered why they thought Bow wearing jeans and a crop-top hoodie was in cosplay, but that question was answered when Adora gave the phone back and smelt the sweat and alcohol lingering around them. “Oh my god, thanks!” one squealed.

“Is there a convention around?” Another asked in her ear.

“Who are you going as?” The third asked, long nailed finger pressing into Bow’s chest.

Adora looked at Bow, both flustered. “A small one.” Bow said. “It’s her first.”

“Haha! I knew it!” The second cheered. “This one thought you were in like, Circus Soleil!”

“But he might have been!” The first replied.

“I still think he looks like that cute guy that’s on all the TVs.” The third noted, hand reaching up to clasp his face and turn it left to right. “Why was that guy on TV?”

“He’s famous right?”

“No, I thought they were looking for him or something.”

“Allllright . . .” Adora gained her courage before this spiraled and pressed Bow and the girls apart. “We should get going.”

“Aww . . .” The girl sighed as she fell back into her other friends. “You’re no fun.”

“Don’t be mean.” Another said.

“Yeah, don’t step on her man!” The last cheered too loudly.

Adora paled. “He’s not my-!” She stopped herself. “I would never even be inter-! Never mind. Bow?”

“Yeah, we should go.” Bow agreed, but as they said goodbyes his eyes lit up. “Wait! Do you know where we could find a cab or a limo?”

They all scrunched up their faces. “The party we were leaving had some waiting to pick people up, but we decided to walk.”

“Stupid idea.” Another mumbled.

“Party?” Adora raised her eyebrows.

“Yeah! Oh dude it’s such a cool scene! A non-stop bash all the way to Christmas Day! We’re not going to be here but the start of it was awesome!” They gave Adora and Bow an address for a casino a half mile or so south of them. It was a lead. Bow thanked them and they all went on their way.

Adora approached Bow. “Well, those drunk strangers seemed to like the real you, Mr. Maker.” Bow shrugged. “Mr. Cosplay.” She teased.

Bow laughed that off, so Adora gave him a little glare. “. . . Yeah, they did.” He admitted.

“They liked you, I like you, Glimmer likes you. Catra hasn’t said one bad thing about you. Next to all that, I don’t think you have to worry about your dads.”

Bow side-eyed her with a miffed smile as he pulled out his phone and tried to find the hotel. “Never even be interested, huh?” He said as he typed.

Adora’s eyes went wide. “That’s not what I meant!” She insisted.

“Right.” Bow nodded.

Glimmer’s phone brought them to the Venetian, which had open shops. She and Catra went in through a quiet side entrance. Inside, their footsteps echoed against the striated marble floors and the Mediterranean architecture. White pillars and colorful frescos glittered, bedecked with Christmas lights and giant ornaments. Angels and cherubs lounged on fluffy clouds, bright golden goblets and dark grapes in their hands.

“So . . .” Glimmer said as they navigated the bowels of the resort.

Catra glanced at her, mismatched eyes peeking over her sunglasses. “So?”

Glimmer swallowed. “I wanted to apologize.” Catra’s hat flexed, her ears perking up beneath. “Back in the cabin, and afterwards, I said some horrible things to you. I could say I didn’t know your story at the time, but that would be an excuse. It was uncalled for . . . regardless of your past. So, I’m sorry.”

“I . . .” Catra’s mouth was hanging open slightly. “Thanks, Sparkles. I . . .” She clenched her jaw, then said near silently. “I’m sorry too.”

Glimmer’s eyes widened, asking dumbly. “What for?”

Catra looked like she was being tortured. “That same time, I called you a weakling. I didn’t know your story either.”

“Oh.” Glimmer thought back and remembered that Catra had. She hadn’t given it much thought at the time. It had seemed so true.

But now, the alien contradicted those whispered thoughts, adding. "You're not. Weak, I mean. It was true before you took a swing with that shower pole."

Glimmer nodded, fighting the emotions that swirled with that statement. "Thanks." She said, adding, "You too." limply afterwards.

They turned a corner in the hotel, and ahead there was a security guard. Catra's hand pushed Glimmer back, and they leaned against the nearest pillar, waiting for the guard to move off. Glimmer stared at Catra's fur backed hand across her chest, protective and strong. Even with the black claw nails, it wasn't scary. When the coast was clear, Catra said, "Let's go." and tapped her across the chest with the back of her hand to urge her forward. That wasn't scary either. It was almost friendly.

The next room was huge. Glimmer turned in a circle to take in the bizarre but beautiful place, nose twitching at the fake canal that smelled like a pool running down the center. Fake brick building façades lined the walls, styled to look like Venice but currently strung up with snowflakes and red and green lights. Each building led to a boutique shop, and above their rooves was a surprisingly convincing fake sky. It was permanently early evening here, fluffy painted clouds just slightly yellow and pink. It was quiet save for the Italian covers of Christmas songs playing through the speakers, only a few people milling about. None seemed to immediately recognize them, to Glimmer's relief. "As if my circadian rhythm isn't screwed up already." She rubbed her eyes, scanning the stores.

"Are all human cities like this?" Catra asked beside her.

"No, Vegas is a special brand of weird." Glimmer admitted, seeing the store she was looking for. "It's all supposed to keep you gambling as long as possible, make you forget what time it is."

"Just like Zon Amea." Catra noted quietly.

“Where?” Glimmer asked.

“Nevermind.” Catra dismissed the conversation as they entered the clothing store Glimmer had picked on her phone. It was a very fancy place Glimmer would normally never give a second glance at. The checkout counter was being managed by a miserable looking young cashier, who greeted them limply. She was dressed up, makeup hastily applied. Glimmer nodded to them and went for the coats, rifling through the rack to find a replacement for Catra. She found a black wool number with a fur lined hood and an absurd price tag, but it was the right size and they were loaded with cash at the moment. “Slip this on.” She said to Catra. Catra pulled off her own coat, but didn’t like the material.

Glimmer grabbed another off the rack, keeping her eyes open for other people. Her own coat had purple shoulders, but it wasn’t ridiculous, so after a quick peruse decided she didn’t need a replacement for herself. Three jackets in, Catra liked what she had. It was a plain dark gray windproof thing with lots of pockets.

They went to check out. Glimmer smiled as the cashier scanned the tag, who didn’t seem to give a damn what was going on. Glimmer felt bad, and was going to get right to the point, but remembered her conversation with Adora earlier. “They really make you work on Christmas Eve, huh?” She asked to be conversational.

“Unfortunately.” They mumbled. “No idea why, I’ll probably have five customers all day.”

Glimmer nodded. “You from around here?”

“Born and raised.”

“Nice place then? Overall? I’ve never been before.”

The cashier looked at her, and briefly Glimmer wondered if it was in recognition, but then answered as if it were obvious. “I suppose, lots to do at least. Shows, sports. Not great for kids through.”

“I imagine with the gambling. Do you have kids?” Glimmer asked, noting they looked pretty young to have any.

“No, but I was one.” They said, and Glimmer swallowed, feeling the sting. She was quiet for as long as it took for her to not feel like an asshole for asking another question, paying with cash and accepting the change.

“Say, do you know anyplace we can pick up a cab? My phone’s been acting up.”

The cashier tipped their head. “Anywhere with people maybe. The ice skating in front of the Cosmopolitan once it opens would probably be a good bet.”

“Ice Skating?” Glimmer smirked. “I guess there are things that aren’t very Vegas-y around, huh?”

The cashier nodded limply, Glimmer thanked them, and they slipped into the bathroom. Catra changed her coat, leaving the old one in the stall. It was Razz’s once upon a time, Glimmer was pretty sure. Hopefully she wouldn’t miss it.

“Ready?” Catra asked Glimmer as they headed out back into Fake Venice.

Glimmer nodded, looking around. She was about to turn back towards the entrance they’d come in through when she noticed a store that she hadn’t seen on their beeline in. “Or . . .”

“No.” Catra immediately replied.

“It’ll only take a minute.” Glimmer assured.

“No.”

Glimmer knew they were probably right, but. “C’mon Catra,” She turned her big sad eyes on. “it’s Christmas.”

"Your human holiday means nothing to me." Catra frowned. Glimmer just stared. Catra looked away, then shook her head. "I'm such an idiot." She muttered, and gestured for Glimmer to lead the way.

Glimmer tried to move fast in the store, getting everything prepped and packaged as quick as possible. Catra, by her request, kept watch from the entrance. She appeared back at Glimmer's side right as she was slipping everything into her backpack. "We gotta move." She hissed icily.

Glimmer's heart accelerated. She pulled her hood up and they headed towards the exit. Glimmer started to ask, "Did you see some-" when,

"Excuse me." Their voice called, blocking the way out.

A policeman stood over them, looking down. Glimmer swallowed. "Yes, officer?"

"I believe someone is looking for you." The officer said.

"We're not who you think we are." Catra said.

The officer chuckled. "Oh, I disagree."

Glimmer looked at Catra. "Now, sir . . . we don't want any trouble." Glimmer tried to ease him.

The cop's face was stone. "Well, that's unfortunate, because you're already in a lot of it."

Catra reached forward and grabbed Glimmer's forearm to pull her back a step. The cop took a step forward in return. There was a tense silence. "Well," Catra challenged, bravado brazen. "Come on then. Pull out the cuffs."

The thin crowd moved around them. "We can do this the easy way or the hard way, Kitten." Their eyes blinked vertically.

Glimmer barely got the gasp out before Catra's fist was slamming into the changeling's stomach. "Run!" She cried as people around them gasped.

Glimmer didn't need to be told twice. She turned and bolted, heading deeper into the hotel. She looked back. Catra was behind her. The changeling was rising, locking yellow eyes with hers.

Catra pulled up alongside. "We need to find another way out."

"No shit." Glimmer replied. They came out into a hall filled with slot machines and table games. The sculpted white ceiling was lit by golden chandeliers with red and green bulbs. A few gamblers milled around. Glimmer watched as Catra ran right over the line between the marble tile and the carpeted gambling area.

"Wait!" Glimmer called.

"Hey!" A security guard watching for underage kids like them hollered.

And now they had two people chasing them. Great. Glimmer crossed over the line and they weaved through the casino floor, between the clicking reels, ringing bells, and flashing lights. They dodged past people and staff, Catra barreling through anyone in the way.

"Sorry, s'cuse me! Coming through!" Glimmer weaved behind as she watched Catra vault over a craps table. Glimmer took the long way around past the young dealer, who was looking very cute in a button up and suspenders. "Sorry!" She whispered with a blush as they brushed chests. She pulled her eyes away just in time to watch Catra shove an old man with a cane to the ground in order to get by. Jesus. "Here!" Glimmer reached down and helped him up, taking a second to make sure he was steady.

"Sparkles!" Catra called. Glimmer looked up then back. The changeling in disguise and the guard were both running towards her. Glimmer turned and ran faster.

But her fastest wasn't enough. Catra pulled ahead, and she lagged behind. Her lungs, weak from the hospital and inactivity, burned. She kept glancing over her shoulder. Each time the pursuers were closer. Then, as she was running past a poker table, she tripped, and landed chin-first on the carpet.

Grunting, Glimmer saw one of the men sitting at the table had stuck his foot out for her to stumble on. He tipped his cowboy hat with a frown as Glimmer struggled to her feet.

"Stop!" A hand grabbed her shoulder. The security guard had her. She was spun around and was seized on the other shoulder by the Changeling.

Years of conditioning kicked in. Glimmer screamed bloody murder. "Let go of me!"

"Whoa! Whoa! Relax kid!" The guard tried calm her.

"NO!" Glimmer didn't let up. She kicked and shoved and tried to get her arms up. "That's not a cop! That's not a person!" She wrenched an arm free and threw at the changeling's face. It struck. They barely flinched. Pain exploded in Glimmer's knuckles. When she pulled them away, the changeling's fake face was scrunched-in and deformed. The security guard went limp, gaping. The changeling laughed lowly. The noise was distorted through twisted flesh.

"What the fu-" The guard began before being cut off by a much faster fist to both their and the changeling's stomachs. Catra knocked them both off, and in a breath had Glimmer up in her arms, bridal style.

"You're a real pain in my ass, you know that?" Catra said to her as she started to run.

Slot machines flew by. There was wind in her ears. Glimmer's heart was beating so fast she needed to think back and replay what Catra had just said to reply. "Oh, and you've such a dream yourself?" She managed. It was supposed to come out confident

and cocky, but ghost of hands on her arms and shoulders trying to force her still turned it into a whisper. “Let go of me!” Glimmer demanded, beginning to squirm.

“Hey!” Catra protested.

“Put me down!” Glimmer insisted.

“We’re faster this way!” Catra replied, stopping in a grand intersection centered on an ornate fountain. Catra’s boots squeaked on the floor as she slid to a stop. “Which way?”

“How the hell should I know!?” Glimmer balked, giving Catra a good shove.

Catra dropped her, looking in all four directions. “Just keep up.” She scolded and went right. They ran down the hallway, but it ended at a staircase going upwards.

“We shouldn’t be going up!” Glimmer noted.

“No shit!” Catra clapped back, looking around. “How do you spell exit in your language again?”

It was starting to sink in for Glimmer how screwed they were. Then, there was a roar behind them. An actual roar. Goosebumps prickled up her arms as a shadow appeared around the corner. First humanoid, then changing into a long four-legged creature. And it was a creature which turned the corner; something like a mangey dog with a face full of tentacles. It looked at them with yellow eyes, and roared again, tentacles opening around a ring of dark teeth.

“Pick me up.” Glimmer whispered.

“Make up your damn mind.” Catra grumbled as she did and rushed up the stairs, which brought them out into another huge gambling hall. Her grumbling grew louder.

“That way!” Glimmer pointed down an adjoining hallway with windows on both sides. Windows were better than not windows for finding the way out. Catra ran, carrying her down the length of the corridor. From outside, neon and pre-dawn light threw streaks over their faces. The shapeshifter’s roars grew louder behind them.

Then, a nightmare. The hallway was a dead-end of closed, unmarked doors. Catra set Glimmer down and yanked on one. Glimmer did the same with another. They rattled in their frames, locked.

“Watch them!” Catra shouted, lifting a hand up to the keyholes of one of the doors. Glimmer turned, glancing back to see Catra’s suit shift up her hand and change, in front of her fingertip, into the shape of a key. Catra slipped it into the lock and jiggled her hand.

The changeling appeared around the corner, running them down on four talon-filled paws. “Ten seconds!” Glimmer guessed from their speed. “Hurry up!”

“I’m trying!” Catra growled, focus on the door.

“Five seconds!”

There was a click and Catra threw the door open. Glimmer ran through with her, Catra slamming it closed behind. Glimmer snapped the deadbolt into place, backing away and watching under the door. Unlike the one at the hotel, this door had a rubber strip beneath, sealing it shut. Glimmer thought she was safe until it lifted and a thick black and green slick began creeping out from underneath. It was only slowing them down.

Catra lifted her leg and slammed it down on the growing oily blob, causing it to scream in an inhuman way, retracting behind the door. Like that would stop them. Glimmer turned around, and nearly screamed.

“What the hell?” She gasped out. Dwayne The Rock Johnson was staring back at her, all six-foot-something of him with a terrifyingly fixed smile. Glimmer’s hammering heart stared, ready for fight or flight until she realized the movie star wasn’t moving, or breathing. She looked around. Above the velvet ropes crossing the closed ticket stalls ahead of them was a sign written in gold.

Welcome to Madame Tussauds Las Vegas!
The World’s Greatest Wax Museum

Glimmer’s heart dropped. “You gotta be fucking kidding me.”

Adora was hoping to hell that Glimmer and Catra were in a better situation than them. “How many you think?”

Bow slid down below the concrete barrier again. “At least fifty. It’s like their sweeping down the strip.”

Ahead of them both, right in the way of the resort they were heading towards, the streets were crawling with cops. In uniform, they walked from sidewalk to sidewalk, stopping every car and pedestrian down the street, showing them pictures, asking questions.

“They’ve got the cabs pulled over.” Adora noted, peeking and seeing cars with those magical four letters ‘TAXI’ on the side. She looked over at Bow, and they locked eyes for a long silent moment. Both were trying to think of a way out of this. Both were coming up empty.

No, no no no, c’mon Adora. Think. There must be a way to do this. There had to be. Think! “We go up and talk to a driver. Pass’em a hundred to pick us up after the cops move on.”

“Without being spotted?” Bow asked. “Without the cabbie turning us in?”

Adora shook her head. “You got a better idea?”

Bow frowned. “Wait for a better opportunity.”

“Everyone in this city is out to get us, Bow!” Adora whisper-shouted. “How much longer do you think we can sneak around?”

“Longer than throwing ourselves right into them.” Bow shook his hands at her.

“We have to try!” Adora shouted, then immediately closed her mouth, realizing she was too loud. Bow looked at her with something like pity. Adora’s frustration built. “I need to fix this!” She insisted.

Bow’s expression didn’t change. “Do you?”

Adora’s frown deepened. “Yes.” She assured, and moved to stand. “I said you didn’t need to follow me into this, and you don’t. You can still walk away.”

Bow caught her arm before she could head into the fray. “I’m not going anywhere.”

They quietly followed the side of the buildings, slipping past the officers checking cars and got up close to their target, the Grotto Resort. Outside the doors was a small crowd of the confused, drunk, or both. Adora looked to Bow, and they slipped into the throng, hoods up, eyes down, and headed for a parked cab stuck by the curb. Adora knocked on the passenger’s window.

“Hey.” She said when it rolled down. “We we’re hoping to get a ride.”

The cabbie inside chuckled. “And I’m hoping to give somebody one, but as you can see.” He gestured past his windshield. “Freaking circus here.”

“Yeah, we know. But we we’re hoping to get you once you’re let out.”

“For a long drive.” Bow added beside her.

“Yeah, but if you pick us up a couple blocks south on the corner.” She pulled out a 100 from her coat, and waved it into the car. “We can make it worth it.”

The driver looked at the bill, then at her face. His eyes went wide, recognizing them.

“If you can keep quiet, that is.” Adora pulled the bill back again.

The cab driver looked at the pair of them, mouth closed. “Well,”

“Hey!” A voice shouted behind them. Adora turned. A man was pointing at them. “It’s them!”

Others turned, eyes widening. They became parrots, gasping and repeating. “Look!” “There!” “That’s the people they’re looking for!”

Bow grabbed Adora’s arm. They looked left and right, but there were cops already closing in. “In the hotel.” She told Bow.

They ran into the crowd, pushing past the people pointing and staring. Some tried to grab her, but a little shove kept them off. The commotion grew louder and more hectic. They pushed through to the far-side. The golden framed doors of the hotel were right in front of them.

A woman in a suit stepped into their path. She crossed her arms with a sly smile, the neon shining in her aqua-blue hair. Mermista. “Hey there again, *Diana*.”

“Your species . . .” Catra muttered as they wandered through the maze-like interior of the museum, looking for the exit. It was closed on Christmas Eve, but Glimmer and Catra weren’t alone. Unblinking glass eyes stared at them from all sides. The perfectly still wax dummies holding them posed in the deep shadows cast by the dim emergency lights.

Glimmer had to agree with Catra on the vibes of this. It made her skin crawl. She jumped as they moved from room to room,

recognizing the celebrities mingling in the dark. Eerie facsimiles of Brad Pitt and Angelina Jolie stood next to one another, seemingly trying to ignore the unblinking Jack Black posing with rock-on hands a few feet away. In the next room, Muhammad Ali, boxing gloves up, lingered in a corner, fixed smile unendingly staring at a lineup of recent presidents across the hall.

There was a bang on the metal entrance door behind them, and Glimmer flinched, freezing for an instant. Her breaths came ragged and she clenched her fists tight until she felt her fingernails digging into her palms. She locked eyes with the figures in turn, all looking at her. The changeling had decided it would be faster to bash the doors down.

"Sparkles." Catra called her from the threshold into the next room. Glimmer didn't move. There was another bang. "Sparkles." Glimmer tried, she really did, but she couldn't move. Catra exhaled sharply, pacing back to her.

"I don't think I can do this." Glimmer whispered.

Catra sighed. "C'mon Sparkles, work with me here."

"Work with you!?" Glimmer hissed back, squeezing her eyes shut. Bang! ". . . This is like a horror movie."

"And that's what makes you draw the line? Not everything's that come before?"

"I didn't sign up for a horror movie!" Glimmer rebutted.

"Well, it's not going to stay a movie if we don't keep moving." Catra said, and grabbed her arm. It wasn't a friendly grab this time. Glimmer jerked away. Catra growled. "Sparkles, seriously!"

"STOP CALLING ME SPARKLES!" Glimmer suddenly roared, her voice echoing off the walls. She clapped her hands over her mouth immediately, but it was out. The banging ceased for a long terrifying moment, then resumed even louder. "Just . . ." Glimmer exhaled through shivering teeth. "Just give me a second."

Catra let go of her arm, and allowed her to breathe. “Fine,” Catra conceded. Bang! “Glimmer.”

Glimmer nodded through her closed eyes, hunched over. “Thank you.” She gasped out. Bang! Bang! Bang!

“Glimmer.” Catra tried again.

“I said one second.” Glimmer kept her eyes closed, trying to slow her heart.

“We won’t-” Catra growled, then cut herself off, and let her breathe for another ten seconds. “Why did you do it?” Catra asked.

Glimmer blinked open her eyes, looking up at Catra’s neutral face in confusion. “What?”

“Why did you try to kill yourself?” Catra asked it plainly.

Glimmer’s eyes widened with so many emotions: shock, horror, dread, shame. Why the fuck would she ask that, and here and now of all places!? She couldn’t think of a reason, unless. A shakey peal of laughter escaped her quaking lips. She was trying to shock her out of this state, get her moving. “Ohh you are such a bitch.”

Catra nodded, looking away. When she spoke again thought, it wasn’t with condescension, or malice. She just talked. “I don’t get it.” She admitted. “Or, well, I do. I really do. But you . . . you don’t seem like the type.”

“The type?” Glimmer echoed, settling into somewhere between disgusted and confused.

“I’ve seen it before.” Catra said. “People kill themselves. But none like you. It was always . . . after battles, y’know?” She snarled softly and her ears flattened, but whether it was from how this was coming out or old memories Glimmer didn’t know. “You don’t

. . . you don’t have a good reason. You shouldn’t feel the way you do.”

Glimmer shook her head. “Wow, now that you’ve pointed that out, I’m cured.” She sassed.

“That’s not what I’m getting at.” Catra insisted gruffly.

“Could’ve fooled me.”

The alien sighed, eyes everywhere but Glimmer. “Yeah, me too.” She let out, then was quiet for long moment. “On campaign . . . I thought about it. On the worst nights. Big gun in your hands; it’d be easy.”

Glimmer flinched. “What?”

“I’ve said it once, alright?” Catra snarled at her, teeth bared. “Don’t make me say it again.” Glimmer shut her mouth, and Catra exhaled, gripping one of her backpack straps with a crushing grip. “Don’t tell Adora about that.”

“She doesn’t know?”

“No.” Catra said. Glimmer just stared at her. “Promise.” Catra leveled a clawed finger at her.

Glimmer nodded quickly. “I promise. I promise.” She assured.

Catra backed off. Bang! The door rattled in the distance. “What I’m getting at is this:” Catra spoke swiftly now. “when you’re in a living hell, literally, it can seem like it’ll never end. But, then you find yourself in a place you never could have imagined existing.” She gestured to the empty wax husks of people watching their pep-talk in the dark. “Talking to people you never thought you’d meet.” She looked at Glimmer, then scrunched up her face like she had just licked something really sour. “Just, take it from the least deserving person in this whole stars-damned galaxy: life finds a way to surprise you . . . ugh, that sounds like something Perfuma would say.”

Glimmer managed to smile a little, wiping her eyes. Maybe she did have a soft side after all. Then there was a horrible shearing sound that echoed through the museum. Twisting metal screeched and shocked her ears.

It was inside. She looked at Catra, who asked. “Ready?”

Glimmer nodded, and walked into the next room and a few steps out of the mud. It would be a shame to miss the next unimaginable thing trying to kill her . . . probably.

They moved on and on, but some of the doors in the museum were closed, and nowhere seemed to be the way out. Their odds dwindled as the stress rose. “Who designed this place?” Glimmer whispered in frustration as they ended up back in a room they’d been in before.

Catra silenced her with a finger. She looked left and right, ears twitching. “Hide.” She ordered.

Glimmer’s hummingbird heart somehow beat faster. She looked around the room, for anywhere to cover. There was nowhere, except.

Glimmer dragged Catra over to a diorama of three cavemen huddled around a plastic fire. She pulled a fur off one and tossed it over herself. Catra did the same with another, and they sat facing the wall, hunched over. Glimmer took a deep breath. Be still.

A door opened, and there were quiet footsteps. Glimmer tried not to shake, tried not to even blink. Next to the cavemen were the cast of the Wizard of Oz, and in the reflection of the Tin Man’s shiny body, she saw a tall figure in a suit and a top hat looking around the room. And now she was being hunted by Abraham Lincoln.

The president who was actually an alien lizard crossed the room, scanning each statue in turn. They pausing at one. With a tilt of a

head, Lincoln became David Bowie. His signature sparkly lightning bolt across the face and pale eyes pierced in the red lights.

Bowie continued his search, but didn't seem to notice them. They turned for the next room. Glimmer counted the steps. Five, four, three, two-

Glimmer's phone started to vibrate in her pocket. The shapeshifter froze. Glimmer's stomach dropped like it was full of lead. No no no. Not now. Now is not the time to have found a car, Adora.

Glimmer slowly, so slowly, reached for her pocket. Her fingers slid into her jacket, grasping the phone. She reached for the silence switch.

The floor suddenly moved below her, engulfing her in a rising tide of alien goo. Glimmer gasped, trying to grab her phone as she was launched off the ground, but it slipped from her fingers, falling into a little tendril of shapeshifter waiting to catch it. Glimmer was pushed into the nearest wall, black bands covering her arms, legs, and over her mouth. Everywhere it touched was like insects over her body. She tried to fight it off, but it was too strong. In her struggle, she saw Catra being constrained on the floor, wrapped in a cocoon at - and made from - the changeling's feet. In fact, a significant chunk of their body seemed to be used to hold the two of them still.

The guise of David Bowie fell away, and in its place, Glimmer found herself. She met her own eyes as the phone was lifted up. The changeling answered it.

"Help." Adora's voice came through on speaker.

"Adora?" The changeling responded with Glimmer's own voice, disturbingly sympathetic. Glimmer tried to scream, tried and shout for her sister not to listen, but the band over her face only tightened, threatening to spill into her mouth.

"Help." Adora repeated, then paused for a long moment. "Need . . . help." Glimmer realized that they hadn't found a car, and that

something was very wrong. Adora words were forced gasps.

The changeling realized it too. “What’s wrong?”

“Stuck . . . can’t . . .” Adora said. “get away.”

“Away from what? Adora are you alright?”

“. . . Cops.” Adora said. There was silence for nearly ten seconds. Glimmer shook her arms and legs, fighting uselessly. “Too much.”

“Too much what? Adora? Where are you?”

“Got cornered . . . Grotto Resort . . . needed . . . a way out.”

The changeling looked at Catra and Glimmer with a wicked smile. “Oh no, you didn’t . . .” They said into the phone with a fearful tone.

Adora responded with one word. “Lens.”

It had been all she could think of. Adora and Bow had made it to the second floor, but there were just too many of them. A tear dripped down Adora’s cheek, and she fought for the strength to lift her eyes a fraction of an inch. In a circle around them, the endless impossible facets of the lens in her hand were the focus of fifty frozen police officers, two suits, and anyone else nearby that was too curious for their own good.

Adora had tried to break its hold on her, tried to think her way out of the trance. What she had managed in ten minutes of sheer willpower was call her sister. Sweat now dripped down her forehead from the effort, but it had paid off.

“We’re on our way.” Came through the phone.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Discussions of suicide and PTSD

Looks at last upload date Hahaha . . . whoops.

Chapter 13: Nock and Draw

Chapter Notes

> So, I burned out. Sucks to admit, but I did. Part of it was that this chapter was hell on me for some reason, lots of action and blocking frustrated editing and rewrites, but that's an excuse, and I'm getting back into the swing of things now. No posting timeline promises here, except that come Hell or high water, I will finish this thing!
>
> I'll probably delete all this once we're a few more chapters in. So, for now, thank you to everyone's who's made it far, especially those who are coming back after the impromptu hiatus! That more than 5,000 of you are giving my story any or all this time means more than you can know.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The changeling hung up her phone and, to Glimmer's horror, placed it inside their liquid body with a ripple of black and green. Glimmer, with heaving breaths, stared into the alien's burning gaze. She was confronted; this could be the end. What a way to die. A tentacle lashed out towards her. Glimmer braced, but didn't close her eyes.

The wall an inch beside her was smashed inward. Glimmer's heart kept beating. She let out the contents of her shaking lungs.

"Glitter and grit." The changeling said in approval. The tentacle began ripping wire and metal from the walls. "This has been fun, and I've got to say, this place is an absolute riot." They shifted between a variety of different forms one after the other, settling on the late queen of England, bedecked in jewels and blue robes. "If we had more time," they said in a regal British accent. "I would treat you both to tea and crumpets. But, alas, you two don't have what I need." The fleshy tendrils around Glimmer and Catra retreated, replaced by knots of electrical cables and metal

stringers. The pair was tied up on the wall next to one another. "Fret not, I'll be sure to treat the others just as I treated you. Would you like me to deliver a message to them?"

Catra snarled and strained at her bindings.

The queen vanished in a swirl of flesh, replaced by the Changeling's 'true' form. "Hmm, that might be a little too aggressive. How about I just tell them you two were *hanging out*, instead?" They laughed glibly.

"You're a monster." Glimmer managed through a quivering jaw.

The changeling chuckled. "Now that, is a lovely compliment." They bowed. "But I'm afraid there'll be no encore tonight, as I just have to go. Hang tight." They walked away, footsteps fading into the adjoining rooms.

Silence returned to the wax museum. Glimmer tried to calm herself, hanging with sharp metal digging into her wrists, waist, and ankles. She tried to pull an arm free but hissed when the metal sliced into her skin, dropping little dots of red onto the floor. "Catra?" She asked when she was sure the Changeling was gone.

"Working on it." Catra grunted, and there was a squeak from her bonds as she tried to fight her way out.

Glimmer nodded, swallowing the tension in her throat. "Why didn't it kill us?" She whispered.

"What?"

"They didn't kill us." Glimmer repeated. "I don't . . . I don't understand."

"It doesn't matter." Catra said. Glimmer looked over at her. "I mean, don't try to understand. Maybe they've got some weird moral code. Maybe they were lazy, or didn't want things to get messy. I have no idea. What matters is . . ." She lunged her head forward and bit down on the bindings holding one hand up.

Glimmer heard the crackle of an electric spark and a grunt from Catra before she yanked back and ripped the wires away with a noise from her throat that sounded like a roar. She pulled her arm free. Blood dripped down the multicolored cables. “that we get to Adora and Bow before they do.”

Adora had been so stupid. So so stupid. Fear and loathing and nausea from being unable to look away from the crystal in her hands built and built until she could barely think. Everyone around her was frozen. Further away, she heard whispers of people starting to keep their distance, worried, confused, or thinking the crowd was some kind of performance. The radios on the officers’ belts kept going off, asking for updates. Bow was to her right, but she couldn’t see him. In her field of vision instead was a middle-aged cop directly ahead. He was almost making eye contact and looked terrified. Twin tracks of tears stained his cheeks, and he was breathing very heavily. But they were all stuck. “I’m sorry.” Adora barely managed to say to him.

Time passed, Adora didn’t know how long. Minutes flew as seconds crawled. She felt sick to her stomach, staring at the broken crystal. Like a horrible scent for the eyes, its acrid facets stung her retinas. Adora had to force herself to blink as she stared ahead, unendingly, until, out of the corner of her eye, she saw neon purple, yellow, and blue. Adora gasped in relief as Catra approached the circle cautiously.

“Hey, Adora.” They smiled at her, passing behind frozen figures.

“Hey!” Adora nearly sobbed, smiling so wide. She wished she could turn her head and look her directly in the eye.

“We’re stuck.” Bow said from the side.

“I can see that.” Catra noted with a smirk. “This is going to be tricky, and we’re going to have to be fast. Get ready to run in this direction.

Adora tried and failed to nod. Catra took several steps back, then ran towards them. With a graceful leap, she cleared the police officers' heads and landed by Adora's side. "Let's go!" She cried, shoving the lens away from her line of sight. Adora reacted, jamming the damn thing in her pocket. The whole scene suddenly unpaused. Chaos erupted. Police officers unfroze. Some ran at her, others stumbled to the ground in shock, still more immediately lost whatever their last meal had been onto the floor. Adora didn't pay any of it mind. She just stayed close to Bow and Catra as the latter plowed people aside.

They escaped the circle and fled deeper into the hotel, around a corner and past a series of doors. "Where's Glimmer?" Adora asked, just barely keeping her own stomach down. Bow was looking nearly as green as she felt.

"Waiting outside." Catra said. "C'mon, we found a good way out." She stopped at an unmarked door, which swung open to reveal a bare concrete utility staircase. "This way." She started upwards.

The humans paused. "Up?" Bow asked.

The distant sounds of the police running after them grew closer and closer. Catra glanced behind him, then locked eyes with Adora. "Trust me."

Adora followed. Bow brought up the rear. Once inside the staircase, Catra closed the door and kicked the handle, bending it down and hopefully locking it in place. They ascended two flights and crashed back out into another hallway, breaking into a run.

Adora made it twenty feet before somehow tripping on the perfectly flat surface. She stumbled onto her knees, catching herself with an arm. The lens nearly jumped out of her jacket in the fall. She jammed her other hand into her pocket to keep it out of sight.

A glance up saw Catra holding out a hand to pull her up. "Maybe you should give me the lens." She said as she lifted her to her

feet. “I won’t freeze.” Adora nodded, but hesitated. She would have to see it to hand it over. “It’ll be out for only a second.” Catra said impatiently, flanked by a nervous-looking Bow.

“But,” Adora said, brain frazzled.

“We don’t have time to argue!” Catra insisted.

“Close your eyes, Bow.” Adora said. Bow did so. Adora shut her own and began to pull out the lens.

“Adora, stop!”

Adora’s eyes snapped open, turning to see Glimmer running towards them. At her side was, “Catra?”

“That’s not her!” Glimmer shouted. Adora spun to watch Catra’s face melt away.

“So close.” The changeling shrugged and lunged for the lens. Adora yanked the hand holding it back, out of her pocket and away. It slipped from her panicked fingers, tumbling through the air and landing against Bow’s chest, who awkwardly caught it.

“Run you big-chested nerd!” Catra, the real Catra, cried, pulling Bow’s eyes away before they could get snared in the lens. He moved. The changeling’s unnaturally large hands gave chase, stretching and reaching past Adora. Seeing the huge liquid talons racing for her friend, she grappled one without thinking and instantly regretted it. The oily flesh grabbed onto her arm, then locked into place, freezing like water into an iron grip.

A snarl filled Adora’s ear. Quicker than she thought possible, Catra had closed the distance between them. Her claws swept down, and the Changeling howled. Adora was pulled away as the severed alien arm flopped to the floor, still moving. Adora screamed. One that was silenced when, in an instant that left her terrorized body and racing mind a hot mess, was lifted up into a bridal carry and away from the changeling by Catra.

“I thought you knew me better by now.” Catra said to her as she ran her to safety. “I said move, Bobby B!” Catra shouted to get his legs working too. Glimmer fell in alongside.

“Where . . . when? How did you-!?” Adora sputtered. She looked back to see the changeling’s arm slither back towards their body and reconnect with it, then their yellow eyes locked with hers.

“Long story.” Catra dismissed.

“It involves a wax museum.” Glimmer offered.

“What!?”

“Long story!” Catra repeated.

“How did you get past the suits?” Bow asked as he pulled his bow off his back and grabbed an arrow.

“What suits?” Catra asked.

“Stop right there!” A voice called out.

Adora looked ahead. Seahawk and Mermista were blocking the way. “Those suits.” She deadpanned.

“Hands and weapons up!” Mermista ordered. Seahawk had his handgun drawn, black and intimidating, but not raised. No cops were flanking them this time as they stood in the center of a t-shaped intersection, breathing heavily.

“I must say!” Seahawk beamed brightly while huffing out breaths. “You four are quite good at giving us the slip! However,”

“This whole thing is over.” Mermista cut him off in a cold deadpan. “So just like, please come quietly and we can get this all sorted out.”

They all screeched to a halt on the stone floor. Catra put Adora down but kept a hand on her side. Adora was so adrenaline high

she hardly noticed it. Bow raised his bow above his head as the four of them looked at each other. Two choices. Ahead, the suits. And behind,

"Well well well, thank you very much!" The voice of the changeling called. Everyone turned to see them approaching at a leisurely pace. But while they were green and reptilian before, now they looked like an average - and very human - man dressed in a blue suit. "I have to thank you two. I was getting pretty tired of the chase myself!"

Everyone looked at one another one more time, and then swiftly walked over to Mermista and Seahawk. "Whoa whoa!" Mermista eyed them all carefully as they approached. "Seahawk, check them."

Seahawk approached and quickly patted down Adora, Glimmer, and Catra's pockets with one hand. "Salutations once again!" He said to Adora has he checked her. "Seems you've been quite the *adventure* I in the last twenty minutes." He pulled Catra's hood down when he got to her, revealing her ears and the vicious glare she was giving him. "It's umm . . . lovely to meet your friends!" He smiled at her, turning to Bow and Glimmer. "The ever-ready **Seahawk**, at your service! Tell me, do you know one another from-"

"Seahawk, shut up." Mermista ordered. "You." She called to the changeling. "What's your interest in this?"

"Why, I'm trying to get these kids home, just like you." The changeling lied sweetly. "Their parents are very worried."

Mermista looked at the teens, then back to the changeling. "You're a PI?" She asked them.

The changeling didn't answer for a fraction of a second, then jumped back in. "Of course! Is that so surprising?"

"That's not true!" Glimmer suddenly cried. "That thing is chasing us!"

“Glimmer!” Adora cut her sister off. It wasn’t like these two weren’t chasing them either.

“She’s right!” Bow echoed. “Please, they’ve hurt us!” He lifted his bow towards them.

“What!?” Mermista looked back at them. “Weapon down, kid.” She pressed his arm toward the floor. Adora’s mind began to race.

A stream of alien curses tumbled from Catra’s lips. “She’s telling the truth!” She joined in, then turned to Adora. “We don’t have a choice.”

The changeling’s smile faded. “Desperate people will say anything.” They urged. “Let’s just talk this over.” They took a step forward.

Seahawk lifted his handgun an inch. “That, my tall lanky friend, is quite far enough for now.”

“Seahawk.” Mermista warned.

“I’m just trying to help.” The changeling said, taking another step.

“You’ve tried to kill us!” Glimmer returned.

“Everybody stop!” Mermista ordered much more firmly. She turned to the changeling. “You, I want identification. Paper, phone, I don’t care. Pass it over here.” She pointed at the teenagers. “You four, tell me about that thing.”

“It’s an alien shapeshifter.” Bow said to her.

Mermista, surprisingly, didn’t react oddly to that statement. She just stared down the changeling in disguise, who was standing still, silently. “I said I want ID, sir!” Mermista repeated.

The changeling chuckled. “Ooo, so serious.” They cooed. “And your partner is so theatrical! A classic contrast!”

“He is not my partner.” Mermista ground out, to a gasp from Seahawk.

“Dearest!”

“Jesus, we’re in the middle of something here.” Mermista growled at Seahawk. The changeling started walking towards them. “Stop right there.” She ordered. “I said stop, sir!”

The changeling said nothing and didn’t stop.

“I’m warning you!” Mermista repeated, louder. “Stop. Do not approach.” Mermista reached into her suit and retrieved a small rod into her hand. With a flick of the wrist, it lengthened into a two-foot baton capped in a row of three spiked and golden prongs. An electric prod.

“Stop!” Mermista repeated. “I said stop right there or use force against you!”

The changeling didn’t stop. Adora felt the dread rising in her stomach again when she caught something out of the corner of her eye. “Look out!” She warned to Seahawk.

“What?” He looked at her. The camouflaged tentacle, barely visible as it slithered up from the floor, grabbed Seahawk’s gun. He gasped, trying to pull away, but the limb flickered to black and grabbed his arm. There was a tussle, and Adora saw the pistol go flying from his hands, sliding across the floor twenty feet away. The changeling chuckled, human disguise falling away.

“What the hell.” Mermista whispered.

“Alien shapeshifter!” Bow repeated as the main body of the changeling closed the gap. Ten feet, five. It was on them.

“Get behind me!” Mermista ordered, shoving past and lunging with her prod. The changeling dodged easily and came back with a punch for her face. Mermista retreated before it made contact, pressing the teens still further away.

Seahawk shook out his shooting hand to dispense the pain of the gun being ripped away. The changeling, while still fighting Mermista, sent its other hand out flying towards him. Seahawk yelped in surprise, then grunted when he took it to the chest. He replied with a fisticuff of his own, battering the arm away.

“Oh ho! You think I’m weak simply because I’m unarmed, creature!?” He declared boisterously, posing like a Victorian boxer. “Think again!” He took a second punch to the stomach. Adora heard the air being driven from his lungs.

Mermista jabbed at the shapeshifter herself. But it was too fast, too flexible, bending away from each strike like a rubber hose cartoon. Mermista took her fist hit on the knee. She let out an awful shout and limped back. The changeling pounced on her weakness, and Mermista’s eyes went wide.

That was when Seahawk started to sing.

“Come all you young sailor men, listen to me!
I'll sing you a song of the fish in the sea!”

The changeling froze, turning away from a very relieved, and yet very annoyed-looking Mermista. “Now this, is unexpected.” The changeling smiled, then lunged. Seahawk jumped aside and threw a mighty punch. He blocked another with his forearm. They began to trade a series of blows, and all the while, the man bellowed out lyrics to his shanty.

“For it’s windy weather, boys, stormy weather, boys!
When the wind blows, we're all together, boys;
Blow ye winds westerly, blow ye winds, blow
Jolly sou'wester, boys, steady she goes!"

While the alien was distracted, Mermista circled behind. She lunged, but the changeling sensed it, stepping aside. The suits collided with one another. Mermista nearly electrocuted Seahawk.

From the sidelines, Bow knocked another arrow, asking. “What do we do?”

“We should run.” Catra said immediately.

“Catra!” Glimmer said, obviously worried.

“What? They’ll be fine.” Catra frowned. Glimmer looked very unconvinced. “They took the risk.” She appended.

Glimmer looked at Adora, who gritted her teeth as the fight continued. She nodded. “Let’s go.”

They started to back up, not taking their eyes off the fight. Five steps back, the changeling’s eyes snapped over to them. They grabbed Seahawk around the chest, slamming his back against the wall and dropping him. “Where do you think you’re going!?” They asked the teens, moving towards them.

“I said, stay put!” Mermista stepped in between. She swept her prod in front of her, the electric tip crackling. She got a tail in the side for that, knocking her to the ground as well.

The changeling made it three steps before stumbling to the ground and splatting out like ink.

“Haha!” Seahawk bellowed out a laugh from where he had tripped the alien. Diving atop them and throwing body blows down, returning to verse.

“Up jumps the eel with his slippery tail!
Climbs up aloft and reefs the topsail!
For it’s windy weather, boys, stormy weather, boys!”
Blow ye winds westerly, blow ye winds, *blowww*!” His voice jumped up an octave he was catapulted off by a pillar of flesh that was the changeling standing again. He landed near the teen’s feet.

“Stop singing and fight!” Mermista growled as she stumbled to her own feet. The changeling was now on the far side of Mermista and Seahawk

“I’m doing both, dearest!” Seahawk answered, and they dogpiled the changeling.

Adora saw their chance. “Run.” She called.

They spun and charged down the hallway, which ended in a pair of double doors. Slamming against them, they pushed and pulled. Locked, again.

“Catra!” Glimmer shouted to her.

Catra pushed Adora aside and watched in surprise as she morphed one fingertip of her suit into a key shape and stuck it into the lock.

There was a scream behind them. Adora turned to see Seahawk slam into a wall again, this time with red gashes torn into the stomach of his shirt.

“Catra!” Glimmer repeated much more panicked.

“I’m working on it!” Catra insisted, fiddling quickly.

The changeling turned on Mermista, whose eyes flicked over to Seahawk, who wasn’t getting up. Locking eyes with the alien, she let out what Adora could only describe as a battle cry, got to her feet, and ran for the changeling. It struck for her with one arm, but she ducked beneath and closed the distance, slamming the tip of the prod into the changeling. It elicited an instant reaction. The changeling convulsed and jerked. A sweep of a hand turned into talons was dodged by Mermista with a feint. She stabbed again. The changeling jerked again, and, amazingly, disengaged. It backed off beyond her reach, and slowly began to circle, prowling.

Mermista panted heavily, sparing a second to glance at the kids.

“Got it!” Catra declared that same instant and swung the doors open. They were immediately assaulted by blasting music.

The party – Adora realized she had forgotten about the party - was in full swing. Club covers of Christmas music pounded over red and green flashing lights. Bodies crowded the large packed room. Adora's eyes went wide as they slammed the door behind them and relocked it. The crowd was mostly young and drunk. Girls danced in skimpy tops, pressing against their friends and partners. Adora felt heat buildup under her collar. The smell of sweat and booze hung thick in the air, humid and hot from what had to be a couple hundred people.

"Jesus." Adora said, but her voice was stolen by the music. She looked at her friends. In their thick coats and with Bow's archery equipment, they didn't exactly fit in. They looked back at her.

Bow waved to grab all their eyes, then pointed along the wall where it was slightly less dense. They nodded and began to follow him as they skirted the edge of the party, looking for another exit.

But then the music changed. Adora instantly recognized the next song, as did the entire party. Cheers and groans went up in unison as Mariah Carey's *All I Want for Christmas is You* began to blast.

The crowd surged, and Adora was suddenly cut off from the others. As the first lyrics began to play, she found herself in the thick of the crowd, alone. "You all seem to know this one!" A voice hollered over the din. Adora looked up to see the DJ on a raised stage. He was young but wearing a full Santa beard on his face. "Everybody, sing along!"

The party cheered and began to drunkenly join in.

"I don't want a lot for Christmas
There is just one thing I need
I don't care about the presents,
underneath the Christmas tree"

Adora was pushed and shoved, blushing and panicking as she felt a hundred dancing bodies along her own. Some people shoved

her away when she bumped into her, others gave her strange looks or grabbed her hand and smiled at her. She found herself dancing with a boy a good ten years older than her. Adora managed to push him away and fell back into the throng. She grabbed at her ponytail, teeth clenched.

"Catra!" She shouted as loud as she could. "Glimmer! Bow!?"

"I just want you for my own
More than you could ever know
Make my wish come true"

A grip on her shoulder stopped her panicked spinning. Catra turned her around, a serious war face on despite the upbeat music. Adora smiled in relief.

"All I want for Christmas is you!" The crowd screamed and pushed Catra and Adora together. They crashed against one another; bodies front to front. Too Adora's shock, Catra pulled her into a fast-tempo dance, swaying Adora with the beat. She blushed fiercely, and Catra noticed, winking and suddenly twirling her over her head. When Adora was pulled back in, her hand found Catra's waist, and they skipped along to the tune, nearly bumping the people around her. Catra's feet landed expertly with every step, never missing a beat.

"What are . . . what are you doing!?" Adora managed to shout over the music.

Catra leaned in close to her ear. "Stick close. We gotta blend in." She said as goosebumps ran up Adora's arm. "They're in here by now." Adora's eyes widened. Catra smiled at her again, and said, "Try to keep up." Turning Adora around and pulling her back into her chest. Adora's was already overheating, this was going to make her explode. The stepped apart, then back together, and Adora was dipped, held with her strong arms. The disco ball swirled overhead, casting red and green beams through the air above her bright mismatched eyes, confident and smiling.

"Oh-oh, all the lights are shining so brightly everywhere
And the sound of children's laughter fills the air
And everyone is singing
I hear those sleigh bells ringing
Santa, won't you bring me the one I really need?
Won't you please bring my baby to me?"

"I . . . I didn't know you could dance!" Adora said, surprised at how easy it was to tango with her.

Catra rolled her eyes and smiled. "It's not that hard."

With a look like that, Adora believed everything would be okay. Her eyes glanced down to Catra's lips, so close. She thought about what Bow had said.

"**Get away from my Adora.**" A voice snarled. Adora looked over her shoulder to see . . . Catra, glowering at Catra . . . the Catra she was dancing with. She barely got to look back at them before the new Catra tackled them off, with nothing less than a roar leaping from her throat.

The shoulder Adora had dislocated was wrenched hard as they were pulled off, and she bit back a scream and clutched at it, stumbling back into other dancers as she watched the two identical Catra's roll on the ground, slamming their fists into each other and clawing. People screamed. The Catras hissed. Adora stared at the sudden violence, frozen, only one thing on her mind.

My Adora?

Bow managed to keep next to Glimmer by hooking an arm around her waist. He kept an elbow up as he pressed through the crowd, looking for Adora or Catra. "Damnit!" He had no idea when they had been separated.

“We won’t find them like this!” Glimmer shouted. “Put me on your shoulders!”

“What?”

“Do it!”

Bow crouched, and Glimmer stepped up, legs around his neck. Bow stood, turning slowly so she could scan. “There!” Glimmer tapped and pointed. “I see Adora!” Bow couldn’t through the madness, but he trusted her.

“We’ll never get to her like this.” He knew.

There was a slam behind them, and Bow turned to see the door they had come through open and close quickly. Someone chasing them was inside. Whether it was human or alien he didn’t know. “We need to stop the party!” He shouted.

“The DJ!” Glimmer pointed.

Forging ahead, they made their way to the raised stage where the DJ was set up. His eyes found them, obvious with Glimmer on his shoulders, then went wide as Bow let her step off up next to him.

“Whoa, hey! You can’t be here!” They said as Bow hauled himself up after. He rose to see Glimmer trying to reach the turntable, but being held back by the man in a white Santa Beard. People were screaming Christmas tunes all around them.

He couldn’t believe this was happening. Bow ran forward and grappled the DJ, pushing them off Glimmer. “Go!” He said to her, focused on fending off his hands. Glimmer ran to their setup. A second later, the music cut out.

Shouts called out, and the singing drunkenly died off. Bow turned to watch everyone stopping their dancing, angry or confused, and looking up towards the DJ stand.

“There!" He shouted to Glimmer, pointing to a growing circle in the crowd, where two identical Catras were fighting. At the edge, Adora was watching with wide eyes.

Glimmer grabbed the microphone from the table and called into it. “Adora, the lens!”

Adora looked up from beside the fight, saw the pair of them, and didn’t hesitate.

“Close your eyes Glimmer!” Bow shouted as Adora pulled out the lens and hurled it across the room.

It was an easy catch. After all, he couldn’t keep his eyes off the tube as it spun through the air. Snatching it from the air, he thrust it aloft.

“Hey everybody!” Glimmer called into the loudspeakers. “Get a load of this!”

The hall fell into silence and the sound of flying fists.

Adora turned away the moment she threw the lens, only knowing she had thrown it well when everyone around her froze, still and silent. All save for two.

She watched the brawl on the floor below her, two identical Catras. Punches were thrown, claws were out. The Catra on top yowled and swiped her claws across the other’s face.

The Catra underneath responded by grabbing the other’s wrists and twisting. With a hiss, they were forced off. The top Catra landed on her hands and feet, glaring. The other Catra stood, snarled out, “You bitch.” They both crashed to the floor again. “Adora!” One shouted. “Adora! Help!”

“No!” The other Catra yelled. “Don’t listen to them!”

Adora’s eyes flitted between them. This was way too cliché. She searched the pair, looking for any distinction between the two.

A collective flinch passed through the crowd, and as they became unstuck Bow and Glimmer appeared beside her. “I didn’t want to say one of us would end up fighting ourselves, because I knew it would jinx it,” Bow said as the Catras ran for one another again, trading blink-and-miss blows. “and I know this is bad, but you gotta admit, it’s pretty cool too.”

“Bow!” Adora glared at him, sounds feeling muffled with the sudden absence of music. She looked back at the fight before her, taking a poised stance, trying to determine which Catra was real. The Catra currently on top was trying to choke the one underneath.

“Guys!” The bottom one managed to gasp out, more desperately this time. “Could really use some help here!” Adora twitched, stopping herself from running in.

“Keep your mouth shut!” The top one said back, pulling one of her legs forward to pin the other’s arm to the floor.

The freed crowd was now paying attention to the scuffle, trading whispers.

“Are they sisters?”

“Man, they must hate each other.”

“You think they’re high?”

“Why do they look so hairy?”

“Are they furries?”

“C’mon, Adora.” The bottom one grunted. “You . . .” They coughed. “You know me.”

“Should we pull them apart?” Bow and Glimmer asked at the same time.

“No.” Adora replied. That would leave whoever was unlucky at the changeling’s mercy. One shapeshifted spike out their back and you were done. Adora watched closely.

The top Catra looked at Adora quickly, eyes pleading. She got a kick to the face for taking her eyes off her opponent. “Gah!” They wrestled the leg away, pinning it back beneath them and commenting. “Your species is so funny about personal space!”

Adora blinked. Why would they say that? Your species is so funny about personal space. Catra had said that when they shared a bed in Snowville. When they shared a bed in Snowville! Adora ran in, and without hesitating, kicked the lower Catra in the head, hard. Instantly, she stopped fighting back, and slumped to the floor, unconscious.

The top Catra leaned back in the relief, still straddling the duplicate. “Stars . . . thanks Adora.”

Adora nodded, lowering their hand to help them up. “Well, the changeling was right about one thing, I do know you.” The crowd stared in utter confusion. Adora pulled Catra up from the floor. “You alright?”

“Hey, I’ve been in street fights before, don’t sweat it.” Catra said, wiping her cheek where a claw had grazed, and leaving a green streak. Adora’s eyes widened, and Catra stared at her. “What?” They glanced at the back of their hand, seeing the mark. “Drat.”

“AAUGH!” Catra, the real Catra, awake and angry and dripping scarlet blood from her knuckles, leapt past Adora and struck the changeling in the face with her fist, causing them to stumble back and disappear into the gasping crowd. Rubbing her fist, she said. “Damn Adora, you got a mean kick.” Adora realized she had just kicked the real Catra in the head so hard she very well might have given her a concussion, and went pale as a sheet. Catra sighed.

“Come on Adora, don’t you get emotional on me now. It’s fine. It’s good.”

Adora didn’t feel that way but forced herself to focus, the crowd was still staring at all of them with wide eyes, and they didn’t know where the changeling was. Adora watched where the alien had gone into the crowd, scanning heads for anything suspicious. Nothing immediately happened. Now they just needed to-

“Hey!” A hard voice cut over the crowd. From the opposite direction to where the changeling had gone, Mermista shoved someone aside. Adora turned to run, but Mermista clapped a terrifyingly strong hand down on her and Catra’s shoulders.

“Nope.” She assured. “This way.” With a shove, she was moved roughly towards an exit door.

“Wha-” Glimmer blinked.

“All of you.” She glared at Bow and Catra.

“But!” Glimmer said, panicked. “They’re . . . we’re!”

“Move it!” She shoved Adora and Catra forward. Adora tried to resist; she should have resisted harder! But she was exhausted, and her shoulder was screaming in pain. At least, hell, **at absolute least**, Mermista wasn’t the changeling.

The suit led the four of them out of the party, down a flight of stairs, and out an emergency exit into the cold. It was a dark alley beside the hotel, full of dumpsters and random trash.

Adora nearly fell, catching herself on the far wall of the narrow space. She glared back over her shoulder, watching Mermista as the door closed behind her. “Sorry kids, just doing my job.” She said to them. The door latched. Adora noticed there was no handle on the outside. Wait. “Which is a lot easier when you’re all just so gullible.” Mermista’s suit flashed to green and black and they grew tall and slender.

“You.” Bow gasped.

“Me.” The changeling agreed, then attacked. Bow stumbled back, trying to get his bow, but only managed to get it up to his neck before the changeling slipped behind him and grabbed the handle, yanking the string into his throat. Coughing, Bow was dragged along as he ran over to Glimmer, arm stretching towards them.

Adora hated this. She hated hated hated this bastard tricking her again. Adrenaline rallied her. She looked down and saw a metal pipe laying there. “Get away!” She picked it up and swung. Their arm was battered away from Glimmer. Glimmer backed out of reach. She swung up at the other arm. It helped Bow get his weapon off his neck. He coughed as he also backed up.

The changeling’s eyes locked on her. The first arm came back with lightning speed. Its fingers were talons.

Catra grabbed her coat and yanked her backwards just in time. She looked pissed. “Bow. Arrow. Now.”

Bow pulled one from his quiver, tossing it to her. She clasped it in her hand and stalked towards them. “I’m done with this.” She rumbled at the changeling. “I am not letting you hurt them anymore.”

The changeling chuckled. “Are you now?”

Catra stepped forward. “You and me.” She demanded.

“Catra!” Adora gasped.

Catra didn’t look back. “You, and me.” She repeated.

The changeling started at her for a long moment. “Very well.”

They slowly started to circle one another in the narrow space. Bow, Glimmer, and Adora all backed off, huddling close together in the direction of the exit to the alley. Police lights flashed down there. It was a way out, but not a good one.

Catra twirled the arrow in her hands, swiping at the changeling if they came too close. The changeling laughed at that. They were still holding Bow's bow in one of their hands. Using it as a cudgel when they attacked, swiping at Catra.

The speed slowly rose. Hits came faster, harder. Catra got the changeling in the side, leaving a green cut. Catra was hit in the head. the swipe ripping the hat off her head. Her ears sprung up as it fluttered to the ground, promptly stomped by fighting feet.

Adora watched the bout with barely cognizant dread. Her body burned. Her head throbbed. Catra was defending her. She should do something, because as time passed, Catra began to slow, and the Changeling gained the upper hand. Adora needed to do something!

Catra was attacked with the bow. She grabbed the upper limb and yanked. It clattered to the ground, just in time for the alien's real attack with a second set of formed arms to hand. "You are such an amateur!" They called gleefully, as Catra was struck.

Catra rumbled, reposting with a slash.

The changeling dodged. "Missed me!" They lilted.

"Shut up." Catra growled.

"Why should I? You can't make me." They replied with a blow to Catra's shoulder.

"Augh!" Catra twisted. She threw two punches back. "Shut! Up!"

"Seriously, pah-tehh-tic." They continued to mock, shifting to dodge each. "Who even taught you?"

Catra lunged for them. They bent back, but it was a trick. Catra swept one of the changeling's legs off the ground. But their other leg simply bent like a rubber hose. They nearly touched their back to the ground before springing forward again, catching Catra in the stomach. Catra staggered back, wheezing.

“No no, don’t say anything, let me guess” The changeling smirked, tapping a finger to their chin. “No one did!” They called with a huge bright smile full of faux realization.

“Shut up.” Catra growled, but she didn’t lunge again. She stood there, looking hurt.

“Catra.” Adora called as loudly as she dared. They needed to run.

“You’re just a worthless little street rat, aren’t you?” The alien accused.

“Shut up!” Catra closed her fist.

“Learned those punches beating up on other little lost cubs?” They continued. “I should have known, with your name being that.”

“Stop!” Catra roared, blinking fast.

“You’re just a miserable little runt. One your family never even-”

Catra screamed so loud the noise shook Adora’s chest. Catra was instantly across the alley and slamming the changeling into the far wall. Blows fell like drumbeats, and through the pounding she ranted. “Is this what you wanted!?” Bam! “To make me mad!” Bam! “It’s what you’ve been asking for, right!?” Bam! “Well, you finally got it!” Bam! “You finally got a fucking rise out of me!” The changeling got one in the face. “Just like you’ve always wanted to on-” Bam! “EVERY!” Bam! “FUCKING!” Bam! “MISSION!”

Everyone froze. Catra threw another massive swing, but this time the changeling caught it, holding her fist between them. Then, they didn’t take advantage of the opening it provided.

Catra didn't notice it at first and threw a punch with her other free arm. This connected, but again, the changeling didn’t react. Catra roared and went in for another hit, but stayed it when she realized they weren’t fighting back. “What are you doing!?” She demanded.

"Aww, kitten." The Shapeshifter cooed. "You broke character. And it was getting so good!"

“I-” Catra, heaving out breaths, stared at the changeling’s eyes. Then, slowly, she turned and looked at Adora.

Adora knew the confusion was plain on her face. The emotions on Catra’s flickered rapid fire, settling on something like panic. She suddenly reared back and went to punch the Changeling again, who this time easily dodged.

Adora’s heart was hammering as her head was trying to catch up with what had just changed. Catra wasn’t acting like she was supposed to. The Changeling wasn’t reacting like they were supposed to. “Broke character?” She whispered as the Changeling melted out of Catra’s hands like liquid, reforming again a few feet away.

“Well, it was fun while it lasted.” They sighed, dusting their hands off. “I’ll be taking this.” A shadowy appendage lifted up off the ground, the lens in their hands.

“Wha- hey!” Bow slapped his jacket pocket, but the changeling had snuck it out while they were all distracted. They slipped into their liquid body with a flash of black and green.

The changeling looked at Catra. “I’ll be here when you’re ready to come up with a new plan, Force Captain.” Then with a look into the humans’ eyes that Adora couldn’t quite place, they shapeshifted into a large crow and flew off into the dark sky above the neon lights.

The alley turned quiet. The four of them stood in the dark. “Catra?” Adora asked, carefully watching the alien. “What just happened?” Catra didn’t say anything. “Catra?” Adora repeated. “What was that?”

“Adora.” Catra’s glowing eyes were shaking. Adora stared at her for several seconds, running the end of the fight through her head

again. Over and over. Each time her eyes went wider. ‘Always wanted.’ ‘Every mission.’ ‘Broke character.’

“What did they mean?” Adora asked.

Catra took a step towards her. “Adora I- I don’t know why they were saying that!” She cried. “I told you, they’re desperate. They must be trying to drive us apart again!”

Adora heard the click of Bow fitting an arrow onto his retrieved weapon, down but at the ready. “Don’t-” He coughed. “Don’t lie to us, Catra.”

Catra looked at him, then his weapon, betrayal and anguish plain. “Adora, please.” She begged to her. Adora felt the hair on her arms rise in goosebumps. Catra had never said please to her before. Never begged for anything. Even when she knew Adora was her only way home. When Catra had been . . . all alone . . .

Adora swallowed, voice quavering when she demanded. “Answer the question, Catra.”

“I-” Catra looked around. “Guys, come on, you know me.”

“Answer the question, Catra!” Glimmer suddenly shouted, her voice echoing off the stone walls. “Who are you!? Who is that shapeshifter!? What did they mean ‘break character’!?”

“It’s not what you think.” Catra said.

Glimmer took a breath, shaking her head. “You’re lying.” She stepped forward. “You’ve been lying to us, haven’t you? This whole time!”

“It’s not what you think.” Catra repeated.

“They explain it to us.” Bow urged. “Help us understand.”

“You wouldn’t.” Catra said.

“OH, WE WOULDN’T? WE WOULDN’T UNDERSTAND!?” Glimmer roared. Wow, she was furious. Adora didn’t think she had ever heard her that mad. “WE WHO PUT ASIDE EVERYTHING TO HELP YOU!”

Catra scowled, looking down at the garbage in the alley, and when she spoke her voice was low and bitter. “Come on Adora, we should split up, your sister’s too hysterical, she’ll be noticed.”

Adora stepped between Catra and Glimmer, and with a voice darker than she ever thought she could make said, “You **do not** talk about my sister like that.” Catra flinched as if she’d been struck. “. . . Tell me the truth, Catra.”

Adora saw the moment Catra’s fear turned into anger, and suddenly she was yelling too. “Oh! So, the moment that lizard says something suspicious you don’t believe me anymore!? Everything we’ve been through is suddenly worthless!?”

“NO!” Adora shouted right back. “I’m listening to what YOU said! You said, ‘always wanted’! You said, ‘every mission’!”

“When I was fighting for my life!? You believe every little grunt that comes out of my mouth then!?”

“Yeah, because you’ve always been so loose-lipped before!” Adora lifted her arms up, incredulous. Catra chuffed, looking away. Adora’s dread fueled her anger. Why was she hesitating!? Why wasn’t she denying it? “Come on Catra! C’mon! I know you’re not . . .” She exhaled, entire body shaking. “Just answer the question! Please. Why did you say that?”

Catra suddenly wheeled on her, shouting, fangs flashing, spittle flying into her face. “It’s complicated, okay!?”

“So is everything with this! Has that stopped me before!?”

There was a long pause, Adora’s voice fading slowly. A police car drove past the end of the alley, blue and red sweeping over them

and making their shadows run across the walls. “No.” Catra admitted.

“Then answer the question, Catra!” Adora demanded. Catra said nothing, so she repeated, louder. “**Answer the question!**” Catra still said nothing, her face a perfect mask. “**ANSWER THE GODDAMNED QUES-**”

"**YOU WANT TO KNOW THE TRUTH, ADORA!?**" Catra broke, snarling at her.

"**AFTER EVERYTHING I'VE SACRIFICED FOR YOU!? YEAH! I THINK I DESERVE THE TRUTH!**"

"**FINE! I'M A SPY, ADORA! THERE! HAPPY!?**"

Adora’s anger was swallowed by shock, and silence returned to the alley.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None

Chapter 14: Nine Lives

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two Days Ago: December 22nd

"Where are you going?" Adora asked as Catra put on her coat, kicking the anti-roach towel out from under the door of their Snowville motel room.

"Just . . . outside. I need to get some air for a minute." Catra lied, praying Adora couldn't hear the tension in her voice.

"Oh. Okay." The human seemed skeptical.

"I'll be careful." She assured.

"I know." Adora replied, and Catra stepped out into the night, making sure the door was shut behind her.

The stars overhead burned in a crystal-clear black sky, one which allowed all the heat of the day to escape. It was awful how cold it was. Catra could hardly believe anyone lived in this climate for an extended period. With the mountains no longer shielding them, the sharp prairie wind roared, turning the snowy landscape into an icy sandblaster. She felt woefully underdressed, even in coat, hat, and gloves. She tucked her head further into her neck and looked left and right down the L-shaped building. Along the other leg, above a blank section of wall, there was a flickering amber light.

There was nothing below it. It clicked off. When it came back on, two eyes were watching her from out of the bricks. Another flicker and a slender figure stood in the orange pool it cast, waiting.

Catra approached quickly, moving her muscles to try and work some heat into them. This would have to be quick for multiple

reasons. She checked for eavesdroppers, then looked over her shoulder to make sure Adora wouldn’t be able to see them from out their window.

“There you are.” The figure before her cooed. "Was beginning to think you were going to leave me out in the cold."

"You don't seem to mind that much," Catra grumbled. “Double Trouble." Of all the people to get assigned to this with her. Why did it have to be them . . . again?

"Kitten." They greeted. It really was surprising they didn't seem to mind the weather. Their too-tall reptilian body – which was as close to a natural shape as Catra had ever seen them take - would radiate heat like nobody's business. Long pointed ears listened for any approaching threats, and lurid yellow eyes looked down at her with a mirth that didn't feel well placed, considering their circumstances. They blinked with horizontal eyelids.

"Don't call me that." Catra said for the umpteenth time. Double Trouble just smiled. "Let's get this over with. Adora is still awake."

"Very well." Double Trouble reached into their body and pulled out a thumb-sized device. Damn, she wished they had been issued their own radio.

"Earth report four." Catra began, speaking to the device and Double Trouble. "Night five. I've left the landing site with the primary local contact after she determined that she would be willing to help me return us to the Fright Zone and complete the mission. Radio was . . . left behind, unsalvageable. Only remaining resources are local barter materials and Adora." Double Trouble looked at them poignantly. “And the damaged radio lens.” She added.

"And you believe you can trust Adora?"

"Completely. I've even gotten her to leave her family unit without their permission." Catra tried to smile with her teeth like she always did, but it didn't come out right. “Conservative estimated

time to arrival at a capable communications array is two days. Will link up with a relative of Adora and try and contact the Fight Zone. Rapport with Adora is increasing quickly. She trusts me. She'll tell me everything we need to know."

"Good." Double Trouble said. "Be sure to continue to gain information on culture and defenses. As we get closer to the array, I will want to see what I can sneak into."

"Understood." Catra replied. "End of report."

Double Trouble returned the recording device to within the safety of their own body. “Well, that’s all I need. You should get back to your girlfriend before she comes after you.” Catra scowled. “Quite the hero that one.” They glanced at Catra, then checked their fingernails. “Tell me, how are you going to spin that all-day joyride with her to Shadow Weaver?”

“Trust building.” Catra said, ears flattening.

Double Trouble laughed. “Ah, of course . . . that’s good. It’s lucky for you that that woman knows nothing about friendship.”

Despite the truth in that statement, Catra was well past impatient and knew it was time to head back to the room. But first, “Must be awful, having to spend all this time where you can’t hear the sound of your own voice. Tell me, did the dead animal heads in the cabin make for good conversation when we were gone?”

“Sadly not.” Double Trouble sighed. “You, on the other hand, don’t seem to be having any trouble with the wildlife.” Catra didn’t take that bait. “Come on, Kitten; you know what’s going to happen. What will Blondie over there think of you when she finds out why you're really here?"

She couldn’t stop herself from biting. "I'm doing what I have to do."

Double Trouble looked her up and down, one clawed finger on their cheek. "Indeed. Still, how tragic. I can picture those sad blue

eyes right now." They mused, then started to change. Catra's scowl consumed her entire face as Double Trouble morphed into Adora, dressed in the pajamas that she had just seen her in. "Maybe something like this?" Not-Adora mused, then set her face in a haunted, betrayed expression. "Catra, no . . . that's not true, is it? How could you lie to me like this!?"

"Get out of here."

"What?"

Catra slammed Double Trouble against the wall. "Leave!" She snarled, pinning them in place. "You have my report."

Double Trouble looked panicked for a second, then just laughed. The laugh had Adora's voice, but it was derisive, mocking. It didn't sound like her. Flickering to black, they melted right out of Catra's hands, appearing at her side back to 'normal'. "Meow. Alright alright. I'll get out of your fur." They dusted off their shoulders. "You really like this one, huh?"

Catra just hissed.

"Ohoho." Double Trouble blinked at her, Cheshire smile wide and full of pointed teeth.

A rumble rose from Catra's throat. "You're lighter than I thought. I'm surprised, I heard you were tough."

Their voice dropped from fun to serious. "Remember Kitten, this one is going to end just like the others." Catra's eyes dilated, and the hair on her neck raised. Seemingly satisfied, Double Trouble parted with, "I'll be watching." and turned to walk off. Catra heard their footsteps clacking against the asphalt for ten paces, then they transformed again. She was smart enough to watch them become one of the local birds, the big black ones with the ugly cries, and fly off into the windy night.

Two Days Later: December 24th

For a long beat, no one in the alley moved. Everyone stared at Catra. Adora felt sick. When she finally was able to speak, it was only a single croaking word. "What?"

"I'm a forward scout for The Horde.” Catra said. Her anger was snuffed away, voice now cold and distant. “The Fright Zone, it’s not a science vessel. It’s a scout ship.”

“But . . . you crashed. There was an accident. You, you can’t be a-” Adora tried. Catra cut her off.

“No. There was no accident. I was sent here on purpose. The valley I landed in was chosen beforehand.”

Bow recovered from this revelation first, lifting his weapon an inch. “Explain, concisely.”

Catra looked at the arrow tip, silver in the dark, then nodded. “My job aboard my ship is . . . this. Being sent down to uncontacted planets. We intercept local transmissions, learn all we can, then send two people down to see everything firsthand. I befriend members of the local population and gather information on the planet, the people, the culture."

"Why?" Bow asked, mood inscrutable.

"So that when The Horde arrives, they have all the information they need to subdue the planet and add its resources to The Rebellion."

"Subdue." Glimmer repeated. "You mean invade."

"If the planet's governments don’t cooperate? Yes."

“This is your job . . .” Adora whispered. Her job was to befriend people. Befriend her. “You've done this before?" She paled. Catra nodded grimly. "How many times?" Silence. "How many times Catra!?"

"Three times." She muttered.

"And what happened to those planets?" Bow asked.

"Two joined The Horde without a fight." She recalled. "One didn't. It took them three weeks to surrender. The bombs fell on the holdouts for a while longer."

"And the changeling?" Glimmer asked, voice venomous. "They're not with Horde Prime?"

"No, the Changeling - Double Trouble" Catra named them. "they were in the pod with me. My job is to understand the average person. Double Trouble sneaks into the places those average people can't go: military installations, government buildings, computer network hubs."

It was all a lie. Everything. It was as if the ground Adora had been standing on had turned to quicksand. Everything about the last few days, every instinct she had trusted, every goal on the horizon she had followed, had been a mirage.

"I can't believe it." Glimmer muttered under her breath. "I can't believe you got me to trust you. After the painting and everything else."

Catra's ears lifted. "Painting?"

"Yeah! When you waxed poetic about the duck painting in the cabin. Went all 'all species are savage in the end.'

Catra looked down, thinking. "That wasn't me."

Adora blinked, and realized the implication, shuddering. "They were in the cabin. With us the whole time . . . How did it get in?"

"Because I let them in."

Adora's legs wobbled, and Glimmer walked up, steadying her. "You've . . ." Her shock and confusion were changing now, burning down into anger. She managed to reply, her voice quickly rising to

a yell. “You’ve been . . . it was all a lie!?” She jabbed a finger at Catra, who winced with every word.

I trusted you! You let that thing into my family’s home. You let them into our home and I trusted you!” She was crying now, and had to take a second and wipe her eyes, voice coming down to a horrified breathy laugh. “You've been leading us on a wild goose chase this whole time . . .”

“Adora, no.” Catra tried to walk forward again by was stopped by a hard look from Bow. “It’s not all like that. It was supposed to look like a crash, but something went wrong. I wasn’t supposed to be unconscious. The radio shouldn’t have been broken. I should have been able to contact my . . . superiors from my pod.” When Adora didn’t say anything, she continued, talking fast. “But it's different now!" Catra begged. "I met you. You showed me this place. Your friends! Your world. It's . . ." Adora tilted her head back to keep the tears from running down her face, and because she couldn’t even look at Catra. "Why would I tell you all this!?" Catra screamed. "I'm not supposed to tell any of you this! About being a soldier, about being a spy! You have to believe me! Please! Look at me, Adora! Please!" Adora shuddered, then lowered her gaze. But this time it was not full of kindness and curiosity, shining blue skies. It was hard, razor-sharp like ice. Twin bolts of electric blue lightning which roared and stripped Catra's heart bare before her, and found it wanting.

Adora stared her down. “Was any of it real?”

“Adora . . .” Whatever words were in Catra’s throat died and shriveled as their eyes remained locked for several seconds. Then Adora sloughed off Glimmer’s hand, turned around, and marched out of the alley.

Adora didn’t know where she was going. She just had to move. She walked down the strip, slipping past the cops, past neon monuments, past flashing billboards, past the very few people out

on the wee hours of Christmas eve until her legs burned and her tears stained lines on her cheeks.

Her phone kept ringing in her pocket. She ignored it as long as she could, but eventually grew so frustrated she growled and snapped it to her ear. “What!?”

“Adora.” Glimmer said on the other side softly. “You okay?”

Adora’s anger evaporated. “Glim?”

“Yeah.” Glimmer said, then waited for an answer. But Adora wasn’t thinking about that.

“Where’s . . . where’s Catra?”

“She ran, Adora.” Glimmer said, frustration in her voice. “We tried to keep her there but she just ran, literally jumped over our heads.”

Adora shut her eyes. “I’m so sorry Glimmer. I’m an idiot.”

“I know.” Glimmer said, and Adora could see that tiny smile on her face through the phone. “But we are too. She convinced me.” Glimmer took a deep breath. “How could she do that, Adora!?”

Adora had been trying not to think about it, but now was forced to. “I don’t know.”

The Earth was going to be invaded. The Earth was going to be invaded and crushed like a bug by a power beyond man’s imagination. Worse, they were being invaded to help supply a war. The Rebellion was coming for materials, food . . . soldiers.

A new fear coiled around Adora’s throat like a snake. Soldiers like Catra. Soldiers like one she might become.

Why? Why would Catra do this? To innocent people living on primitive worlds. She had thought she was a good person, despite all her quirks. Adora hadn’t believed Catra was capable of

anything like this. Was she so wrong? She had to be, right, if Catra had let that psychopathic shapeshifter into their home. "Adora?" Glimmer broke the silence.

"I don't know Glimmer . . ." Adora repeated. "It just doesn't make any sense. I thought . . . and the Shapeshifter:" What had Catra called them? "Double Trouble. They . . . work together, but it was attacking us . . . including Catra."

"I know." Glimmer echoed.

Why was Double Trouble fighting them? Why would they attack them when they knew Catra, when they could have just introduced themselves as another crashed crewmate? That didn't make sense. Adora thought back, her brain just needing something to focus on. Something to figure out.

They had first attacked . . . after Zion. But they had been around the whole time. So why attack them then, not sooner or later? Because they were spending hours not trying to get to Goldstone? Wasting time? That seemed reasonable. Double Trouble needed them to contact their ship as much as Catra did.

So maybe they weren't attacking to steal the lens? If Catra was telling the truth about the crash and the broken radio, then the lens was truly worthless. Another lie. If Double Trouble was trying to drive them forward, it also made sense why they had come back once the car broke down. And during their fights, with abilities to change shape so dramatically, it was obvious that the changeling was insanely skilled. Taking hits from Glimmer with a shower rod then backing off with a villainous monologue seemed . . . beneath them. Unless they were throwing the fight. But why throw the fight?

"I'm not supposed to be telling you any of this . . ." Adora muttered.

"What?" Glimmer was still on the line.

"Catra said she wasn't supposed to tell us what she just told us." That made sense. Catra was a spy, she couldn't just reveal the master plan, lest the planet get wind of an invasion before it happened. "Why would she tell us?"

"Who knows?" Glimmer dismissed bitterly. "She hasn't told us an honest thing since the start."

"That's not true." Adora knew immediately. Some of Catra's stories had been true. The soldier story especially stood out. Catra had actually been one. Adora wasn't exactly trusting in her instincts at the moment, but she knew that one was true. Also, the way Catra had reacted when Adora asked if any of it was real. She had been so mad but Catra had looked hurt by that suggestion. Maybe, just maybe, some of it had been real.

Why tell them the plan? Why fight back against Double Trouble? When they had attacked them, Catra hadn't looked confused, just mad. When they were fighting, Catra had been **pissed**.

Something went wrong.

Had the changeling been going off script? If so, why? If they were allies, why attack Catra without warning her beforehand? And why, when they did, did Catra not seem to be too surprised to be betrayed? Unless Catra was a stunningly good actor (her stories and general grumpiness were evidence in Adora's mind against this) The only reasonable explanation seemed to be that the changeling felt like they had to, and Catra understood why. Double Trouble felt like they had to drive them all forward, towards contacting the ship, completing the mission. Had to because Catra might not.

I'm not supposed to tell you this.

It's different now.

Please, Adora.

When the realization overcame Adora her chest shook, and she asked Glimmer. “Did you see which way Catra went?”

“South.” Glimmer said. The same way Adora had gone. She stopped, turning around and scanning the crowd. “Adora?”

Adora started to run. Glimmer heard the sudden labored breathing and clap of her boots on the sidewalk. “Adora, what’s going on?”

Adora opened her mouth to tell Glimmer she was going to call her back, then stopped herself. She had been about to do it again. She had promised Glimmer she wouldn’t do it again.

Adora had a second, even better idea. “Alright Glimmer,” She began. “I have a plan, and you’re going to hate it.”

Her sister groaned and Adora couldn’t help it, she laughed. “Please, Adora, no.” Glimmer begged, but Adora could tell she could convince her.

“I know, I know.” Adora admitted. She explained her plan. It was stupid, and irrational, and Adora realized that it hinged on a stupid, very likely irrational hope. But she apparently dealt in stupid irrational hopes now, and despite Glimmer’s skepticism, and Adora’s guts warning her that she should never trust Catra again, she ran regardless.

Her sister, then Bow, with some input from them, agreed to the plan, at least for the moment.

That would be enough. With the Best Friend’s Squad together, no alien invasion stood a chance.

Catra’s mind was just indiscriminate noise. Thoughts stood as distractions. Inertia was her fuel. She walked down the nearly abandoned strip. People looked at her ears as she passed. She let them look.

This was always the worst part. After the truth came out.

“Hey.” A voice at her shoulder said, and Catra jumped, looking over to see a well-dressed human man walking beside her. They were thin, tall, and had blue hair that fell like a wave over one side of their head.

“Double Trouble.” Catra snarled.

“You recognized me.” They said, bemused. From nowhere they then handed her the lens.

“I know you.” Catra pocked the lens angrily. “You said you would wait until I was ready.”

“You’re not?” Double Trouble smiled happily.

“You’re an idiot!” Catra turned and jabbed them in the chest. "What were you thinking!? You’ve ruined everything!"

Double Trouble rolled their eyes. “Oh, come on. I just trying to keep the pressure on, Kitten. Can't have you getting too comfortable playing hooky with Blondie and her crew. We’ve got a job to do . . . unless you’ve forgotten.”

Catra scowled darkly and pressed down her feelings. “I haven’t.” She said coldly. “But you just cost us my . . . contacts. How the hell are we supposed to cross hundreds of miles of desert with no transport!?”

“Ye of little faith.” Double Trouble pressed a hand to their chest, mocking offense. “As always Catra, I am here as nothing but your humble ally, and as such can provide a solution.”

“Even with your powers, it’s a wonder how good you are at kissing your own ass.” Catra muttered.

Double Trouble tisked. “So mean. It’s true Shadow Weaver might like you, but an attitude like that makes it easy for The Rebellion to find someone else who can do your job better. And I think you know where you’ll get reassigned if that happens.”

“Tell me where to go.” Catra demanded.

“There’s a warehouse at this address.” Double Trouble handed her a slip of paper written in a language she could read. “I’m sure you’d love to hear how I managed to get it, but honestly, we should move before Blondie, Shortstack, and Bellybutton call someone you can’t seduce.”

“Are you going to come with me or-” Catra turned. They were already gone. “Of course.”

She arrived at the address after a nearly hour-long walk. The place was in a sea of commercial buildings. Wide grid-shaped streets separated semi-identical old warehouses, factories, and offices with blown-out windows. Catra scanned them all, reading the numbers on the sides until she found the right one.

It was good Adora taught her at least the basics of how to read. Adora . . .

Catra pushed those thoughts down and approached the warehouse, which was rusted in places and had no signs on it. The only entrance was a plain gray metal door. She pulled up her hood, then slammed her fist against the door several times in greeting. After a long moment, it cracked open, revealing an annoyed-looking pair of eyes.

“What do you want?” They asked, voice raspy.

“I’m looking for transport to Fort Irwin, California.” Catra explained. “They said you people could get me there.”

“Who’s they?”

“The guy.”

“What guy?”

“The guy in the club. He said I should come here if I ever needed help quietly.”

“And what makes you think we can do that?”

Catra reached into her pocket and flashed a stack of cash from the gold. “Because it’ll be worth your while.”

The person inside glanced at it, then the door shut. Catra waited impatiently for several minutes and, eventually, it opened again. Their eyes belonged to a skinny woman wearing a gun under her suit and a strange headband with felt antlers on her head. She ushered her inside. “Come on.”

The hallways inside the building were dark, lights above turned very low. Fine for Catra’s eyes. She noticed the second woman who stepped out of the shadows to flank Catra’s right side immediately. She was short, stocky, and also armed. They arrived in a much larger room, empty save for some wooden crates stacked in the corners and at the very center, under a single hanging light, a wooden desk with a large woman with long white hair parked behind it. She was eating something.

After a pause, the antlered one coughed into her hand and drew the woman behind the desk’s eyes up from a stack of papers, “Boss.” She said. “Got us a visitor.”

“Interesting.” The woman said, voice husky, then asked shortly. “What do you want?”

“Transport.” Catra said.

“Who says I can do that for you?”

“I know you can.” She replied easily.

The woman chuffed, tapping their fingers on the desk. “You’re assuming a lot for someone I’ve never met. You on the run? That why you need help?”

“Something like that.” Catra admitted. She gave where she needed to go again.

“Pretty big ask, me driving you right to a military base.”

“You can drop me off aways away. I can make it on foot once I get close.”

The boss woman seemed to find that funny. “Sneaking on a military base through the desert, at night presumably. So, you’re stupid as well as reckless.”

“You don’t know anything about me.” Catra snapped back.

The big woman chuckled lowly. “You’re not from around here, are you?” She asked with a dark eye on her hood. Catra didn’t respond. “Didn’t think so, so how ‘bout I let you in on a secret. There’re only two rules in the desert.” She lifted one finger at a time. “One, the strong make the rules. And two: don’t disturb me while I’m eating. Can you guess which one I am, and which one you’ve broken, kid?”

Catra’s scowl rumbled in her throat, and her tail swished frustratedly inside her coat. “Are you going to help me or not?”

“Perhaps.” The woman admitted. “How about this, let’s establish a little trust first.”

“Someone in your business should know better than trust.” Catra said. She didn’t know this woman’s business, but she had met enough criminals to know one when she saw one.

“Hah.” The woman laughed. “Ain’t that the truth. But someone who’s survived as long as I’m guessing you have should know how a little knowledge greases the wheels.” She took another bite of whatever she had, asking with her mouth full. “How about a name?”

Catra’s ears shifted. Evidently, this woman knew what she was seeing too. “Catra.”

The woman nodded. “See, that wasn’t so hard, was it?” She smiled, then put a hand to her own chest. “Huntara.”

“Didn’t ask.”

The woman nodded. “You're a rather interesting bird, or should I say cat?"

"Yes." Catra flattened her brows. "I have a condition; you probably can't pronounce it."

"It's called hypertrichosis." Huntara smiled. "Should I spell it for you?" Catra blinked. "Take off your hood." When Catra didn’t move, she gestured sharply to one of the goons. “Take off her hood.” The tall girl reached for her but hesitated when Catra hissed at them.

“Come on kid, give a little and I’ll give you some right back.” Huntara egged. “You’re not going anywhere with that attit-”

“Alright.” Catra cut her off, officially out of patience. “Here’s how this shit is going to go. I’m going to give you this.” She pulled out the cash she had. “And in return, you’re going to take me where I want to go. No more questions asked.”

Huntara lifted her chin a hair. “And if I don’t find that deal satisfactory?”

“Then we’re done here.” Catra glanced at the short woman, who was eying the money closely. She slipped it back under under her coat, moving her skin-suit to hold it close against her body.

“And if I say we’re not?” Huntara’s voice made the veiled threat clear.

Catra lifted a hand and showed her claws.

Huntara smiled and snapped her fingers. The two goons started moving in towards her, raising their arms, not their guns. Catra inhaled deeply, calming herself, then couched slightly. When they were five feet away, she sprang. Leaping for the tall girl first, her foot collided with her stomach and knocked her back. The sound

she made when she hit crates against the wall let Catra know she had driven all the air from her lungs.

By the time they hit the floor, the second henchman was on Catra. She was squat, but clearly dense and strong. She threw a left hook. Catra feinted left. The powerful blow passed her by, but Catra's dash pulled her hood off her head. Her ears revealed, and the goon's face briefly filled with shock. That moment was all Catra needed to bear her claws and rake them down across her face. The woman screamed, stumbling back and clutching at the four bloody lines in her face.

Catra turned again, confirming as she returned to face the antlered goon that Huntara was still sitting behind her desk. She obviously didn't feel the need to get her hands dirty in this.

The antlered goon was heaving, trying to get air in her lungs. Catra ran for her. They saw and fumbled for their side. The pistol slid from the harness. In the long shadows cast by the single light, it rose.

Catra stared into the goon's hard dark eyes, anticipating what she realized was coming. Left or right?

"Wait!" Huntara shouted, but it was too late. Catra dove right. She had stood on Catra's right when leading her in here. Now the gun was in her same hand. Catra hoped that was enough.

The black weapon barked like a cannon in the enclosed room. Catra felt the air pressure of the bullet tear past her left shoulder. She closed the final few yards and pinned the woman's arms against the floor with a foot, rearing back to knock her out.

"That's enough!" Huntara roared, and Catra was amazed she could make herself heard over the high-pitched ringing in her ears.

Catra stayed her hand, glancing over her shoulder at the gang leader. Huntara was now standing, ready to intervene. But when she saw Catra had stopped, walked over slowly. The towering

figure of the woman loomed over her. “I’ll give you what you want,” Huntara put out an open palm. “where was it you need to go?” Catra exhaled, her heart rate still up. She pulled out the cash, placing it into Huntara’s palm as she told her. The woman nodded, and Catra released the goon’s arm. She had somehow managed to keep that stupid headband on through the fight. “You two:” Huntara said to her goons. “Get yourselves cleaned up. You,” She looked at Catra. “Follow me.”

Adora’s breath was ragged in her chest. She ran down the strip, stopping everyone she passed and asking about Catra. Half of them were too drunk to answer, the other half didn’t give anything useful. She ran further. Her feet burned. Her head spun. Her heart was . . . her heart was too much to think about right now.

Slowly, the rhythm of her feet slowed, then stopped. Adora gasped and heaved, bending over and putting her hands on her knees. Tears threatened her eyes. She blinked them away with a gasp through her teeth. She took a step to keep running. One was all she managed.

She tilted her head back. The light from the neon-clad towers reflected off Adora’s foggy puffs of breath, green and purple. Beyond she saw the band of the sky above, still pitch black with night. The city drowned out everything, save for the loneliest, brightest stars.

Why? Why why why why why why WHY!?

Her shaking hands closed into fists. They stayed closed for several seconds. She inhaled deeply through her nose, then out through her mouth. Her hands fell open. Adora wiped her face and took a step, then another, then another. Their rhythm accelerated once again. “Hey, you!” She called to the first passerby she saw.

It took fifteen minutes more to find someone who had seen Catra, flashing every stranger she passed on the street the picture from Zion. When she did, she was pointed into a suburb. There she

found another person who had seen her walking. They remembered her ears. That tip led her to an industrial district where a third pointed her to a nondescript block of buildings.

The last leg of her track was the hardest, she wandered between the warehouses, convinced that Catra must have hidden between a few. Peeking through fences and around corners, she searched for her friend. At least an hour must have passed, and she had nothing to show for it. Until a hoarse voice called her.

Adora turned, noticing someone who was certainly homeless sitting in a spot somewhat tucked away from the street. It was an older woman, with a shopping cart full of possessions and a blanket laid out on the sidewalk, a second wrapped over her shoulders. "You there!" The woman cried. Adora approached, at first worried this could be the shapeshifter, then relaxed when she realized all the stuff everywhere around her had to be real. Even for someone as obviously dramatic as Double Trouble, this set was too complex to just be a prop. "You're looking for something, ain'tcha?" The woman pointed a knobbed finger at Adora.

"I am." Adora confirmed. She showed her the picture on her phone. "I'm looking for my . . . friend, she and I got separated and she doesn't have her phone." She waited for the inevitable confused look at Catra's appearance, but didn't get it this time.

"All the way out here?" The woman asked, white eyebrow rising.

"We're . . . tourists." Adora said, hoping it didn't sound too unbelievable. Usually, that hope meant it did, but apparently, it was satisfactory this time.

The woman pointed behind Adora, and she turned to see a completely unmarked warehouse with nothing but some loading bays and a single door on it. It was so plain Adora had already walked by it a couple of times. "She went in there."

"Really!?" Adora said to her, so grateful. "Thank you! I never would have been able to find that out on my own." Damn, that

was lucky. She wished she could give the woman something. Food or water or another blanket. She couldn't imagine sleeping on pavement on nights like this one. The only thing she had on her was . . .

Adora patted her pockets and pulled out her stack of cash, passing half of it over. "Here."

The woman looked confused, but took it, eyes widening at the number of bills. "But . . . this is . . ." She flitted through it carefully.

"Yep." Adora smiled. "Long story, but it's not stolen or anything, I promise. Go stay somewhere nice for the night!" She turned and jogged towards the warehouse. "Thank you again for helping me!"

The woman looked absolutely baffled. "You're welcome . . ."

Adora texted Bow and Glimmer her address, received a thumbs up in return, then shut her phone off. Stopping before the plain gray door, she glanced around the lot, saw no one, then knocked. Ten seconds later, it creaked open an inch, revealing an eye peeking over a chain latch. "And what the hell do you want?" A raspy female voice asked.

"Uhhm, hi." Adora greeted with a wave. "I'm looking for someone. A girl, about my age. This tall." Adora gestured. "Kind of, really hairy?"

"Who's asking?" The doorwoman cocked her head.

"I'm a friend of hers."

"Mmm." The doorwoman scowled; mouth barely visible in the darkness of the interior of the building. "Stay here." She ordered and started to close the door.

"Wait!" Adora called before she did. "I can make it worth your while." She assured, peeking her remaining cash from her pocket.

“So can everyone tonight, apparently.” The woman grumbled, closing the door.

The wait was agonizing. Adora impatiently tapped her foot as she glanced left and right at the surrounding warehouses. But eventually, she did return and the door was opened all the way. Adora blinked. The woman was wearing a black suit and a cheesy Christmas headband, antlered like a reindeer, over her mohawk hairstyle. She had also come with a second, far shorter woman by her side, stocky and very muscular. She was wearing a hilariously ugly Christmas sweater depicting Santa Claus and his elves running from a T-Rex under her own suit jacket. Adora tried not to laugh, instead forcing herself to focus on the four long blood-stained bandages on the shorter woman’s face, and the bumps present on both their hips. Handguns.

“This way.” The raspy antlered girl gestured inside. Adora noticed she had a nasty bruise on the inside of her forearm.

“Is she here?” Adora asked.

The woman said nothing, and Adora briefly considered not going into this unbelievably sketchy situation. Then she looked at the woman with the bandages on her face again, and realized she recognized the shape of her wound. She had seen metal torn like that.

Adora allowed herself to be led inside, through a series of dimly lit hallways and past closed doors into a large dark warehouse. The corners were lined with wooden crates, and in the center, framed under a light was a desk. Behind it was a buff woman.

She was leaning back in her chair casually, but her eyes were locked on Adora. Her hair was long, white, and shaved all but for a band running down the middle of her head. Unlike her goons – she was clearly the boss, despite her simple outfit: a muscle shirt with a fur-lined denim jacket over it. The antlered woman crossed the room and whispered in her ear. The boss nodded and

dismissed her with a wave, leaning forward. “Welcome.” She greeted; voice gruff. “What’s your name?”

Adora considered using the same fake name that she had used in Snowville, but thought better of it. “Adora.”

The woman nodded. “I hear you're looking for someone. Why do you think she’s here?”

“Someone across the street saw her come in here.”

“And you trust this person?” Each of the woman’s responses came hard and fast, and Adora felt like an interesting trinket in the eyes of a predator. One who was enjoying a good game of cat and mouse.

“Enough to be here.” She tried to play along.

The woman gained the faintest shade of a smile. “Do you have any idea who I am?”

“No ma’am.”

“Mmm, I thought not. So, let me be frank, my business isn’t taking little lost girls. Especially ones the police are after.” Adora’s eyes widened. “Oh yeah, I know who you are, and I ain’t getting mixed up in that.” She gestured to her goons and picked up a piece of paper on her desk. “Take her back outside.” She said, not even looking at Adora.

Adora swallowed and steeled herself. “She’s fearsome, isn’t she?”

The woman glanced upwards. “What?”

“Catra is here. Her face says so.” She gestured to the shorter henchwoman. “If she came and left, I doubt you would have even let me in here.” She eyed the boss. “Stop me if I’m wrong.”

The large woman stood, rising to her full six-and-a-half-foot height. Oh, wow she was tall. Oh, wow she was ripped. Huge

muscular arms swayed as she walked around her desk. Adora tried not to get too entranced by them as she approached. “Who is she to you?” She asked.

“Important.”

“How important?”

“Enough to still be talking with you.” Adora said. The woman’s eyes narrowed slightly. Adora continued. “You agreed to help her, didn’t you?”

“Maybe I handed her over to the police.” The woman offered. “And I’ll do the same to you.”

Adora hadn’t thought of that, but she managed to control her reaction. She tried to think of a way out, but couldn’t. Damnit, she was committed now. “Then do it.” She dared.

There was a long moment of tense silence, then the woman smiled. “Heh, you’ve got guts kid, I’ll give you that.” She extended her hand. Adora shook with a clammy hand. “Huntara.” She greeted.

“Pleasure.” Adora managed, smiling stiffly.

“Two lost little girls on one Christmas night.” Huntara said. “Very different, and yet alike. Sounds like a classic Yule tale, doesn’t it boys?”

The two henchwomen glanced at one another. “Sure does, ma’am.” They replied together, both sounding pretty confused.

“You want a ride to Fort Irwin too?” Huntara asked. Adora nodded and pulled out the money. Huntara took it.

“You’re going to help me?” Adora asked, still somewhat in disbelief.

“What can I say? I’ve been surprised twice tonight. Maybe it’s a Christmas miracle.” Huntara shrugged. “Search her, then take her to see her friend.”

Adora was patted down. Her phone and wallet were taken, and then she was led out of the room. But just before she was out, Huntara called. “Hey, kid!” Adora turned. “What’s with the ears?”

Adora considered not saying anything, then figured this woman wasn’t one to tattle on her to the police. Besides, no one would believe her if she talked. “She’s an alien.” Adora revealed, and was led out, down the hall, and to an unmarked door. She was told a driver was coming to take them both, and she was let into what looked like a small break room.

Cheap chairs and tables were scattered about, and in the middle of it all, Catra sat. Her head was hung low so that Adora could see a poster on the far wall that otherwise would have been obscured. It was one of those terrible inspirational ones from the 90s meant for offices, and read 'S U C C E S S', in big yellow letters. The picture was one of a person receiving some kind of award. In the hum of florescent lights, it was a bitter icon. The goons closed the door behind Adora.

"Hey, Catra." She announced herself.

Catra didn’t look up. “What the hell are you doing here, Adora?”

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None
A chapter on schedule! Whoo! Happy holidays everyone!

Chapter 15: Adore

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Unfortunately, Adora was right, Glimmer hated her sister's plan. It was shortsighted, naïve, and almost certainly dangerous. But as Adora continued to explain it, Glimmer increasingly knew it was the right call.

And yes, that was the most frustrating part.

Bow caved first; Glimmer followed. But they insisted on two conditions.

One: they involve the authorities at this point. Catra's talk of a full-blown alien invasion, regardless of its truthfulness, meant they were officially in too deep. Whatever the punishment would be for running away from home was now certainly the lesser evil.

Adora had agreed.

Two: Adora needed to go into this recognizing the fact that Catra might not be her friend. Some part of Glimmer wanted to believe what Catra had been saying. Begging that, at some point, she had changed. But she couldn't do it. Not again. Not yet.

Adora had agreed to this as well. Glimmer heard her say it and knew she was serious. She let out a deep breath. "Find her quick." She said into the phone. They would lose Catra for good if she didn't.

"I will." Adora promised.

Glimmer nodded. "And how do we find *them*?"

"My backpack." Adora said. Glimmer turned, seeing Bow had gotten ahold of it in the chaos. "There's a business card." Bow

rummaged and produced a black slip of paper. He nodded.

“Found it.” Glimmer told Adora, then hesitated. Here she was, her sister running headlong into danger again, and this time she was letting her. “Be safe, sis.”

“You too.” Adora said. “You both.”

Glimmer said it almost without thinking. “I love you.”

There was a tiny pause. “I love you too, Glimmer. See you soon.”

The line dropped, and Glimmer had to take a moment to wipe her eyes. Bow appeared at her side, one arm around her shoulders and holding her tight. “She’ll be okay.” He assured.

“Yeah . . .” Glimmer managed, gathering her wits. “Lemme see that.” Bow handed her the card. It was completely unmarked save for a phone number. She dialed.

It picked up on the fourth ring. “Oh my god, what!?” The blue-haired woman - Mermista’s - angry voice shouted. “We’re kind of busy at the moment.” There was noise in the background, lots of people talking. The aftermath of the party, Glimmer guessed.

“It’s us.” Glimmer said.

“What?” Mermista asked, then spoke in a lower voice, not into the phone. “Hold still, you big baby.”

“Wait!” Came the voice of Seahawk. “Not like that, dearest! You’ll cause my incredible chest to scar.” Well, at least he was okay.

“It’s us.” Glimmer repeated.

This time, Mermista seemed to get it. There was the sound of footsteps and the call of, “Mermista!? Where are you going!?”

A door slammed, and the background noise vanished. “Hey.”

“Hey.”

“You’re actually calling us.” Mermista said.

“I am.” Glimmer answered.

“Why?”

“Because things have changed. We need help. I’ll tell you where we are, and we’ll cooperate, but first, you have to tell us who the hell you are.”

A pause. “We’re special agents working for the FBI.” Mermista revealed. “Our department focuses on unusual matters.”

“Like Catra?”

“Like Catra.”

“You know?” Glimmer asked.

“We know.” Mermista assured.

Alright then. “If we meet, will you arrest us?” Glimmer asked.

“That depends on how things have changed.” She said.

Glimmer covered the phone with her hand and looked to Bow. “You sure this is a good idea?”

Bow shrugged. “It’s these guys or the police.”

“Are they any different?”

Bow shrugged, and Glimmer sighed. At least they seemed to know some of what was going on. Plus, they seemed incompetent enough to sneak away from if they should need to. “We have conditions . . .” She began negotiations.

Adora stood before Catra in the plain, windowless room. Catra didn’t look up from her seat. “What the hell are you doing here, Adora?”

She had so much to say, but first things first. “Are they . . . is Double Trouble here?” She asked Catra.

“. . . No.”

Adora nodded, then took a deep breath. “I know . . . a lot’s happened. Hell, a lot’s still happening, but I . . . we need to talk, Catra.”

Catra did talk, but what she said wasn’t what she wanted to hear. “You’re an idiot, Adora, getting roped in with these people. They’re dangerous.”

Adora had to clench her fists to stop them shaking. “I know.” Catra’s eyes flickered up to look at her, then dropped back down again. Adora continued. “But you need to explain this.”

Catra lifted her gaze a second time, this time holding it on her, letting Adora see the anger in it. “No, you need to **go**.”

Adora stood her ground. “Not until I get answers.”

“Then get ready to wait!” Catra snarled, tail twitching and teeth flashing.

When her voice rose, Adora felt her muscles stiffen. When the shout faded, she released a tense breath. “You promised.” She said. “You promised we would stick together, as a team. You can talk to me, Catra.”

“You wanna talk Adora?” Catra said roughly. “Alright, let’s talk. Let’s talk about how I’ve been leading you on from the moment I landed. How I’ve eaten your food and drank your water and led you all the way out here! . . .” She gestured at their surroundings. “because I needed you to do it. You say we’re a team? We were never a team.”

Adora stared right back. “Even if you hadn’t said all those things back there, I wouldn’t believe that. I know you better.”

Catra barked out a short, harsh laugh. “Ohh you know me? You think you’re special, Adora?” She challenged. “I told you what I do. I’ve played this game before, on planets just like yours, on stooges just like you, and I won, every single time.”

“This isn’t a game, Catra.”

“Ohhoho no. It isn’t.” Catra confirmed. “Not for you.”

Adora stared at the smile Catra wore at that, trying to see if it reached her eyes. “And that’s what this is? Victory?”

Catra stuck her arms out as if to say ‘ta-da!’.

“So, this is what you do now? Laugh at the people you’ve tricked as you fly off to do it again? Does that make it easier? Or do you just forget them? Their faces? Their names?” Adora's nails dug into the flesh of her palms. “All this time . . . is this what you wanted?”

“It’s my job.” Catra said, coldly, evenly.

Adora searched desperately for something, any sign of a chink in the wall Catra had put up, for light peeking through a crack. “I came here . . . because you’re more than that, Catra.” Adora said. “I’ve seen it.” She insisted. Catra said nothing. Adora’s frustration built. “Please, Catra, it’s not too late. The Horde, Double Trouble, everything, we can fix it all, together. We can get you home, just like I promi-

“**What the fuck is wrong with you, Adora!?**” Catra stood so fast her chair crashed to the floor. "Stop! Stop doing this! Stop trying to help me! You need to just **go home!**" She stood with shoulders up, teeth bared, claws out, hair raised into an angular mane, eyes burning with blue and gold ferocity.

Adora instincts pricked, and she nearly took a step back. Catra was shaped like she’d been that very first morning. Her body an other, alien. But her voice . . . that voice was still all Catra. Adora

forced her foot to remain where it was. She wasn't going to be afraid of Catra. Not when there was a chance. "Was it real?"

Catra blinked. "What?"

"Was it real, Catra?"

Catra stared at her, anger deepening. "Are you even listening!?"

"That's not an answer!" Adora shouted. Was this really a chance? More like a delusion. Her common sense pushed words up and out of her throat. "I've done this whole insane thing for you, Catra! I left my family stranded in the mountains for you! I stole their car for you! I've been spending their money across four states for you! Bow and Glimmer flew out here, for you!"

"And that was your mistakes." Catra said.

Adora felt the tears stinging her eyes. She pushed on, taking a deep breath. "The movies, watching the stars, snowmobiling, hiking, taking for hours. You're telling me that was all a lie. That you didn't care about any of it?"

"What part of spy don't you get?" Catra growled.

"But you told us you're a spy." Adora pointed. "You said you weren't supposed to tell us that. You said everything was different now."

"I was lying." Catra said. "It's what I do best." That was a lie.

"No!" Adora called it out. "I'm not falling for that! You don't get to say you don't care after you poured your heart out to me!"

"Poured my heart out?" Catra scoffed. "Stars Princess, what world have you been living in?"

"The real world." Adora said through gritted teeth. "The one where I know that you're more than just the evil alien invader. The one where you won't tell me the truth!"

“And what’s that, Adora!?” Catra demanded. “What’s my big fucking secret!?”

“That you don’t want to help the Horde anymore!” Adora screamed. Silence fell over the room, the only sounds both their chests heaving. Adora wiped her eyes. “I’m not letting you just walk away. Not after everything we’ve been through. Not after everything you told me. That meant something.”

“Wow, you really have been obsessing over me this whole time, huh?” Catra smirked.

Adora took a lunging step towards Catra, shouting. “**Why did you say those things in the alley!?**”

“Oh, for fuck’s sake!” Catra snarled. “Just because I said a few words in that alley, that means I secretly care about you!?” Catra’s bared lips tightened into a wide smile. “Well, I don’t. I told you **everything** you and your pathetic, primitive little friends need to know. I work for the big mean Horde Rebellion! We conquer innocent little worlds and draft their people into our armies and throw them at an unstoppable enemy. It’s as simple as that! Everything I’ve done from the moment I landed here was to help **them**! If you heard secret little messages of friendship in there, then that’s all on you. Stars, I knew you were an idiot, Adora, but for once in your life, how about you do the smart thing!? Do what everyone else always does and **LEAVE ME ALONE!**”

Her voice echoed off the concrete walls, ringing in Adora’s ears. Why was she here? Why was she trying? Catra was right, the smart thing would be to just walk away. Let the police handle everything. She could leave, start her life over, and forget all of this. It would mean she wouldn’t have to feel this horrible burning twisting in her gut anymore. In that way, it would be easy.

So why was she here? Was it because she had made a promise? Was that enough? Or was it something more? Something Adora swore was inside Catra. Something that assured her she wasn’t a

supervillain, just someone hurting. Someone who had made a mistake. Someone a little like herself.

Adora wished more deeply than she could wish that the world could give her one more shot. She might not be able to give herself one, but she could do that for Catra. One last chance.

"Tell me it meant nothing, then." Adora said to her. "Tell me that, and I'll go."

Catra said nothing, just stared at her. They were barely three paces apart.

Adora waited, then took a step forward. "Tell me." She asked again. Catra said nothing. Adora took another step forward. "Tell me!"

Catra's face morphed into rage, and a roar leapt from her throat. Time seemed to slow. Adora ducked underneath Catra's wild slash, and trusted that tiny part of her brain whispering about hope. She stepped forward under her arm, closed the final gap, and wrapped her arms around Catra. The alien hissed in her ear, and Adora felt claws dig into her back. She winced, but just held tighter. She held tighter because Catra was still silent. And that meant, in her stupid, frustrating, angsty, thick-headed, sass-filled, stubborn-as-all-hell way, that she cared. Catra cared. And that meant,

"I'm not going to leave you." Adora promised.

Catra's breathing went shallow. The claws twitched in the muscles of her back. Her injured shoulder was starting to burn. Five long seconds passed, then Adora was released and shoved away. She tumbled onto the hard floor, landing on her butt. She grunted, then looked up.

Catra was crying. She hissed and twitched, wiping her eyes and blinking furiously. Then glared down at Adora, who was crying just as hard and must have had a completely indescribable look on her face.

“Why do you have to make this so fucking hard!?” Catra cried.

Adora was glad her sinuses were so full of mucus that the sound that escaped her sounded more like a sob than a laugh. “Because . . .” Adora began, then realized the words that her mouth was going to say next, and stopped herself. “Because I made a promise to a friend.”

It was like a western standoff: Bow standing next to Glimmer on one side of the alley, facing the suits - Mermista and Seahawk - on the other. Mermista’s hair was mussed, out of its braid, and with rogue hairs sticking out in all directions. Seahawk had more to worry about than fashion. Under his half-unbuttoned undershirt, Bow could see rows of bandages wrapped around his chest. They were stained a light red from the wounds underneath. If they hurt, he wasn’t letting it show. That boisterous smile Bow was already growing used to seeing was still affixed to his face.

“We believe you.” Mermista said when Glimmer finished explaining what had happened.

Bow blinked. “Wait, really?” He asked, baffled.

“I’ve seen weirder.” Mermista said without a hint of emotion in her voice.

“In the FBI?” Glimmer asked, a little skeptical.

“Fret not!” Seahawk eased. “As agents of the-”

Mermista slapped her hand over his mouth. “Yeah, you can’t say what you’re about to say.”

“You’re the Men in Black, basically.” Glimmer summarized. Seahawk nodded excitedly.

“How did you end up following us then?” Bow asked.

“My parents called the sheriff. The sheriff called the feds. The feds called you.” Glimmer guessed. She had told Bow about how officials had been contacted not long after Adora had run, and they subsequently swarmed the crash site and the cabin. They were sent home, from where she ran off with Bow.

“Got it in one.” Mermista confirmed.

“So, you’ll help us?” Bow asked.

“Just give us the address your sister and the alien are at, and we’ll take care of everything.” Mermista said.

“No.” Glimmer immediately shot that down, annoyed. “We are not just letting you do this without us.”

Mermista pressed both her hands against her face. “Kids and their hero complexes.” She muttered, sounding very very tired.

Bow stepped forward before she could start. “Look, we could have this whole conversation where you tell us how it’s dangerous, and you’re more qualified. But we’ll just say we’re coming anyway because Adora is our friend and we don’t trust you. You’ll say you have their best interests at heart. We’ll say you probably want to imprison and or experiment on Catra, which we don’t want to happen if she’s not . . . you know, a crazy alien psychopath bent on planetary subjugation.” Mermista blinked at Bow. “But the longer we stand here bickering, the odds of something going wrong go up.”

Glimmer stood beside him, declaring. “We’re coming. No cops. Just us two and you two. Take it or leave it.”

Seahawk was smiling at the pair of them, though whether from humor or genuine impact, Bow didn’t know. He glanced over at Mermista, arms across his chest. Mermista shook her head no at him. Seahawk gave her a ‘why not’ gesture with an open palm.

Mermista let out a long, painful groan and rubbed both her temples. “Fuck me.”

Adora and Catra ended side by side, sitting on one of the tables. “I’m sorry.” Catra said. Her voice was liquid and hoarse.

“Huh?” Adora didn’t sound much better.

“You know . . .” Catra struggled, her ears down. “Your back.”

Adora smiled, knowing that apology was about more than where her claws had gone. “It’s alright.” She eased, ignoring the pain that was pulsing through her lats. “Barely hurts.” She doubted they were even still bleeding.

Catra didn’t seem eased by that, so Adora reached over and gave Catra’s hand a little squeeze, then left it there. “Hey, it’s okay. We’re on the same side now, for real this time, right?”

Adora saw the exact moment it sank in for Catra just what she had decided to do, what she was going to do. It was too complex an emotion to describe. But when her eyes came back to Adora, some of that fear and shock fell away, and Catra looked at her in a way she didn’t think anyone ever would. “Yeah.” She said softly.

Adora smiled. “Then it’s water under the bridge. Hatchet buried.”

Catra stared at her. “Are you using those just cause you know I don’t know what they mean?”

“Yep.” It was also to take her mind off anything darker.

Catra chuffed, giving her a sideways glance. “Tide caller.” She accused.

“And that means?” Adora prompted.

“Wouldn’t you like to know.” Catra sassed. They both laughed, and the air seemed cleared. After a moment of companionable silence. Catra pulled her hand away. “We’ll still need to contact my ship.” She said.

Adora balked. “What? But . . .”

“If we don’t send up some kind of signal, they’ll just send down another spy. One not as susceptible to your . . . charms as me.”

“Oh, so I’m charming too?” Adora raised an eyebrow.

“Don’t push it.” Catra pressed, and it was clear she had shifted back into serious soldier-mode.

Adora swallowed and turned away, clasping her hands together in her lap. “Right, sorry.”

“If I’m going to do this, we need to do it right. If we can contact them, I’ll report that Double Trouble was killed in the crash and that the natives are incredibly hostile. That your planet is too dangerous to co-opt.”

“Will that work?”

Catra’s ears flattened. “It’s the best I’ve got.” That wasn’t exactly confidence-inspiring, but it meant they still had the same goal. Goldstone or bust. “Please tell me you had a plan when you decided to risk your neck and come after me?”

Adora nodded and explained that the plan had been:

Find Catra.

Make sure she wasn’t an evil brain-eating alien overlord.

Hold her in one spot until Bow and Glimmer could pick them up, preferably with transport acquired.

Simple? Yes. Steps one and two? Accomplished. Foolproof? Apparently not. Her mistake had been making the apparently unreasonable assumption that Catra wouldn’t be able to find her own transport in the hour it took to find her. She hadn’t thought Double Trouble would have that covered. She really hadn’t thought that that transport would take the form of a questionably

legal gang taxi service that took her phone from her, preventing her from sending updates. Now off the grid, the plan was in limbo, and Glimmer and Bow would surely assume the worst.

Though honestly, assuming the worst was fair at this point.

But this could be surmounted, Adora knew. They just had to sneak out of here before-

The door opened again. Adora and Catra looked up to see Huntara. Shit.

"Come on, *Good Omens*." Huntara beckoned. "Your chariot awaits." They were led down a different hallway towards a large garage with bay doors open to the dark night, the ones Adora had seen from the outside, she'd suspected. In the center was a big black SUV with tinted windows. Next to the SUV were two women dressed in black suits. "These are your chaperones." She introduced. "Spinnerella,"

"Hello." The first woman, tall and curvy with pale skin, waved with a friendly smile. Her hair was flowy and dyed a lilac color. She was wearing a pale blue tie.

"and Netossa."

"Hey." The second nodded. She was of an average height, black, with hair shaved on one side and dyed a pale blue. Her tie was lilac. "We're all set, boss." She told Huntara.

Huntara nodded and looked at Adora and Catra. Adora really didn't want to get into that car, but going back on the deal now was definitely a bad idea. "Can I get my phone back?" She asked Huntara.

The huge woman smiled an imperious smile and tossed the phone to Netossa, who caught it easily. "When you drop them off." Huntara told Netossa, who nodded and climbed up into the driver's seat.

Spinnerella opened the rear door for them. “Let’s be off then.”

Adora turned to Huntara. “Thank you for your help.” She parted with and got a respectful nod in return. She got up in the back seat, Catra followed, and it closed behind them. The inside was dark, all black with soft leather seats, and filled with the scent of an air freshener so strong it seemed like it was there to cover up other smells.

“If we just ended up in a trafficking ring . . .” Adora said so low she knew only Catra would hear.

Catra bumped her in the rib with an elbow, then set a hand on hers. Right, together, for real this time.

Glimmer watched as Mermista finished talking to the very happy-looking homeless woman packing up her things and walked back to the car. The car was, according to Seahawk, called the Dragon’s Daughter III. Glimmer and Bow were now literally in the belly of the beast. That belly being the back seat of an early 2000s Crown Vic.

“She saw them both go inside.” Mermista said when she sat back down behind the wheel, closing the door. “Catra went in about an hour ago, Adora about thirty minutes after that.”

Glimmer muttered a curse that would definitely get her grounded. “Who the hell have they gotten in with now?” When Adora had texted them the address of a nondescript warehouse, she had figured they would just pick her up on the side of the road, with or without Catra. Instead, they were now parked half a block away, staring at the building, trying to see through its gray walls. The area was sketchy. The street was cracked and baked pale from the sun. Half the streetlights didn’t work, and the light from the ones that did were overpowered by the unnatural gloam of the metropolis against the dark sky. It was 4:00 in the morning now, and the city of lights was living up to its name, drowning out the stars.

“Maybe Catra found a ride?” Bow suggested.

“It’s possible.” Mermista said.

“That place doesn’t exactly look like a taxi service.” Glimmer noted.

“That woman said that black cars move in and out pretty often.”

“The mob then?” Bow guessed.

“Maybe.” Mermista said. Glimmer’s heart rate spiked even higher. Goddamnit Adora.

“Fiends!” Seahawk shouted, then started coughing, clutching his chest.

“You should keep quiet so people nearby don’t hear.” Mermista said to him, “But being injured is also a good reason to shut up.”

“Nonsense, dearest!” Seahawk said between hacks. “I’m fit as a fiddle. Ready for whatever this adventure brings!” His coughs continued.

“What do we do now?” Bow asked.

“Storm the facili-!” Seahawk cried hoarsely.

“We wait.” Mermista overruled. “We don’t know what’s in there. If they’re here for transport, we can stop them when they leave. If things have gone bad, we can call for backup.”

“But,” Glimmer tried to stop her.

“One hour.” Mermista gave. “Then I’m calling everyone in.”

Glimmer clenched her jaw tighter, but nodded.

Time passed. Five minutes became ten, then twenty. In the quiet of the car, Glimmer’s eyelids became heavier and heavier. Her view of the warehouse through the windshield slid behind her

eyelids. God, she was so tired. When had she last slept? She had lost track. Was it all the way back in Idaho? If it was, then it wasn't a surprise that even with the engine of the car off and the temperature inside the cabin dropping like a stone, the old leather seats of the Dragon's Daughter were like a siren's song. She tried to blink and shake away the drowsiness, keep herself awake. She checked her phone over and over again, repeatedly confirming Adora's location was no longer updating. Someone had turned her phone or tracking off. The lack of any of their new texts from her made Glimmer suspect it was the latter. "Come on, Adora." She whispered.

"There there!" Bow's voice came with a shake on Glimmer's shoulder, who shuddered up from whatever space between sleep and wakefulness she had fallen into. Blinking desperately, she saw where he was pointing up over Mermista's shoulder. One of the cargo bay doors on the warehouse was opening, revealing a big car inside.

"We see it." Mermista batted his hand away, grabbing a pair of binoculars from the center console and looking out the windshield with them. "Black General Motors full-size SUV, no front plate, tinted windows." Mermista said. Seahawk copied everything she described onto a pad of paper, including that the drivers are armed. A minute passed in horrible silence. Glimmer's heart was in her throat. Then Mermista reported, "Some people have come in; they're talking." Glimmer leaned forward and squinted for every detail she could make out. Glimmer almost wished she hadn't caught the flicker of Adora's blonde hair and red jacket as she stepped up into the car. A second later, she saw a dark coat. "Eyes on them." Mermista said. "They're in the back."

Shit. Shit shit shit. What are you doing, Adora? "Can we stop them when they pull out?" Glimmer asked.

"When the drivers are packing and only two of us are armed? Not a good idea." Mermista said.

"Then how are we going to track them?" Bow asked.

“We’ll put out an APB.”

“I might take days to find the car.” Bow said.

“I thought we agreed no cops!” Glimmer said.

“It’s that or do nothing.” Mermista shut them down firmly.

Glimmer looked at Bow, and Bow looked at Glimmer. She watched as the gears turned in his brain, her own desperately trying to find a third option. “What if they’re getting kidnapped?” She asked him, heart jumping even faster. “Catra’s an alien. What if they found out? What if they’re trying to sell them!?”

“Keep quiet back there.” Mermista said.

“Catra’s good about hiding her ears. They wouldn’t find out.” Bow said, but it almost sounded like he was trying to convince himself.

“What if they did!? We might never see them again if we let that car drive off.” She looked in Bow’s conflicted eyes. The lights of the car came on. “Can we take that risk!?”

“I said be quiet!” Mermista hissed.

Glimmer saw Bow clenched his jaw. “Did Adora and Catra look like they were in distress?” He asked Mermista and Seahawk.

Mermista took her eyes off her binoculars for a fraction of a second and glanced at him. “It’s too far to tell.”

Through the sound-deadening of the car, Glimmer heard the SUV’s engine turn over, then watched in growing horror as the car rolled out of the warehouse, driving fast, lights seeping over them as they turned to head onto the road. It was going to drive past them.

“Do something! Pull out in front of them!” Glimmer cried at Mermista, reaching forward to grab the steering wheel. The agent firmly shoved her back into her seat.

“This isn’t a TV show!” Mermista rejected the idea.

Glimmer tried to read the license plate, but the little lights that were supposed to illuminate it weren’t on. She couldn’t see a thing. Not the plate, nor the driver, nor Adora or Catra in the backseat. She looked at the car, then back at Bow. Then at the car. Then at Bow. Could they stop them, or at least make it so the police would be able to follow them? She didn’t know. ‘Bow!’ She mouthed, begging him for an answer, any answer.

At the last second, his eyes lit up, and he dove for his stuff under his seat. His bow came up, then his quiver, which rattled as he rifled through the arrows. Glimmer’s relief quickly turned to dread as he fumbled, struggling to find what he was looking for. "Bowww!" Glimmer cried. The car was growing closer by the second.

“What are you doing, kid?” Mermista asked sternly. “Sit down!”

“I got it I got it!” Bow suddenly declared, grabbing an arrow with a flat head, muttering, "Knew I should have color-coded them." as he nocked.

Glimmer’s heart was in her throat, looking up just as the car passed by. The instant after it was past, Bow stumbled out of the car, stood, and pulled his arrow back. Lifting his arm just a hair, he drew a breath, held, and released. With a fwip the black arrow vanished into the dark. There was silence for two seconds, then Glimmer saw a flash of shadow near the car's taillights as a soft thump echoed over the engine back to their ears. Unperturbed, the car roared off into the night.

Glimmer, stumbling out of the car after him, grabbed at her hair and pulled. “Bow!” Oh God, Mom was going to actually kill her now. This was like the 4th lifetime grounding, but still, this was the worst.

Mermista and Seahawk were out of the car right after her, the former looking pissed, the latter just confused. But Bow’s face was

all smiles. "I know, that was a great shot." He beamed, putting his weapon back over his shoulder. "Hundred yards in the dark."

Glimmer blinked at his reaction. "Wait, you weren't aiming for the tires?"

"What?" He lifted an eyebrow. "No!" He pulled out his phone, opened up maps, and showed everyone. "Tracking arrow."

Glimmer leaned in. "An Air Tag?" Relief hit her like a truck. "You're diabolical!"

"With some sticky paste on the end. Let's see . . ." Bow refreshed the page, and to Glimmer's relief, Mermista's begrudging respect, and Seahawk's awe, the geolocator appeared a quarter mile down the road. "Bullseye."

Chapter End Notes

Trigger Warnings: None

Umm, hi. Sorry for the delay (massive understatement). Not sure anyone cares, but a bunch of factors piled up over the last year that cause me to keep pushing back working on this.

The biggest thing is I bought a condo six months ago! (Which I thought was illegal for people in their 20s in this century, but apparently not, haha). My lovely place isn't quite a fixer-upper, but I'll be damned if every moment of my free time hasn't been swallowed up by painting and rewiring and replacing old broken stuff and shopping for the eight million things it turns out you need when you live on your own. Adulting man . . .

Even so, I could have gotten this done sooner were it not for this chapter being particularly difficult to write for me as well. Because stars, those 1600 words of Adora and Catra's argument nearly killed me. I've lost count of how many times I've rewritten it now. On and off, tearing it apart and reassembling the sections in different orders. Weeks on end

of just re-reading it over and over and over again, making tweaks or just starting over. I never want to look at it again. But I must admit, it was worth it because now I think it's one of my favorite pieces of dialogue in the whole story. I hope you agree and think it was at least worth maybe 1/3 of how long I made you all wait for it.

Unfortunately, the next one (or two, depending on if I break it up) chapters I can tell are still going to be a slog. But after that, we should be over the hump and into draft material that I'm much happier with, pretty much all the way to the end. Again, no promises on timing, but I WILL FINISH THIS!

Chapter 16: So Close

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra watched the streetlights and billboards stop as they passed the outer rings of the city. Beyond marked the return of empty, uninhabited desert, the return of stars in a cold, moonless sky. The stark land here was flat, the hills beyond windswept and contoured. All of it was drowning in the deepness of the night.

Adora's foot, which had been tapping furiously against the carpet since they got in the car, was slowing. Despite looking wound tighter than a fusion coil, Catra knew Adora was running on empty. Her species seemed to need to sleep about one-third of the time, and it was going on a full day and night now since she'd done so. She looked exhausted, and as minutes of silence passed, her eyes began to flutter, then close, only to spring open again with each bump in the road.

Catra drew her glance with a touch on the arm. "Get some rest." She said.

"But," Adora began.

Catra reached out and covered her mouth with the tips of her fingers, sending with it a judgmental look. Adora frowned, but nodded, and leaned back, shutting her eyes. There, at least now one of them would be-

"Soo . . ." Netossa broke the silence, and Adora jerked to attention. The muscles in Catra's claws twitched. Their driver was watching them through the rear-view mirror.

"Net . . ." Spinnerella warned with a gentle voice.

"What?" Netossa asked. "I'm just trying to be friendly."

“We both know what you’re really trying to do.” Her partner replied.

Catra and Adora blinked between the two women. Adora opened her mouth to speak, but was beaten by a question from Netossa. “So, what brought you to Huntara’s door on Christmas night?”

Spinnerella sighed, but didn’t protest. Catra looked to Adora to answer. She still hardly knew what this ‘Christmas’ thing was.

“I’m helping her to get home.” Adora said. “I’m taking her . . . back to her family.” Well, there were worse lies.

“I see.” Netossa nodded. “That’s pretty romantic, ain’t it Spinny? Helping your lover through thick and thin?”

“Honey,” Spinnerella sighed.

Catra didn’t know what ‘honey’ was, but she instantly understood the pair’s relationship from the soft, familiar, exasperated tone of that single word.

“She’s not my-!” Adora blurted out, swallowing and looking down. “She’s my friend.” She said, smoothing her pants with her palms.

Netossa laughed triumphantly at that. “Hah! See, I’m right!”

Spinnerella chuffed.

“What?” Netossa challenged.

“That doesn’t count.” Spinnerella said easily.

“Umm, no.” Netossa contradicted. “She said ***friend***, Spinny. What more do you need?”

“Do you even hear her?” Spinnerella replied.

“Wait,” Adora looked up, pointing at the pair. “Were you guys taking bets on why we’re out here?” Netossa looked in the

rearview mirror with a smirk on her face. “You were!” She accused.

“Spinny bet ten bucks you guys were in a lover’s quarrel. I said you were just friends.” Netossa revealed.

Catra refused to react to that statement. That . . . wasn’t what mattered.

“We are,” Adora said. “friends. I’m getting her home.”

That was what mattered. Catra had a mission, and even if it wasn’t the one she had been sent to this place to do, she was going to complete it, for Adora’s sake. For her planet’s sake. Nothing else mattered.

Spinnerella turned around in her seat to look back at the pair of them with a sigh.

Adora blinked. “What?”

Spinnerella smiled wanly, but didn’t answer.

“How much further, honey?” Netossa asked.

“Just a few minutes.” Spinnerella said.

“Few minutes? We can’t be at Goldstone yet.” Adora said.

“We’ve just got to make a quick stop.” Netossa said.

“Quick stop?” Catra asked, sensing Adora tense next to her.

“Don’t get your hackles up.” Netossa eased. “It’ll only be a few minutes.”

“Yep.” Spinnerella agreed. “Actually, it was quite convenient that you were both heading this direction. Saved us an extra trip delivering these-”

“You gonna tell them everything?” Netossa cut her off.

Spinnerella grimaced. “Whoops, sorry babe.”

“This was not part of the deal.” Adora said.

Netossa’s neutral tone darkened a shade. “The deal is we need to do this, and you’re going to sit still while we do it.”

“You’re smugglers.” Catra said. No need to be flowery about it.

“Well,” Spinnerella said, sounding at least a little ashamed. “It’s more complicated than that.”

“So you all say.” Catra answered.

Netossa looked at them through the rear-view mirror. “You want to get out here?”

Quiet obedience followed the threat. As promised, the car soon turned, swerving directly off the highway onto an unmarked dirt road. Adora looked sick as they headed down the track into absolute darkness.

As they rumbled over the gravel and dust, Catra felt that feeling building in her gut again. That anticipatory twisting. It didn’t mean there was going to be a fight, but the ones who stayed alive listened to that feeling every single time.

Their destination was revealed by the beams of the headlights. Ahead, on the side of the road, was a monument of some kind.

“What is that?” Adora asked.

“You’ve never heard of the Seven Magic Mountains?” Spinnerella asked brightly.

“Can’t say I have.” Adora admitted, not nearly so enthusiastic. The structure was a grouping of – yes, seven – stone monoliths, each made of half a dozen or so large boulders stacked up into columns. Each stone in the stack was painted a different, wildly bright color.

“It’s a roadside attraction. Or I guess more just a weird piece of art.” Spinnerella explained as they pulled over into what could only charitably be called a parking lot, some hundred yards from the rocks. It was empty save for one other black car parked a good distance away.

Netossa shut off the engine, and both their chaperones jumped out, opened the tailgate, and grabbed a pair of long, heavy-looking black plastic boxes, one handle of each box in each hand.

“Hey, so good idea? Not moving an inch.” Netossa warned callously. “We’ll be back in like, five minutes.” She set a box down to hit the trunk closing button. “Oh, and be quiet too.” She added as the tailgate shut them in. The lights of the interior of the car shut off, and the smugglers turned and started moving toward the monuments.

“And now we’re an accessory to whatever this is.” Adora whispered to herself. Catra reached across Adora and clicked the window on her side of the car down. “What are you doing?” Adora hissed as the motor whirred.

“Listening.” Catra whispered in her ear, her own swiveling to catch the receding words of their drivers. The air outside was still and cold. But it was a different cold to that of the snow-swept prairies. Instead of bitter, sharp, and painful, this was a dry, hollow cold. She pitied any animals adapted to survive here. Without the tint of the windows, Catra could easily see the pair walking towards the stone towers. They weren’t elegant, stumbling on the rough, rocky path.

“Ow!” One whisper-shouted when the other stepped on their foot.

“Sorry, babe.” The other hushed back.

She’d definitely seen better smugglers.

After what felt like an agonizingly long time, they reached the monument, and Catra watched for what came next. What came next was five figures stepping out from the far sides of the pillars,

clicking on flashlights and training them on Spinnerella and Netossa. When they swept over the car, Adora grabbed Catra and pulled her back, one hand covering her eyes. Catra came very close to clawing her.

"Watch your eyeshine." The human whispered, and Catra forced herself to calm. Pressing Adora away, she fished through her pockets and found her sunglasses, putting them on, then pushing Adora back to the far side of the car.

"Watch your hair." She replied, taking a lower position by the open window, keeping only her eyes and ears over the sill. It was much harder to see with the glasses on, but she could still hear just as well. Adora stayed back, pulling her hood up to obscure her blondeness.

Voices came with the flashlights.

"Good morning." Netossa said.

"Merry Christmas!" Spinnerella said brightly.

"We're not here for eggnog." A gruff voice replied. Yep, five people. The one who had spoken had a huge, hulking silhouette. "You got it?" He asked.

"Right here." Netossa set down the boxes with her partner.

The big man made some kind of gesture, and some of his friends moved forward and opened the crates. A moment of inspection, then a briefcase was produced. "Pleasure doing business." He held it out.

Netossa reached to grab it, and it was at that exact moment that a pair of lights flashed over Catra and Adora from behind. They jumped, twisting to see a car coming up the road. They locked eyes with each other, immediately realizing what was happening. Catra had no idea how, but Glimmer and Bow had tracked them here.

Out among the Magic Mountains Catra heard, “What the hell?” and “Who the fuck is that?” From the goons. She turned back around and pulled off her glasses. Guns had come up.

“Whoa whoa! Easy.” Netossa said as she and her partner put their hands in front of them. Catra’s gut twisted tighter. She could hear Adora’s heartbeat through her chest.

“You trying to screw us?” The big man, the boss, asked, dead serious.

“No.” Netossa assured.

“We don’t know who those guys are.” Spinnerella said.

“So, you were followed then.” He said with a huff. “And you think that’s better? Grab them.” There were shouts of complaints as the goons took hold of Netossa and Spinnerella. Then the boss said, “Check their car.”

Catra rolled the window up.

“What’s going on?” Adora asked. Catra looked the other way. There was no way the incoming car got to them before the goons did. “Catra!” She whispered desperately.

“The deal’s gone sour. We’re about to have company.” She said, thinking quickly. “Can we start the car without the key?”

Adora blinked rapidly, trying to keep up despite looking exhausted. “I don’t know how to hotwire a car.” She said.

“Then can we use your phone somehow?”

“I think they still have it.” Adora said, “And how would that help us?”

“I don’t know! I have no idea what half the things on there do!” Catra admitted.

Adora, despite the panic, chuckled at that. “You’re a bad spy.”

“Fine, sure. But we need to go.” She jumped over Adora, going to the door facing away from the Magic Mountains and the deteriorating situation taking place beneath them. But when she opened it, the opposite one swung out at the same time, and a flashlight exploded the interior of the car into sharp relief.

“Don’t move!” The person who’d opened it, lit in silhouette, barked, reaching in and grabbing Adora by the wrist.

Adora yelped. “Stop! Let go of me!” She flailed, trying to get the man off her, but his grip was too strong, and she started to be pulled out of the car.

“Adora!” Catra lunged after her, getting her other arm and shoulder. Adora’s blue eyes were so wide, shocked full of fear.

There was a brief tug of war. Adora tried to kick at her assailant, but the angle was awkward and did little to slow him down. Catra, in response, tried to pull Adora back, but the tug elicited a sharp, pained gasp from Adora. Catra instinctively dropped her arm. She’d grabbed the one Adora had dislocated. That momentary lapse was all the man needed to tug Adora halfway into the night.

“Run, Catra!” Adora cried, her fingernails sliding uselessly over the leather seats.

Catra’s entire body wanted to dive after her, wanted to throw herself at the enemy and shred them to pieces. But against that red haze that filled her mind was the twisting. The twisting that was screaming to hold her back. So, even as she watched Adora be dragged away, she didn’t attack. Instead, before the man could get Adora under control and go after her, she ducked out the far door and vanished into the dark.

The Dragon’s Daughter III’s headlights illuminated the strange, colorful rocks, revealing five men with guns standing over three silhouettes. One had blonde hair.

“I’m going to kill her.” Glimmer muttered. “If we survive this, I am going to actually literally murder her.”

“What do we do?” Bow asked.

“And where’s Catra?” Glimmer scowled. “If she had something to do with this . . .”

Mermista had a hard look on her face. “No speculation.” She ordered. “We don’t know what’s going on here.” Her fingers tapped on the wheel. “Yeah, so this is the point where we stop compromising on you two’s safety.” She revealed. “We’re going to handle this.”

Glimmer wasn’t arguing this time.

“We should all get out of the car.” Seahawk said. “They’ll be less rash when they know where everyone is.”

“Mmm.” Mermista nodded and shut off the car, but left the headlights on. She turned to the back seat. “We’re all going to get out, and I need you two to stand in a place that’s visible but keep behind the car. If things go south, hide behind it. You got that?”

Bow and Glimmer glanced at one another, then nodded.

“Seahawk?” Mermista turned to her partner, who also nodded, this time without a cheesy quip. Somehow, that fact made Glimmer the most nervous about their situation. “Alright, let’s go.”

Adora watched the two figures walk towards them in the headlight beams. Their shadows stretched long in front of them; Adora’s and the Magic Mountains’ tailed long behind. The men who had come to buy whatever was in those black cases had pistols out. She pulled at her hands, bound behind her back by actual metal handcuffs, wondering if her heart had ever beaten this fast for this long.

“Ahoy there!” One of the figures called as they came close. It was Seahawk.

“No fucking way.” Netossa muttered.

Sure enough, Mermista and Seahawk became visible in the glare and were halted with a firm, “That’s far enough.” From the boss, who was a massive man with a huge chest and shirt that was at least two sizes too small for it. “Who the hell are you and what the hell do you want?”

“We’re here for . . .” Mermista began, then trailed off when she saw the two women kneeling next to Adora. “Netossa? Spinnerella?” She blinked.

“Wait, you know these guys!?” Adora asked, incredulous. Things were still getting more complicated. She was beginning to hate the fact that things kept getting more complicated.

“Guess it is a small world after all.” Spinnerella chuckled, voice warm despite also being handcuffed. “How’s it going? Mermista? Seahawk?”

“I’ve had better days.” Mermista replied. “Guessing you two have too?”

“Just a couple.” Spinnerella joked.

“Put it on the list!” Seahawk barked happily, and Spinnerella laughed like she was hearing an old joke.

“Everybody shut up!” The boss seized control of the conversation again. Everyone did, and his voice echoed over the black desert. “What the fuck do you two want?”

“Chill out, dude.” Mermista replied. “We’re here for . . .” She glanced down the line. “these guys. We didn’t know anyone else would be here.”

“Ah.” The boss exhaled. There was a long pause, too long. Adora’s hairs began to rise on the back of her neck.

“What?” Mermista eventually asked.

“Why do you care about them?”

“That’s none of your business.” Mermista dismissed. Adora clenched her jaw. This guy didn’t seem like the kind to take a rebuff like that in stride.

“Mermista.” Seahawk interrupted quietly, a hand on her wrist. He seemed to agree.

Mermista glanced at him, sloughed off the grip, but did lower her tone. “Alright, looks like things have gotten testy here. Have you gotten paid?”

“. . . Yeah.” The boss said.

“Then you take your goods, we take our friends, everybody’s happy.” Mermista proposed. “Nobody has to get hurt.”

“No, they don’t.” The boss replied. Adora felt the ‘but’ coming, but still flinched when he said it. “But I ain’t one to hand over something I have for free.” He slapped his hand down on Adora’s shoulder, and her entire torso tensed. “How about a trade?” Mermista only stared back at him silently, so he continued. “We’ll give you these three, and in exchange, you give me . . . him.” He raised a finger to point. Everyone turned to Seahawk.

Mermista actually laughed. “What the hell do you want with . . .” It died as soon as she saw the look on Seahawk’s face. Adora realized that Seahawk had been looking very nervous throughout this entire exchange. “Oh fuck, what did you do?” Mermista asked.

Seahawk laughed nervously. “Ahah, Scurvy!” He addressed the leader with a wide, shaky smile. “Long time no see! You’re looking well.”

And everybody knew each other. Adora cursed internally. Of course they did.

"Little Seahawk, back in the desert after all these years." The boss, Scurvy, tisked. "Gotta say, not a smart move. Not that you've ever made any of those before." The goons snickered. "If I recall correctly, that price the Deserts put on your head never did have an expiration date, did it, boys?" The color seemed to drain from Seahawk's face. "But he never told you about any of that, did he, girlie?" He asked Mermista.

"Now, Scurvy." Seahawk eased nervously. "I know we didn't part on the best of terms, but . . ."

"You burned out three of my Escalades!" Scurvy barked, rage bubbling.

"And you worked for him." Mermista realized.

Yep, Adora **hated** that things kept getting more complicated.

"How do you know they still care about him?" Mermista asked.

Adora could feel Scurvy's smile as he put on a mocking pirate accent. "Fret not, lassie. If them thar bounty do prove to have gone dry, methinks I'll be happy to take my pound from him in flesh instead of gold." The goons laughed. "So, do we have a deal?" He asked, voice like a knife. Adora stared into Mermista's eyes as she debated internally for several seconds.

"My dearest!" Seahawk cried in alarm at her hesitation.

"Doesn't look like you care for him too much anyway." Scurvy noticed.

Mermista bit her lip, then grumbled out. "Why do you always have to make my job so hard?" The shuffling of clothes was followed by the clicking of metal. Adora saw the dark glint of her gun barrel. In an instant, everyone's weapons were up.

“You do care!” Seahawk cried for joy.

Mermista ignored him. “Your crates. Our friends. No trades.” She demanded once again.

“Brave.” Scurvy raised an eyebrow. “Stupid, but brave. It’s five versus two. Think you can take those odds?”

“Think you’re willing to risk it all over a payday?” Mermista replied.

There was a silence then. One breath, two. The stillness of the night trembled with tight wrists and narrow eyes, precarious. Adora’s knees ached against the ice-cold ground. She looked towards the road, where the silhouettes of Bow and Glimmer were watching from beside the car. The stars were so bright out here.

Then one of the goons screamed. Adora’s eyes moved just in time to see his flashlight land in the sand, and the last of his legs being yanked into the darkness.

Flashlights swung, but by the time the beams got there, the goon was sitting on the ground against one of the pillars, groaning and clutching the back of his head. There was a red stain on the pillar he’d be slammed against. Catra.

All hell broke loose.

Gunfire was overwhelming, as it turned out. Blinding muzzle flashes. Ear-ringing gunshots. Fury that crisscrossed through the air. Adora's brain was filled to panic. Everyone else ran for cover, sliding behind the nearest pillar. But Adora sat, shocked still, kneeling in the dirt.

Netossa slammed into her side. Adora gasped as she was knocked over, barely understanding what was going on when the blue-haired woman jammed her head between her bound arm and shoulder. Bracing her neck against her armpit, the smuggler lifted Adora into the air, carrying her out of the line of fire. She made only five steps before stumbling, but that was enough. They went down together behind a pillar, sprawling into the dirt. Sharp points

dug into Adora's cheek as she slid face-down against sand and gravel. She may or may not have yelped at the pain; she couldn't hear over the raging of bullets.

"Sorry." Netossa grunted over the cacophony, disentangling herself from Adora. "You alright?"

"Buhh." Adora managed, sitting up as the pops and whistles continued from every direction.

"Ahh, first firefight?" Netossa asked, as if making casual conversation. She backed into the rock, trying to find a sharp point to break the chain of her handcuffs on. Adora looked at her as if she were the alien here.

Speaking of, "I owe you one." Catra said to Netossa, emerging from the darkness of the desert like a shadow, nearly giving Adora's already pounding heart a full-on cardiac episode. "Deep breaths, Princess." She ordered Adora. Once again, that hard voice of hers cut through the din, and Adora started to breathe deep. As she did, Catra reached behind her and, with a sharp yank, split the handcuffs holding her apart.

"How did you do that?" Netossa asked in awe.

"Like this." Catra said, moving over and breaking hers next. "Care for a gun?" She held a pistol up by the slide. Adora only realized much later that Catra had gotten the weapon from the goon she bodied.

Netossa smirked. "Merry Christmas indeed." She took it and leaned around the boulder, joining the fray.

"Stay here." Catra told Adora. "Stay down."

Adora somehow managed a nod, and Catra vanished back into the dark again.

No sooner was she gone than another body rushed over to them from another pillar. "Ah! Netossa!" Seahawk called joyfully as his

back slammed next to hers.

“Seahawk.” Netossa smirked. “You always have a way of making things exciting, you know that?”

Seahawk laughed with his whole chest. “I knew you missed me.” He declared, then asked. “How was the honeymoon?”

“Beautiful!” Netossa beamed, then leaned around the pillar to take a shot. “How’s going straight?”

“Lots of paperwork.” Seahawk admitted. They were talking like they’d run into each other at the grocery store. A bullet pinged off the rock they were hiding behind, sending a flash of stony shards spraying into the sand just inches from Adora’s foot.

When had her life turned into an action movie?

Catra’s claws dragged the screaming man behind another pillar, and just like the first, a swift smash to the back of the head sent him writhing in the dirt. There was a voice like Shadow Weaver’s in her head, telling her to kill the man, but she tuned it out, simply grabbing his gun and rushing back off into the dark before his friends could follow, Catra slid down behind another pillar, listening to the frightened words of the men still standing.

“What is that!?” One of the two remaining goons asked over the gunfire.

“Mountain lion.” The other goon said.

“Bullshit. Not out here.” The first replied.

“No. They are.”

“Even if, the noise would scare them off.”

“Shut up, both of you.” Scurvy barked.

Catra, remembering the video Glimmer had shown her yesterday, let a grumbling yowling sound from deep in her throat, as loud as she could. The gunfire ceased. The battle easiest to win was the one you didn't have to fight. Catra just hoped intimidation would be enough to scare them off. The crates they'd come here for were right next to them. They could just take them and go.

One of the two remaining henchmen had the exact same idea. "Boss, let's get out of here."

"Yeah." The other echoed.

"Not a damn chance." Scurvy replied, cuffing his man with the back of his hand. "I'm getting what I deserve out of that sniveling worm."

Catra's sensitive ears picked up the whimper of Seahawk in the distance. She rolled her eyes. Feet treading silently over the sand, she peeked around one side of the rock stack she was using for cover. Behind one of the other outer pillars, backs lit by the headlights of the car, were Scurvy and his henchmen. Her angle was terrible. If she stepped out, she too would be fully lit by the headlights.

She slipped to the other side. Across the center of the Magic mountains were her allies. Behind one pillar, barely visible, were Netossa, Seahawk, and Adora. One pillar closer was Spinnerella, still handcuffed, unarmed, and smartly trying to keep low.

Catra waved at the latter, drawing the pink-haired woman's eyes. She signaled for her to make a noise. Spinnerella tilted her head, confused. And of course, they had no idea what that meant. "Aliens." She muttered, then tried again, cupping her hands around her mouth and mock shouting, then pointing in the direction of the enemy.

This time, she got it. Spinnerella flashed a thumbs-up. At least Catra knew that gesture. She crept back to the other side of the pillar, readied herself, and waited for the opportune moment.

“Nobody has to die here tonight!” Spinnerella called out. “We can all just walk away! Don’t be stupid!”

“You wanna walk away!?” Scurvy called. “All you gotta do is give me what I want!”

Catra peeked out. All three of them were looking in the direction of Spinnerella’s voice.

“That’s not happening, man!” Netossa replied. “Take what you can get!”

“I will! You’ve got ten seconds to come out with your hands up!” He ordered, then started counting. Nine! Eight! Seven!”

Catra took one last look, then dashed out with gun pointed. The firearms on this planet seemed to work in the same way as the ones she’d used for years. She came into view of the three men still standing behind the pillar, picked her target, and squeezed the trigger.

With a violent kick in her hands, one of the goons crumpled to the ground. By the time he was down, Catra was already back behind her pillar.

“SHIT!” The other goon yelled, interrupting Scurvy’s count and calling their comrade’s name, kneeling at their side.

“I’m good.” The strained reply came from the man on the ground. Catra had made sure to shoot him in the meat of his leg.

“Jesus, dude, you’ve been shot, you are not okay!” The other goon cried.

“Eyes up!” Scurvy focused his men. Catra peeked around from her new hiding spot, eye-catching in the headlights. She expected them all to be distracted. But Scurvy surprised her, already aiming in the right spot. A bullet broke a chip off her rock an instant after Catra ducked back behind it. Too close. She took a deep breath,

then made more mountain lion sounds to scare them. Come on you bastards, run!

“Seriously, what the hell is that!?” The man she’d shot asked.

“Doesn’t matter.” Scurvy said. “I meant what I said!” He bellowed out to everyone. “Come out now, and I won’t make you all watch Seahawk die!”

This guy was crazy. No smuggler talked like that. None that lived long anyway.

Crack crack! A pair of bullets crossed between the pillars, and there was a deep grunt. Netossa or Seahawk had hit Scurvy.

This was her opportunity, Catra reacted. She stepped out to finish the job. Scurvy and his goons were distracted, the boss struggling to his feet. He’d also been hit in the leg. Catra pointed and squeezed, but the gun only clicked in her hand. Shit! She fled back behind cover. Did the idiot she’d taken down not fully load his gun!? Or maybe she just didn’t know how to use it.

Catra heard the shuffling in the dirt as Scurvy stood.

“Give it up man!” Netossa shouted.

The last uninjured henchman spoke quietly to Scurvy. “He’s bleeding pretty bad, boss.” He said of the man Catra had shot. “We should go.” He implored, then added. “It ain’t worth it.”

“I said, shut up!” Was all Scurvy said.

Catra weighed her options. No more ammo, none she could guarantee at least. That meant she needed to get close. But she’d be completely exposed if she stepped out into the headlights and tried to cross between the pillars. She wished they had turned off the car when they parked. Wait . . .

Catra turned, and there, cowering in the car’s shadow, were Bow and Glimmer, looking terrified. Catra waved at them, drawing their

eyes, and started making motions to get them to shut the car off. They looked at her like she was an alien. UGH!

No choice then. “Shut the fucking car off, you idiots!” She bellowed at them.

Everyone’s attention turned to the pair, who flinched at being called out. Thankfully, none of the buyers chose to use the moment to take an easy shot at them. After a pause, Bow opened the door to switch off the headlights.

The tension in the air spiked. There would be a brief moment of darkness before all their eyes adjusted to the starlight. This fight would be decided in those few seconds. Scurvy and his one uninjured henchman whispered to each other before the curtain dropped. No human would have had any hope of hearing what they were planning under their breaths.

But Catra wasn’t human.

Bow turned off the headlights, and the battlefield was plunged into darkness. Catra didn’t move. She listened, ready for what was coming. It came with a distinctive sound. Step, drag. Step, drag. Step drag. Scurvy, limping on his wound, coming closer.

My mind is the face of the universe. Catra set her gun down in the sand, readying for the moment he came around the pillar. My mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed. When he did, he didn’t expect her to leap down on him from ten feet up. My mind is magic.

Her claws slashed his clothes as they went down together. One arm pinned his gun away from his body. The motion made him squeeze the trigger and sent a wild shot ricocheting off the rocks beside them, whisking past her ear. Catra pinned him down and pried his gun away, taking the victory to thank her perennial luck one more time. Discipline, training, skill, it all kept you alive on the battlefield. But no one who survived to the end of wars did so

without luck. Catra wasn't sure if luck was something that could be measured, but if it was, she had more than she deserved.

Catra bared her teeth down at the human pinned below her, his massive frame unable to budge her alien strength. The anger and confidence on his face was gone now, replaced with utter terror. His words shook when he asked. "What . . . are you?"

An alien. A soldier. A medic. A killer. A healer. A spy. A traitor: to herself, and now to her people. A survivor. "I'm Catra." She said, then raised her voice. "I got your boss!" She called to the last henchman. "Put down your gun!"

She heard him drop it like it was red hot.

If Glimmer had eaten in the last 12 hours, she surely would have thrown up by now. Instead, she sat, stomach roiling as the gunshots cracked and echoed, each seeming a nail being pounded into a coffin. Her blood turned as cold as the tears freezing on her cheeks.

But then, after what felt like an eternity but was probably no more than 2 minutes, the sound of gunfire stopped, and was replaced by the shouts of familiar and unfamiliar voices crossing between the strange, colorful pillars.

"No screams." She shuddered. There hadn't been any screams. That meant . . . did that mean?

One of the voices talking in the distance was Seahawk, who soon called them over with a request for duct tape from the trunk.

Kneeling in the center of the stones, the five men who had attacked them were bound by the tape. Doing the taping was Mermista and Seahawk, as well as two other women Glimmer didn't know. The drivers of the car Adora and Catra had been in. Speaking of, Catra was standing there too. Glimmer met her eyes, and she couldn't help but stare at the alien, nerves twitching. Where did she stand? What had happened to get them here?

Catra rolled her eyes at this reaction. “Relax, Glimmer.” Catra eased. “I’m on your side now.”

“She is.” Another voice entered the conversation. Glimmer snapped to look at Adora as she approached them, looking utterly spent. Her normally perfect posture was hunched, her eyes half closed, and there were red scratches on her cheek. “Sorry, I didn’t text. Things . . . got a little out of hand.”

Glimmer didn’t have it in her to reply with a sarcastic comment to that understatement and a half. She just ran up to her sister and seized her in a crushing hug, which was readily returned.

Scurvy tried to shout something, but his mouth was immediately covered by tape with the blue-haired driver’s hand. “So,” She said after muffling him. “this was fun.”

“Yeah, fun.” The pink-haired driver she was with said dryly. “You okay, babe?” She asked.

“Fine.” The first woman replied. “How are you all?” She asked everyone else. A quick check led to the confirmation they’d all somehow made it out of this with nothing more than bumps and scrapes.

“What do we do with these guys?” The pink-haired woman asked. “Get out of here, then call it in anonymously? I feel bad leaving the ones who got shot out here in the cold.”

“The wounds are mostly superficial.” Mermista replied, who was currently dressing the shot goon’s bleeding leg with his own jacket. “They should be fine for the hour or so it takes an ambulance to get here.”

“Still . . .” The pink-haired woman persisted. “Do you two got a hotline for these kinds of things?” She asked Mermista and Seahawk.

Before Mermista could reply, there were blinding spotlights on them, lighting them the same instant as the whooping of sirens

echoed over the desert. A dozen police cars were bearing down on the lot. Some were already parked, officers spilling out with flashlights and guns.

“You’re all under arrest!” Came through a megaphone.

Glimmer’s eyes went wide as plates, and she spun to Mermista. “You promised no cops!”

Mermista looked at her with something like pity. “I lied.”

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None

Everyone go to listen to this right now: A Light or Something' - Warriors. I listened to it for the first time this week, and oh my God, it’s so this story coded. If this thing were a musical, our two favorite idiots would sing something very like it, I’m sure.

Chapter 17: The Best Way Out

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was imagining her prom night when the sun came up through the little slit window near the ceiling of the county jail cell. Her dress would be red; Glimmer's would be pink. Her sister was going with Bow, of course. Adora was going alone, and there were flowers woven into her braid. But then, right as Angella and Micah would try to shuffle them into the yard to take the obligatory pictures, the doorbell would ring,

And Catra would be there, in a suit she hardly knew how to put on.

And she would have a bowtie and a corsage that matched Adora's dress.

And she would joke about how she couldn't drive her to the ugly hotel where the dance was being held because she wasn't a citizen and didn't own a car.

And Adora would joke back that they couldn't exactly take her escape pod either.

And when they danced together, surrounded by sweaty bodies sipping smuggled-in booze, Catra wouldn't have to hide her ears of tail from anyone. They would just dance, eyes only on each other, laughing and stepping on each other's feet.

Adora was crying, but not for the reason most people did in cells.

She kept quiet so as not to wake the others.

The police managed to get Adora's broken handcuffs off, only for another pair to go right back on. They were all read their rights and taken to the police station of some small desert town she

didn’t even know the name of. There, Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Bow were all locked up together in a cinderblock cell, one with actual metal bars and everything. She was never going to forget the thunderous sound of the rollers as the door slammed shut. She was pretty sure everyone else they’d been arrested with were in the adjacent cells.

They had all already been tired, but when that was added up with the numb shock of being arrested and having their mugshots and fingerprints taken, well, it pushed them all over the edge of exhaustion. So, even though there were nervous glances between Catra and Bow and Glimmer, and unsaid words, they all fell back onto the plastic benches that lined each wall of the cell and crashed into unconsciousness, even Catra.

It was the rising sunlight falling in her eyes that had woken Adora. She’d gotten a few hours of rest, at least. Not that that eased her aching head and heart. The others were still snoozing. Catra was curled up in a ball at the far end of her bench, tail resting over her eyes. Bow and Glimmer were at 90 degrees to each other in the other corner, Glimmer’s head resting on Bow’s shoulder.

The door at the end of the hall their cell adjoined to clunked open, and Adora heard footsteps. She looked up as a police officer came up to their cell, a melancholy expression on their face as they surveyed the scene. “. . . Can I help you?” Adora asked, quiet enough to not wake the others. The police officer melted away, twisting and turning into a new shape, a lean reptilian one. Adora’s eyes widened. “You.”

“Me.” Double Trouble confirmed, voice not at all hostile. “And to answer your question, no.”

This was the first time Adora saw the changeling unmasked in full light. As a shape in the dark, Adora had thought them tall, and they were, at least six feet in this - their current and seemingly default form - but they seemed even taller from how thin they were. To Adora’s eyes, their long slender body was too narrow, impossibly or, well, inhumanly so. It didn’t make them any less

unnerving, looming over the cell. Adora tried to control her breathing, but it was very difficult when she knew too well that they could walk through the bars separating them as if they weren't even there.

"Aww, too scared to speak?" Double Trouble asked when the silence stretched. They kept their voice low, seemingly also not wanting to wake the others. "That's alright. Here, I'll add your lines in." Double Trouble took a step to the left and, in a flash, turned into a replica of Adora.

Adora stared at herself as the duplicate gained a truly terrified expression on her face. Was that how she looked right now? "Why . . . why are you here?" They asked as her.

Double Trouble took a step to the right and turned back into themselves. "Oh, I'm so glad you asked." They answered themself. "Honestly? I'm curious." They admitted. "Here I left your little troupe shocked, aghast before the truth. All bickering and accusing one another. I expected that to be the end of the show. But what do I find instead? You're all still together." They noted, staring at Adora, waiting for a response.

When they didn't get one, they once again assumed Adora's form. "So?" They asked as her.

They changed back. "Why?" Double Trouble responded.

Back to Adora. "What makes you think I'd tell you anything?"

Back to Double Trouble. "Don't be so dismissive of me."

Back to Adora, "You literally attacked us."

Back to Double Trouble. "Oh, relax. That was all part of the performance, Blondie!" They insisted. "Besides, you're only counting the bad moments? No appreciation for the time I rescued you from that state police officer, stopped them right in their boots?"

Adora blinked. What? What were they - the motel in Snowville. Catra had come into the office and stopped the state trooper and the woman at the desk with shards from the radio lens. That . . . hadn't actually been Catra. Double Trouble smiled unnaturally wide at her realization. "Aww, it's okay if you didn't recognize me." They assured. "I wasn't myself at the time." Adora didn't find that funny, especially when it came with a reminder that yes, Double Trouble had been on this journey too. Just hidden behind the scenes.

"When I saw you four still together," They continued. "I first thought, well, there you go, this species really is just stupid. Just a bunch of industrial age bipeds running around, poisoning their planet, and killing each other in new exciting ways." They frowned and said, deadpan. "Charming. But yesterday I snuck into a few of your species' higher security facilities and found out that said bipeds have figured out nuclear weapons, so obviously you have a few brain cells up in those heads of yours." They poked their own dome. "So, then I thought: you're just an unusually loyal species. That happens, you know, certain groups get all uptight about always keeping to oaths and honor debts and all that crap. But then I remembered you abandoned your own parents like it was nothing. So obviously that can't be it."

Adora's brows were so tense and low they were starting to hurt. Whereas Double Trouble seemed as calm as could be, almost mirthful. "So, if it's not those two, then Kitten must have just told you a damn good lie to keep you on side. And if that's the case, then bravo to her. It would be her best one yet."

Adora resisted a scoff. Partially because of how preposterous the thought of Catra still lying to her after their very emotional conversation in the warehouse, and partially because Adora didn't want to accidentally give Double Trouble any information on Catra's new loyalties.

But however much she resisted a reaction, obviously Double Trouble saw something in her. "Ah, it was that one." They nodded. "Make sense. I wonder what she told you? Maybe . . . she

threatened you?" They postulated, pointily glancing at Adora for a reaction. "Or maybe she offered you all comfy positions in The Rebellion after all this is over? . . . Or maybe she even told you that she changed her ways. That she's on your side now."

"She didn't lie to me." Adora's mouth moved before she could stop it.

"Ahh, there she is." Double Trouble cooed. "You sound confident."

Adora kept her mouth firmly closed again, so Double Trouble shrugged and once again morphed into Adora. But Adora was tired of their puppet show. "You may be able to look like me, but you don't know how I think." She told them.

The faux Adora smiled back at her, a sharp smile that didn't look right on her face. "I'm going to stop Double Trouble with Catra and my friend's help. Together we're going to Goldstone, fix the lens, contact the Fright Zone, and tell them there's no way they can conquer this planet, thus stopping you." Real Adora wasn't able to fully contain her reaction to how close to the truth that was.

Double Trouble changed back into themselves. "How was that? You can correct me if I'm wrong." They offered. Adora said nothing, and Double Trouble sighed. "Of all the uncontacted planets I've been on, I've never met any quite like your species. You're certainly something, humans. Lots of hope. Lots of sadness, too. Suppose that's why you still think your little plan is more admirable than stupid." They paused to judge her reaction, adding when they didn't get one, "That's a compliment, by the way."

Adora resisted rolling her eyes.

"It's much more stupid, by the way." Double Trouble added. ". . . That one wasn't a compliment." Adora figured that out. She just glared at the smarmy alien. "Aww, so serious." They cooed. "You really need to learn to lighten up."

Adora remained silent. Double Trouble, seeing her lack of a reaction, shrugged and turned back into a copy of her. “Well, sorry if I’m not too enthused to be talking to you.” They said as her, then paused. “Hmm, would you use that word there? Enthused? What do you think?”

So, they weren’t perfect. Adora thought. But Double Trouble was already moving on, turning back into themselves. “Come now, you don’t even know anything about me! Anything that’s true anyway. No, it’s all been from Catra, hasn’t it, that paragon of trustworthiness?”

“Catra’s told me enough,” Adora spoke for herself. “You attacked us without telling her first. I think that’s enough to form an opinion.”

Double Trouble hissed, a sound like a rumbling alligator. “Catra forced my hand when she went off script. I had to . . . improvise.” A scowl briefly knitted their liquid brow, then vanished just as quickly, and the annoyance in their voice was replaced by that nigh sadistic glee once more. “Pretty effectively if I do say so myself.”

“And look where that got you,” Adora noted. They’d successfully duped three teenagers.

“Big talk from someone in a cage.” Double Trouble retorted, but then sighed. “Like I’m doing better. Mine may be bigger than yours, but it’s a cage all the same.” They gestured all around them. “Not that it’ll matter, in the end.”

“We’ll stop you,” Adora assured, regretting it the moment it came from her mouth. That might imply Catra was in on it.

Double Trouble blinked. “Stop me?” They touched their own chest with splayed fingers. “Ohoho, please, tell me, stop me from doing what?”

Well, she was in it now. “From whatever it is you’re planning.” She said. “From telling the Horde to invade Earth.”

Double Trouble looked at her with something like pity. “You know, I’ve done this job even longer than Kitten over there has.” They gestured at Catra, still asleep. “So, trust me when I say, I’ve seen *this*” They waved their hand over Adora, “before. Kids like you, so brave, so kind. Hearts so big they’re fit for bursting. They’re always so excited to have the big secret revealed to them: life in the stars. They’ve looked up from their little farms into the vastness their whole lives and seen infinite possibility. But, to peel back the curtain, out there? There’s no possibility. It’s only inevitability.”

Adora stood and stared the shapeshifted down. “I’m not going to give up.” She vowed.

Double Trouble smiled at her. “You do understand, right? I could walk through those bars right now and snap all your pretty little necks without breaking a sweat.”

Adora let out a shaky exhale. “Then why haven’t you?”

“Because it wouldn’t matter.” They said. “You won’t believe it, but I’m not the bad guy here, human. Oh sure, it’s fun to play one when given the opportunity, and yes, I am a killer, just like Catra.” Their eyes darted over to their sleeping form. “But at this point, it would just be wasteful. Kill you - spare you, stop me - don’t stop me, contact the Fright Zone - don’t contact the Fright Zone, it’ll all end the same way, Blondie. Your world’s been marked. Hordak is coming. There’s no stopping this.”

It was the calmness with which they spoke that struck Adora most deeply. They were talking about sending more scouts down, like Catra implied. “We’ll let everyone know,” Adora promised. “We’ll stop you, then we’ll stop the next scouts, and the ones after that, until they stop coming.”

“And it won’t matter.” Double Trouble assured. “The Rebellion is fighting a war to the death. Hundreds of thousands are lost every single day. On that scale, a few dozen scouts are nothing, especially against eight billion potential recruits.”

Adora inhaled sharply. “And if those recruits refuse to join your little war.”

“I would hardly call a battle for the survival of the galaxy little, Blondie.”

“You’re saying the Horde is secretly the good guys?”

“Oh, they are.” Double Trouble replied easily. “But, as someone used to looking through other people’s eyes, I understand your fear.” They paused. “Catra told you, didn’t she? That we’re fighting for people like you to exist. Or would you prefer Horde Prime sterilizes your world? I would certainly prefer that your species recognizes the greater good here. I’ve seen it when people don’t, and trust me, it gets messy. A planet resisting us, it’s a grisly thing.” They ran their hand through their long hair for a moment, remembering. “Here, since you are a *captive* audience right now.” A ghost of a smile flickered over their face. “Let me give you some advice. After you get out of here . . . leave. Go home. Go back to your family with your friends. Apologize to them, go live your life, as much as you can before the fleet arrives.” Adora scowled, and Double Trouble sighed. “I know it’s not what you want, but trust me, it’s the best deal you’re gonna get.”

“And what will you do if we don’t?” Adora challenged. “What will you do if we fight?” Double Trouble straightened and locked their eerie yellow eyes with Adora, pupils tall and narrow.

“Nothing.”

Adora blinked. “Nothing?”

“Nothing at all.” They confirmed. “I don’t think you get it. You four could do anything in the world now, and it wouldn’t make a difference. You can scream, you can hide, and yes, you can try and fight, find a way to stop the invasion. Honestly, please try; it’ll be fun to watch. But whatever path you take, the end will be exactly the same. The Horde will come, your planet will surrender, with or without a fight, and you’ll join the Rebellion. The script is

already written, little human. You and me? We're just actors. All we can do is read our lines and try to have as much fun as we can before the end of the tragedy."

Adora refused to believe that. The future was not fixed like that. "Not all plays are tragedies."

Double Trouble shrugged. "Maybe. Or maybe you just get cynical after watching the inevitable so many times. In either case, good luck, little human. Enjoy the time you have, in this fight you think you can win. Don't say you weren't warned, and oh yeah . . . I'll be watching." They turned to go, but paused. "Oh, and one more thing." Their face took on a look of genuine candor. "While you have the chance, look up at the stars. Feel that possibility, because it doesn't ever come back." They walked away, slamming the door to the hall on their way out.

The bang startled her cellmates awake. Catra jumped from her curled-up position nearly a foot into the air, landing on her knees, eyes on a swivel.

"What was that?" Bow asked, rubbing sleep from his eyes.

Adora's legs felt like jelly. She sank down beside Catra, her heart still hammering. "Double Trouble." She said.

"Oh." Bow exhaled.

"Yeah." Adora looked up at the others. Catra looked angry, Bow nervous, Glimmer still exhausted. Nobody had said much while the police were arresting them. Adora had sat next to Glimmer in the back of one of their cars, both silent the whole ride.

"What did they want?" Catra asked.

"I don't really know . . ." Adora admitted. She reached up to rub her forehead, but hissed when her fingers brushed over raw skin. Oh, right, she had done a skateboard grind with her face in the sand back there.

Catra was at her immediately. “Are you alright?”

“Yeah.” Adora dismissed. “I’m fine.”

“You’re not.” Catra denied. Adora looked at her in protest before noticing both Catra and Glimmer giving the exact same look. “Come here.” The former said.

Adora was forced to sit and point out all the spots she was sore or scuffed, and on each, Catra applied a little patch of her skinsuit. While she did, Adora explained some of what Double Trouble had said. “They said it was all pointless, from the start.” She finished, voice a mumble.

Bow turned to Catra. “Is that true?”

Catra finished the last patch on Adora, exhaling and letting her arms drop to her lap. She thought for a few seconds, thumb rubbing against her forefinger. “That’s what they believe,” Catra said. “And it's not . . . wrong. No planet ever selected by the Rebellion has ever made it out the other side not a part of it.”

“This was all for nothing?” Glimmer muttered.

“That’s not what I said.” Catra stood, moving over to help Bow and Glimmer with their scrapes. “What I mean is: they’re not lying.” She said to Glimmer.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. “But you did.”

“Hey. She’s with us now, for real this time.” Adora promised.

Glimmer looked at Adora, then returned her eyes to Catra, keeping them on her when she asked Adora. “You’re sure?”

“I’m sure,” Adora said.

Glimmer’s glare didn’t ebb. “You lied to us.” She said to Catra.

Catra’s tail twitched. “I did.”

“About everything.”

“Not everything.”

Glimmer chuffed. “Oh yeah, I forgot there was a little truth in there to make it all go down easier.” She sassed.

“Glimmer,” Adora exasperated, and immediately regretted her tone. Damnit, she was trying to be better, but she was still tired, and it was making it hard to be the bigger person.

“We’re in a cell, Adora,” Glimmer said darkly. “and Catra put us here.”

“Double Trouble did that.” Adora tried to argue.

“No.” Glimmer glared. “You did this.” She pointed at Catra. “Do you know what this means for us, for them?” She gestured at Bow and Adora. “Do you know what an arrest will do to their futures!? Their college applications!?”

“Glimmer, stop,” Adora begged.

“Ohoho . . .” Glimmer turned towards Adora slowly. “don’t you think you’re getting off lightly here. If I hadn’t agreed to this plan . . . ugh!” She palmed her entire face with a frustrated hand. “Your . . . woolly-headed stubborn ass and the hero complex it rides in on are so mindbogglingly reckless it’s a miracle you haven’t gotten us all killed. You get in too deep, and you just can’t help but try and hold your breath, can you, Adora!?” She asked desperately. “Actual mob shootout. You realize how crazy that shit is, right!?”

Adora felt the anger flare in her chest and was about to raise her voice in return. She realized only later that Glimmer was yelling because she was more worried for her than mad at her.

Catra’s soft voice saved her from sticking her foot even further in her mouth. “I’m sorry.”

Glimmer's anger was quenched by surprise. "What?"

Catra didn't answer for a moment. She was looking down at her feet, only glancing up when no one spoke again. There was a drawn-out silence.

"Guys, maybe we should just take a breath." Bow interrupted, recognized how tense everything had gotten, and how uncomfortable Catra now seemed.

"No." Glimmer cut off the exit he presented. "I want to hear what she has to say."

Catra's ears flared out flat and low, and she clenched her fists by her side. When she spoke, it was through a tight jaw. "I'm sorry, okay?" She said louder this time. "That . . . that this ended up like this. And for . . . you know . . . whatever else. I should have, I could have . . . done something, earlier." She frowned. "But I didn't realize when I arrived that maybe this place might . . ." She grumbled, running her hand through her mane. "You don't deserve what my masters want to do to this place." She finished with a sharp gesture. "That's . . . that's the truth." She looked up at Glimmer. "If you can't trust me anymore, that's okay. But believe that I'm not on Double Trouble's side anymore. I hope that's enough to at least let me help you with your wounds." She extended an arm towards Glimmer.

Glimmer had watched Catra the entire time she had spoken. Adora could see her trying to study her expressions for authenticity. Then she looked down at the offered arm and nodded. "Okay."

"Okay?" Catra confirmed.

"I accept your apology." Glimmer said.

Catra's ears flicked in surprise. "You do?"

"I do."

Catra looked dumbfounded. “Why?”

Glimmer smiled subtly. “Because you looked so uncomfortable apologizing.”

An annoyed noise came out of Catra’s throat, then she started to patch her scrapes. Silence fell over the cell again. Adora watched Catra work for a minute, then looked over at Bow. “How are you?” She asked.

“Scared.” Bow admitted, standing and moving to sit next to her. “Stressed.” He plopped down.

“Yeah . . .” Adora nodded. Actual oncoming alien invasion. It was still sinking in. “I’m sorry too, by the way.”

“Oh?”

“Yeah.” Adora sighed. “Your dads, they’re going to find out where you are now, and it’s gonna be in a jail cell.”

“Well, they were going to find out the truth one way or another.” He shrugged. “It could be worse.”

“Could it?” Adora asked.

“Maybe not.” Bow conceded.

“I’ll vouch for you to them,” Adora assured. “For whatever that’s worth.”

Bow nodded with a smile. “Plenty.”

It was at that moment that Glimmer started laughing. Slowly at first, then it devolved into belly cackles, which forced Catra to stop patching her wounds. Catra looked at Adora with confusion as Glimmer slumped back against the wall, holding her gut, tears in the corners of her eyes.

“Glimmer?” Bow asked carefully. “You, okay?”

Glimmer nodded through her laughter. “Yeah.” She managed, calming down. “Yeah, I’m good. It’s just . . . Merry Christmas, am I right?”

Adora blinked. Oh. Oh man. It was Christmas Eve. She had completely forgotten it was Christmas Eve. She felt a chuckle rise from the bottom of her throat. She fought it, then thought: to hell with it, and let it bubble to the surface. Seeing Adora laugh broke Glimmer’s resolve, and she descended back into laughing. Bow joined in as well, and the cell felt a lot lighter.

“I don’t get it,” Catra said, and that somehow made it funnier. Adora shook her head. The reason they were locked up on Christmas was the only one who didn’t find it significant in the slightest.

“Let’s just say our parents won’t be happy to find out we got put in jail on the most family-oriented holiday of the year.” Glimmer said, sounding incredibly bubbly, considering.

“You don’t seem mad?” Adora didn’t intend it as a question, but it came out as one.

Glimmer thought for a second, then shrugged. “Well, I’ve always wanted to go to a protest, and a little part of me always kind of wanted to get arrested for it. 50% of the way there! Also, I thought a mugshot would be good for Tinder.”

“You’re still seventeen, Glimmer,” Adora noted, slightly concerned. “But, really? You’re not mad?” She asked, shocked.

Glimmer looked at her sister with a face of pure love. “Oh, I’m definitely still mad.” She revealed. “But I got arrested helping my sister. So, I’ll get over it.”

“Oh.” Adora exhaled and felt the tears come rushing up.

“Oh, stop.” Glimmer discouraged when she saw the rising waterworks. “Oh, you’re not stopping.” Adora managed to scoot down the bench and wrap her arms around Glimmer before she

devolved into a snotty mess. Glimmer just smiled, patted her back, and accepted the hug, leaning her head against her sister's. She appreciated this for a bit, then glanced over at Bow and found him crying as well. "Bow . . ." She sighed with a smile.

"I can't help it!" He squeaked out. "It's so wholesome!"

"You're both saps." Glimmer and Catra accused simultaneously, causing them to blink at the jinx.

"Get in here." Adora tilted her head, and Bow joined the little crush. Then together they all pulled in Catra, who grumbled but joined the hug without a word. There, for a little moment, despite everything looming around and above them, everything seemed like it might be okay.

"So, what now?" Glimmer asked when they parted. She now had a little patch of skinsuit on her cheek, and Adora thought it made her look plucky.

Everyone looked at each other, a little baffled at their circumstances. Jail hadn't exactly been on any of their schedules for this trip.

"Did anyone make their phone call?" Bow asked the group as Catra moved over to cover the one scrap he'd gathered in the last 24 hours.

Head shakes of no went around. "We get a phone call?" Catra asked.

"We do," Adora confirmed.

"Who do we even call?" Glimmer asked.

The obvious answer came to Adora's mind, and she couldn't help but immediately recoil from it.

She told herself the apprehension was because they had to make sure nobody could track their little fugitive gang down before

Adora's promise was fulfilled, but that thought was ridiculous now. They were in custody. The manhunt was over. They were going to find out.

While Bow and Glimmer were rapidly coming to the same consensus as Adora, she thought about how fast this had all gone insane. Just days ago, she'd been sitting nervous and alone, a nobody in a random cabin. Now she was one of only three humans on the planet who knew what was coming. Someone that no other race in the galaxy had ever been able to stop. So, no pressure. Nope, none whatsoever.

"What do we even tell them?" Glimmer asked the room, chuckling with a manic disbelief. "They hardly believed Catra was an alien."

"We tell them we need their help to save the world," Adora said.

Everyone looked at her. "Can we?" Bow asked. "Save the world?" Double Trouble's words hung in the air. Everyone exchanged glances.

Adora couldn't deny that their offer to go home wasn't tempting. Maybe, if she capitulated now, if she didn't continue to insist they needed to risk it all and put their faith in Catra, they'd be more willing to take her back.

But that temptation was selfish, and Adora's heart knew it was the wrong thing to do. So, regardless of the consequences, she was going to do the best job she could to get Catra, and the whole damn planet, out of this as best they could. Don't let anybody tell her she didn't fight when their backs were to the wall. "Maybe not," Adora admitted. "But that's going to stop me from trying." She declared. "Who's with me?"

Glimmer looked back at her, and in her gaze, Adora saw a little of the sparkle that had been missing so often recently. "Sure, why the hell not?" She smiled.

"Me too." Bow nodded.

Catra looked at them all, an expression on her face that Adora couldn't quite read. But whatever it was, it vanished behind a brash smile and a confirmation that, "Your species is insane."

Adora thought it was the best compliment humanity had ever received.

So, the four of them crowded the bars and bashed on them, all hollering words Adora thought she'd never have to say her entire life. "I want my phone call!"

Sometime a few hours later, three cops, real cops this time, reentered the cell block, leading a familiar face. The gaggle of them, including their rescuer, Castaspella Brightmoon, stared at Catra with big, big eyes. Adora was so used to Catra that she forgot just how weird she looked to the average person. But then again, her own eyes were probably nearly as big. She was finally face-to-face with the person she'd wanted to talk to all week.

Their aunt Castaspella was a tall, several inches taller than her brother Micah, a plainly attractive woman. Comfortably middle-aged, she had an hourglass figure, the blackest hair Adora had ever seen, and warm brown eyes that gave her a look that was one part small town, one part commanding leader. Currently, her wardrobe was leaning her towards the latter half. She was dressed in a deep blue suit with a pink undershirt, her NASA ID badge clipped to the jacket lapel. Her inky hair was done up into a wide bun, simple but professional, and easy to maintain during late-night shifts. The movements of deep space probes didn't care for whether it was day or night on Earth, accounting for the dark circles under her eyes. Completing the look was dark lipstick matching the suit, and a simple necklace with an eight-pointed star charm.

"You know, whenever someone busts into my office saying I have to leave the quiet zone to take a phone call, usually it's because my funding is about to be cut and I'm going to be fired."

Castaspella began. “So, when I learned that you kids had run away to see me, I was at least hoping for presents.”

“Heyyyy, Auntie Casta.” Glimmer smiled between the bars. “Long time no see?”

Casta chuckled silently, shaking her head and putting her fingertips to her brow. The smile beneath contained many emotions all at once. “Let them out.” She waved to the police officer with the ring of keys, who moved and opened their cell. “I paid the bails of those of you who had them.” She revealed, and Adora let out a deep sigh of relief as she passed the threshold.

“Wait, so we’re free to go?” Catra asked.

“Not entirely,” Casta admitted, eyes landing on the alien, ears and eyes and fur and tail all in plain sight. “You.” Catra swallowed. “Was everything my brother and sister-in-law said about you true?”

“Probably,” Catra said.

Casta exhaled strongly, and Adora saw the impact of ‘oh yeah, actually an alien’ hit her. She recovered surprisingly quickly. “Alright.” She pointed at Bow, Glimmer, and Adora. “Then in that case, you three are free until your court date.” Everyone swallowed. “You,”

“Catra,” Adora said her name.

Casta nodded. “Catra is going to have to come with me back to the base. That’s the deal the police made an hour ago.”

“With who?” Bow asked. “The government?”

“More or less,” Casta admitted. “I’ll explain later. For now, would you three like a ride with her to Goldstone? Or would you rather stay here and think about what you’ve done a bit longer?”

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer suddenly found the floor very interesting. Coughing into their hands, they admitted. “We’d like to come . . .please.”

“Good.” Casta smiled. “Now then, with business attended to: come here!” She rushed forward and engulfed the trio in a smothering hug. “How are you doing, kiddos?”

Adora laughed, accepting the hug greedily. “Hey, Auntie Casta.”

“Two years.” She said sternly. “Two years since I’ve seen any of you! I know I’m busy, but still! And on top of that, none of you are wearing the sweaters I knitted you! And you don’t go saying it’s too warm for them on Christmas of all days!”

Adora did suppose that was true, but they were just so itchy. “I’m wearing the socks you knitted me!” Bow declared eagerly.

Casta beamed. “I was so glad when I learned that Glimmer hadn’t made you up, Bow.” She laughed and walked up to hug the boy again. Glimmer’s face twisted into a combination of supreme annoyance and utter embarrassment, and Adora had to fight the laugh that welled up.

“Castaspella.” Bow greeted warmly.

She scoffed immediately. “Oh, nonsense. Call me Auntie.”

Bow looked to Adora and Glimmer, shrugging subtly as if saying, ‘I tried’.

“And Adora,” She turned to her next, getting another hug. “I always thought you might be a little rebel deep down.”

Adora felt her stomach drop like she was on a rollercoaster. “Umm . . . well . . .”

Thankfully, Casta quickly moved on to Glimmer, who accepted a hug. “How are you doing, Starlight?” She asked, question loaded.

“I’m alright, Auntie.” Glimmer said.

“You’re sure?”

Glimmer’s smile was a little pained. “Yeah.”

“Alright then.” Casta ruffled her hair. “This looks good short.” She smiled, then turned to the others. “Ready to get out of here?”

Everyone very much was. They left the station quietly, signing the paperwork they had to sign, collecting their bags (which had thankfully all made it to the station), and thanking the cops because it felt like what you were supposed to do rather than for the actual quality of their stay. As they left the hall of holding cells, Adora looked at the ones next to theirs. In the first past them, Scurvy’s one uninjured goon was sleeping alone. The others had all been taken to a hospital by ambulances, according to the officers. In the next one were Netossa and Spinnerella. Apparently, Seahawk's chest wounds also warranted more than just first aid, and Mermista had gone to the hospital with him. In the second cell, only Netossa was awake, Spinnerella’s snoring head in her lap, looking at them with an expression Adora couldn’t place.

Adora didn’t know what to think of the pair. They were criminals, and she didn’t know what either of them had done in the past, but they were also undeniably charming and had protected them all during the firefight. Hell, Netossa had basically saved her life when she dragged her out of the line of fire. Adora stopped for a moment in front of them. “Thank you.” She said to Netossa. “For what you did for us.”

Netossa nodded, and they moved on.

“Do you kids need anything?” Casta asked as they walked out of the station into the cold morning.

“Food." Glimmer and Adora moaned in unison.

“A shower.” Bow added.

Adora nodded at this. She leaned down, subtly smelled herself, and nearly gagged. When had she last had a shower? Oh yeah, like two days ago. Two days? Three? Who knew at this point?

"I have snacks in the car," Casta said. "A shower will have to wait until we get to Goldstone, unfortunately." They walked up to Castaspella's ancient Buick woodie station wagon. Adora had been told stories about how she and Micah had gone on road trips in the thing when they were in their 20s; it was amazing it was still running. At the car, Casta turned to look around the parking lot. "Alright, now all we need is . . ." She began, then there was a blur in the corner of Adora's vision. She spun as a very short woman ran right up to Catra and got inches away from her face.

"Incredible!" The woman cried. She had violently purple hair done up into two huge ponytails, which hung down past her grease-stained white tank top, which looked far too light with how cold it was, and very scuffed jeans nearly to her ankles. Apparently, she didn't mind the cold. She reached up to adjust round glasses before looking at Catra closer and declaring in a very excited voice. "It's all true! A real alien lifeform! I have so many questions!"

"Ah, Entrapta, there you are." Casta smiled.

Through bared teeth, Catra snarled at the woman just millimeters from her face. "Back off."

"Augh! Fascinating." Entrapta, completely unaffected, stuck one of her fingers **into** Catra's mouth. "You possess a similar dental arrangement to both primates and carnivorans. These carnassial teeth are almost a morphological halfway point between the two. Tell me, do you believe your physical similarities of life on Earth are a result of convergent evolution or some kind of distant shared ancestry?"

"Entrapta," Casta said more sternly. "Personal space."

The purple-haired woman looked at Casta, then at Catra, who looked more than ready to bite the offending woman's finger right off. "Oh, right." She stepped back. "Sorry."

"This is Entrapta." Casta introduced her to the group. "She's one of the communications leads at Goldstone. I asked her to ride along with me." She gestured to the car. "Come on now, there'll be plenty of time to ask Catra questions.

"Alright!" Entrapta said happily and ran over to jump into the middle row.

"Kill me," Catra muttered next to Adora.

"I'll sit next to her," Adora assured, bumping her gently on the shoulder as she sat next to the practically vibrating woman. She immediately noticed the smell of cutting oil and - was that burnt electronics - hovering around her.

"Glimmer?" Casta asked, opening the passenger door and gesturing with her hand.

"I wanna sit in the back with Bow." Glimmer said, lifting the tailgate to sit down in the rear-facing third row. Her hand reached out to pull Bow in after her.

"Oh . . . well . . ." She turned to Catra. "Ma'am?"

Catra's face twisted a little, but she went over and sat down, immediately putting her feet up on the dash. Casta sighed, but smiled, and got in, pulling away. They were actually really finally on their way to Goldstone, for real this time.

"So," Adora began. "No more secrets." She looked back at Glimmer, who was smiling at her. "Auntie Casta, Catra was sent as an alien spy. She is here with another alien who's working to contact their people and report on Earth's defenses. That report will lead to an actual alien invasion. Catra's on our side now, but we need to find a way to get her home without ending the world."

Casta glanced at the rearview mirror, judging her conviction. When she saw it was absolute, she shook her head and exhaled. “Umm . . . alright. I would not believe a word of that if the proof wasn’t sitting right beside me. What’s your plan?”

“Well, it was getting you to contact Catra’s ship with the antennas,” Bow said. “But that was before the whole, y’know, summer blockbuster plot came up.”

“Do we need to contact Catra's ship at all now?” Glimmer asked. “If we do nothing, Double Trouble can't contact the horde, Earth stays safe."

"No," Catra spoke. "If we do that, then they'll just assume I died and send another scout. One who probably won't be as willing to sell them out to you primitives as me . . . no offense.”

“None taken,” Adora assured.

“I think the best way to keep your planet safe is to beat Double Trouble to the punch,” Catra said. “Contact my ship, say they died, and get me off the planet before they're any wiser. Once I’m up there, I'll lie and say the planet isn't worth it."

"But will that work?" Bow asked.

“It’s the best I’ve got,” Catra admitted.

Adora nodded. “Will you help us, Auntie Casta, if that is our best chance?”

She sighed. "We’ll see, I’ll have to run it by my contact at the government.” Everyone stiffened at that. “Don’t worry, he’s an old friend, and despite this being a right mess, he’s been known to bend the rules before.” She rubbed her temple with a hand. "My, when I heard my nieces were coming to visit, I wasn't expecting to sign up for this.”

“Welcome to the club.” Glimmer smiled.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None
Everything in this chapter needed more work than I thought it would 😩. But, shoutout to the commenter who asked about Entrapta all the way back in Chapter 3! Hope she's worth the wait, and I'm happy to say that she's a big character in the story from here on out.

Chapter 18: Goldstone

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The drive to Goldstone was filled with Catra being bombarded with questions from Entrapta about space. After what had to be the fiftieth one, Catra exasperated. "You already work with space. Don't you ever get tired of thinking about it?"

Entrapta beamed. "I LOVE THINKING ABOUT SPACE!"

Adora had no idea whether she was charmed or terrified by the woman sitting beside her. Maybe it was both at once.

"So, this other alien, Double Trouble." Castaspella managed to interject during one of the brief moments when Entrapta remembered she had to breathe. "If they can change shape so convincingly, how do we know they're not following us?"

"Oh, they definitely are," Catra assured.

Castaspella's fingers tightened on the steering wheel. "I'll let my contact know. They'll make sure the guards are on the lookout for anything suspicious." Adora didn't know if that would help at all, considering how well they all had been duped by them more than once, but it was something.

"What is their deal?" Bow asked, shaking his head. "They come up to our cell to just, what? Gloat? Rub it in?"

"They love a bit," Catra noted. "If that bit was playing the villain, trust me, they can't help themselves."

"But is that really it?" Glimmer asked. "I find it hard to believe they're just doing all this to have fun. It's a lot of work. Catra, I know you told us they were a mercenary, but . . ." She rubbed the

back of her neck. Yeah, nobody wanted to bring up that that had been one of Catra's lies.

Adora thought back to the things they'd said to her in the cell. About how they had emphasized the Horde's mission, about how it was for the greater good. Adora's gut told her that they cared about this almost as much as they liked games. "They're way more than mercenary, are they?" Adora asked Catra.

"Yeah," Catra confirmed lowly. "They're the real deal."

Fort Irwin, California was a military base first and a town second. It was thirty-one miles from the lonely highway exit beside an abandoned gas station to the front gate. That isolation, and the fact that it was well within the patchwork quilt of restricted airspace that covered this part of the southwest, was good for both Area 51 and deep space communication. That front gate, which was guarded by armed soldiers, cordoned off everything within the city limits, including Goldstone, which, while not part of Fort Irwin itself, was on the far side of it and only accessible by passing through. The soldiers spoke to Casta for a long time, making several calls until they were all given slips of paper to quote: 'carry at all times'. Catra seemed to be the sticking point, though, with her hood up, they seemed more concerned with her lack of ID than the fact that she wasn't human. When they were let through, Casta explained as they drove through what looked like one of those fake towns used in the 50s for nuclear bomb testing, that it was probably best if she stayed on NASA property. "All hell is going to break loose on this."

"Wait, so you're what . . . sneaking Catra in?" Adora looked away from the window where she was looking for plastic people sitting inside the rows of identical houses.

Casta didn't seem to love her wording, but nodded. "My contact has been given point on this, but honestly, yes. I'm taking advantage of the red tape she has to go through to make sure she's on NASA property, rather than the military's. It'll be better

for you.” She said to Catra, then mused. “If I get flak for it, well . . . ask for forgiveness, not permission.”

“Alright, Aunt Casta!” Glimmer cheered from the backseat.

Casta blushed. “Thank you, Glimmer.”

The way to Goldstone was another long desert road, this one lined with gun ranges where soldiers were practicing their aim. Yep, just a normal small American town. Fort Irwin was officially the Fort Irwin National Training Center, and operated exactly how you would expect something with that name. On the borders of the only fake-looking neighborhoods were actual fake neighborhoods built to look like Middle Eastern slums or Russian towns that the military used to train.

They drove up a large ridge, then, finally, over the hills came dishes, massive white satellite dishes, and on the side of one of the nearby ridges, ‘GOLDSTONE’ was spelt out in white rocks. Bow clapped Adora on the shoulder. “Well, you did it. We’re here.”

“We’re here.” Adora echoed, and a wave of profound emotion swept over her. Nothing about the past week of her life had been normal, so the fact that she had actually accomplished one of the crazy goals she’d set for herself and Catra at the beginning of it? It meant a hell of a lot. Step 1: Get Catra to Goldstone, check. Now for the hard part. Passing through a much less scary-looking gate, their phones were confiscated to stop the signals coming off them from interfering with the antennas.

They pulled to a stop at the base of the smaller dishes and all piled out. Casta pointed out the larger antenna in the distance and which spacecraft were being used to communicate with them. “That biggest one is being used on Voyager 1 right now, past the edge of the solar system. The smaller ones are some of the main Mars links: Curiosity and Perseverance rovers, and the orbiters. We’re downlinking MRO mapping images right now.

“So cool.” Adora gawked up at the scene that looked like it had come straight from *Contact*.

"And this is Deep Space Station 12: 'Echo'." Casta set one hand on her hip and gestured up with the other at a smaller dish. "37 meters in diameter, she was decommissioned in 2012, but everything is still in there. When Entrapta inquired about the old arrays, I gave her the keys. I’m going to have you four bunk here.”

Into the pale desert sky rose a jagged lattice structure. Like some kind of strange fungus or a tripod from War of the Worlds, the radio antenna stood on three white legs, all peeling with rust. They each connected to the underside of a large rectangular structure with no windows, clearly some kind of office or control room. Above that rose the dish itself, a sweeping mesh bowl mounted to a huge bearing for positioning it towards anywhere in the heavens. Even though it was clearly old and ungainly, it was beautiful in Adora’s sore eyes.

"Ohh . . ." Entrapta bounced on her heels, clapping her hands. "I'm so excited to show you what I've been cooking up!" She led them to the base of one of the legs, then up a winding flight of structurally questionable stairs towards the office. Adora swallowed each time she heard one of the perforated metal steps or railings creak, and regretted every glance down to the ground below.

At the top of the stairs, there was a small balcony in front of the office door. Entrapta fished through the pockets of her overalls, pulling out a truly monumental ring of keys. The mass of chrome, rusted steel, and keys wrapped in floral plastic shells jangled as she flipped through them, muttering a name past each. "Eunice, Meredith, Emily, Beatrice, Echo!" She perked up, sticking one into the loose old lock. "Here we go!" She pushed the squeaky door open and stepped inside. "Make yourselves at home!"

The gang shuffled in, eyes on a swivel. It was all very 1980s: brown carpet, wood-paneled walls. Entrapta walked over and

opened a breaker panel, clicking several of the heavy switches. With each clunk, obsolete technology whirred to life. Fluorescent lights flickered on between the drop tile ceiling, and Adora noticed that the translucent covers had been wrapped in amber-colored plastic film to soften the harsh glow. The left half of the room was all business, masses of archaic beige computer towers and monitors hooked together in a terrifying maze of cables, dozens of which snaked across the threadbare carpet. Computers were on the floor, on the desks, and the left wall was all computers, huge ancient ones with actual tape reels that began spinning as Entrapta strode into the center of the chaos and started turning on monitors.

The right side of the room was more lived-in. A small round particleboard table was near the corner, surrounded by four office chairs, none of which matched. The peeling veneer looked nearly as old as some of the take-out boxes absolutely littering the top of it. Beside it was a water cooler, then a half-opened filing cabinet exploding with clothes. Atop it was a coffee machine. A hole in the top corner of the cabinet was serving as one of two anchor points for a hammock that was stretched across the nearside corner of the room.

"Entrapta?" Casta looked around. "Have you been . . . living up here?"

"Only Monday to Saturday." She beamed. "You said I could work here whenever I was finished with my regular duties. It became inefficient to drive home."

"I . . . umm . . . Casta swallowed and tipped her head. "Wow."

Glimmer wandered over and very gingerly picked up a foul-looking Chinese take-out box. "If this is the life my parents want me to get a college degree for, I'm not sure I want one anymore."

Catra just shrugged. "I've lived in worse." She plopped into one of the chairs and put her feet up.

Aunt Casta sighed. "Could anyone help me get some bedrolls . . . and some cleaning supplies?”

"I will, ma'am." Bow immediately volunteered.

"So . . . what have you been doing up here, Entrapta?" Glimmer asked when they were gone. “Besides . . . this,” She gestured at the garbage that Adora, fingers twitching, already found herself picking up.

“Well, repairs for now, but soon, research!" Entrapta cried, running to one of the ancient computers and logging in. "I've been cross-referencing several surveys on the radio emissions of nearby stars and nebula trying to track down some observational discrepancies." She brought up a spreadsheet on one of the monitors that was just a wall of numbers. "I've suspected for a while that there's a factor that's been missed. If I can add my own data to the list, collecting it with one instrument and in as short a time as possible, I'll be able to cross-reference the numbers!"

“What are you looking for?” Glimmer asked.

“This! Look here!” Entrapta tapped the glass screen in a few spots. Look at how different these frequencies are. Rigel is off between these studies by almost point zero three percent!”

“So?”

“So, that shift is correlated with when the data was taken! Don’t you see!?”

Glimmer blinked. “No?”

“The change is a real phenomenon! Something is affecting the signals, and it's occurring all around us, shifting in different ways in different places. It’s as if there’s this . . . field that distorts the signals ever so slightly, and I plan to measure it!” She declared.

Adora tried to focus on the conversation. She always liked the cosmos: globular clusters and supernovae. But it was difficult to keep her brain on track. With the fluorescent lights and the computers and the old CRT screens, the entire room was filled with an uncomfortable buzz that seemed to seep into her sinuses and put her on edge. "That's great, Entrapta, really, but" She rubbed her temples. "when do you think the antenna will be ready, again?"

"I think a week or less!" Entrapa said excitedly.

"A week!?" Adora's eyes shot up.

"I know, I'm so close now. I had to rebuild the entire antenna control program from scratch! The floppy disk files didn't survive my recovery initiative." She reached down and pulled a very charred-looking electronics box by its power cable up out of a pile in the corner.

The three of them looked at one another, all knowing they didn't have a week. If Double Trouble wasn't already lurking nearby, then they would be soon, and that would risk them contacting the Fright Zone before they could.

"Can you speed that up?" Glimmer asked.

"In order to make first contact!?" Entrapta balked. "Is a quasar a high-energy radio emitter!?"

Glimmer squinted. "Umm . . ."

"That's a yes," Adora said, then doubted herself. "Umm . . . it is, right?" It was.

When Bow and Casta came back in, they did so like in a sitcom, a stack of pizza boxes in their hands. "Anyone still hungry?" Bow asked. Adora and Glimmer cheered. Even the granola bars they'd had in the car hadn't sated the hunger days of stress and running had built up.

Aunt Casta seemed crushed to not encourage their cheer. “Well, don’t thank me yet. This is mostly a bribe.” She set the boxes down on the too-small table. “I really can only keep you here for the night before I have to start telling everyone important that I have you. Your parents, for starters.” She looked at the human teens. “And one way or another, the police and my friend who’s very interested in Catra won’t be far behind.”

“Then if we are going to send a signal to Catra’s ship, we need to work fast,” Bow said before taking a bite of pizza. “Aunt Casta,” He glanced at her, “do you have any better ideas than what we’ve come up with?” After she asked about their plans and some follow-up questions, she admitted she did not. “Then we need to start prepping what we have, and hope the antenna is ready in time.” He glanced at Entrapta, who had already gotten to work, messing with some of the cables leading from her main console into the other racks. “When it is, we’ll need a radio message that they’ll interpret as an attempt at contact.” They all sat down, and the brainstorming began.

"Prime numbers," Casta suggested between bites. "We start with one. Then pulse. Two. Three. Five. Seven. Eleven. Just like *Contact*."

"No, no ma'am." Bow ran the end of his pen through his hair. "The space around Earth is filled with intelligent signals; it would get lost in the noise."

"Not just basic primes. Not from such a strong localized source." Casta tamped her own notepad frantically. “We’re only broadcasting to the L2 point.”

Catra’s eyes followed the debate going back and forth, then chipped in, mouth full of her own slice of pizza (sans cheese, of course). “A song.”

Bow looked over. “A song?”

“The Fright Zone’s communications officer,” Catra explained. “Perfuma, she’s . . . a little different. She’s Plumerian, and they’re all about ‘harmony’ and ‘oneness’ and whatever; always humming these songs, mantras, really. It’s a part of their species culture. Catra bit her lip, then started humming a soft, simple tune. Adora’s eyes widened at the gentleness of her voice, and felt her cheeks warm. “Play that, she’ll know it.”

“That’s perfect!” Bow called, pulling up the recording app on his phone and a sheet of paper to start taking down the notes.

“That’s great, but none of this helps if we can’t even send the signal cause the repairs aren’t finished.” Glimmer gestured at the room around them. “Are you sure we can’t use one of the other dishes, Auntie Casta?”

“I’m sorry, honey, but no. The schedule is booked months in advance. There’s no way to slip you in.”

“If only we could just use the damn lens.” Glimmer grumbled lowly. “We’ve gotten into enough trouble with that thing as is; it should come good now.”

“Lens?” Entrapta stuck her head out of the computer she was working on. There was a dust bunny on her cheek.

Adora sighed. “Catra’s space radio used this crystal. But even if we still had it, it was broken. We can’t use it.”

“I still have it,” Catra said.

Bow, Glimmer, and Adora’s eyes all swung towards her. “You still have it!?” They cried in unison.

“Yeah,” Catra said nonchalantly. “Double Trouble gave it to me when giving me directions to that mob boss’s place.” She reached behind her to a lump on the small of her back, Adora hadn’t noticed, pulling out the lens from where it had been stored under her skinsuit.

“Oh, wait, close your-” Adora tried to warn everyone, but it was too late. All the humans became fixed on the thing. All but one.

“Fascinating . . .” Entrapta appeared in Adora’s field of view, walking right up to the lens and plucking out of Catra’s hands, entirely unaffected by the twisting scintillating shards within the glass ampule. She turned it in her hands, observing how it changed shape. “This has all the hallmarks of an object with higher physical dimensions. But that implies . . .” She tapped the glass, and it rang strangely, like the sound was coming from every direction. “Ohhhohoho . . . You say this crystal is a lens? If so, then it could function as a window into an entirely undiscovered part of our universe!”

“Subspace,” Catra said.

Entrapta looked like she had stars in her eyes. “Don’t tell me there’s an entire shadow reality that exists just beyond what our instruments can measure.” She asked Catra.

“I mean, yeah, basically,” Catra said.

The squeal of excitement that came out of Entrapta’s mouth was of a pitch so high Adora was shocked she could even hear it. “THIS IS INCREDIBLE! With something like this, I bet I could . . . no – YES! I could funnel a signal through the crystal itself and probe this ‘subspace’, like sonar! Sending signals into the dark and seeing what echoes back.” She pressed the lens right up against her nose, staring deeply into it and whispering. “This is going to open up entirely new fields of scientific discovery!"

She then started to pace, which blocked the lens from Adora and the others’ line of sight, who all took the opportunity that having control of their bodies offered to look down at the floor. “How does she do that?” Glimmer muttered to Bow, who shrugged.

Adora tried to focus. "That’s cool, Entrapta, but how does that help us communicate with Catra's ship?"

"Help!? HAH!" Entrapta barked. "With this, I could tap into their signals directly! We can send them a proper message on their terms!"

“Hello, what part of broken didn’t you understand?” Catra asked.

“That’s a technicality,” Entrapta assured. “With a little fidgeting, I should be able to get this crystal more or less reassembled.” She stared at it. “Ooohohoho I never thought I’d get to use that month I studied four-dimensional objects! I wonder what the original shape of this was, perhaps a 24-cell icositetrachoron? Ooo! Or maybe it’s not even a regular polytope! Aauh! So many possibilities! With each facet a three-dimensional portrait painted onto a beautiful self-intersecting sculpture. AHHH! Science is incredible! What was I saying? Oh, right! Communicating! The crystal shouldn’t have to be perfect to work; it just has to carry a signal, any kind of signal.”

“What about sending the song?” Casta asked.

“Even if we can’t send a true song, the rhythm of the notes should be sufficient.” Entrapta scratched her chin. “If Catra’s ship receives a subspace message directly from the surface, well who else could it be?” She was practically drooling over the object. “AUGH! I can’t wait any longer. I need to start working on this!”

She moved to dash off, but was caught on the collar by Casta before she could slip back into the depths of wires and computers that served as her lair. “Entrapta, I know you’re excited, but you need to wait until after I get the go-ahead to make this, okay?” She stipulated.

“Right!” She saluted, then turned to her desk, then turned back. “Can I at least reassemble the crystal now?”

“. . . Yes.” Casta acquiesced, releasing her and moving to get her blazer. “But **nothing** more after that!” Entrapta nodded sharply. “Alright,” Casta sighed and took survey of the situation with hands on her hips. Seeing everyone going back to eating, she seemed

satisfied. “I need to get to my shift,” She announced. “I’d like all of you to stay on the antenna for now, please.”

“Don’t worry about us, Auntie,” Bow said. “We’ve got plenty to figure out here.”

“And these dummies still need more sleep,” Catra added.

“Catra . . .” Adora wined.

“You do.” Catra insisted. “You’re all still not operating at full; I can tell.”

“We don’t have time to rest more.” Adora pressed her.

Catra walked over and put a hand on her shoulder. “It’s gonna take that one,” She gestured at Entrapta, who, with a single sweep of her arm, cleared a desk of piles of electronics to start work on the lens. “a while to get that thing working. Resting now and working after will make you more effective than burning up now and crashing when it matters.”

Adora frowned, but nodded. That made sense. “Is this a field medic thing?”

“Yeah.” Catra insisted. “That goes for all of you. I’m ordering bedrest.”

“Boo!” Glimmer cried sarcastically. “Lame! Catra doesn’t want to stay up at the sleepover!”

Casta seemed satisfied with Catra ordering them around. “I’ll be back this evening.” She turned to go.

“Thank you, Auntie Casta.” Glimmer said.

“For everything,” Adora added.

She nodded and stepped out, and after eating their fill, all of them helped clean up the side of the room not covered in electrical

equipment and set up the bedrolls. In the tiny attached bathroom, Adora changed, brushed her teeth, and washed her face (apparently, a shower would have to wait a little longer). When she came back out, the windowless room had been plunged into darkness save for the hundreds of little lights from the computers and the two of Catra's eyes. Bow handed Adora a pillow, and she laid down. She realized how tired she still was the moment her head hit the floor. Her sleep schedule was fully ruined at this point, but she didn't care. She exhaled and started to settle . . . for about ten seconds. Actual sparks began to fly off of Entrapta's workbench. Yeah . . . she wasn't sure how much rest she was actually going to get.

Adora tried to sleep; she really did. And to her credit, Entrapta stayed pretty quiet after the first fifteen minutes, changing to working with a headlamp and a soldering iron. No, it was the buzzing din of the wires in the walls that made her head squirm, and her teeth itch, and after a while, she just had to get out of there. Heading out the door, she sat on the landing just outside. The metal grate was uncomfortable on her butt, and the height – a good forty feet – was a nerve-wracking. But, with her legs dangling over the side, the lower bar of the railing was the perfect height to lay her arms on.

The bright, cold day stretched out into the distance. The land was scrubby, dry, and pale. The hills in the distance rippled in the desert air. By Mojave standards, it must be freezing, but to Adora, coming from the depths of a northern December, it was positively balmy. It had to be almost seventy degrees. She inhaled a soft breeze as it danced over her bare shoulders and the straps of her tank top and tried to stop and be in the moment, but her brain was never very good at sort of thing.

Before at least, all her attention had been locked on the now. How to get past this obstacle in their path. How to get the next mile down the road. All the fear for the future she had pushed down because she didn't have the bandwidth for it.

But now, they'd reached their destination, and it was impossible not to have her mind wander. When this had started, it had seemed simple. Just get Catra here, and she'd get to go home. Trying to figure out how they were, or even if they could, get out of this without the red wings of the Horde, emblazoned on Catra's pod and the back of her skinsuit, flying over every capital was just a tad more complicated. It didn't help her relax.

Then the door opened behind her. Adora looked over her shoulder to see Catra coming out. She had also decided to lie down, even though Adora suspected her species didn't need any more sleep than she'd gotten back at the jail. Adora was worried that it was a sign that Catra expected a fight was coming, and wanted to be at her best.

She tried to shake the worst of her fears out of her mind before asking. "Can't sleep either?"

Catra stretched her arms above her head, a purring noise escaping her throat as she did. 'Big stretch'. Adora's brain supplied, and at least that made her smile. "Oh, no." Catra denied. "That was the best sleep I've had since I landed here."

"Really?"

"Yeah, sounds like my ship in there. Lots of little machines going." She sighed, tipping her neck left and right to stretch that too. But halfway through, she froze and leveled a sharp gaze at Adora. "Wait, you're not Double Trouble, are you? Catra asked.

"What?" Adora blinked. "No."

Catra stared at her very closely for a long moment, then seemed to decide she wasn't lying. "Sorry, just, they're fucking with my head." Catra sat beside her, also crossing her arms on the lower railing.

"It's okay." Adora supplied. "I'm . . ." She considered talking about what she was feeling. Her nerves about the Horde, but couldn't get the words out.

“What?” Catra asked.

“It’s nothing.” Adora dismissed. Catra looked unconvinced. “That song you hummed earlier, I liked it,” Adora said, definitely not trying to change the subject.

“Oh, that old thing?” Catra huffed. “Yeah, it’s nice . . . I guess.”

“What is it?”

Catra frowned. “It’s a ship hymn. A song that’s sung aboard the Fright Zone. There’re dozens of them. That one is Perfuma’s favorite. It’s . . . it’s stupid.”

“I don’t think that’s stupid,” Adora said. “Does it have lyrics? How does it go?”

Catra nodded. “It . . . doesn’t really work if I translate it. But it’s something like:

We’re on the edge of greatness, turning darkness to light.

We’re right beside you, ready to fight.

We must be strong, and we must be brave.

We must find every part of strength that we have and never let it go.

We’re bound to the struggle, with mighty sword and flame.

We’ll never fail you when you call our name.” She looked at Adora. “Then we’d all scream FRIGHT ZONE! At the top of our lungs before the next line.” Adora chuckled. Catra looked off into the distance and sang one more line, in tune with the song, or as much as she could. “We must be strong.” She tailed off, then pressed some hair out of her eyes. “It’s corny.”

“Yeah, but cool too. I like it.”

“You would think that.” Catra sassed.

Adora chuckled, and silence fell over them again. Adora thought about the lyrics, about how . . . righteous they sounded. Not exactly an evil anthem. Double Trouble did truly believe the Horde were the good guys. The things they'd said . . . she was reminded of something. Something they'd said to Catra. "Earlier," Adora began gently. "Double Trouble said something to you. About your name. What did that mean?" She looked over at Catra to see her eyes wide, her pupils tiny.

"Not this, Adora." Catra said in a whisper. "Anything but this, please."

"Catra I . . . I didn't mean to-"

"I know. I know. It's just . . . It's not bad. It's just, not right now, please."

"Okay." Adora backed down. "But you can trust me, Catra. You know that, right?"

Catra took a deep breath, and Adora noticed her claws retracting from the gouges they'd put in the metal grate below them. "I know." She looked over at her, eyes fond. "But I gotta keep my mysterious persona up, don't I?"

It was a joke, but not her best, and that was okay. "I know." Adora acquiesced. Once more, there was a pause, and the wind briefly picked up, whipping their hair. "Is . . . is this the right thing to do, Catra?"

"Contacting the Fright Zone?" She asked.

"Yeah."

Catra sighed. "Like I said, I really don't know. I wish I did. I wish there was some like . . . what'd'ya call it, precedent to fall back on. But you lunatic humans really can't stop from breaking the mold."

“No.” Adora chuckled. “Guess not . . . Just . . . I keep thinking that . . . if no other planet has not been invaded before. Isn’t contacting them basically like putting a huge sign up on our planet saying 'Tasty humans, mostly defenseless!’, right?”

Catra smiled at her. “Well, even if it was, I doubt it’d be false advertising. I bet you taste pretty good.”

Adora was sure her entire face turned red. It was a joke. It was a joke. She definitely didn’t mean it like that. Definitely not. “But still . . .” She managed.

Catra sighed. “I wish I could promise you that it’ll all turn out okay, but I can’t.”

“I know.” Adora sighed. “At least this way we’re doing something about it. Instead of just sitting and doing nothing.”

“That’s better than what my planet did,” Catra said.

“What?”

“We did nothing,” Catra said. “Just let the Horde land and tell us what to do, according to the histories. Or, at least, according to what the other members of my species told me about our histories. I wasn’t exactly nose deep in books as a kid.” Adora wasn’t surprised by that. “Stars, couldn’t we have tried something at least? Anything?”

Adora nodded. “How long ago was it? When the Horde came to your world?”

Catra paused to do the conversion in her head. “A couple hundred years ago.” She said. “Roughly.”

So long. “How long has the Rebellion been fighting Horde Prime?”

“Who knows,” Catra said dismissively. “Millenia? Long enough that all their posters say killing for them is the greatest thing I could ever do.”

Another thing Double Trouble said echoed in Adora's mind. "How . . . how many people have you killed?" She asked quietly. Catra's eyes snapped over to her, pupils narrow. Yeah, they were having this conversation. Adora wished she didn't care, but she did.

"I've lost count," Catra admitted. "In some battles. You don't know if your bullet was the one that took them out, or if it even killed them.

"But . . . if you had to estimate . . ."

"Adora . . ."

"Please, Catra." Adora clenched the railing.

Catra was surely looking at her, but Adora couldn't meet her eye. "Dozens." She guessed eventually. "But also, only one." Adora squinted in confusion. Catra elaborated. "Horde Prime, his entire army, his entire empire: it's all clones. Every soldier I've ever faced had the exact same face. The same green eyes." She ran a hand over the back of her neck, tail curling around her stomach. "Just so you know, they're also . . . not really people. At least, that's what some of the others say. That the swill of indoctrination, drugs, and the mental link chip that's been filling their heads since the moment they came out of their incubation pod makes them . . . empty. They're drones, hollow soldiers."

"But the leader of the rebellion, Hordak, you said he was a drone once, too, right?" Adora looked at her.

"Yeah," Catra said. "He broke free."

Adora didn't press on what that implied. That if given the chance, all of those soldiers Catra had killed could have broken free, too. "Horde Prime . . . he's really that bad, huh?" Adora said.

"Worse," Catra said.

Adora looked up at the sky and tried to see that infinite potential Double Trouble had spoken of up there. But - and she hated to

admit this - it was already gone. She thought of the millions of lives lost to him, the worlds that were apparently being destroyed. She was terrified of the Rebellion coming down and conquering Earth. Of drafting her and her friends and family into an interstellar war, but . . . if Earth escaped the Rebellion, and then the Rebellion lost, Horde Prime would find Earth one day, and there would be no one in his way to stop him. Was it right to try and stop the Rebellion then? Was the just thing to allow it to happen?

Angella's grandfather had fought in World War II. He had stormed the beaches of Normandy on D-Day and everything. Angella was rightfully proud of what he had done. He'd risked his life for a noble cause, one done, in part, to preserve life, even if lives had to be taken to do it. Thus, by extension, Adora couldn't help but see draft dodgers of that time as cowards.

Was this fight to preserve the Earth she knew no better?

When they went back inside, Catra fought Entrapta (by yelling and threatening to rip her computers to shreds) until she turned every buzzing, humming, whirring, clicking thing in the antenna off (which was A LOT of things), and Adora finally got some real sleep. Even though it was well into the day on a thin sleeping bag in an unfamiliar place, she was so utterly exhausted that it was an amazingly refreshing rest. Almost perfect, in fact. In fact, the only thing wrong with it was that they were all woken up by armed soldiers.

"Wha-WHOA!" Glimmer shot awake and up to a sitting position. "What the hell!?"

Adora blinked the sleep out of her eyes, sitting up to find Catra already awake from her spot at the end of Adora's sleeping bag. Standing over them were half a dozen fully armed soldiers with rifles out. The barrel pointed in her general direction woke her up very fast, and her eyes roved all over, landing on the open doorway to the outside, where a woman in a blue suit stood,

flanked by, of all people, Mermista and Seahawk. She was tall, black, with hair shaved nearly to the scalp. Her suit was well-fitted, angular, and with huge 80s power suit shoulder pads. She stood straight as an arrow, with fingers gently interwoven in front of her. When she spoke, her voice was smooth and with only the faintest hint of emotion. "Hello. My name is Agent Lighthope, and I will be the facilitator of this situation going forward." She stepped closer to them, and Adora leaned away, unable to get her legs free from her sleeping bag. The woman leaned down slightly, looking at Catra. "I see you were correct, Casta. This one isn't native."

Adora's eyes widened, flicking to the doorway, where Castaspella appeared, looking very worried. "You said we were going to handle this gently." She said, voice hard.

"That was before you informed me of the details of this situation. Now that I am apprised, there is no time for delay. All four of you, please stand. You're going to be questioned." The nearest soldier reached for Adora, but Catra hissed at him, claws flashing.

"What are you going to do to Catra?" Bow asked, crawling awkwardly out of his sleeping bag and putting his hands up.

"That will depend entirely upon how she cooperates," Lighthope said.

Catra looked around at the room, the guns, the words they were using. "Alright. I'll go. I'll talk."

"Catra," Adora said, terrified.

"It's alright, Adora," Catra said. "I'll be fine." She stood, and Mermista brought out a pair of cuffs, walking over to her.

"She doesn't need to be restrained," Adora said to Lighthope.

"I will not allow any risks to be taken. Not when this situation is so delicate, and the consequences of a mistake so dire. You will all be restrained."

The ratcheting of handcuffs filled the room. As the links clamped down on Adora’s wrists for the third time in less than 24 hours, Agent Lighthope looked into the cold stare Adora leveled at her Aunt, then the agent herself. Lighthope spoke in a voice that held no malice, nor any room for debate.

“Please do not resist.”

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Discussion of killing during war.
Omg, the end is in sight.

Chapter 19: Choices

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was interviewed last, if how long she was left alone in the interrogation room was any indication. It was that, or they were just trying to psych her out. She sat in the metal chair, rubbing her wrists while she waited. At least they'd taken off the cuffs.

When the door did open, Lighthope came in alone. She sat with a pad of paper and a silver pen. The questions were about what Adora expected them to be. Catra, the Horde, Double Trouble. Lighthope was skeptical of the first, nervous about the second, and annoyingly nonchalant about the third. "They're good." Adora underlined about the shapeshifter. "Way good. Way better than you think."

"I assure you, we're taking all necessary precautions," Lighthope said, setting down their pen and looking at her. "That concludes all the questions I'd like to ask you, for now, except for one. Is there anything you'd like to ask us?"

Adora was angry the woman even had to ask. "Where's Catra? What are you going to do with her?"

Lighthope nodded. "She is being held in a secure cell, here at Fort Irwin." She said plainly. "I cannot speak to her long-term future right now. There are many hands in this, so to speak, and both national and planetary security must be preserved. In that regard, Catra is-"

"A person." Adora interrupted. "A refugee."

"She is an undercover agent," Lighthope corrected. "One, by her own admission, sent with hostile intent."

“But she doesn’t want to hurt the Earth!” Adora slammed a fist down on the table. Not anymore. “She just wants to go home!”

Lighthope frowned at her. “Home to a belligerent alien regime.” She braced her hands in a cradle. “She knows much about our planet and our defenses. Knowledge that could be valuable to them, should The Horde become our adversaries.”

“She wouldn’t reveal anything.” Adora insisted.

“She may not have a choice in such matters,” Lighthope said. “From what Catra has told us, her people do not, as you might say, live and let live. She could be tortured for the information, by means traditional or exotic.”

Adora’s eyes widened. She hadn’t considered that, but Lighthope had a point. They could torture her. Hurt her. Adora’s fingernails dug into the flesh of her palms.

“You must understand that the risks of returning her to her people are . . . incredibly high.” Lighthope continued.

“You can’t know that,” Adora replied. “Not for sure.”

“Catra has informed us that no other planet that has been infiltrated in this way has emerged from the ensuing contact with the Horde independent,” Lighthope said. “That is more than enough information to warrant this response,” Adora said nothing, a deep scowl furrowing her cheeks. “It is clear you care for Catra deeply.” Lighthope said. “If that is true, then please be assured, the best way you can help her is by cooperating.”

“By leaving her here as a prisoner?” Adora challenged.

“Is that so much worse than returning her to someone who could reasonably be described as her abuser.”

Adora’s head snapped up. "Abuser!?"

“Yes. This,” Lighthope checked her notes, “Shadow Weaver. Catra does not appear confident that she would be forgiving of any perceived or actual failures of her mission on this planet. Combined with the fact that Shadow Weaver has had a long domineering presence in Catra’s military career, and the fear she displayed when mentioning her, leads me to believe such a description may be apt.”

“Catra . . . she told you all that?” Adora asked, voice tinged with hurt.

“Not all,” Lighthope said. “The fear I deduced from her body language, if such a thing can be trusted for a non-human species. But verbally, Catra has been most forthcoming.”

“And yet you still don’t trust her,” Adora said.

“It is not in my job description to be trusting,” Lighthope said.

Adora supposed it wasn’t. “What is your job?” She asked, annoyance slipping into her voice.

“As I have said previously, I have been appointed the facilitator of this situation.”

Adora resisted biting her cheek. This woman. The things she said were so . . . direct. It felt like talking to a computer. God help you if you didn’t ask the exact right question. “And what are you going to facilitate?”

“All possible avenues are being explored,” Lighthope said. “The actions pursued will be the ones most likely to preserve the safety and security of the country, the planet, and all human life.”

“None of those ‘most likely’ plans involve Catra going home, do they?” Adora asked.

Lighthope shook her head. “Not at this time, no.” Adora looked away. “You are curious, Adora Grayskull.”

“Thanks.” Adora sassed.

Lighthope continued. “You wish to assure Catra returns to her people, even if that action endangers the Earth?”

Adora met Lighthope’s eyes, but the intensity of her gaze forced them down again. She felt like a child being talked down to. “Yes.” She said, but it didn’t sound as confident as she would have liked.

“Why?”

Adora fought to keep her voice steady. “I made a promise.”

Lighthope hummed. “Your passion is admirable; I would even say heroic. But not all promises can be kept.”

“People need to stop using that as an excuse to not help people.”

Lighthope slowly interlaced her fingers, looking for the right words before she began again. “Heroic, yes.” She echoed. “Unfortunately, right now, we are not in a position of privilege when it comes to heroics.” She exhaled. “I understand your determination to complete the goal you’ve set for yourself, and that completing it would provide you great satisfaction. But such actions would expose the planet to an unacceptable level of risk; thus, they are actions we will not allow.”

“So, you’re saying I don’t get a choice anymore,” Adora said. “You’re saying I’ve failed.”

“If you are using the goal of getting Catra back to her people, then yes, you have failed,” Lighthope said neutrally.

Adora prickled at her bluntness. “You’re not very nice.”

“Nice is unimportant when the safety of the planet is at stake,” Lighthope said.

Adora exhaled and sank down onto the table, head resting in her arms. “Yeah, I suppose it isn’t.”

"We must all make difficult choices. You cannot expect the life of one person to weigh more than that of the entire world."

Adora resisted the urge to fix her poof and ponytail. Getting Catra here just hours ago had felt like a dream. But dreams turned to nightmares so quickly sometimes, didn't they? "I'd like to see her." She demanded firmly. "Can I at least choose to do that?"

Lighthope frowned at her, but Adora couldn't tell whether it was from pity or not. "You may."

Adora was led out of the interrogation room to find Bow and Glimmer also waiting to see Catra, with the indignant declaration of "Of course we're going!" from Glimmer. Together, they were taken through Ft. Irwin to a much fancier jail than the one they had been in that morning.

Catra's second cell on this planet was nicer than her first. That was a low bar, but Adora's government cleared it by virtue of there being an actual bed (bolted to the floor) and a bathroom with a curtain (a translucent curtain). No privacy – one of the walls was floor-to-ceiling glass – but it was more space than she got aboard the Fright Zone . . . so there was that at least.

The Fright Zone. The last time she'd been aboard that sweltering hulk felt so long ago now. Catra resisted pacing. Stars, she been down here long enough that being stuck waiting in a closed room was beginning to make her antsy. C'mon, Catra, get a hold of yourself, she thought.

People who had never left their planets might disagree, but waiting was a skill. Everyone who'd spent time in the Rebellion fleet knew it. The ability to keep yourself occupied, or at least relaxed and unbothered, during the weeks or months with nothing to do while traveling between solar systems without driving yourself insane took practice. Catra had been amazing at waiting. Now she was struggling to stop her toe from tapping.

The door to the room on the other side of her glass wall opened, and Adora, Glimmer, and Bow came in, led by Agent whatever-her-name-was. Of course, they had come to see her, and of course, they all had stupid, sad looks on their faces. “Hey, Adora.” She greeted her, then Bow and Glimmer. “Guys.”

“Catra,” Adora walked up to the glass and put her hand on it, fingers splayed. Her voice came through speakers in the ceiling. “I’m so sorry.”

“For what, Adora?”

“For this!” She gestured at the cell. “I promised I’d protect you from getting captured like this. I promised I’d get you home.”

Catra took a centering breath. “Hey, hey, it’s alright.” She spoke casually, walking up and setting her hand matching Adora’s on her side of the glass, their palms separated by an inch of acrylic.

“It’s not,” Adora said, tears welling in her eyes.

Bow and Glimmer approached beside her. “We’ll do what we can, Catra.” Bow assured. “To make sure you’re not stuck in here for long. We’ll get you out.”

Catra saw the agent’s face harden. So, she smiled and rolled her eyes. “And here I thought you were smart, Bobby.”

Bow, indignant but misty-eyed, glanced away, and Glimmer took the moment to speak. “Catra.” She exhaled. “I wanted to . . . I wanted to apologize.”

Ugh, these saps. “You already did.”

Glimmer clenched her fists, “I know. But still, I misjudged you. I **kept** misjudging you. It was wrong of me.”

“Sparkles,” Catra sighed. “Not your fault. My shadows made it pretty tough for you.” She looked around at the stupid emotional humans that had become her friends, all fighting tears, then at

the perfectly neutral look of Lighthope, that was her name, watching it all. “Come on!” Catra wined. “Are we just gonna mope here or are you gonna make this place less boring for me? Not exactly much to do in here.”

“But we have to be able to do something!” Adora suddenly sobbed, hand curling into a fist against the glass. “It’s not fair! You don’t deserve this!”

“Adora,” Catra said softly, feeling the desperate desire to dry her tears. Some part of her resisted the emotion, but she ignored the instinct. This was the end. There was nothing to lose anymore. “Hey, look at me, Adora.” Adora, after a shudder, met Catra’s eyes with her wet blue ones. Stars, her eyes were so blue, she thought for the thousandth time. No other species or being Catra had met had blue eyes quite like Adora's. She’d seen light blue ones and dark blue ones and even ones with vivid blues like her own right eye. But that flashing sunlit shine in Adora’s, with irises streaked like nebulae? It was unique. Liquid oxygen blue, sparkling and roiling like how it looked the instant before it caught fire. Her eyes were powerful: raw chemical potential energy made flesh. She tried to commit them to memory as she said to Adora. “It’s okay. I've known the universe is unfair for a long time. So, thanks for tricking me for a while.”

Adora’s gasped in a breath, and words, messy and broken, tumbled out. “We- we can come up with something they’ll let you tell The Horde. The truth, a lie, anything! Whatever it is they don't want to hear. That we're secretly really advanced, or-or on the verge of tearing each other apart! Or that we can’t be controlled! Whatever will make them decide this planet isn't worth it! Or if that won’t work, tell us what to do! I can’t just leave you like this, Catra! Please. Please, tell me what to do to fix this. I need to fix this!”

“They’re not going to let me talk to them,” Catra said.

“But there has to be a way.” Adora pressed.

There was no way these three humans just happened to have more hope between them than the rest of their species put together. No, that bottomless optimism, that determination, it really was just how humans were, wasn't it? Every single one had more fire in them than the entire populations of some planets she had been to. It was simultaneously baffling, beautiful, and a little terrifying. Catra had never thought any amount of hope would work on her like this, especially now. She had so little leverage left. Still, for Adora, she used it. "If you don't let me go home, the Horde will send more spies." She said to Lighthope. "Spies who won't be as cooperative as me."

"We will capture them as well," Lighthope said, as if any other possibility was utterly impossible.

"It took you over a week to get me." Catra challenged. "And I didn't even have a working radio."

"We did not know what to look for before your arrival," Lighthope said. "That is why we did not detect your landing craft. Its exterior was enveloped in a stealth coating that was most difficult to track."

Bow's eyes widened. "Ohhh."

"However, now that we know its composition, similar vessels will be far easier to find in the future," Lighthope revealed.

"So, you capture the next spies; then what?" Glimmer asked. "What if they send more again?

"We will capture them as well." Lighthope declared.

"And after that?"

"We will continue to apprehend spies for as long as necessary."

"Necessary until what?" Adora asked. "So, what, it'll just keep going on like that forever?

“Each time we capture a spy, more information will be gathered. And perhaps, continual failure of their missions will inspire The Horde to take a different approach.”

“You're hedging your bets.” Glimmer deadpanned.

“That is the optimal method of approaching this situation, per our available moves.”

“You're talking about this like it's a game.” Adora frowned.

“It is a game," Bow said. "Game theory."

"Precisely." Lighthope nodded. “There are two primary outcomes to this current scenario. One, contact with The Horde is prevented, at least for the time being, and two, contact is not prevented. In the event of avoidance, we are likely to learn more information. In the event of contact, there are two possible outcomes. Peace,”

“Or invasion.” Glimmer finished for her.

“Per all information provided by you, Catra.” Lighthope nodded to them. “We believe that should contact occur, the more likely outcome is invasion. Thus, we are incentivized to prevent that occurrence for as long as possible.

“The rebellion has been fighting for thousands of years,” Catra said. “They don’t give up easily.”

“You have said yourself, however, that our species is particularly stubborn,” Lighthope noted. “We shall use that to our advantage.”

Catra sighed and crossed her arms. Yep, all humans really were like this, even the ones that didn’t seem like it on the surface. “Well,” She said as casually as she could manage to her friends. “There it is.” There was nothing she could do. “I’m sorry, Adora.”

Adora’s eyes welled again. Catra looked at Glimmer, who took the hint and moved over to her sister, hugging her from the side and

pulling her head down into her shoulder, whispering calming words into her tears. Bow approached from the other side and leaned on the glass as he joined the hug. Catra blinked some kind of dust that was definitely in this room out of her eyes and slumped forward against the glass, taking deep, steady breaths.

No, the truth of her purpose on this planet coming out hadn't been the worst part of the mission; this part was. "You've all already done more than enough for me," Catra said to them softly. "So, all of you, don't worry about me." Adora wiped her murky eyes and stared at Catra unlike anyone ever had. "Go, Adora." She insisted to her, wishing she could hold her hand one more time. "Go and live spectacularly."

For me, she added selfishly in her head. If for nothing else, then do it for me.

Adora was inconsolable on the ride back to Goldstone from the prison. Bow and Glimmer tried their best, but "Please, just . . . not right now." She stopped them. There was a storm in her mind, and a black hole in her heart.

The mood when everyone reconvened in the antenna was equally somber. Adora took the hammock in the corner while Bow and Glimmer sat at the table. Casta was there when they got back, off her shift at the main facility, supervising the only happy person in the room, Entrapta, who – also having been released - was neck-deep in the wiring of the computer consoles, happily humming to a tune Adora couldn't place. Casta pulled out a deck of cards from one of the desks. "Care to join, Adora?" Her aunt asked. "Three thirteen?"

"No."

Casta turned the cards over in her hands. "I'm sorry about Lighthope." She said gently. "She's always helped me before. I guess . . . I didn't know her as well as I thought." Adora didn't reply to that. "Alright." Casta sighed. "Alright." She sat next to Bow

and Glimmer and dealt a three-handed game, and as the first few rounds passed, a conversation between the trio filtered, trying to come up with any solution to the predicament. To find a way to somehow communicate with the Horde in a way that would guarantee the safety of the Earth before getting Catra home. No good ideas appeared. Adora listened to it all, furious that she had only worse ones.

Glimmer won the first game by a landslide. Three Thirteen was mostly luck, but it didn't help that she seemed to be the only one listening to Entrapta's comments about the most statistically advantageous strategies while she worked. She would peek up at each deal and look at Glimmer's cards before scuttling away again. "How can you possibly be doing whatever it is you're doing and thinking about my hand at the same time?" Glimmer asked as they reshuffled for a second game.

"Oh, I'm done now!" Entrapta declared, emerging from the depths of the wall of consoles covered in decades of dust bunnies and grease. "The new subspace communications link is operational!"

"Entrapta!" Casta shot to her feet. "We talked about this! I said only reassemble the crystal!"

"I knowww!" Entrapta squealed as she turned to start flicking switches. Screens flashed on. "But this is uncharted scientific territory! I couldn't resist! Just imagine the kind of data this system could collect! If my theories are correct, we could study all kinds of celestial phenomena based on the mere impression they leave in the region of the universe this crystal can access. The mass and orbits of small exoplanets, the internal magnetodynamics of neutron stars! We might even be able to peer beyond the event horizon of black holes! These observations could completely change our understanding of reality itself! AHAHAHAHA!"

Adora was mildly creeped out by what could only be described as a mad scientist laugh out of Entrapta before saying. "Or communicate with Catra's ship."

“Oh yeah!” Entrapta waved her hand. “That’s easy. All you gotta do is push that big red button right there, and it’ll transmit whatever you say! If what Catra explained earlier was true, then they’ll be able to hear you.” She pointed at a large button on the wall of tape computers. It was tinted red glass and blinking slowly. On. Off. On. Off. Goosebumps rose up Adora’s arms.

“Entrapta!” Glimmer grabbed at her hair. “The changeling is still at large!”

Entrapta looked at her. “Who?”

Glimmer blinked. “The alien that’s been trying to kill us and can now call down an invasion using what you just built!” She said slowly.

“Ohhh . . . right,” Entrapta said, face blank. “Well! I’m going to get started on some initial surveys of the Orion Nebula. That should be a good test for the system’s range and resolution in detecting-HEY!”

She was grabbed by Casta, who dragged her away from the keyboard she had started typing at. “Oh no, you’ve done quite enough already, Entrapta.”

“But . . . but!” Entrapta lifted her arms towards her computers as she was dragged, heels sliding along the carpet.

They were kicked out of the antenna the moment Lighthope learned about what Entrapta had built. The techy girl had refused to dismantle her creation, insisting on the potential it had for research. That insistence got her taken away in handcuffs (again), and Adora, Bow, and Glimmer were moved to a different staff building a couple hundred yards away. Adora watched a chain-link fence being set up around the perimeter of the dish by soldiers as Casta led them inside what looked like a big communal dorm or hostel.

“We use this for big events that happen super late. Mars landings, important maneuvers, the like.” Casta explained. There were

easily fifty beds there for the now three of them. “Pick your poison.” She offered.

Adora chose one way in the back by the corner, sighing as she set her bag down. Unwelcome tears still pricked her eyes constantly. Sniffling and wiping them away, she unzipped her backpack and rummaged through it for her toiletries, only to realize they were still in the antenna control room. Curses bubbled in her throat as she found her phone instead, and against her better judgment, started to flick through the pictures she’d taken in the last week. Their selfie in Zion. Catra stuck in the snow during snowmobiling. The picture she’d taken of Catra working in the escape pod, looking so confident, frustrated, lost, and beautiful between the broken sooty sunbeams coming through the window above.

“One more thing,” Casta announced. Adora looked up, and her aunt’s face was conflicted, going between Adora and Glimmer and Bow, who were bunking next to each other a little ways away. “All your parents have been contacted. I believe they’re all going to be here sometime tomorrow morning.”

Dread coiled around Adora’s neck. She nodded at that information, or acknowledged it somehow as she sat on the bed, and her head fell into her hands. Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer and Bow were giving her nervous glances, but they gave her space.

Night was falling, and Adora felt tired, so tired. But sleep seemed less attainable than Catra’s freedom. So, she laid awake, staring at the yellowed drop tile ceiling and just . . . felt. Felt as the feelings piled up, heavier and heavier, like a pyramid was being built on her chest, until the weight was so much each inhale made her lungs burn and eyes sting.

Was this grief?

Grief for the life she had been so lucky to have with Glimmer, Angella, and Micah? The one she had thrown away for nothing. Grief for Catra, locked away, probably soon to be taken

somewhere Adora could never go, forever. Was it even possible to feel grief for something that hadn’t ended yet? Mourn someone that wasn’t quite gone?

She needed to move, get up. Turn some of the flood in her mind into motion.

C’mon Adora. Get up.

Her body refused her.

Get up! Get up get up get up GET UP!

A gasp unlocked her, and she tore out of the bed in a tangle of sheets and tears. She yanked on her coat and boots and headed for the door.

Glimmer looked up from where she was reading. “Adora?”

“I’m going for a walk,” Adora said back, hands jammed into her pockets.

“Adora.” Glimmer said, more concerned. Adora paused at the door and looked back at her sister. She knew that look. Glimmer seemed very torn on whether to let her go, but she nodded, and Adora went.

“She really does seem crushed.” Double Trouble finished their story. "It’s touching, in a sad way.” They were currently disguised as a security guard, which at this point seemed rather basic to Catra.

“What do you want?” She muttered through the cell glass.

“The short one fixed the radio. Big flashing red button in the control room. You can't miss it.”

Catra wanted to scream, wanted to unleash every vile word she’d ever learned from three dozen species at them. It really was over.

“Congratulations.” Was what she said instead. “You have my report. Now stop rubbing it in and just go press it.”

But Double Trouble neither gloated nor went and pressed it. Instead, they lifted the human card at their waist, which was apparently a real badge, and scanned it on a receiver. Catra’s cell door opened, and her eyes narrowed. “What are you doing?”

“Giving you a chance, Kitten.” They said. Catra remained confused, and Double Trouble sighed. “To finish the mission.”

Catra’s eyes widened.

“I really shouldn’t do this,” They continued. “After everything I’ve seen. But I’m nice,”

Catra scoffed, and Double Trouble scowled.

“If you’ve seen so much, what makes you think I’ll go and press that button?” Catra challenged. She looked out the open door. Freedom, beckoning. “Why would I ever trust you again?”

“Ugh, stars, look at you. I have told you you’re no fun, right?”

Catra had to take a steadying breath. “I repeat my question.”

Double Trouble shrugged. “You can’t be sure, honestly. I’m appealing to your morality here; call me crazy. But,” They stared at Catra with those yellow eyes that, for the first time, didn’t seem to be hiding anything. “You still have a chance to do the right thing. If you do, I’ll leave every little *traitorous* act you’ve done on this planet out of my report to Shadow Weaver.”

Catra’s eyebrows raised. “Ohoho yeah, I know she’s a bitch, I’m not an idiot. The Catra I knew before this mission didn’t deserve the hate she gave you. The one in front of me now though . . .” Double Trouble scratched their chin, glancing towards the rest of the prison. Others would notice the security breach soon. “I’ll also recommend Blondie and her little friends get put somewhere away

from the front lines. Hey, with both of us putting her into records, she might not even get drafted."

Catra looked at the open door, then back at Double Trouble, then back to the door.

"Last chance kitten."

Adora stood at the base of the antenna, hand resting on the links of the fence around it. Atop the wall were cameras facing the inner yard, watching with infrared vision for the shapeshifter. It was the cusp of night. The sharp orange band on the horizon – the coattails of the sun – brought the antennas into black silhouette. Adora looked up through the mesh surface of the dish, rusted and punched through with patches of deep indigo sky, and felt the ache deep within.

There was a red light on the tip of the tripod of arms that rose from the inner surface of the dish. It, like the red button she'd seen inside, flashed slowly.

On. Off. On. Off.

Adora didn't know why the light was there; there were no airplanes allowed to get anywhere near enough for it to be useful to them. Maybe they were there just because it felt right for big industrial structures like it to have big red blinking lights on them.

On. Off. On. Off.

Angella and Micah would be here in the morning. One of them would have to stay behind to pick up the truck in Vegas after it was fixed. Adora didn't know if she would be able to see Catra again. If she would even get to say goodbye.

On. Off. On. Off.

She'd intended to walk in the opposite direction of Echo dish, but now she was at its feet. Her fingers tightened on the steel chain-

link fence, and in her head, she calculated how long it would take to climb it, then the stairs, then make it inside to the button. It was far less time than any of the guards posted at the staff building would take to reach her, she knew. One button press, and her promise could be fulfilled. Catra would go home.

On. Off. On. Off.

"Gah!" Adora hissed. Her boots scraped in the soil as she turned away from the mocking tower of metal, fighting the hammer of her heart and shame in her chest with every step. Coward. One part of her snarled in her mind. No, you're not. Another immediately replied. It's not cowardice; it's sanity.

Sanity. Sanity, or an excuse?

Adora looked up to see where she was going and found herself at the beginning of a small trail up the hill beside the antenna. The same hill labeled with the 'GOLDSTONE' letters. The toxic swill that haunted her mind propelled her, and she climbed in the last dregs of sunlight. Her eyes adjusted in the settling darkness, legs brushing soft sagebrush leaves as she watched for rattlesnakes, even though her chance of encountering one was heavily damped by the cold.

Her mind was such a storm that she was actually surprised when she reached the top of the hill, blinking and looking out over the landscape in all directions. In one, antennas stood in a row, each red light on them blinking in sequence out towards the horizon. All, save Echo, were slowly following the turning of the sky. Adora followed their aim upwards. The near ones were pointing towards an orange dot high in the west. Mars.

Adora looked north to see Orion rising, brave and bright with his bow pointing upwards. She spotted his belt, then the Orion Nebula, then the black spot of sky Catra had pointed towards what felt like a lifetime ago. Somewhere there, like a mote of dust impossible to see in a dark room, was Catra's sun, a nuclear fire a quintillion times more massive than she. And though it probably

burned some 500 million tons of hydrogen every second to fuel that fire, it was invisible.

Adora thought of a fact she had learned binging space videos. About how light experienced no time. As *Interstellar* had first taught her, time for you slowed down the faster you went. Go fast enough, and minutes for you were centuries for anyone standing still. Photons of light, moving as fast as the universe would allow anything to move, experienced infinite time dilation. From their perspective, the moment they were created and the moment they struck something and were absorbed were literally the same instant. More bizarre, because no time passed during that instant, no distance could be traveled. To the photon, the beginning and end of its journey were in the same place. She was pretty sure there were caveats to that, something about how ascribing photons - a subatomic particle - a subjective experience at all was meaningless and broke physics, but it gave her goosebumps all the same.

Because it meant she was literally connected to the universe. Touching its furthest reaches in the strangest way, always, with every point of light. Her eyes and skin to the sun through the dying glow on the horizon, to Mars above her head, to every star now appearing above her. Even the dark patches, to stars like Catra's, too dim to make out, and the even fainter galaxies uncountable beyond, had at least a little light falling on her.

When she first learned that fact, her goosebumps had been from wonder. Now that wonder was tinged with fear. That light was also connecting her to distant battlefields, to warships, to the suffering of a galaxy at war.

Perhaps one of those uncountable numbers of photons coming at her from all corners of creation was from that seemingly black patch of night next to Orion’s sword. A photon that came from Catra's home star. Perhaps it passed down through the blue sky of her homeworld and bounced off of one of her ancestor's blue or gold irises, then back out into space. Where it flew blindly across the black, taking 2000 years and yet an instant before falling into

one of Adora's eyes. How lucky that photon would be to strike and connect two sapient beings like that.

Adora looked away from the universe and back towards Ft. Irwin, and couldn't help but notice how similar the view here was to that of looking towards town from the hilltop behind the cabin back in Idaho. A little patch of flickering gold in the cold rippling air; an orderly grid of human circuitry at the edge of a great dark wilderness. All of it watched over by stars that felt so close, and at least for a few days, some aliens as well.

Adora cried. Anger, sorrow, relief, longing, and dread all silently slipped out of her eyes and dripped onto the dry cold ground. Her teardrops froze into frost after they hit, turning into pointy bursts of white on an earthen canvas of dark grey, like stars shining through gaps in a snowstorm.

It didn’t feel like the end of the world.

Lighthope thought they were on the precipice. That contact, of any kind, would be fatal to the Earth they all knew, and therefore, any delay in contact was an advantage. Waiting, trying to capture Double Trouble and allow the Horde to make the next move: Adora knew there was logic in that. If this was a game, it was smart not to play when you didn’t fully understand your opponent or the rules.

All Adora would have to do to help that plan was nothing. She would just have to stand aside and leave Catra to her fate, whatever that fate might be. The government said she wouldn’t be harmed. The government said . . .

Doing nothing. It would be easy. It would be logical. Lighthope was just trying to protect the planet in the best way she knew how. Adora could go along with it. She knew in some way that she should go along with it. Look out for her and her own, her own planet, her own people.

But it still felt wrong.

If Adora compromised here, moved the bar, it would just be all the easier to move it again the next time, compromise a little more, do something just a little less okay. Where did it stop? When did questionable become abhorrent? What was the first shade of gray most people would call black?

Lighthope didn't care about such things, obviously. She wanted security, risk management. Catra had more or less agreed to their plan, though not by choice. Bow wanted her to be safe. Glimmer wanted a sister. Angella and Micah . . . well.

What did she want?

Adora scoffed, and twisted her head away. It was too late for that. What she wanted could wait until after this was all over. Whatever the outcome - whether she stood amongst the ashes of her planet or the bridges she'd burnt - could wait. What mattered now was what she could do now. If this was the precipice, Adora's toes were over the edge.

Now, and only now, she had the chance to jump.

Everyone had theories. Everyone had ideas on the best path forward. But no one, not Lighthope, not even Catra, could truly know which of the two outcomes would come to pass if - or when – humanity made contact with the Horde.

Humanity, who was so stubborn and so hopeful Catra thought they were insane.

Catra, whose confidence masked so much pain.

Catra, whose strength echoed the battles she had fought in, and the soldiers she had pulled out of them.

Catra, whose laugh convinced Adora to risk so much.

Catra, who thought she might be able to make a deal with the Horde, if she got the chance.

Catra, who wished that when her own people faced what humanity faced now, had acted.

Maybe Adora was insane, because here, at the beginning of the end, it all came down to two things. One: Adora trusted Catra, and two: Adora had made a promise.

She turned, then walked, then ran down the hill, towards the flashing red light.

On. Off. On. Off.

She stumbled once on the path towards the dish. The uneven ground sending her hands whirling and her legs into spiny brush. She ripped her jeans free, then ran faster.

On. Off. On. Off.

Her lungs were heaving at the bottom of the trail. She ran faster, dashing across the desert, legs pumping.

On. Off. On. Off.

She leapt at the fence, clambering up the metal links fast as she could, sharp steel digging into her fingers. Hands burning and her injured shoulder flaring with pain as she flipped over the top and barely slowed herself from falling down the other side. Her boots scuffed the dirt as she stood. The dish loomed.

On. Off. On. Off.

She crossed the yard. The stairs screeched in complaint as Adora thundered up them, arriving at the door. Her hand clattered on the doorknob. Locked.

On the clock. Adora's boot pounded against the old lock. Thump. Thump. Thump. The metal deformed. The twisting motion made Adora's shoulder scream. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. She felt the bolt shear. One more kick and the door flew open, crashing against its own hinges and the wall. Adora moved inside,

past old computers, towards the button. It flashed in a slow even cadence.

On. Off. On. Off.

She crossed the room, tripping over Entrapta's piles of electronics, coming to the button. She lifted her hand. Her fingers ready, she hesitated, just an inch away.

"Adora." A voice cut through the room.

Adora jumped a foot, head whipping to see a figure standing in the doorway. "Catra," Catra was looking right at her, eyes glowing. Her dark silhouette was outlined in stars.

"Adora." Catra repeated, and took a step towards her. Adora tensed. This could be Double Trouble. But then she said, "Step away from the button."

"What?"

"Step away, Adora. Don't do this."

"Wha- Catra, how . . . why are you here?"

Catra did not hesitate before she answered. "To destroy this."

Adora's entire body rocked. "What?" She croaked out. "Why?"

"Because that idiot in the suit is right. This is the best way to protect your planet. To protect you."

"But . . . what about going home?" Adora asked. "I can't just leave you in prison, Catra. I'm not just going to let you be locked up for years, possibly forever, when I can stop it!"

"And I'm not going to let you blow up your life, maybe your whole planet, for me." Catra replied.

Adora clenched her fist. "No. No, you don't understand. I have to do this. I want to do this. This is the only way to fix things, Catra.

To make sure you can have a future.”

“And what about your future, Adora?” Catra asked. Adora froze. “Eh!? What about yours!?”

Adora answered quietly, with her head hung. “I don’t have a future, Catra. Not anymore.”

Catra took a step closer to her. Adora flinched, finger twitching towards the button. Catra stopped. “You have a family that’s coming for you. You have a sister right out there. Glimmer is-”

“Glimmer’s not going to be my sister anymore.” Adora said.

Catra blinked “What?”

And here it was. “They’re not going to take me back, Catra. Angella and Micah. I disobeyed them. I betrayed their trust. I **stole** from them. There’s no coming back from that.”

Catra seemed to have not anticipated her saying that. “Is that how human families work?” She asked.

“It’s how sane humans work.” Adora replied.

Catra saw something then, an understanding Adora didn’t. “I thought we already established your entire species isn’t sane.” She said, arms opening.

“You don’t know them like I do.” Adora said. “You don’t know what the system is like for people like me - like us - on this planet.”

“I don’t.” Catra admitted. “But I can guess that what happens is up to your foster parents, isn’t it?” Adora looked into Catra’s eyes, and Catra knew it was true. “Then you can’t know for sure.” She said confidently.

“**I know.**” Adora insisted.

“Just like you know what will happen if you push that button?” Catra challenged.

“Those aren’t the same thing!” Adora cried.

Catra stared Adora down, her eyes piercing right into her soul. When she spoke, her voice was even and strong. “From the moment I met you, you haven’t given up on anything. Not once. Not even on me. So don’t you dare start now. Especially when what you’re giving up on is yourself.”

Adora stared back at Catra. “I need to do this.” She said.

The emotions on Catra’s face that she so often hid were shining bright as stars. Her hand was slightly outstretched, desperate to reach for her. “This can’t be what you want.” She said softly, desperately.

Adora felt those words like a force in her whole chest. Her hands were shaking now. “It's okay." Adora whispered, tears in her eyes. "It's okay. It'll just be me. I'll take the fall. I'm okay with it being my fault." She promised. “That way you, Glimmer, Bow, you’ll all be safe. You’ll get to go home, Catra. So, please. Go. The soldiers can’t find you here with me. Go, so you can be okay.”

“No.”

“Catra, please!”

“No!” Catra repeated. “I’m not leaving. I told you we’d stick together. That I would look out for you. This is me making good on that.” Catra took another step forward. Adora twitched again, finger hovering millimeters over the switch. Catra stopped. “Adora, please. Don’t do this.”

“I have to.”

“WHY!?”

“Because I made you a promise!” Adora sobbed.

“Don’t you get it!?” Catra roared. “I don’t care about that! I don’t care what you promised me! I don’t care about going home! I only care about you, Adora!”

Adora’s mouth fell open. “. . . You do?”

“Yes!” Catra cried. “Stars in the sky, yes! You’re more important than any promise in the universe! I don’t need any of them! I need you to be okay, Adora.”

Adora was stunned speechless. Her mouth remained agape.

Catra took a step towards her, and when she didn’t react, closed the distance between them and took Adora hand. “So please, don’t press that button.”

“But, what about going home?” Adora asked, eyes wide.

Catra laughed. “You’re such an idiot. I won’t go home.”

“What?” Adora asked.

“I’ll stay, Adora. I’ll stay with you. I’ll fight your government to do it, the whole damn planet if I have to.”

Adora’s finger hovered behind her over the button. She looked into Catra eyes, tears running down her cheeks. Adora took a shaky breath. Her finger wobbled, then retreated into a closed fist.

Catra’s exhale of absolute relief was followed by a desperate crushing hug. “Thank you.” She whispered into the crook of Adora’s shoulder.

Adora, in turn slowly wrapped her arms around Catra, and held on for dear life. For a long moment the stood there in the dark, Adora’s fists pulling Catra as close as she could. When they broke, Adora stared at Catra with wide eyes. “You’ll really stay? On Earth? With me?”

“There’s nowhere else in the universe I’d rather be.” Catra said.

The button pressed down.

“This is Agent One-One-Five-Two-Zero-One-Nine. Requesting extraction at source of this transmission. Code Five Six Two Blue. Tell Shadow Weaver to make a show for these primitives, Perfuma.”

Adora and Catra whirled to see the shadows move, and a figure emerge from where it had been crawling flat as a sheet along the wall. Double Trouble melted from a shifting black form, clapping slowly. “Bravo, bravo.” They sneered. “That truly was an incredible performance you two. It was so good, you almost made me forget how much I hate breaking my promises. Almost.”

Double Trouble attacked.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None
I was worried about this chapter, but honestly, I think it came out pretty spectacular!

Chapter 20: Promises

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra impacted Adora's side, shoving her out of the way of Double Trouble's first strike. Their arm passed between them, lengthened into a needlelike lance. Adora caught herself on a filing cabinet. Catra charged their assailant.

"Still too slow!" Double Trouble laughed, rippling like a mirage as they bent out of the way. "You'll have to be quicker than that if you want to-OWW!" They cupped their cheek. Catra snarled, green blood dripping off her claws. "Now that was just rude." Double Trouble wiped the cuts. "But I suppose it should be expected for a traitor." They spat the last word out like venom.

Catra leapt back from the return swipe, landing atop one of the desks. "Oh, I am so sick of your voice." She said, perched, then dove towards them, claws forward.

Double Trouble caught the snarling ball of fur and momentum, turning with the attack and throwing Catra over themselves towards the far wall. Catra crashed atop a desk and slid off the far side, dragging computer towers and monitors with her in a tangled mass of beige wires. Then they turned towards Adora.

Adora stole a glance back towards the door to the control room, still open to the night. Now would be an opportune moment for those soldiers she had tried to run in here ahead of to arrive.

Double Trouble noticed. "Don't worry. We won't be interrupted." Their grin curled upwards further than it should have been possible. "I killed all the guards." Adora's blood ran cold. "Come now," Double Trouble cooed, pacing towards them with fingers stretched into razor-sharp talons which squealed across a metal desk. "Neither of you thought it was weird you could just run right in here without being seen?"

Adora was frozen, shock locking her feet as the shapeshifter approached. No. That couldn't be- "Glimmer. Bow." She whispered.

"Oh, don't worry, they're alive, for-." A computer tower slammed into Double Trouble's back, sending them stumbling forward towards Adora.

"Stay focused!" Catra barked. She was in a rat's nest of cables, which she was fighting to rip off her.

Catra's words, as they always could, cut through the noise in Adora's mind, so when Double Trouble lunged up towards her, she was ready. When they came, Adora didn't panic; she didn't throw a wild punch. She waited for the first lightning strike to come, and stepped aside from it, reposting immediately with fist raised. She missed, Double Trouble twisting away almost lazily, eyes rolling. But Adora had been expecting to miss. She waited for the opposite arm to snake at her, bending unnaturally high in the way Adora had seen it do in the hotel and when they were fighting Catra in the alley. The instant she saw it, Adora dove to her knees, popping back up inside their guard and landing an upcut right to Double Trouble's chin. The bones of her knuckle rattled inside her hand. It was like punching heavy clay. But Double Trouble did stagger, head snapping back to an unnatural angle.

"That trick won't work on me anymore," Adora vowed.

Double Trouble growled and reset their neck with their hands. "I'll give you that one, Blon-"

Catra, now untangled, leapt from the shadows. She landed on Double Trouble's back, digging deep and down with both hands. The changeling cried out. Then their body rippled. Catra was thrown back in a black explosion of flesh. Their body, like a rising anvil-head cloud, dripped green rain onto the carpet from six huge gashes.

Catra landed on her feet, ears back and hackles raised. Double Trouble whirled instantly, body collapsing into a slender bolt that snapped across the room at impossible speeds. “You selfish traitorous bitch!” They screeched, and Catra had to scramble backwards out of the path of their liquid claws, crescent tips as long as hands.

She crashed back into Adora, hitting her on her bad shoulder, which smarted in pain. Adora grit her teeth and pushed past it. They shared a glance. Determination. Trust. They were side by side when Double Trouble came again.

Catra swung for their face, Adora kited right, kicking down at one of their legs. Her boot bounced off their knee harmlessly. Double Trouble smiled. Adora was sent flying back with a battering ram hand to the chest, feet leaving the floor before she struck the far wall in the middle of her back. Pain spiderwebbed through her chest like lightning as all the air was driven out of her lungs. She slumped down onto the carpet, gasping for breath.

Catra’s eyes didn’t leave their opponent, only taking a step over to put herself between Adora and the heaving oily mass. “Why!? Why did you fight this!?” The changeling demanded, shrill and furious. They came at Catra hard and fast, and trading a flurry of blows that Adora could barely keep up with. Each one Catra landed seemed to mean nothing, whereas Catra had to juke and stagger to check each given in return. Her arms came up defensively near her head, fighting like a street rat, taking hits and giving back with opportunistic gut checks. But she could only last so long.

A hit on the shoulder opened Catra’s guard. Double Trouble slammed their fist into her cheek. “You know it’s pointless!” They roared, going for a cross with the opposite arm. Catra ducked below it and lunged with arms open, tackling them both to the ground. There was a tumult of blows and kicks. Double Trouble’s limbs bent and hinged in every place they shouldn’t, until one found purchase and Catra was hurled off them again.

This time Catra hit a desk in the middle of her back, and Adora let out a shout as she watched Catra fold unnaturally, then crash down. She was slow to get up. Double Trouble didn't so much as stand as flow seamlessly into an upright posture. Their eyes slid around the circumference of their head until they faced Catra again, knees switching from folding one way to the other. "No matter what you do, this planet will join the Rebellion." The changeling assured.

Catra fought to stand, getting an elbow under her. "They're going to resist." She grunted. "We both know that."

"They're going to be a part of something bigger." The Changeling destined.

"And millions will die. Millions and the guards you killed just now."

Double Troubled laughed. But it wasn't mocking. It was low and cynical and dark. "Ohoho, you think I'm the monster here, Kitten?"

Adora realized they were no longer putting on an act.

"You know what the rebellion could do for this planet." Double Trouble continued. "You've seen it. All the wars these humans are fighting with themselves? Ended. All the diseases they die of? Eradicated. All that raw potential this species has, that we've both seen? Channeled for the liberation of the universe." They loomed over Catra. "Compared to that? The 23 guards I killed were a bargain."

"Shut up," Catra growled, trying to stand. She received a swift kick to the stomach for her efforts, and crumpled, wheezing.

"You think this is all about you, don't you!?" Double Trouble continued. "Well, it isn't!"

Adora forced her diaphragm to work, pumping oxygen back into her lungs. The adrenaline was starting to kick in. She felt it like an itch in her bones.

“But ***you*** . . . you really are that same tempestuous child I saw when you first came aboard the Fright Zone. The one who always had to make things difficult! I shouldn’t be surprised that this is where your character arc landed. So, tell me, my self-actualized little kitten, did turning traitor finally make you happy? Are you having fun?”

“I said, shut up.” Catra wheezed.

Adora, wind back in her lungs, forced herself to her feet. One of Double Trouble’s eyes slid across their head to look at her. One of their hands slithered down and seized Catra’s head, forcing it to look at Adora. A claw dug into the flesh of her forehead, and blood began to drip over her nose. “You could have done so much more for the rebellion. But if you really wanna die for this planet? For her? So be it.”

With a roar that sounded like the fire in some industrial furnace, Double Trouble dragged Catra along the floor forward by her scalp, hurling her into the air, where she collided with Adora. Adora tried to catch her as best she could, managing to stay on her feet while they righted each other, both looking up only to see Double Trouble stretched up to a towering height, nearly to the ceiling, and with two huge arms erupting from their back, wrenched one of the ancient computers from the wall. Lights went red all over the room as the shapeshifter lifted the sparking vending-machine-sized mass high and hurled it towards them.

“Adora!” Catra pushed Adora aside. Time seemed to slow. Adora watched Catra try to dodge the computer. But she’d taken too much time getting Adora from its path. The console caught Catra on the shoulder. She twisted away from it and crumpled, but the computer kept going, several hundred pounds of vacuum tubes and steel punching through the floor like it was made of cardboard.

The entire antenna shuddered. The steel beams in the floor screeched as they were bent and torn. Adora felt the motion in her stomach, heard the creaking of the walls and the pop pop pop

of bolts all around her breaking free of the decades of rust that had held them still. Between Adora and Catra was now a ten-foot-wide hole. Adora watched as the computer, unbothered, completed its fall, tumbling 40 feet down before crashing onto the dark, cold ground below.

"All I wanted was for you to complete our mission, just like all the others!" Double Trouble stalked to where Catra lay on the far side of the hole. "I tried to make it easy for you! Tried to put up with you! Stars, even tried just to have some damn fun along the way." Any semblance of charm drained out of their voice as they spoke. As it dripped away, underneath was revealed an empty burning menace, which they wielded with savage precision. "You are helping Horde Prime."

Catra's eyes went wide. "No. I'm not." She said, trying to press up onto her knees.

Adora herself tried to stand, tried to help, but her shoulder, her chest, her entire body shattered with pain. She fell back to her knees. Double Trouble stepped towards Catra, who rose, throwing a desperate punch, which landed against what looked like water. Double Trouble struck back tenfold, their entire body twisting like a whirlpool and slamming Catra back to the ground. "You are! YOU ARE!" As they grew angrier and angrier, Double Trouble's body lost any semblance of a humanoid shape. They melted and twisted into a boneless black and green apparition, sinuous as they swept from one blow to the next. Catra repeatedly tried to get up, but each time was struck down. Like fighting the tide, the moment she got her footing, the next wave of the black alien ocean was upon her.

In the flickering red computer lights, it was like watching the darkest thunderstorm, Catra taking each thunderclap to the head or body. Adora felt a cry tear out of her as she watched Catra absorb each blow. Each time one came down, the room shook, and the metal all around them groaned. Double Trouble's wrath was their eyes; jagged, fiery yellow pits of anger. Their hands were liquid shadows, claws and hammers and wrecking balls.

They screamed as Catra's blood began to splatter on the carpet, red mingling with the green.

They were going to kill her. They were going to kill them both.

Shoulder and spine screaming, Adora began to crawl – she couldn't manage more – along the floor, around the hole towards Catra as the beating intensified. She needed to do something, anything. She made it half the distance to Catra when the blows finally stopped falling. Briefly, silence returned. Catra did not get up.

"Did you think you could protect this planet?" Double Trouble growled, entire body vibrating to make the sound. "Become a little hero to them? All you were doing was signing their death warrants."

Adora was only sure Catra was still conscious when she heard her deny with a single word, coughing out. "No."

Panic filled Adora. She dragged herself another arm's length. Reaching forward, her hand ran over a cable that had been thrown across the floor when Double Trouble ripped out the computer. It was as wide as her fist. The dozens of wires inside sparked and crackled. She remembered what had happened when Mermista had hit them with her electric prod. Adora knew what she had to do.

"Horde Prime is coming." Double Trouble said. "You know he probably won't be stopped before he reaches this planet. Even if you stop Hordak now, the only thing that will buy this planet is a few blissful decades. Then, instead of dying fighting, as heroes of the rebellion, they will die screaming victims, their bones ground into an easy road for Prime to walk over towards inhabited planets beyond."

Slowly, incredibly, Adora saw Catra put an arm beneath herself through her tears. She began to push herself upwards. "I told you

. . . to shut up.” Catra gasped through phlegm and blood in her mouth.

Adora’s hand seized the end of the cable. Her fingers tingled. There was static on her tongue. She took a deep breath through her chest. The adrenaline was dulling what she realized was probably broken ribs. She looked up at Double Trouble, totally engrossed in Catra, and readied herself.

“The Rebellion is the only hope of all life in all the galaxy!” Double Trouble bellowed. “If you turn your back on it, you turn to him! You’ve never understood what’s at stake!”

“You . . . you don’t know what I went through,” Catra said.

“Was your planet scorched to ash by Horde Prime!?” The changeling roared. “Was your entire species nearly wiped out in hours!? Are you the only one left who knows the language your mother sang to you each night!?”

The next blow that fell was so heavy the entire room cracked. Adora felt the floor beneath her shift, then slope down, towards the hole. Adora began to slide. One hand on the electrical cable, her other clawed uselessly at the threadbare carpet. She didn’t slow down. She was going to go over. She dropped the cable, which rolled over the edge. But even both her hands scrambling for anything to grab onto wasn’t enough. It was pure instinct that tore the “Catra!” From her mouth.

Adora couldn’t believe it, but Catra looked back, and with a burst of strength, twisted, kicking upwards with both her legs and managed to get Double Trouble off them. They raced across the room as Adora’s feet, then legs, then hips went over open air. She gasped as she felt gravity take her, and terror gripped her heart.

Then there was a spine-chilling, tingling sensation over her hand, and her fall stopped. Adora pried open her eyes, looking up to see Catra holding her, a tendril of her skinsuit extending down and wrapping around her free hand. “I got you.” Catra exhaled.

A shadow appeared behind her. “Catra!” Adora cried.

Double Trouble’s foot stomped down on the prone Catra, pinning her in place. Adora reached around her, trying to get a hold on the metal beams of the floor, or the swinging end of the cable, whose tip was now twenty feet below, dripping yellow sparks down into the cold dark. Both were just out of reach.

Double Trouble looked down at them both with something like pity. “Why don’t you understand? Why don’t you primitives ever understand? Nothing is more important than the Rebellion.” They tolled. “Why!? Why are you doing this!? You fight this desperately for one planet, for one pathetic person! And yet you reject the opportunity to help thousands of worlds! To save trillions of lives!” One of their arms shot down, grabbing Catra’s head and twisting it so it would meet their eye. Catra glared back. “WELL!?” They demanded, releasing Catra’s head and raising the arm high, tip a curved scythe.

Catra’s head slumped back down. She forced a breath into her lungs and looked at Adora. Adora, hanging, looked back, then poignantly glanced at the cable. ‘Together’. She mouthed.

Catra’s eyes dilated, and determination returned to her face. She nodded, mouthed ‘Together’ back at her. It was the adrenaline, but that made Adora smile.

Catra twisted her neck, glaring up at Double Trouble, answering. “Because we made a promise.”

“A promise.” Double Trouble echoed in soft disbelief. “A promise?” They chuckled. A chuckle that turned into a shaking, unhinged laugh. “A PROMISE!? Well, if promises mean so much to you, let me remind you of another one you made, Kitten. The only promise that matters! The same one I made when we joined the Rebellion! The same promise Hordak made when his mind broke free from Prime!

That this universe can only truly live when the minds of every being within it can experience it!

That no matter how many of those beings, those worlds, are destroyed, their minds will never be forgotten!

And that when those minds fight together, anything is possible!

My mind is the face of the universe!

My mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed!

MY MIND IS MAGIC!”

On the word magic, Catra acted. With a mighty heave, she pulled Adora upwards. Adora felt the acceleration and closed her opposite fist. By the time her head was passing back through the hole in the floor, there was a rush in her ears. A rush that gave her fist the momentum to slam into Double Trouble and knock them off Catra.

Adora’s arc peaked when her feet were a foot off the floor, then she landed again, crumpling, but falling in the right direction. She looked up from where she had fallen and saw the cable right there, snaking along the floor and then over the edge of the hole. She lunged for it, grasping, then, hand over hand, began to pull it back up into the control room.

As she did, she looked over to see Catra. Who, with a wipe across her eyes and a roar that came from the bottom of her chest, managed to stand and charge Double Trouble one more time.

But her scream was drowned out by the roar of liquid flesh.

Double Trouble’s form twisted and expanded, arms and legs and body overflowing the desks surrounding them until a massive green-black geyser rose in the center of the room. Adora watched, terrified, as Catra, her Catra, charged fearlessly into the furious maelstrom. Adora hauled the cable up faster.

Catra landed. She ripped and tore with tooth and claw. Green blood mingled with convulsing flesh, splattering against the ceiling and walls. But the riptide was too strong, and Catra was ensnared in the deluge. Ensnaring became engulfing. Catra fought with her arms, trying to rip them free. But each time a hand escaped, the oily tendrils only came back stronger, and soon barely more than her eyes remained above the roiling muck.

"You accused me of working for him." The words reverberated out of the Double Trouble's skin in all directions, so twisted they were barely intelligible. Despite that, Adora knew every emotion in them: fury, desperation, insult, anguish. "For being a pawn in his conquests!"

Adora pulled up the last foot of cable. The end crackled, a spark jumping to her hands. She almost dropped it; shock making muscles twitch, but held on. She turned towards the shadow, which was drawing Catra deeper, black tendrils reaching for her face, forcing her mouth open. "I'll admit it, I put you on this stage." Double Trouble boomed. "But you cast me as the villain, Catra. And now, you're going to see my performance." Black flesh began to cover her mouth, ready to plunge down her throat.

With a last burst of strength, Adora lunged forward, driving the end of the cable as deep into Double Trouble as she could.

All the lightbulbs in the room exploded as the most inhuman sound Adora had ever heard bellowed from the shapeshifter. Their entire body convulsed. Adora pushed the cable deeper. The flesh around the end smoked and bubbled. Limbs emerged from Double Trouble's form, sharp and broken and twisted; spikes and arcs of every color erupting all over their body, flickering and flashing like a shattering kaleidoscope as they seized.

Then, all at once, they collapsed. The spines and tentacles went limp as their entire body fell to the floor in a splashing heap, and became a slowly expanding smooth blob on the floor, barely an inch high.

From within the core of the sludge, a form began to emerge. “Catra!” Adora gasped, crawling towards her. “Catra, are you okay!?” She grabbed her shoulders and hauled her from the thick slime, pulling her into her lap. Blood, mixed with black sludge, dripped from several cuts on her head. “Catra? Catra!?”

Catra coughed. Adora cried out in relief, any words she might have said overcome by the emotion. Catra turned and hacked up globs of muck from her throat, then sucked in a desperate breath, slumping back into Adora, pressing an ear against her chest. Slowly, she opened her eyes and smiled.

“Hey, Adora.”

“Hey!” Adora laughed through the reply, relief shocking her. She reached down and clutched her close, tears tumbling down her cheeks. After a second’s pause, Catra’s arm came up around Adora’s back, fisting her shirt and desperately pulling her head into the crook of her shoulder. “Are you okay?” Adora asked.

“I’d say I’ve had worse but . . . I haven’t.” Catra said with a jokey tone. “I think most of my ribs are broken.” Adora pulled away to look her in the eyes, terrified. “But I’ll be okay, Princess. I’ll be okay.” She assured.

They sat there, breathing for a long moment. Then, shouts in the distance, the sound of engines. Soldiers were finally coming. Adora looked down at Catra, whose eyes were closed again and mouth curled up into a small smile. Adora guessed the adrenaline would wear off soon, and they’d both be in a lot of pain. But until then, Adora reached down and pressed a loose lock of wiry hair behind Catra’s ear. She purred softly. “So, this is familiar, huh?” Adora said to her.

“Huh?”

“You, in my arms, in a pile of goo.” Adora smiled.

Catra chuckled weakly, but it felt so good to hear her laugh. “Just like when you found me?” She opened her eyes.

“Just like when I found you,” Adora confirmed.

Catra shook her head, then reached up and wiped some of the slime from Adora’s shirt. “At least that goo wasn’t made of people.”

“Yeah, I’m trying not to think about that,” Adora whispered. Catra laughed again, a smile lighting up her face through the cuts and bruises like a sunrise, and Adora was struck with two thoughts simultaneously. One, that she wanted to make Catra smile like that forever, and two, that this might be one of the last times she would ever see that smile.

“Three for three, by the way,” Catra said.

“What?”

“Saves. Me catching you makes three each.” Catra clarified. “We’re even now.”

Adora smiled. “I guess we are.” She said, but that was a lie. Adora would never be able to repay Catra for everything she’d done for her.

Then, a familiar voice in the distance, joining the approaching chorus of stomping boots. “What the hell is going on here!” over the clattering of chain-link as it was pulled down, then a small crowd appeared through the hole in the floor. Near the center was Castaspella. “What’s happened!?” She asked the soldiers she was with. “What . . . is this?” She dipped a toe in the small pool of alien that was dripping down from the control room.

“It’s Double Trouble!” Catra shouted.

Eyes and guns went up. “Catra!?”

“Here!” Catra cried, exhausted.

“I’m here too!” Adora echoed.

“Adora!?”

“Auntie Casta, we got them,” Adora revealed.

Her aunt looked down at her feet, then recoiled with disgust. Pulling out a walkie-talkie, she reported. “Yes, security. I’ve found Double Trouble. At Echo. They’re . . .”

“Unconscious.” Catra coughed out, and the fact that Adora hadn’t killed them was a relief to Adora.

Casta reported that as well. “Yes, bring the mobile container, quickly.”

As neither Adora nor Catra found they could stand, they sent a single soldier up the now very unstable stairs into the control room, who brought them down one by one. There, they were laid down on the soft sand and told Casta what had happened. Adora was too tired to lie. Casta probably should have been angrier, but she just looked exhausted.

Stretchers arrived, which turned out just to be scavenged cots from the base’s barracks. Catra and Adora took one each. The dozen or so others weren’t going to be following them to the base hospital.

As the stretchers were hefted up by two soldiers each, Casta followed along, saying, “Come on, you two. It’s finally over.”

Adora and Catra just looked at one another, knowing she wasn’t wrong.

Glimmer was woken from a light doze to Seahawk and Mermista coming into the staff building. The expressions on their faces said everything. She cursed under her breath as she sat up, wiping her eyes. “What now?”

Mermista looked at her, then at her partner. “I’ll get Bow. Be quick.” She said to him before walking over to the boy’s cot. He,

also just being disturbed, opened his mouth to protest, but was led outside after a brief exchange Glimmer couldn't hear.

Glimmer noticed that Adora wasn't in the room with them and felt something twist in her throat. "What the hell did she do now?" She asked as Seahawk walked over to her bed and told her. Glimmer's curses spattered out between her lips like water on a hot pan.

"We don't know exactly how many dead there are yet." He told her.

"But my sister, and Catra?"

"Moderate injuries." He said. "Broken ribs. They'll both recover."

Glimmer exhaled, shaking her head. Then her next question. "Why are you here? Where's Lighthope?"

Seahawk didn't answer, instead sitting beside her with a wince. A hand cradled his chest, still bandaged beneath his half-open shirt. He saw her concerned expression. "Fret not, I'll heal." He waved her off. "And when I do, I'll have quite the **adventurous** story to tell about this!" He laughed, but the mirth didn't quite reach his eyes. After a moment, it dropped away, and he sounded more serious than Glimmer had ever heard him be. "I have a favor to ask, my little crewmate."

"Crewmate?" Glimmer lifted an eyebrow.

"Of course!" He smiled again. "You rode with me and my darling Mermista into danger aboard the Dragon's Daughter III! That makes you a member of the crew in my book."

Maybe it was because she was just waking up, but Glimmer had somehow learned to find Seahawk's insistence on roleplaying some bygone mariner charming instead of strange. "What kind of a favor?" She asked.

“Can I trust you to tell the truth? To speak your mind, no matter the pressure?”

Glimmer squinted at him, trying to parse what he said. She would have thought this was another of his bits, but the way he was looking at her was too serious, too grave. “I . . . I’m not-” Seahawk raised a hand towards her, stopping her from sputtering out a dozen noncommittal words.

“Can you?” He pressed her.

Glimmer, sensing the gravity of it, took another moment. She thought deeply. Then, she answered. “I can.”

Seahawk clapped her on the shoulder. “Atta girl. I knew you’d be perfect.” He pulled his phone out of his pocket. “She’ll probably ask you some rather direct questions.” He said as he punched in a number. “Give her direct answers. Tell her what you think, got it?”

“Okay?” Glimmer said. “What are you doing? What’s happening?”

Seahawk smiled at her. “Mutiny.” He pressed dial and put it on speaker. “Hello, we’re ready.” He said to the receptionist who answered. Glimmer wondered how he got his phone past the radio dead zone right up until they replied with,

“Very well, please hold for the president,” and Glimmer’s eyes nearly flew from her head. A moment later, the line connected and a voice she’d only heard on TV came up out of the phone.

“Agent Lighthope.” The voice of the President of the United States said. “I’ve been waiting for your update.”

“Apologies, Madam President,” Seahawk replied in an apologetic tone. “But my supervisor is unable to come to the phone right now. She’s still busy containing the situation that you were informed of earlier. My name is Agent Seahawk. She assigned me to speak to you in her stead.”

A pause. “This is unusual.”

“Well now, I guess that’s unsurprising after the week we’ve all had,” Seahawk answered.

A soft chuckle. “I suppose so; however, while I appreciate you reaching out on her behalf. I would prefer to speak to Lighthope herself. Please tell her to contact me as soon as she can. We have . . . several important matters to discuss.” Her tone changed, indicating she was going to end the call. “Good luck to you, agent Seahawk.”

“Actually, Madam President!” Seahawk said desperately. “Before you go. I was hoping to speak to you on the situation in front of us.”

“I assure you, agent, I’ve been briefed by the base commander. On that situation, I requested Lighthope’s opinion, not yours.”

“And if Lighthope is wrong?” Seahawk asked quickly.

Another pause. “You don’t have permission to do this, don’t you?” The President asked, this time with a warmer tone.

Seahawk tensed his jaw. “No, ma’am. I don’t. But my supervisor’s actions . . . I feel the need to make this call.”

A long pause here. Seahawk fiddled with his watch. “I am open to hearing what you have to say.” The president replied. “I’ll call you.” The line dropped dead, and Seahawk exhaled.

“What is happening!?” Glimmer asked Seahawk in a desperate whisper.

“Transferring to a secure line,” Seahawk said. The phone rang. He answered.

“All of this will be off the record.” The president said. “This conversation never happened.”

“Yes, ma’am.” Seahawk agreed.

“Say your peace.” The president offered.

“One question first, if you please,” Seahawk said.

“Yes?”

“Is it true the ship is coming?”

The president paused. “Multiple NRO assets have confirmed that the object believed to be the Horde’s ship has left the L2 Lagrange point and is accelerating towards the Earth. We estimate 12 hours before they reach the atmosphere.”

Glimmer’s eyes went wide. Oh my god. This was really happening.

“I see.” Seahawk nodded. “My partner and I have just spoken with Catra. She has requested political asylum in the United States and has expressed her desire to help with negotiations with her people.”

Glimmer’s eyes went wider. Catra wanted to stay? But then, as soon as she thought that, it didn’t seem shocking at all. Of course she wanted to stay.

Seahawk was continuing. “Lighthope has dismissed this outright. I believe that is a mistake.”

“Catra?” The president asked.

Glimmer balked. She didn’t know? “That’s her name.”

“Whose name?” The President asked. “Who is this speaking?”

Glimmer’s spine jumped straight when she realized she had spoken up. “Umm . . . oh . . . umm . . . my name is Glimmer Brightmoon, ma’am. My- My sister, Adora, was the person who pulled Catra, the alien, from the wreckage. I’ve spent the last several days with her.”

“I wanted you to speak with Glimmer to get a closer understanding of who this person is.” Seahawk clarified.

“I see.” The president hummed. “And by this person, you mean one of the aliens who was sent here by a belligerent regime explicitly to infiltrate our planet and gain an understanding of our defenses.”

Seahawk looked at her, encouraging her to speak. Glimmer, somehow, managed to find words. “That . . . is a good reason not to trust her.” Glimmer began. “I admit I didn’t trust her in the beginning either. But after talking with her, travelling with her, I’ve learned who she really is.

“And who is she, really?” The president asked.

“She’s umm . . . sassy, Madam President. Witty, quick with a joke, or an insult with a smile. I suppose that doesn’t cast her in the best light either, but . . . she’s a bit of a shit, to be honest.” Glimmer chuckled.

“I see.”

“She’s also someone who's done terrible things.” Jesus, Glimmer, she thought to herself. Laying it on a little thick. “**But** she did those things because she’s someone who never had a choice growing up. Who’s done everything she’s done to survive. Who, when presented with this place, decided to make a change. She told us about her secret mission; she protected us from Double Trouble.”

“Double Trouble?”

Glimmer laughed awkwardly. “That’s the shapeshifter’s – the other alien’s - name, ma’am. And I know, it’s strange.”

“Well, what isn’t anymore.” The president mumbled, half to herself. “At least we have the both of them now.” She got the sense the president was rubbing her face in exhaustion.

“Catra’s brave, Madam President.” Glimmer continued. “She’s smart, pragmatic, knowledgeable, and she defends her friends. She’s saved my life several times in the last couple days.” She took a breath. “Basically, Catra knows the Horde better than anyone else on this planet. She’s lived there, served with the ship that’s coming, and if she says she wants to help us against them, I believe her. I think she has a better chance than anyone of . . . well.”

“You said, friends.” The president noted. “Would you consider yourself her friend?”

Glimmer’s words caught in her throat, but only for a moment. “I would.” She confirmed. “I trust her.”

“Understand what you are saying, Glimmer.” The president pressed. “We could be placing the future of the entire human race into her hands. I can see the rewards, should it come good, but the risks of her sabotaging the negotiations.” The president trailed off, then seemed to get to the 8-billion-person question. “Glimmer, deep down, fundamentally, do you believe we can trust this individual?”

That Morning:

Glimmer sighed and set her head against the bricks of the county jail, her skull resting in the mortar seam between two. "I know you're awake." She said in a whisper to the cat curled up on the bench on the far side of the room. Unlike her unhearing human friends, Catra opened one huge eye towards Glimmer, golden iris alien and alert, waiting for her to say her peace.

"Did you make friends like us?" She asked. "On the other planets?" Catra said nothing, so she continued. "Because you're young, as young as us, according to Adora. Which means you're probably not super respected by adults on other planets, yeah?"

The alien remained silent.

"So, you're pulling these *E.T.* pranks on people like us, kids looking for adventure, looking up." She exhaled, exhausted, pinching the bridge of her nose and holding it there, blocking her vision. “Only for them to look up into an invasion.”

Catra spoke. "I didn't make friends like you."

"Not like Adora." Glimmer corrected for her.

Catra exhaled, not replying, and Glimmer nodded grimly. Why was she so special? "They don't have it figured out up there, do they?" She asked, peeking over her thumb.

Catra's tail twitched. “No.”

“Yeah, I figured.” Glimmer sighed. “Never a magic bullet, eh?”

Catra’s eyes narrowed, but not in anger. “I didn’t . . . I haven’t ever made a friend like you either.” She said. “Nobody who *sees*.”

Glimmer lowered her hand and looked unblinking at her single open eye. "I think so too." She admitted.

Catra's ears moved ever so slightly downward. "Would you? Make friends? Were you me?"

Glimmer was quiet for a long breath, mind full of the fluorescent hum of the lights above her. "Get some sleep, I'll keep watch." Glimmer told her. Catra stared for a long moment. "We'll all need it." She added, and Catra shut her eye.

Present:

“I do.” Glimmer said. “I trust her. I think that she’s trying to do the right thing now.”

There was a long pause, then the president said. “Well, I would like to speak with this Catra before making any final decisions, but I believe that you have made a strong argument in favor of

allowing her to help.” Seahawk pumped his fist in victory. “But as for the other matter . . . You say this alien has requested political asylum?”

“She has, Madam President,” Seahawk confirmed.

“Your thoughts on this, Ms. Brightmoon?”

It felt weird to be called Ms. Brightmoon. “She doesn’t seem to have much connection to her people.” Glimmer said. “No family. No ties.” She pursed her lips. “She’d be happier here.”

The president sighed again. “Well, in a perfect universe, perhaps that could happen. But Catra isn’t human, and presumably a citizen of this Horde Rebellion. We have no treaties with them, or way of knowing how they will react to an attempt for us to – from their perspective – remove one of their people from them without their consent. They could insist upon her return.”

“Asylum would protect her from that,” Seahawk noted.

“It would . . . but we’re not dealing with a rogue state here. We’re dealing with an alien empire that might consider her return a red line. And if exchanging her is what keeps all of us safe . . .”

As she trailed off, Glimmer’s brain was originally nodding along to his train of thought. But as she followed it to its conclusion, it turned bitter on her tongue.

“Now, I wanted to ask about-”

Glimmer interrupted the President. “But that’s so cowardly!” She raised her voice suddenly, mouth moving before her head could catch up. “Shameful too! Talking about her like she’s some political bargaining chip!" Glimmer slapped her hand over her mouth. She had just said that!? “Umm . . . no offense, ma’am.” She amended, horrified.

Silence blanketed the line, so Seahawk stepped in. "Glimmer, I’m afraid she is a bargaining chip.”

But the president, voice neutral, said, “Continue.”

Glimmer was shaking, heart hammering. “Umm . . . she’s umm . . . not, ma’am.” She insisted. “Not just some thing. She's a person. A person from a faraway place, who just wants to be happy, to be free to make a life somewhere where she can be safe. Where she can choose her own future. Isn't that the whole point of this country?” As she spoke, some confidence she was hardly sure of the source of rose in her, and she spoke more clearly and firmly. “Tell me it isn't. Tell me that isn't what all humanity should strive for.”

“Tell me,” The president replied, voice hard. “Would you risk the entire planet for one girl?"

Glimmer swallowed, glancing at Seahawk, who was looking at her in a way that said. Answer honestly. “Maybe.” She admitted. “What’s the point of principles if you abandon them the moment they become hard to uphold?”

Another long pause. “Madam President?” Seahawk asked when the silence stretched.

“Kids, man, you got more hope than sense.” The president said. “Thank you for your honesty, Glimmer, and . . .” She could almost hear her smile. “For sticking to your guns. *That* is a rare thing in someone your age. You’re a very brave young woman, to have gone through all this, and supported your sister the whole way.”

Glimmer swallowed. “Thank you. It’s . . . umm . . . an honor to speak with you, by the way, Madam President. Big fan.”

The president chuckled. “Well, I suppose it’s an unexpected pleasure to be speaking with you too, Glimmer. I hope you don’t go into politics.”

Glimmer’s brows knitted together. “And why is that, ma’am?”

“Because I don’t think I’d stand a chance against someone who's both so earnest and so fearsome.” She admitted. “Seahawk?”

“Ma’am?” Seahawk

“You’re a steely-eyed missile man, agent. I’ll give you that. I’ll be speaking to Agent Lighthope and the base commander about updating our response.”

“Understood, ma’am, thank you for your time.”

“Regardless of our actions, however, I want to offer the best to you both the best in these coming hours.” The President said. “It’s a straight gate, what we’ve got here.”

“And broad is the way that leads to destruction.” Seahawk finished a reference that Glimmer didn’t quite know.

“Indeed.” The president said. “Godspeed.”

The line went dead. A moment, then Seahawk turned to her and started laughing. “My god, I told you to speak your mind, kid, but Jesus!”

“I’m sorry.” Glimmer said, then changed her mind. “Wait, no! I’m not! I can’t believe you just sprung this on me!”

Seahawk clasped her shoulder again. “You’re right not to apologize. Don’t apologize to anyone for any of what you just did.” He said. “I am sorry for tossing you in the deep end, but I did it because I knew you could handle it.”

Glimmer balked. “How could you possibly know that?”

Seahawk smiled at her. “Because even though we’ve only just met, I can tell you're a brave soul, Glimmer." Seahawk insisted. “One who won’t shy away from speaking up, saying what needs to said, when everyone else is too afraid to. Every group needs someone like that, and it’s quite obvious you’re the one among your friends who does.”

Glimmer shut her eyes and nodded at the sagely words. “You can say that again.”

“I could, but how about I let you get back to bed." He removed his hand and stood. “Thank you again, truly, Glimmer. I’m very glad you were here.”

Glimmer watched him go, his words still sinking into her, but he was pretty sure he was right.

It would have been a shame to miss this.

Adora was taken back to the base and forced to shower inside a biohazardous stall. It was painful, but she managed to do this by herself and keep her dignity. Hissing through the sharp and dull aches, she removed all her clothes (including her favorite red jacket), which were ordered via speaker above through a hatch in the wall, never to be seen again. She was then told to scrub every surface of her body very thoroughly. Adora would have done that anyway, taking nearly half an hour to wash and beginning the process of never thinking about what had been touching her again. Nope, not going to question if Double Trouble would be okay with bits of them missing, or what the government was going to do with the bits that washed down the drain. Nope.

At least there was a seat inside the shower to rest her body somewhat.

When Adora stepped out of the shower, there were fresh clothes waiting for her. The undergarments and socks were hers from her bag, but everything else was new. There were what had to be standard-issue army boots, as well as a pair of gray sweatpants with the NASA worm logo going up the sides of the legs, and a blue sweatshirt with the NASA meatball logo on the front and a New Horizons mission patch on the shoulder. Outside the quarantine room, Castaspella was waiting with a wheelchair, and she babied Adora as she was rolled to get bandaged, X-rayed, and given an amount of painkillers that made her as worried as it made her feel better. The clothes had been from Castaspella, or rather, a closet at Goldstone which held old unclaimed merch. The sweater was a bit big, she told her aunt, but it fit.

The base medics couldn't do much about her broken ribs (she had two, by the way). She was just prescribed rest, ice, and more painkillers. But as she found out when she stepped back out of their office, she could walk.

"Are you sure you're alright to stand?" Casta fretted. "You can keep the chair."

"I'm okay, Auntie Casta. I really am. I want to walk." Adora insisted.

Casta nodded.

"Where's Catra?" Adora asked.

"She should be out of quarantine now." Her aunt said. "Which means the medics will be trying to find out from her how and how they can't treat her. I believe at minimum she needs stitches for some of her wounds."

Adora nodded. "Then I guess it's time for Lighthope to drag me back into the interrogation room." She sighed.

"Oh," Casta shook her head. "Oh no, honey. You're to go back to the bunkhouse whenever you're ready."

"What . . . but-"

"Lighthope has been suspended from command as of-" Casta checked her watch. "Fifteen minutes ago."

"Suspended?"

"There are 23 dead, Adora," Casta said. Adora froze. Double Trouble hadn't been lying. "When your security choices lead to that, well . . . there are consequences," Casta added, then briefly explained the believed timeline of events. All of the dead were guards that had been surrounding the staff house or the antenna. All were killed by Double Trouble in just a few minutes time in total silence and without detection. Adora didn't ask how they

died, but it was quick and quiet enough that not a single radio alert was raised during the massacre, nor did any of the hastily set up cameras on the fence see anything.

The last two to have died were probably the guards stationed just outside the door to the dorm block house (which Adora hadn't even known were there). They had been dragged around the building barely a minute before Adora stepped out for her walk. If she had looked down, she would have seen their last bootprints.

"Then . . . who's in charge now?" Adora asked.

"I am," Castaspella announced. "I just got a call from the President."

"I . . . you . . . the president!?"

"I know." Casta rubbed her forehead in exhaustion. "Strangely enough, she told me I have 'quite an impressive niece', though I have no idea how she would know such a thing."

Adora just needed to eject any sense of normalcy in her life at this point. Nothing was off the table anymore. "Auntie Casta . . . that's . . . you're . . . but you're-"

"Not remotely qualified for this role or a part of the military in any way?"

"Yeah," Adora admitted.

"I'll admit it is unusual. But these are extraordinary circumstances, and time is short. I'm more just coordinating. Mermista and Seahawk are assisting on the government side, and the base commander on the military side." Adora blinked at that. "Yes, it's all very complicated," Casta admitted. "But what you need to know is that right now I need you to go back to the staff house and hunker down with Bow and your sister. In the morni-"

"But what about Catra?" Adora interrupted.

“Catra needs medical attention. But after that, she and I, once I get the go-ahead, need to prepare for first contact tomorrow morning.”

“First contact?” Adora exhaled.

“Their ship is on its way, Adora.” She informed. “It’ll arrive sometime near sunrise.”

It was really happening. But before Adora could ask anything more, Casta’s walkie-talkie beeped. Mermista was on the other end.

“I’m sorry, Adora. I have to go,” Casta told her. “The guards will escort you back! Sorry!” She was gone in a stress-filled flash.

Adora, in somewhere between overwhelmed and in shock, allowed herself to be escorted back to Goldstone. There were now several hundred guards surrounding the antenna and surrounding buildings, with four standing at the door to the staff building.

Bow and Glimmer tackled her as soon as she stepped inside. The latter gave her one last half-hearted chewing out for being an idiot. Adora didn’t even try to argue. Hell, it was almost appreciated at this point. It was 11 PM, and Adora was as tired as she was awake. She sat with them, half teary, half scared, and soon they had three beds pushed together against a wall, all sitting in a pile of blankets from the 70s and listening to Glimmer as she read the end of her book aloud. Adora tried to stay calm, in the moment. Her fingertips ran over the coarse weave of her blanket over and over, trying not to worry about what was now on its way.

“You think they’d let us sit outside?” Adora asked at one point.

“Only if you promise not to call down the apocalypse again.” Glimmer replied dryly. Adora looked back at her, and it was obvious on Glimmer’s face that that had sounded funnier in her head. “Sorry.”

“It’s okay.” Adora hung your head.

Bow leaned over to her. “It wasn’t your fault.” He read her mind, rubbing her back gently. “Double Trouble did it.” Adora nodded. That was true, but it was hard to make herself believe it. “You know, I think I saw a fire pit around the side of the building when we got here.” Bow noted.

Glimmer straightened. “And didn’t Casta mention snacks?” She added. “I wonder if they have stuff for smores?” A smile crossed her face, and she crawled out of the sheets. “I’m gonna go look!” She ran off into the back of the building.

Bow went to help her. Adora headed, with his encouragement, to go ask the soldiers very nicely if they could have a fire. She slipped her boots on and opened the door, but her question caught in her throat. Catra was standing on the stoop, looking nervous. Her left arm was in a sling made from her skinsuit, half-hidden inside a new shiny zip-up NASA jacket of her own.

“Catra,” Adora said.

Catra’s face changed into a soft smile. “Hey, Adora.” She said tiredly.

“Catra!?” Glimmer and Bow’s heads peeked around the corner, then they charged her full speed, shoving Adora aside and wrapping Catra up in a tight hug. Catra yelped as she was lifted off the ground.

“Aiegh! Put me down!” Catra struggled as she was squeezed. “You’re going to break even more of my ribs!”

They relented, and the crushing hug became a long, gentle one.

“What are you doing here?” Adora asked. “Aren’t you supposed to be-”

“Your Aunt let me go,” Catra explained. “Told me to get some sleep before tomorrow.”

“They’re not putting you back in a cell?”

“Nope,” Catra announced. “Said since I’m helping there’s no reason to hold me anymore. Plus, you know, Double Trouble’s in a tube.”

“That’s . . . amazing.” Adora exhaled, and despite it all, found herself smiling like an idiot at Catra.

Bow saw the look on both their faces. “Let’s go find the rest of those snacks.” He said to Glimmer, putting a hand on her shoulder and starting to lead her back inside.

“But-” Glimmer protested before she was pulled away. “Fine.”

Adora smiled at Bow sympathetically before turning back to Catra. “I asked the guards for some space,” Catra explained, gesturing for Adora to come out with her.

Adora nodded, stepping into the night and shutting the door before all the heat escaped. Indeed, their four new guards were there, rifles hanging at their torsos, but they’d stepped back a good 40 feet. Close enough to monitor everything, but not enough to listen in.

“So . . .” Adora started.

“So . . .” Catra replied. She turned and sat on the single step up to the door, tail curled tight against her back. Adora sat down beside her. Their hands brushed, and Adora hooked her pinkie around Catra’s again. Catra shut her eyes, taking a deep breath. Neither said anything for a long moment.

Catra reached into her coat pocket and pulled out a small object, turning it in her palm. It was the pentagonal badge she wore on her breast, emblazoned with the winged symbol of the Horde Rebellion. Adora had never seen her take it off. “I’ve asked for asylum.” She broke the ice.

Adora looked at her. “You have?” She really wanted to stay.

“They said it might not work out. It depends on how tomorrow goes, but . . . I have to try.”

“How tomorrow goes?” Adora tilted her head.

Catra rubbed her pinkie against Adora’s. "They’re going to keep me if they can. See if they can give them Double Trouble and let me stay.” She paused. "But they're going to give me up if it keeps your planet safe."

At least they were being honest. "I’m sorry."

"Yeah."

Adora hated that she had to ask the next logical question. "What happens if nothing works? If they still want the Earth?"

"I don't know," Catra confessed and looked upward at the looming stars. “Your planet might be screwed, Adora.”

Adora inhaled and held it. All those doom-and-gloom things that had been said about the Horde echoed around her head. She exhaled. “Well, don’t count us out yet.”

Catra took her eyes off the sky to stare at Adora in bewilderment. “Are you ever not optimistic?”

Adora just stuck her tongue out at her, hiding the fact that she was definitely not optimistic about tomorrow. “Well, if anyone can do this, you can, Catra.”

Catra looked at her. “You really think I can convince them." She realized.

Adora nodded. “I do.”

Catra took this in. “I’m going to try to do both.” She said. “Convince them and stay.”

“I know.” Adora smiled. “I’m glad.”

Silence fell over them again. Adora tried to squeeze Catra's hand, but hissed when the motion sent threads of pain across her chest. Catra looked so guilty. "I'm fine," Adora said. Catra just looked at her. "Okay, I'm not totally fine, but it's nothing bad. I'll heal."

"You got hurt," Catra said.

"Not as bad as you," Adora noted back at her arm tucked tight against her chest. "Is it?"

"Broken? Yeah." Catra admitted.

"And your ribs?"

"Six broken, more cracked."

Adora just about panicked. "I'll heal too," Catra insisted, "And faster than you, according to the doctors." She smirked, but it faded away into discomfort. "But still . . . I'm sorry."

Adora bumped her with her shoulder. "S'okay."

"Shouldn't be." Catra said. "You shouldn't have been put in danger. You shouldn't have had to go through any of this."

"That wasn't your fault," Adora insisted. And why was that so much easier to insist to Catra than to herself? "Besides, we're only here because I decided to take us on this crazy road trip in the first place, remember? I wanted to help you."

Catra looked into Adora's eyes, then back out at the stars. "You once told me I was stronger than you could ever be." She began. "But you're wrong, Adora. You thought you were giving up everything you ever had. A loving family, a bright future." She paused and laughed breathily. "And then you go and try and do something that might end your entire world . . ." She sighed. "When I left home, I had nothing. Nothing to go back to. Nothing to give up." She pulled her hand away, clenching it into a fist. "And it was so hard. It was still so so hard to leave."

Adora needed a moment to process all that, and not focus on how Angella and Micah were on their way. "Catra," Adora rebuked softly. "You were signing up for a war. It's okay to be scared of that, even if you saw it as your only way out."

"Why?" Catra hissed, wiping away unwanted tears from her eyes with a scowl. "Why did you do that? Why help me? What drives you to sacrifice everything, Adora?" Catra finally looked at her, mismatched eyes desperately searching for something.

Adora met those shining planets, that glowing sun and moon, then leaned forward, touching their foreheads together, and thought for a while. Why had she done all this? Why risk herself? Her family? Her whole species? Her head swirled with reasons. Noble ones, selfish ones, self-deprecating ones. She didn't have a full answer when she simply said, "Who would I be if I didn't help someone when they needed it most?"

Catra released a breathy laugh. "You are such an idiot. You would be just like everyone else, Adora. Just like everyone else."

The door opened again. "We found all the stuff we need for . . ." Bow started, trailing off when he saw the position they were in.

Adora and Catra jerked apart, with Catra leveling a stare at the knowing looks on his and Glimmer's faces. "Not a word," Catra said darkly.

Glimmer put her hands up innocently, and Adora knew she was resisting laughing. "Join us for smores?" She asked instead of mocking, holding up a bag with wooden marshmallow sticks sticking out of it.

Adora looked at Catra, who smiled. "Smores sound perfect."

The guards did - after asking very nicely - let them have their fire. They backed off to a little rise forty feet away, but otherwise didn't interrupt as the four of them settled on the smooth stone benches set around the pit. Bow had a bag of firewood under one arm and

a pile of blankets under the other. Glimmer had the same but with smore materials.

In that way, they all sat together around a little fire sharing sugar and stories under the stars. Catra mostly stayed quiet, leaning against Adora through the night, sticking close, head in the crook of her shoulder. Adora kept her arm wrapped comfortably around Catra's waist, ear tickling her neck. A quilted blanket with NASA patches sewn all over it hung draped over both their shoulders, fringes dancing when their soft laughter stirred desert winds. She was purring again. Bow told of inventions exploding. Glimmer of the huge list of rules Razz had given her to take care of Swiftwind. Adora of her and Catra's (now pretty funny) attempt to drive through a blizzard. Catra of-

"What's the coolest place you've ever been to?" Glimmer asked her while she happily set her next marshmallow on fire to get it blackened. "I mean, you've toured the galaxy! I bet you've seen some pretty cool wonders."

"Well," Catra took a breath and considered for a long moment before answering. "I've walked the silent canyons of Katamara Durai." She spoke, quiet. "Climbed the thirty-mile-high cliffs in hard vacuum. I've hung in rings around worlds a hundred times the size of this one. Seen black holes consuming stars. Watched pulsars scorch ships to ash in a millisecond. Crawled across barren planets with three times this gravity. I've fought on worlds where the sun never sets, where even over the screams from plasma burns you can still hear the heartbeat of the trees. The way they shuffle slowly over the landscape, always jockeying for daylight, towering fan sails flush with blood, staining everything red. The way their roots wrap around the bodies-" Her voice caught, and shadow lines of despair formed then vanished into a hard mask. She wiped her eyes quickly, finishing with, "Yeah, I've seen some wonders. But none of them are quite like this place. None of them are like you guys." She gestured to the group.

Adora tugged Catra a little closer. Glimmer reached over and held Catra's shoulder briefly. Bow lifted his perfectly golden

marshmallow out of the fire. “A toast!” He announced. “To the best friends squad.”

Adora and Glimmer lifted their own marshmallows in salute. “The Best Friends Squad!” They echoed, then looked at Catra, who lifted her stick.

“The Best Friends Squad.” She said with a soft smile, and they all touched marshmallows. They were all done to their own preference, so assembly began, Adora happily taking Catra’s offered chocolate so her own could have extra.

Something beeped somewhere. It was Bow’s phone. He pulled it out and muted it, smiling softly.

“Whafds dhat?” Adora asked, mouth full.

“I set an alarm for midnight.” He said. “It’s December 25th.”

“Christmas morning.” Glimmer realized, and it went around the fire.

Adora swallowed her next bite. “Never thought I’d spend it here.” Two weeks ago Adora would have laughed in her face if she’d suggested it.

“I know, right?” Glimmer giggled. “Crazy.”

“Just think of the odds,” Bow said as he started prepping a series of marshmallows to make smores for their guards. “All the things that had to happen for us to end up in this moment.” He looked at Catra. “You had to become a soldier. Go to war, survive that war, then end up with the exact right job on the exact right ship to get sent to uncontacted planets. To get sent to this planet. Where you had to crash in exactly the right spot, at exactly the right time to meet Adora.” He shook his head.

The vastness of that reality swept over Adora and sent tears to the corners of her eyes. “The chances of that all happening.” She noted. “It’s . . .”

“Astronomical?” Glimmer offered.

Adora laughed wetly. “That’s such a bad joke.”

“You love it.” Glimmer smiled.

“I do.” Adora nodded, wiping her eyes. “Stars, I do.” She looked up and saw her sister. Her sister saw her back.

“I’ve never been so lucky.” Catra reflected.

Adora was never going to play the lottery. She’d spent all her luck meeting Catra.

“Maybe it wasn’t luck.” Glimmer offered. “Maybe it was a Christmas miracle.”

Bow and Adora groaned, and Glimmer laughed.

“I still don’t really understand what this whole ‘Christmas’ thing is,” Catra said.

“It’s just a holiday,” Bow explained. “It’s a human tradition where we celebrate . . . well there’s a lot of things. But for our families, and a lot of families, it’s a chance to spend time together, and to give gifts of appreciation. People buy them beforehand, wrap them up, then put them under a tree until this exact date, where everyone opens them together!”

Catra nodded. “Ohhh. So, you guys aren’t actually just sticking boxes under foliage every day of your lives?” She joked. She looked up at Adora, who rolled her eyes. “Well, regardless of how you crazy people do it, I’ll say this is the best Christmas I’ve ever had.” No one bothered to point out that it was the only Christmas she’d ever had.

“Oh!” Glimmer perked up suddenly and began to rummage through her bag. “That reminds me! One sec!” She stood, threw off her blanket like a cloak, and ran (then walked when she was hollered at by the guards) back into the building.

Adora and Catra looked at Bow, who shrugged. She reemerged a minute later with a small bag. “I got something for everyone!” She ran up to the fire and pulled out three little packages wrapped in bright paper printed with repeating lines of 'HAPPY BIRTHDAY!!!'.

"Glimmer!" Adora squeaked as she was handed hers. “When did you do this!?” Glimmer had written their names on each package in her classic pink glitter pen.

“Back in Vegas! Remember when we made that stop at that other store, Catra?” She asked her as she sat next to Bow. “I had these printed!”

Catra shook her head. “You realize we were being hunted at the time.”

Glimmer blew a raspberry. “It was fine.” Catra raised an eyebrow. “What!? It was!”

“Happy birthday?” Bow held his up.

“It was the only paper they had; I didn’t have time to argue!” Glimmer cried. “Now, c’mon! Open ‘em!”

Adora, already on the verge of crying, ripped the package open, encouraging Catra to do the same. Inside, Adora found two identical picture frames stacked on top of one another. Now she really started crying. The first was their selfie from Zion, the four of them beaming into the sunlight with the orange and white valley behind them.

The second was more surprising; it was also at Zion, but this one was at a low angle. At the top of the frame, Adora and Catra were sitting together, looking out over the beautiful sunset. Their sides were touching, and they were both smiling, and as Adora could just make out, this was when they were holding hands. "You took this when you and Bow were below us?"

"Yeah, I looked back, saw you two there, and knew I needed the picture.”

“You didn’t have to do this, Glimmer.” Adora insisted.

“Hey, just be glad I did this before we got arrested; otherwise I would have gotten our mugshots!” Glimmer smiled mischievously.

“Why do I have two?” Bow asked, holding up an identical pair.

“One of those is mine.” Glimmer revealed, snaking one of the frames out of Bow’s lap. “Felt tacky addressing a present to myself.”

“Glimmer,” Adora was still amazed. “I . . . you really didn't have to do this! You . . . I've been so terrible to you!"

"No, Adora, you've been so much better." Glimmer returned. "And honestly, as crazy as this trip has been, it's . . . kind of helped me, in a weird way, more than I thought it would. Besides, you’re always so unstoppable; I couldn't have ever not been dragged along all the way to the end. So, I’m glad I have these memories with you.” She held up her photo. “All of you.”

Bow crushed Glimmer in a tight, teary hug, and Glimmer laughed. Adora looked over at Catra. Catra had the same two pictures as her, but they were in a small lighter bifold frame, one that could be closed so both pictures would be protected and facing inwards. “I kind of planned all this when you were still planning on going back to space,” Glimmer explained to Catra. “So, I got you something that I thought would be easier to have on your ship. I wanted to give you something to remember us by." She finished. Catra stared at her gift in silence. “Sooo . . .” Glimmer pressed. "What do you think?"

“This is . . . for me?” Catra said. Her voice was low, almost angry. Her ears were spread wide and flat. “To keep?”

"Of course." Glimmer replied. "It's a gift. Merry Christmas.”

"You alright, Catra?" Adora let go of her shoulder and turned her slightly to look.

Catra was crying, a scowl on her face.

“No one’s ever . . .” She took a steadying inhale. “No one’s ever given me something like this.” She held the frame so tightly Adora was worried it might snap. Adora rubbed Catra’s back, soothing, smiling over at Glimmer.

Glimmer smiled too, and she got it. They’d all learned to speak a little Catra in their time together. “I guess now it’s a welcome to Earth present then. In more ways than one.”

Catra chuckled under her breath. “Don’t jynx it, Sparkles.” She looked up, wiping her eyes. “Nothing’s guaranteed.”

That dampened the mood a little, and the sound of the fire returned to the fore. Catra looked around at them all, then at the picture again. “I’ve . . . I’ve never helped anyone but myself, in my whole life.” She said. “Never left a place better than I found it. I don’t know if I’m going to be able to do that here, but I promise you guys, stars, I promise I’m going to try.”

“Whatever happens, we’ll face it together,” Adora said. “I wouldn’t want to do it with anyone else.”

“Same here.” Glimmer echoed. “I don’t know what our chances are, but I’m glad you’re on our side instead of theirs.”

“And until then, we still have tonight,” Bow said. “Because I don’t think any of us are getting any more sleep.”

“Oh, hell no.” Glimmer said with a smile.

“Not a chance.” Adora agreed. She looked to Catra. “What do you say? Up for an all-nighter?”

Catra reached up with an arm. “If I’m going to make it to morning, I’m going to need at least two more smores.” She declared. “Pass me a stick, Bobby!”

Glimmer cheered as Bow tossed her another stick and marshmallow, and soon the conversation began to flow naturally again. It wasn't free of the undercurrent of dread that lived in the back of all their minds, especially as military vehicles began to drive down the road past them, towards the dry lakebed that was the most likely landing spot for the Fright Zone in just a few hours' time.

But for a little while longer, the stars above the four of them burned so bright, and Adora's heart felt full. Morning would come soon, but this night would stretch on in Adora's memories forever.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: Light(?) Body Horror, Discussions of War
Hi all! As you can probably tell, we're very close to the end now. **The final two chapters will be posted together as the final chapter (22) is a short epilogue**. I want to thank you all again for spending your time here and giving a stupid hopeful writer a chance; it really is the greatest honor!

Chapter 21: Voices

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They came with the dawn, heralded by the base's air raid siren that echoed across the desert. A long baleful cry which rose and fell, and like the call to morning prayer, drew out the small blinking people of Earth.

Holding Catra's hand, Adora stepped out of the staff building in her new clothes. A soft wind lifted dust and sand off the ground, which was lit low and gentle by the predawn glow and the nearly full moon. Shimmering, it was as though an ephemeral silver spirit, rarely seen, had risen to watch the world be changed. Adora looked east at the coming dawn. There was a band of a deep indigo hue, appearing blazingly bright against the still near-black landscape. Through the thin clouds lingering near the horizon, impossibly huge sunbeams fanned out, coruscate tines as tall as the sky.

Adora and Catra’s eyes met. Adora squeezed Catra’s hand, and received one in return. Bow and Glimmer came out behind them, smiling wanly. Here we go.

A black car pulled up to the staff building, and Castaspella stepped out, followed by a very excited-looking Entrapta. Apparently, Casta had also managed to get her released sometime in the whirlwind that was the previous night. She ran up to them all, vibrating with energy, babbling about how exciting this all was. They loaded up into the car and were driven the two miles down to the dry lakebed that the helicopters and fighter jets would try to guide the Fright Zone down onto.

What had been an empty patch of desert just a few hours ago was now thrumming with activity. Nearly a thousand soldiers had been found and pooled in the previous night, Casta said. They

stood in a massive semi-circle, half a mile wide, manning tanks, APCs, artillery batteries, and a dozen other pieces of equipment Adora didn't recognize, all at the ready with guns pointed inwards.

Their car drove to the midpoint of the arc, where a command center had been thrown together. Behind waist-high sandbag walls was communications equipment, scientific instruments, radio towers, and lots of coffee machines. These were manned with soldiers from Fort Irwin, scientists from Goldstone, and two dozen men and women in suits, lawyers and politicians all side by side. That final group was crowded around a printer, drafting treaties that would hopefully be signed by the Horde. There was even a full film crew set up, with massive cameras ready to record what was about to happen.

All these people stopped what they were doing as Catra stepped out of the car with them, standing in daylight for the first time with nothing hiding her ears, eyes, or tail. All staring except for Mermista and Seahawk, who Adora spotted in the crowd. The agents approached as they entered the command center.

"Are you sure you don't want more security when you go out there, ma'am?" Mermista asked Casta.

Their aunt shook her head. "I will not greet them with guns." She insisted. "Proceed with your part. Operation Drill is a go."

Mermista sighed, but nodded. "Roger that. Alright, you ready, Entrapta?"

"I was born ready!" Entrapta declared.

"I like your enthusiasm!" Seahawk matched her volume. "Let's go! To **adventure**!" Mermista looked very tired as she led the two off somewhere down the arc of soldiers.

"What's that about?" Bow asked.

"A contingency I hope I don't have to use," Castaspella said. Another man walked up to her then, pulling her away. Adora,

Glimmer, Bow, and Catra watched her go. The three of them that were human were here mostly because they had demanded they be. Casta had caved, too busy and too tired to disagree. So, they all found a spot near the front wall of the command center, and waited for destiny to arrive.

“I never thought this would actually happen in my lifetime,” Bow said. “First contact.”

“Wasn’t me meeting Adora first contact?” Catra pointed out.

“Yeah,” Bow conceded, “But this,” He gestured at the buzzing throng of activity all around them, at the cameras. Yeah, it was hard to argue this wasn’t what was going to be remembered as first contact.

As they listened to the callouts of the Fright Zone’s position from one of the HAM radios, the sun broke over the low jagged mountains to the East, snapping the colors of the sky from indigo to lavender and gold, fuchsia and green.

Adora and Catra’s hands found each other, fingers interlacing. Adora thought about how her species had evolved on this planet over two hundred thousand years ago, and over that time tens of billions of humans had come and gone. Each of those humans, from the very first to Adora now, despite the impossibly vast technological, cultural, and temporal distances between them, had all seen a sunrise just like this one.

Gratitude swept through her, that she got to share this sunrise with her. That she got to share her planet with Catra, the cabins and the mountains, the crummy towns and the boring highways, the national parks and the sunrises. It felt very human to take an alien's hand, point at the sunrise, and go: that. We like that.

It had been seven days since Adora had found Catra. It felt like a lifetime ago.

As the sun rose fully above the horizon, the callouts on the radio started to come faster.

“2500 miles altitude.”

“1000 miles altitude.”

“500 miles altitude.”

“The contact is now crossing the orbits of the satellite network.”

“Acquisition of visual signal from the ground.”

“Object is entering upper atmosphere. We can see entry heating.”

“Trajectory confirmed. On track for Goldstone landing.”

“Vandenberg fighters have visual acquisition.”

“Green Bravo Two. Guide-in appears good. ETA to designated point 3 minutes.”

Adora heard Casta take a steadying breath.

Catra spotted it first, of course, but soon everyone else was craning their necks to see the dot that appeared high in the sky above them. A dot which slowly grew into a massive green-gray object as it descended.

The Fright Zone was brutalist and industrial, with a wedge-shaped bow and large areas of hull left exposed to internal pipes and other systems. It had to be at least 1,000 feet long. On the port bow, like on Catra’s escape pod, was the symbol of the rebellion, twin wings surrounding a red diamond.

Fighter jets roared overhead, circling as the ship opened a dozen panels on its underside. With a flash of light, pillars of fiery fury erupted downwards. It took several seconds for the noise to reach the ground, but when it did, the crackling roar shook the earth. Adora felt the vibrations in her chest as it descended into the center of the semi-circle. Its rockets whipped up the dusty ground into a frenzy as the starship extended a set of stubby legs and settled down onto the Earth.

Adora shook her head. Despite everything uncertain it represented about the future, she couldn’t deny it. "That is the coolest thing I've ever seen." She breathed.

Catra looked over at her with that mischievous supernova smile. "What, it's not me anymore?"

Adora laughed, fear anchored by Catra’s hand in hers.

As the dust cleared. Casta approached Catra. "It's time, darling."

Catra nodded, turning to Adora, Glimmer, and Bow. "Thank you, all. Whatever happens, thank you."

"Catra," Glimmer walked up and wrapped her in a hug.

Bow's voice quavered as he piled on top. "You got this!”

Adora joined the fray, squeezing. Then they parted. Catra took them all in again, then turned to Casta, and together they stepped over the sandbag wall and walked out towards the looming alien ship. About halfway to it, they stopped and waited. Catra looked back at them once. The fear on her face was palpable.

Adora’s legs moved on their own.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried out as she ran out between the soldiers, leaping the sandbag wall. She didn’t heed her sister’s call, nor any of the soldiers’ shouts, instead finding a spot next to Catra and taking her hand once again.

“Beside you, long as I can be," Adora vowed.

Catra blinked some tears away. "You are such an idiot."

But I'm your idiot. Adora thought.

Casta’s face, meanwhile, was terrified. “Adora, no! You have to go back!”

Adora faced her aunt. “I’m not leaving.” She insisted.

“You don’t understand,” Casta pressed. “If things go badly, I have orders to-”

“Too late,” Catra said.

There was a hiss of air. Facing forward again, Adora felt the fear build in her chest as a ramp in the nose of The Fright Zone lowered to the ground, and from the shadowy interior, figures emerged. First, two lines of humanoid soldiers in body armor and full helmets. They all had what looked like rifles holstered at their sides. The army all around tensed, orders to stand ready echoing around the circle.

Behind them, two more humanoid beings. One was tall and slender, draped in a long maroon cloak, and wearing a mask of red and black which turned judgingly towards the military response surrounding them with two white lenses for eyes. Behind their head, long black hair rippled and swirled like ink in water. Shadow Weaver. Adora immediately guessed.

The other was a beast of an alien, easily six and a half feet tall and massively muscled. Or well, carapace-d. Their exposed arms were spiked and armored like an insect; their face was a menagerie of moving pieces, jaws moving in three directions at once as they inhaled the new air. Instead of hands, they had two huge dark red pincers. Adora thought they looked a lot like a lobster, until she saw the segmented tail, tipped with a wicked pointed bulb. Not a lobster, a scorpion.

The Horde approached. The soldiers stopped a hundred feet away, while the remaining two continued forward, stopping when there were only a dozen paces between them. Casta checked all the equipment that had been strapped to her suit. Scientific instruments, a radio, a microphone to record what she said and heard. She fiddled with the associated earpiece, then cleared her throat. But before she could speak, Catra cocked her hip, resting a hand there with a smile. "Scorpia." She said to the large alien. Did everyone from space have self-descriptive names? Adora wondered.

‘Scorpia’ wrung her claws together. Adora couldn’t hope to truly understand what feeling was being expressed by the way the many parts of her face were moving, but it somehow looked fretful.

Catra turned to Casta. “She wants a hug.” She explained and took a few steps forward. As soon as she did, Scorpia dashed the distance between them and swept her up in a crushing embrace. "Wildcat!" The huge alien, whose voice Adora tentatively ascribed as female, hauled Catra up off the ground with glee. "I'm so happy you're okay! When your signal dropped, I. Was. Scared. To. Death!"

“Ribs, Scorpia! I’m injured!” Catra wheezed. Apparently, crushing hugs were universal.

“Oh! Oh, my stars!” Scorpia let go of Catra so fast she nearly dropped her. “I didn’t realize! I’m so sorry! I’m just . . . gosh, I’m just really am glad to see you’re alright.”

“Yeah yeah,” Catra smiled a tired smile. Scorpia’s mandibles moved in a way that was probably a smile back. "Thank you though, Scorpia. For coming back for me. It's good to see you too."

"Wow." Scorpia put her claws up near her face. "A real compliment? Did you hit your head or something in the crash? Never mind, well, either way you’re welcome, even though, you know, it’s kind of a part of our job, you know. Rescuing stranded crew members when our ship is struck by a rogue meteor, but still, coming from you, wow."

"They know, Scorpia." Catra interrupted what Adora realized was at least a semi-scripted conversation. "About everything."

"Oh." Her faceted eyes widened. "Oh . . . oh stars, Wildcat. Are you sure you know what you're-?"

“Catra,” Castaspella called, then waved her back when she looked over. Catra nodded to her and retreated while Scorpia and the

shadowy-haired figure came forward. They were now ten paces apart. Castaspella began, "Welcome to Earth." She spoke clearly and evenly. "It is the honor of the government of the United States to welcome representatives of the Horde Rebellion on behalf of all humans on this planet. My name is Castaspella Brightmoon. I have been selected to speak with you."

This was really happening, Adora realized. She had somehow ended up with a front row seat to the single most important event in human history.

The masked woman tilted her head slightly at this candidness. "It is an honor to be received with such dignity." She replied. Her voice was rich and thick and even, like blood flowing from a deep wound. "I am Shadow Weaver, captain of the Rebellion vessel Fright Zone. We have come to retrieve a member of our crew, who, after an accident aboard our ship, crash-landed here." She turned to Catra. "Force Captain Catra, it is good to see you are safe. You have done well, surviving alone on this planet and finding a way to make contact with us. Come, present yourself to me."

Catra was still for a second. She glanced at Adora. 'You've got this'. Adora mouthed.

"Re . . . Respectfully, Captain." Catra began, voice shaking a little. "I can’t do that."

"What?" The smoothness in Shadow Weaver's voice gained an edge sharper than any knife.

“Catra has requested political asylum within our national borders,” Casta explained evenly. “Our laws require that all such requests be given due diligence. While hers is being processed, I’m afraid my government cannot return her to you.”

Briefly, Shadow Weaver seemed too stunned to speak. “Well, I am afraid I am confused. You receive us with dignity, and yet now you hold one of my crew hostage.”

“We are not holding her hostage; she has chosen this, of her own free will. Such freedom to choose is a hallmark of our ways.” Casta responded easily, and Adora imagined the pair sitting across a chessboard from one another, trading pieces and verbal barbs.

Shadow Weaver looked to Catra. “Is this true, Force Captain?”

“It is,” Catra said.

Shadow Weaver’s flowing hair seemed to twitch at this. “Such mutiny is unthinkable within our ranks. Even for such an officer as ***this*** one.” The white slits on her mask narrowed. Catra clenched her fist. “Regardless, Horde soldiers do not have the right to abandon their post. Under the code of my command, I must treat Catra as captured until she is returned to my care. Sheltering her would make us enemies.”

“Then it appears we are at an impasse,” Casta said. “For I am not currently at liberty to surrender her. My primary goal today is to establish formal diplomatic ties with The Horde Rebellion. I would be saddened if one person prevented good relations.”

“Indeed.” Shadow Weaver hummed. “Which is why I must stress the wisdom in returning that singular officer.”

“And I must stress that I cannot give her to you, as she does not wish it.” Castaspella continued. She was, so far, remaining remarkably calm and confident in her words. “It seems we are bound to similar codes under which we both must conform. Perhaps we have more in common than might be assumed.”

“Perhaps.” Shadow Weaver echoed.

“Bitch.” Catra hissed under her breath.

Casta continued. “Our cultures are no doubt vastly different, and it was inevitable that we both would encounter ideals that are mutually exclusive. If neither of our parties’ desires conflict, then I implore you to consider negotiations with us. I am confident we could come to a mutually beneficial relationship.”

Shadow Weaver's voice lost its carefully held calm. "How insulting. I come before you with a simple and honest request, and yet you babble as though you have not heard a word I've said. I had high hopes for this world when we first discovered it, despite your primitiveness, but your eagerness to insult us over one marooned soldier suggests a level of foolishness that borders on the insane."

"Ah, but you have not been honest, have you?" Casta lifted a finger casually, defiance brazen. "You suggested that Catra's arrival was an accident, which it is not. You suggested that Catra is alone, which she is not."

Shadow Weaver bristled, and Casta spoke into her radio. "Bring them out."

A group of soldiers about halfway from the command center to the far end of the arc stepped forward, surrounding a small truck. Inside the bed was a large glass tube, and inside that tube was a snarling mass of black and green. The group came only close enough for Adora to lock eyes with the burning yellow glower from within the container. There were all kinds of tanks and equipment strapped to the top of the tube, no doubt making sure that Double Trouble could breathe in their new prison, but not be able to escape it. Adora heard muttered whispers from the Horde soldiers.

"As you can see, we may be primitive compared to you, but we are not naïve," Casta stated plainly. "So, I expect the truth from now on. What are your intentions here? Because both of the ones you sent claim that it's conquest."

Shadow Weaver stood very still for a second. "That . . . creature," They gestured to Double Trouble. "Is not affiliated with us. They are a servant of Horde Prime and will say anything in order to-"

"That's a lie," Catra spoke up. Shadow Weaver's mask snapped to her. Adora couldn't see her eyes, but she could feel that glare. "One that I warned them that you'd try to use."

“That she did.” Castaspella nodded. “You claim our conduct to you has been insulting. Well then, I must say, the feeling is mutual.”

Adora exhaled a deep breath as once again, Shadow Weaver was sent speechless. The tension in the air grew thicker and thicker. When Shadow Weaver spoke again, the words were pointed at Catra. But she only got the ones, “You insolent little-” before being interrupted by a flash of light.

“That is enough.” A new gravelly voice cut over the air, and Adora jumped at its volume. From a flickering patch on the front of the Fright Zone, a glowing rainbow beam shot towards them. It coalesced in front of Shadow Weaver and Scorpia, forming a figure that flickered ever so slightly before them, twenty feet tall. A hologram.

"Lord Hordak." One of the Horde soldiers gasped before they, all the soldiers, Scorpia, and Shadow Weaver fell to one knee immediately. Catra twitched, as if resisting the habit.

Hordak was a huge, imposing silhouette. He wore a black tunic-like uniform emblazoned with the winged symbol of the Horde in the center of his chest. The outfit left his arms and legs exposed, and in these places, muscle and machinery were fused together, ribbed tubes and shining armor grafted to his flesh. His clawed hands were exposed, and the skin there and elsewhere was a dark blue, but his head was covered in a hard material that looked like bone, white, scratched, and scuffed. Pointed protrusions that looked something like ears jutted up from the sides of his head, and he had no nose, only a chevron-shaped hole in the center of his face. Like a mask, the white of his face moved little as he spoke, only small plates around his mouth and eyes shifting to convey expressions and reveal teeth which glowed an angry scarlet color, the same as his eyes, which were so bright Adora couldn't tell if he had pupils or not.

“Lord Hordak,” Shadow Weaver looked up from her cowed position. “I understand the situation on this planet is different than anticipated, however-”

“Silence,” Hordak demanded, and Shadow Weaver immediately clammed up. “Your efforts this time have proven futile. Deception will get us no further.” He turned to Casta, and everyone beyond. “People of the planet Earth, I am Hordak, leader of the Galactic Horde Rebellion. I speak to you now from across a great distance. We have come to your planet to request your help in a noble crusade of which this planet has thus far been unaware. There is a scourge tearing across the universe, wiping out all unique life one planet at a time, leaving empty worlds behind. We are the last hope for a free galaxy, and today, you will join this fight. Communicate with your leaders, contact all of your planet’s governments to receive my representatives for annexation. Join willingly, and become heroes and defenders of sapience.” His voice echoed across the desert.

“And if some or all of our planet’s governments refuse?” Casta asked.

Hordak looked down at her. “Then you shall join us by force.” He assured. “Know that this is an existential battle for survival. Your resources and people cannot be tied up in petty debates of sovereignty. My armadas possess technology far beyond your capabilities to resist. Should you join freely or not, the outcome will be the same.”

Adora was shaking.

Catra took a deep breath beside her. “It’s not worth it!” She called. Hordak looked towards her, and only then seemed to realize she wasn’t kneeling, and it became a glare. But before he could speak, Catra said, “You sent me to this planet to gain knowledge! So do you want that knowledge or not!?”

Shadow Weaver bristled. “How dare you insult our lord by-”

Hordak stopped her with a hand. “How curious.” He growled. “You will not kneel?”

“No,” Catra replied.

Hordak's glare intensified. "I will let her. Speak." He announced. "Force Captain?"

Catra steadied herself. "This planet is different from the others. Maybe all the others. The people here, they're irrational, and passionate, and fiercely protective. If you get between them and what they want, they'll give everything to defend it." Catra swallowed. "If you attack them, they will band together. They will fight even more fiercely than Horde Prime. They will make you bleed over every yard of this planet until your new dominion is nothing but an irradiated wasteland. Of the few left alive, none will serve you through conquest."

"Lord Hordak," Shadow Weaver interrupted again. "You cannot listen to this officer. She has been compromised by this . . . brutish world."

"The only one compromised here is someone who would destroy everything this planet could give for no reason!" Catra snarled back at Shadow Weaver, at Hordak, her timidness forgotten. "That would be a true betrayal of what the rebellion stands for."

Hordak loomed over Catra. "Do you dare suggest I need a lecture on the Rebellion from one who has betrayed it?"

"Apparently you do." Catra challenged.

"Catra," Casta's voice rose in nervous warning.

Hordak's face twisted into a gruesome aspect. "You forget your place."

Catra took a breath to steady her angering voice, but didn't drop the edge. "You say we can't wait even a day for negotiations with primitive worlds. That the lives of our soldiers matter too much. But think of how much we lose when we rain fire down on these planets. All the strength, all the goodwill we could have used against Prime? Gone. Instead, all we get from these worlds is ash. The one thing we want to stop."

Hordak growled, then his twisted face eased back to how it had been. “I tire of this debate. Seize these three.”

Adora stiffened as the soldiers moved forward. In a flash, two of them were on her, and another two on Casta, forcing them both to their knees with a strength greater than their size.

“No!” Catra cried. “Let them go!” She tried to run for Adora but was intercepted by Scorpia, who swooped her up again.

“Sorry, Wildcat.” She said as Catra fought in her arms, snarling and trying to claw her way to freedom.

“Please!” Her aunt cried, resisting the soldiers. “Don’t do this! Catra is right! There are other solutions! If you claim to want to preserve sapient life, don’t throw any of it away with pointless bloodshed!” Hordak stared at her. “We seek only peaceful cooperation with the denizens of the stars!" Casta pleaded.

Hordak spoke. "Your goal is admirable, human, but naive. The Masters of the Universe do not care for the dreams of lesser beings. The stars are cold and dark." He blinked his glowing red eyes. “Prepare for departure.” He looked at Casta and Adora. “Bring these two with you. They shall be useful for cataloging the species.” He turned to the others. “Your planet has my demands. Pray to whatever gods you have that they are met.”

Shadow Weaver, cowed but loyal, signaled to the soldiers, and Adora and Casta started to be dragged towards the Fright Zone.

Adora grunted and fought as her feet scraped in the dust. “Please stop struggling.” A voice from behind one of the helmets asked. Adora glared at them, unable to see their face behind the visor.

She looked over at her aunt, who was no doubt listening to the voices in her earpiece. “I’m sorry, Entrapta.” Casta muttered. Adora saw the grim resolve overtake the terror on her face, and realized what was about to happen.

“Catra I-!” Adora shouted the same moment Casta said,

“Failsafe.”

“Raise the shield!” Hordak barked out.

It was the loudest thing Adora had ever heard.

All at once, every artillery piece and tank fired on the Fright Zone. Thunder and light shook the ground, and Adora and the soldiers holding her were thrown down by the shockwave that battered in from all directions. Hitting the dry earth, Adora hunkered, expecting to be incinerated as her ears rang. But seconds passed, and she kept breathing.

There was a pattering that sounded like rain, and Adora opened her eyes. Small bits of metal were falling all around her. Shrapnel. She looked up, and through the dust and gun smoke thrown into the air, saw the Fright Zone enveloped in a shimmering shell of green light. A real sci-fi forcefield. The shrapnel was pieces of the shells that had just been fired.

Adora’s hearing came back slowly, the ringing lingering longer and far louder than was healthy. When it was clear enough to hear voices, she heard Hordak’s first.

“Primitive fools.” He spat, hologram flickering in the smoke. “You only prove your own short-sightedness further! Shadow Weaver!” He turned to the masked woman, who was herself still coming to her feet.

“Yes, Lord Hordak?”

“Carry out my orders! I want your-“

His words were cut off when the hologram suddenly vanished. Everyone froze, and eyes began to rove. The soldiers that had fallen didn’t grab Adora again. “What’s?” She asked just as the green shield surrounding the Fright Zone also winked off.

“Hold your fire!” Casta cried into the mic on her cheek. The guns didn’t fire again.

Her voice snapped everyone to attention. The soldiers grabbed and pushed Adora and Casta to their knees once again.

Shadow Weaver recovered. “Status report!” She demanded from Scorpia, who retrieved some kind of electronic pad from her side. Tapping at it awkwardly with her huge claws, she sputtered.

“Well . . . umm . . . I . . . looks like there’s a . . .” She tapped too hard and sent the pad flying out of her grip. Flailing after it, she caught it before it hit the ground. “Whoa! Umm . . . some kind of power failure, captain. We’re totally dead, save emergency systems.

“You underestimate us.” Casta smiled.

Shadow Weaver walked over to her, grabbing her chin. “Explain, human.”

“I thought Catra had made our position clear.” She pressed an arm against her captors to hit a button on her radio. “How you doing in there?”

The hologram flashed and flickered back to life. But it wasn’t Hordak that now towered over them. Instead, clearly crammed into some tiny space, was a familiar face.

“Entrapa!?” Adora cried, fear turned to joy. She was in the ship!?

“AGUH!” Entrapa’s excited voice cried. The background around her was twisting and fading in and out, like a bad green screen. “Ma’am, this is incredible. The number of fully integrated advanced technologies contained within this ship: robotics! AI! Advanced propulsion! AWHHAHAH! I could study this for years!”

Catra’s face, which she was also just pushing out of the dirt, broke out in a wide smile. “Stars, you humans.” She laughed in awe. Scorpia had lost her in the battery.

Entrapa only now seemed to notice she was visible to everyone. “Oh! Hello everyone!”

Casta tried to put her back on task. “I’m glad you’re having fun, Entrapta, but did you find what I asked you to find?”

“Oh, yes! Their main reactor has been taken offline!” She saluted.

The eyes on Shadow Weaver’s mask went wide. She turned to some of her soldiers. “Find her. Now!” She demanded. Half of them peeled off, rushing back into the ship. The captain then whirled on Castaspella. “Do you seriously believe that such a prank will save your pathetic little world?”

Casta just smiled. Hardly a minute after the soldiers went inside, voices called through Scorpia’s pad. “Captain!” One said in a panic. “She’s activated the security systems! Every door in the ship is shut tight!”

“I can’t access any internal controls!” A second called.

“Deck 3’s temperature is off the scale!”

“She’s in the vents! Ahh! Look out!”

Adora laughed silently. Who would have thought a human would be the alien crawling around inside the bowels of a ship?

Shadow Weaver glared ever harder at Casta.

“Entrapta?” Casta called.

“Yeah!?” Entrapta asked, face fish-eying as she moved around.

“Could you please reestablish the link that was occupying this channel before you took it over? Without restoring anything else, of course.”

“Oh, yeah! Sure! One sec!” Entrapa grinned, and sure enough, after a moment of fiddling, she disappeared and was replaced again by Hordak, who looked somewhere between furious and embarrassed.

“Are you going to listen now?” Catra challenged, dusting herself off.

“More backtalk?" The lord growled.

“Yeah, backtalk.” Catra snarled. “I picked up from the people here. They’re experts at coming up with stupid and self-destructive ideas, and then following through.”

Hordak growled, then muttered out. “Speak.”

“She’s not even the smartest of us.”

Adora didn’t even realize that she had spoken until it was already out of her mouth. All eyes turned to her, including Hordak’s, who towered there, flickering. “What?” The lord asked her.

This was it. “I said,” Adora repeated. “She’s not even the smartest of us. Are you sure you want people like that against you, when you could so easily have us as allies?” The skeletal alien glared down on Adora. “She shut your ship down in 10 minutes. Imagine if she had a decade to improve them.” The teenager implored the demigod.

“Who are you?” Hordak demanded.

She steeled herself. “I’m Adora.”

“I have been threatened by intelligences beyond your comprehension, Adora,” Hordak said. “What makes you think that your words matter in the slightest?”

Adora swallowed, but found her voice. "Because my mind is the face of the universe.” She said, and Hordak’s eyes widened. “My mind is the instrument that cannot be unplayed.” She said. She stared up at one of the most powerful beings in the galaxy and said, “My mind is magic.”

Catra stepped up beside her. “This world is more than the number of soldiers it can provide. It’s more than the metal in its ground

and the food in its field. It's wild. It's beautiful. It's irrational, full of people who can do things you never imagined possible. So, tell me, are you going to destroy that? Crush it because you don't understand it, just like Horde Prime would? Or are you going to break the cycle?" She took Adora's hand.

The morning breeze swept over the lakebed. Everyone was looking towards them both now. The human soldiers, the horde soldiers, Shadow Weaver, Casta, Scorpia. The entire world through the rolling cameras, from now through every time it would be replayed. Hordak looked at them for a long time, still, silent. Then, he reached behind his neck, touching a spot there softly before looking upwards, at the blue sky of the Earth. When he spoke, it was without anger.

"I acknowledge your tenacity, humans." He said. "Your determination, and the fortitude of your species in this meeting. This one," He looked at Catra, "would not have defended you were you not so. Perhaps, it is time to reexamine some of our procedures."

"My Lord, surely this is not a wise course of action." Shadow Weaver said. "They have already insulted us!"

Hordak lifted a hand, silencing his captain once again. He looked to Castaspella. "The Horde Rebellion would be honored to open negotiations with your authorities."

Words couldn't describe the level of relief that swept over Adora's body when she heard that. Casta started to cry. Adora wasn't far behind. It was hard not to cry as the suits came forward to verify that yes, they had just saved the world.

Casta and the suits stood on one side on a table that was brought out. Hordak, Shadow Weaver, and half a dozen more holograms – diplomats of every shape and size – stood on the other and, over the course of several hours, an agreement was hammered out. The basis of the document was mutual acknowledgement of the independence of both the Horde Rebellion and the 'Sol System'.

On the human side, that fell under the framework of the Outer Space Treaty. Adora thought that was rather clever, since it listed the Earth, as Casta explained, as the 'common heritage of humanity'. Adora has no idea how every other country on Earth would react to that. It was sure to be a diplomatic nightmare. But at least it would be a nightmare they'd all be alive to have.

Casta kept Adora and Catra near her during the negotiations. They were joined by Entrapta when she was finally dragged out of the guts of the Fright Zone. With nothing else to do, they stood in the open desert and were approached by soldiers from the Fright Zone. Some came out of curiosity, others to catch up with Catra.

"Fraternizing with the locals there, Catra?" One of them asked sassily, gesturing to them still holding hands.

"Shut up, Lonnie," Catra replied.

"Ooo, good comeback." Lonnie chuckled. "Kyle give that one to you?"

"Hey!" The soldier next to Lonnie, the one who had asked Adora to please stop struggling when they were holding them, cried.

"You're Kyle?" Adora asked, pointing at him. He was quite a bit smaller and skinnier than all the other soldiers. He must have been tiny under the armor.

Lonnie immediately started laughing, or at least Adora thought the sound she was making was laughter. Kyle groaned when Lonnie then asked. "Ohoho, she told you about Dara 8347-2, didn't she?" Catra just smiled with all her teeth.

Once the ice was broken, and the adrenaline from the stress of almost being one of the first victims in an alien invasion had faded, Adora found herself practically bouncing with excitement at getting to talk to the other soldiers. There were aliens from a dozen different worlds in the unit! She asked questions of every kind, and got the same diversity of answers back. Her highlight

was definitely when Scorpia happily lifted Adora into the air with one claw when Adora asked how strong she was.

Many of the soldiers couldn't take their helmets off in Earth's atmosphere for various reasons (including Kyle and Lonnie), but one of the really tall soldiers - whose name was Rogelio – could. Adora gaped. He was basically an eight-foot-tall dinosaur. She was in the middle of a translated conversation (via Lonnie) with him when Shadow Weaver turned her masked eyes back at Catra, concluding negotiations with, "Now. It seems we have only one more aspect to discuss: extradition."

Casta sighed, sun now high in the sky. "You're claiming Catra committed a crime?"

"Catra revealed her classified mission to others without authorization." Shadow Weaver said. "That is a violation of military code."

Adora fumed from where she stood.

"And what does the punishment for such a violation normally entail?" Casta asked.

Adora couldn't see Shadow Weaver's face, but she swore she looked gleeful when she replied. "Life imprisonment."

"Hey!" Adora dropped Catra's hand and stepped forward. "That's not fair!"

"What do you know of fair in our society?" Shadow Weaver replied. "You're but a child, one who has never left this planet."

Adora, scowling, walked towards her.

"Adora," Castaspella warned, but Shadow Weaver put up her hand, allowing Adora to approach the woman who had manipulated Catra for years.

“I know enough about what kind of person you are,” Adora assured, stopping right at her feet. “Catra’s told me plenty.”

Shadow Weaver leaned down towards Adora, studying her face very closely. “You truly care for her, don’t you?” She cooed. The glowing eyes in her mask narrowed, and Adora felt a shiver of something cold inside herself, as if the woman was peeling layers of her away one by one to see what was inside.

Finding the courage, Adora said firmly. “I do.”

Shadow Weaver seemed to smile. “Then perhaps we could come to an arrangement in lieu of Catra’s . . . punishment. Take her place. Join me aboard my ship, and Catra may stay here, living blissfully and uselessly far from the real work that must be done.”

Adora had not expected this. But Catra did tell her that Shadow Weaver loved to manipulate people, test people, but she didn’t lie. She never lied. “I,” Adora looked back at Catra, whose eyes were desperate. Say no. They said. So, Adora took a page out of Catra’s book, and smiled right in her face. “Sorry, I don’t wish on monkey’s paws.”

Shadow Weaver chuckled. “What a charming expression.” As she did, the lance of ice retreated from her chest. "A shame. You have a strong soul, child, a good imprint against the veil. I could have taught you much, and you would have been a great asset for The Rebellion.” She rose to her full height and carried on. “Now, where were we? Oh, yes: extradition.”

“Indeed,” Castaspella smiled. “If we are to talk about such things, then we should discuss the shapeshifter. Double Trouble has committed many actions our state considers serious crimes. Espionage, assault, murder.” She listed. “If we are to extradite criminals to your people, then the inverse should also be true.”

“This situation is different.” Shadow Weaver said.

Casta glanced left and right at her colleagues. “I fail to see how.”

“Shadow Weaver,” Hordak growled. “That is enough. Catra will not be imprisoned.”

“What!?” Shadow Weaver turned to her superior. “My Lord, you cannot be serious; Catra must be punished for her transgression.”

“**Force Captain** Catra saw that the situation on this planet warranted a change to her orders.” He turned to Catra. “No plan survives contact with the enemy. Let it be known your case will be dismissed, Force Captain.”

“My Lord,” Shadow Weaver tried one more time.

“Silence!” Hordak growled. “I will hear no more of this.”

“Thank you, sir,” Catra said as she joined them at the table. Adora felt a new dread come up as she realized she was now referring to him as her superior again. It took no time for her fear to be confirmed.

“However,” Hordak continued. “Force Captain Catra has signed a contract with The Rebellion. Her service is not yet complete.”

Adora’s heart cratered.

“We have granted her asylum,” Castaspella noted.

“We have no concept of this.” Hordak dismissed.

“It is a fundamental right,” Casta answered.

“It may be,” Hordak said. “But I am loath to lose a promising officer under any circumstance.” He thought for a moment. “I will allow you to retain one of my citizens.” He stared, unequivocal. “You may choose which.”

“Surely there’s room to negotiate on that.” Casta tried to reason.

“No,” Hordak replied.

Casta stared him down, then turned to look at Catra, then over to Double Trouble, who was now standing bored in their tube. She exhaled deeply, rubbing her forehead.

“No,” Adora realized.

“They guards’ families, Adora,” Castaspella said. “They need justice.” Adora crumpled, and knew she was right. “We’ll take Double Trouble.” She said. Hordak nodded.

“I have one more condition.” He announced. Oh stars. “If you are to retain Double Trouble on your planet, I ask someone else to return with the Fright Zone to my side.”

Casta’s eyes widened. “Surely you don’t suggest we give you an innocent civilian as . . . what? A hostage?

“I do not.” Hordak insisted. “They would be an honored guest and an initial liaison.”

“A show of good faith?” Casta asked.

Hordak nodded.

Casta looked at the other suits, who shrugged. Adora had a feeling this wasn’t part of normal international negotiations. “Alright.” Casta shook her head. “Who then?”

Hordak turned to the purple-haired woman who was currently trying to study one of the soldiers’ rifles. “Perhaps Entrapta could be that liaison.”

“Entrapta?” Castaspella asked.

“Entrapta?” Catra asked.

“Entrapta!?” Entrapta jumped several feet in the air. In an instant she was beside them. “You’d mean I’d get to come with you aboard your spaceship!? To SPACE!?” She asked Hordak. Adora had never seen someone’s eyes get that big.

Hordak seemed a little concerned about her enthusiasm, but said, "I'd welcome it." Regardless.

"Would you be alright with that, Entrapta?" Casta asked.

"WOULD I!?" Entrapta cackled. "Just let me get my stuff! I'll be right back!" She ran back towards the command center, hollering for Seahawk and Mermista to start their car.

"Well then, that's solved. Catra and Entrapta will return to the Horde with you." Casta said as a man furiously typed that into the draft treaty.

"I have one more suggestion, Lord Hordak." Catra stepped forward. Hordak's facial plates quirked in a way that Adora thought might be a smile. "You will need representatives on this planet to maintain ties. I have more experience with the Earth than anyone else." Shapeshifter not included, Adora thought. "Appoint me as a representative," Catra asked.

Adora's collapsed heart leapt up like a phoenix. That was genius. Castaspella seemed to agree. "I'd make it known the United States would be delighted to continue to work with Catra going forward."

Catra blinked at Casta. "You would?"

Casta winked at her.

"Regardless of the humans' wishes, you are not qualified for such work." Hordak decreed.

"Then teach me," Catra said. "I'm a fast learner."

Hordak seemed to be in a generous mood. "Very well. Shadow Weaver, I am transferring Force Captain Catra from your ship. Effective immediately, you will be assigned to diplomatic corps training on Plumeria."

“I . . . I’m honored, sir.” Casta ducked her head. Hordak nodded and returned to conversing with the suits over the final details.

“And after you're trained?” Adora stepped up beside Catra, grabbing her wrist excitedly. “You’d be able to come back to Earth?”

“Such seems likely.” Castaspella appeared on her other side.

“How long?” Adora asked Catra.

“Two years, at least,” Catra replied, and Adora’s reaction must have been obvious on her face. “Aww, come on, Princess, you know you’d get sick of me if I stayed.”

“I’ll never get sick of you, Catra,” Adora replied easily, then felt the blush rising to her cheeks when it hit her brain. Catra was staring back at her, looking equally flustered.

The sound of ink on paper broke their stare. The final version of the treaty being printed out from an office printer that had been wheeled out in the lakebed. The Horde representatives seemed to find this part of human culture charming, in a quaint way.

Singing began, humans first. Castaspella started, followed by the Fort Irwin base commander and several other people with important-sounding titles. While that was happening, Entrapta returned with half a dozen duffel bags full of stuff. Heavy and sharp-looking stuff, judging by the pointy juts sticking out of most of them and the strained faces of Mermista and Seahawk, who were carrying three between them.

Mermista and Seahawk stopped beside Catra, setting her bags down and taking a breath. “Bow told me to give you this.” She handed her a small zip bag that Adora recognized from his luggage. Catra opened it.

“My pictures.” She said, pulling out the frames.

“And some other goodies,” Mermista said. “Bow put it together in case you ended up going back to space after all.”

Catra shook her head with a smile. “Always one step ahead, Bobby B.” She said warmly.

“They want to come up here, by the way. To say goodbye.” Seahawk added. “But the commander had some very strong words about that.”

“So, this is also a ‘wishing you the best’ from them,” Mermista said.

“From us too!” Seahawk said, smiling at Mermista.

“Don’t get sappy on the mission target again.” Mermista accused Seahawk. “C’mon, we’re losing purple hair.”

Seahawk looked over his shoulder and realized Entrapta was already almost at the ramp. How was she so fast on those tiny legs? “Ah!” Seahawk gasped and started to run to catch up.

“Don’t hurt yourself again!” Mermista groaned, picking up her duffels. But before she left, “Seriously though, good luck up there.” She told Catra. Catra nodded, and Mermista set off jogging after her partner.

It took Entrapa even less time to fix the Fright Zone than it had taken her to break it. The whir of systems and engines coming to life echoed over the last humans to sign the treaty. Casta then turned the paper towards the Horde. Hordak gestured at Shadow Weaver, who stepped forward and, with one more scowl, lifted her hand. With a hiss and hum in the air, a black copy of the Horde’s symbol, the winged diamond, appeared on the paper, covering the entire section where their signatures were to go.

Castaspella thanked them all one more time as she rolled up the document in a protective sleeve.

"A diplomatic team will be dispatched promptly to establish an embassy," Hordak said.

Casta nodded. "We look forward to receiving it."

"We will speak again," Hordak said, then ordered his captain. "Shadow Weaver, depart at your earliest convenience."

"Yes, my lord." Shadow Weaver bowed. The holograms shut off, and Hordak was gone.

Everyone started to move. The suits ran back to the command center to copy the treaty, two of them comically carrying the table with them. The horde soldiers sighed as they hoisted their guns back on their shoulders and returned to the Fright Zone. Almost all of them had told Adora about how nice it was to be out in the open air and not on the ship, even if it was just for a little while. Seahawk and Mermista reappeared from the ship, escorted by Scorpia. And in the distance, Adora could see the thousand human soldiers watching the activity with nervous curiosity. They had probably been getting nothing more than snippets of what was happening this whole time.

Catra was talking to Castaspella. They shared a few quiet words, and Casta hugged her. Catra hugged back, then turned to find Adora.

Adora tried to burn Catra into her memory as she walked towards her. The way she moved. The color of her eyes, the way her tail was sticking nearly straight up, only the tip bobbling back and forth. The way her ears caught the sunlight. Adora wasn't ready for her to go.

Catra stopped in front of her, and there was a quiet moment. "I guess this is it," Catra said.

"Yeah," Adora answered.

Catra turned towards the command center, towards Bow and Glimmer, lifting a hand in a wave. Adora saw them wave back,

then noticed four familiar figures had appeared sometime during the negotiations. Behind Bow were both his dads, and behind Glimmer, Angella and Micah. “I’ll leave that last one to you,” Catra told her.

Adora laughed, despite the dread building up in her gut. “Okay.” She looked back at Catra, and they took each other’s hands, staring into one another’s eyes. “I just want . . . I wanna say thank you, Catra. For coming into my life. For being my friend. Stars, for saving my world.”

“Ahh,” Catra smiled a little smile. “You didn’t need me for that last one.”

“What? Of course I did!” Adora insisted.

“No, you would have figured it all out on your own. You’re smart like that.” Catra winked.

“I’m not that smart.” Adora blushed, looking away.

“No! You are!” Catra exasperated. “You’re incredible, Adora. You’re fearless and resourceful and unrelenting and kind. The kindest idiot I’ve ever met.” She took a breath and glanced away, blush tinging her fuzzy cheeks pink. “So, thank you, Adora. For everything. For showing me your world, for never giving up on me, even when you had every reason to. For helping me get me transferred off the Fright Zone for god’s sake!”

“That one was all you,” Adora noted, and they both chuckled.

“Shut up!” Catra squeezed her hands. “I’m trying to be emotional here.”

“Oh, were you?” Adora asked sarcastically.

“Yes!”

“Okay, okay, sorry!” Adora smiled, taking a breath. “Go ahead.”

Catra shut her eyes, smiling. When she opened them again, she said, “For a long time, I didn’t think I belonged anywhere. Not on my homeworld. Not in the Horde. Certainly not in a war. But then I came here. To your stupid planet. To your stupid cabin which is way too cold.” Adora chuckled. “I came . . . to you. And for the first time in my life, I didn’t want to leave.” She took a breath. “Because of you. You brave, stupid, brilliant, beautiful idiot. Adora, you’re the most incredible person I’ve ever met.” She beamed. Adora was too stunned to speak. “And don’t you try and deny it because then-”

Adora leaned in and kissed Catra.

Catra jerked her head back, eyes wide. Adora’s heart stopped. "Ahh! I'm sorry!” She sputtered. "I don't know if your people do that, and I didn't ask first! You were just saying all these amazing things about me and . . . and I just wanted to let you know that I really care about you and-"

Catra leapt with her lips and cut her off. They kissed, arms finding each other’s waists and cheeks and sides, and held them there for a long time, embraced, together. When they finally broke, Catra smiled, whispering just an inch away. "I love you too."

"Could we please stop this unnecessary display and **get moving.**" Shadow Weaver growled behind them.

"Be safe," Adora said, condensing goodbyes that could have lasted days into a few clipped sentences. "Don't die. Stay in touch? Do you have letters in space?"

Catra rolled her eyes but smiled. “We do, and I will.”

“I’ll see you again,” Adora said.

“I promise,” Catra assured.

Adora kissed her one last time, and then Catra let go. She walked to her ship, up the ramp, and her tail disappeared inside. The

ramp rose, and she was gone. Adora returned to the command center with Casta.

Halfway back to the arc of soldiers, Glimmer burst out from it and tackled her in a hug. “You’re insane!” Her sister cried.

Adora laughed. “Yeah, sorry, guess I had one more crazy move left in me.”

Glimmer pulled away to look at her. “Yeah, but that one . . . I get it.” Adora rubbed the back of her neck and laughed awkwardly. “Plus!” She punched her on the shoulder. “You dog! Very romantic.”

Adora’s heart was glowing too bright to find that dig annoying. “Thanks,” Adora smiled. “So . . .” She looked back at Angella and Micah. “You talked to them yet?”

Glimmer turned pale as a sheet. “Ohh shit.” She hissed. “I think the alien invasion kind of broke their brains.” Adora saw the judging stares they were getting from them now. “Maybe they’ll be so happy to see us they’ll forget about grounding me?”

Adora said nothing, heading forward with Glimmer. Time to face the music.

When they reached them, there was a stare-down like in a western, with shoes crunching the desert ground. “Hi Mom, Dad.” Glimmer waved with an awkward smile.

Casta, standing nearby, stifled a laugh at their parent’s reaction to that. She found a reason to pull Bow and his parents outside the blast radius.

“Gimmer Brightmoon.” Angella began, voice dangerously neutral, and Adora felt Glimmer flinch beside her, then the anger broke. “You are in so much trouble, young lady!”

“Ahahaha . . .” Glimmer’s smile stiffened, then froze when Angella’s fiery scowl took on a softer tone.

“But we’ll talk later. I’m glad you’re safe.” She pulled her into a hug, then got one from Micah. “May we speak with Adora first?” She asked her. Glimmer nodded, glanced at Adora, then moved to join their aunt, Bow, and his parents.

Those piercing eyes fell on Adora, and she felt the urge to crumble rushing towards her. “I’m very disappointed in you, Adora.” Angella began. The tidal wave struck hard, tearing her off her foundations. “After we spoke about-”

“What were you thinking!?” Micah interrupted, practically yelling. “I’ve never seen such irresponsible, reckless behavior in my life! If I had thought that even for a second you would have gone and done what you did, then I’d-”

Adora lifted her hand to stop the rant, tears running unbidden down her face. “I- I have no excuse.” She admitted. “I did what I did because I wanted to, and because I thought it was right. I can’t take it back, nor would I want to.” She inhaled, shaking. “I would . . . I would do it again, if I could. I’m . . . I understand what this will mean in the future, what will happen, and I don’t hate you for it. I’ll . . . I’ll miss being your daughter. It was the happiest years of my life.” She hung her head. “I’m sorry but, I’m not sorry.”

There was a long pause, but Adora was too afraid to look up and see their reactions. She gasped when Angella wrapped her arms around her. "First of all, we may not be blood, but you're still my daughter, Adora." Adora couldn't have stopped the tears if she had all the power in the universe. Her eyes shot up, unable to believe the kindness on her face that looked down at her. “And . . . I’m sorry, Adora. What I said before you left, I realized it sounded like I was valuing Glimmer more than you.”

"B-bu-but I t-thought . . . after everything I've d-done!” Adora’s jaw was shaking, breaking up the words in her tight throat. “I've bet-trayed your trust! How can . . . how can you . . . how can you just . . ."

"When we adopted you, we accepted the good and the bad, my child. The ornery and the rebellious. The teenage. Honestly, we expected it, and were a little worried when you grew into such a Goody Two-Shoes. We hoped you'd at least get into a little trouble. Especially the kind of trouble where we adults tell our children to not be kind to others."

“Though the FBI might have been a little more than we bargained for,” Micah noted.

“Micah,” Angella warned gently, then turned back to Adora with a warm maternal smile. "Adora, you never had to be perfect. We'll be here for you after your mistakes."

It was stupid, and maybe should have been obvious, but to Adora those words were like a revelation. As if suddenly realizing she had been living in a tiny room jammed packed with stuff, always tiptoeing over everything so as to not break it, and the walls had just fallen away. They weren't . . . they never . . .

Adora sobbed for several minutes. The dam breaking and all the stress she carried for years, and especially the last week, roaring through the gap. It was undignified perhaps, in front of everyone. But the tears were healing waters, and when they cleared, Adora felt a new clarity in her chest. It was different but not unlike the one that had bubbled up when she stole the truck with Catra. That one had been boiling from fear. This one was a calm, clear spring, sparkling in the sunlight of her soul.

When she was still and only sniffling, Angella stepped back, setting a hand on her hip and cocking an eyebrow. "Besides, you didn’t think you were going to escape your punishment for bringing your girlfriend into the cabin without my permission, right?” She asked.

Adora couldn't totally stifle the laugh. "Mom," She said instinctually.

"That's better." Angella stroked her hair. "I'm so glad you're safe."

“Then you're . . . not mad?" Adora dared.

"Oh, I'm furious." She replied, tone of voice still soft and loving. "You're going to be grounded for a very long time, young lady.”

Adora, after hesitating, ran back in and hugged her mother even tighter than last time. "I can live with that." A moment later, another pair of arms engulfed them both.

"Good to see you, Sunbeam." Micah smiled. "I'm sorry about Catra."

"Thanks. You too, Dad."

Glimmer rejoined them. "Adora." She said, joining the hug.

"Hey Glim." Adora twisted her head so their foreheads could touch. They all held each other there for a long time, her family embraced. HER family.

They parted, and her parents then pulled Glimmer aside for her talk. Adora stepped back, but still heard a few snippets. “Glimmer, it’s okay if you don’t know what you’re going to do with your life.” Micah was saying, “You’re only sixteen, and your kindness, your willingness to help others, people like Catra. I am more proud of that than I could be of any grade or test score you could ever get.”

Glimmer started to cry too, and Adora ran back in for another hug.

When they broke, Angella told them both. “I’ve done a lot of thinking over these last few days.” She admitted. Whoa. Micah reached up and put a hand on her waist, encouraging. “I realize that I’ve put a lot of pressure on both of you for a long time. I told myself I was doing it to push you, so you would become the best versions of yourselves you could be. But I see now that I was just being too hard on you. I’m going to do better going forward, and I want you both to talk to me if you ever feel like I’m being

too much, alright? You've both been old enough for that for quite a while now."

Adora and Glimmer walked forward and hugged her tightly. "We will." Glimmer said.

"Good." Angella smiled.

After the tears ran out, Bow reappeared with his parents, and a roar split the lakebed. Everyone turned to watch as the Fright Zone lit its engines and lifted back into the air. The fighter jets guided it into the distance, where it arced upwards, ascending nearly vertically straight up into the sky. Adora watched it until it and Catra disappeared into a tiny flickering dot high above.

"Don't worry, you'll see her again." Glimmer assured her melancholy expression. "You know what I learned through this?"

"What?" Adora asked.

"A whole lotta shit." Glimmer beamed. "But among them? You two? You're star-crossed, and star-crossed lovers always find one another again."

Adora started to cry again. Stars, how were there still tears in there? Her emotions were interrupted however, by suddenly being swept up off her feet. Adora yelped as Micah lifted her up onto his shoulders. "Ah! What!?"

"Mom!" Glimmer was the next victim, lifted up onto hers. Oh no.

"Hey everyone!" Micah shouted to the crowd. "My baby girls saved the world!" He cheered.

"Oh god, Dad, no, please!" Glimmer laughed in embarrassment. Everyone else around them just stared.

"Hey, hey!" Bow cried, and he watched as his dads also hoisted him up between them, whooping and hollering as they did.

Casta laughed, running over to celebrate with them, pulling Seahawk and Mermista with her. Mermista only clapped, but Seahawk whistled and cheered. In this way, they were all carried back to the cars that would take them home. The relief, joy, sorrow, adrenaline, and bouncing motion of her dad's shoulders sent Adora into giggles, and Glimmer and Bow soon followed. The giggling devolved into full-on belly laughs and joyous shouts into the open sky.

Catra was gone. She'd be gone for a long time. Adora was sure she was going to feel that soon, and it was going to be sad. But right then, in that moment surrounded by her friends, her family, her sister, she was euphoric.

Adora was about to start the grounding of a lifetime, and she didn't think she'd ever been happier.

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None

Chapter 22: Epilogue

Chapter Notes

> For small creatures such as we, the vastness is bearable only through love.
> - Carl Sagan, Contact

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was in one of the remaining escape pods. The air in the Fright Zone was hot, and smelly, and the familiar hum of ship systems was in her ears again, entirely too loud. It was quietest here, at the far end of the pod. She came here often to get away from people and sweat and hot pipes before her time on Earth, but now she had another reason. Looking up from the pilot seat, through the main window, she saw the planet she had never expected to care for so much hanging in the dark. It was already almost gone, a tiny blue speck adrift among a million stars. There were only a few hours now before they would be far enough out of the gravity well to engage FTL, and it would be gone.

Catra tried to cry as quietly as she could. But the memory of Adora standing there, beautiful on the Earth: it was like a hot iron in her soul.

"Wildcat?" A voice called from behind, and Catra jumped, tail puffing out.

"Crap, Scorpia!" She twisted, seeing her peering into the pod. Catra reached up to pat the fur standing up on her neck back down, swallowing her emotions and greeting with a neutral. "Hey,"

"Hey," Scorpia replied, and oh stars, Catra knew that voice. Scorpia pushed herself into the pod, off of the gravity plating. She floated over, asking. “You alright?”

“Of course.” Catra insisted. Scorpia didn’t look convinced.

"Entrapa's already worked through half the ship." Scorpia changed the subject, laughing. "I couldn't stop her, even after dragging her out of the wiring. Let me know if you notice any weird malfunctions. I'm worried her crawling around has knocked some stuff loose."

"Sure," Catra said, level.

"I honestly think Shadow Weaver's gonna eject her out of the airlock before we get back." Scorpia chucked. "These humans, huh? They really are something special."

Catra started crying again.

"Whoa whoa whoa!" Scorpia reached over to soothe her. "I'm sorry, Catra. I didn't mean to upset you. Hordak asked for Entrapta personally; I doubt he'd let Shadow Weaver get away with anything like that."

"It's not Entrapta!" Catra cried, tears overflowing, liquid clinging like a film over her eyes in zero gravity.

"Ohh," Scorpia exhaled. "Sorry . . . I . . . I should have known." She looked up out the window, watching Earth recede. Catra, just to do something, reached into the little bag Bow had given her and unzipped it. From within, stuff floated out into the air. Her two pictures came first. Catra grabbed them both, looking at their faces.

"Well, hey, don't sweat it. Only 600-something Earth days until you can go back, remember? But who's counting, am I right?" Scorpia smiled, or made a face as close as her mandibles could to a smile. Catra leveled a hard glance back at her. "Sorry." Scorpia apologized again. She looked around at the other stuff floating through the air. "Ooo, what's this?" She grabbed the pack of playing cards. A note in Glimmer's pink handwriting was taped to the front, explaining the rules to three-thirteen.

"It's for a stupid game people on Earth play."

“Whoa, really!? That’s pretty cool. Hey, could you teach us? Usually Perfuma, Rogelio, Kyle, Lonnie and I play territory most nights, but we’ve been looking for something new. It’d be great to have you there, specially cause y’know, you’re not going to be on the ship anymore.” She rubbed the back of her neck. “We’ll miss you when you’re gone, by the way.”

“Sure, I’ll play, whatever,” Catra said, mostly just to get Scorpia to leave.

“Great!” Scorpia beamed. “We usually start an hour or so after our shift. See you in the mess?”

“Yeah,” Catra said.

Scorpia nodded, then turned to go. “Hey,” She said softly before she did. “Nice work by the way. Saving that planet. I know people won’t think what you did is heroic, but a lotta people down there are alive because of you.”

“They saved themselves.” Catra insisted.

Scorpia smiled. “Nah, I don’t buy that. I bet you had a big hand in it.” Catra’s mind fed her the memory of Double Trouble roaring at her, calling her a selfish traitor. As if reading her mind, Scorpia continued. “Plus, you got Double Trouble off the ship too, so, bonus! That guy was a jerk, I tell you.”

Catra nodded. “Yeah, they were, weren’t they?”

Scorpia floated, considering her next words. “You know that thing Perfuma always says?” She asked. “That you always hate when she says it." She put on a soft imitation of the flowery officer. "It's hard to keep your heart open, but-"

"But it's worth it." Catra finished.

"Yeah!" Scorpia smiled. "You remembered.”

Catra looked down. "Only because she repeats it so often."

"Well, apparently she needed to, for you to start believing it." Scorpia chuckled, then noted Catra's muted reaction. "Well, I'll get out of your fur." She floated back to the pod hatch.

"Scorpia?" Catra stopped her before she left.

"Yeah?"

"I'll miss you too," Catra told her. "When I'm gone."

Scorpia's face lit up, but she tempered it again before saying. "I'm guessing people . . . well, Shadow Weaver mostly, will call you a coward, leaving active duty to go to diplomat school or whatever it is. But don't let her get to you. You've never been a coward, Catra, and you're still going to be doing something important." Catra nodded at that, half to herself. Scorpia smiled. "Besides, there'll always be another soldier."

She left Catra alone in the pod again.

Was it cowardly? To take an out away from combat like she was about to do? Catra had thought so, but then again, what Scorpia had said was right. Double Trouble was a jerk, and Shadow Weaver- stars, calling Shadow Weaver a jerk was the understatement of the century. The Rebellion was flawed. It targeted poor, vulnerable people like her for recruitment. Captains like Shadow Weaver were able to keep their command. Hordak was a despot, even if his intentions were benevolent.

Catra wondered what the galaxy would be like if he managed to defeat Horde Prime. Would Hordak stay in power, rule in peace? Or would each planet reassert themselves again, return things to how they had been before he had swept through this corner of the universe? Catra didn't know. She didn't know a lot of things right now. But she did know that this ship wasn't where she wanted to be. It made her miserable. There'll always be another soldier, and if there was, that next one would probably be more committed to the cause than Catra was right now.

Right now, Catra just wanted to be happy. She wanted a chance to live, to love. Everyone else on the ship was fighting for something. Their planets and their families, whether they had or hadn't been conquered yet. Catra didn't have a family, a planet, not yet. But for the first time in her life, she knew she had a really good shot at one. If Horde Prime came for either once she did, then he better watch out. But until then,

"I'm coming, Adora." Catra promised the tiny blue dot receding in the window. "As soon as I can, I'm coming home."

Chapter End Notes

TWs: None

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